

AN ADULT ADVENTURE FANTASY NOVEL

A COUNTRY OF DANCING STONE

No center without an exit.



T. K. ARVEN

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An original adult adventure fantasy novel

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Part I

Chapter 1 — The Road That Kicked

The cobbler's awl jumped sideways in Tavra's hand just before the market road changed its mind.

She caught the tool against her thumb, felt its point score the old callus, and planted both boots under the cutting bench. Around her, Dorel's morning market rolled through its familiar noises: shutters clapping open, copper cups striking washbasins, mule bells moving between the bread stalls. Beneath those sounds ran a pressure too slow for most people to notice. It climbed through the central walking stone, crossed the pegged planks of her stall, and pressed against the pale seams in both her knees.

Nine days ago the pressure had leaned east. This morning it twisted south while the held road pulled north.

"Kel," Tavra said. "Get off the stones."

Her apprentice looked up from a pair of carter's boots. At fifteen, Kel Orra had the quick fingers of a thief and the offended dignity of a magistrate whenever Tavra interrupted a cut. "These stones?"

"All of them."

Kel saw her face and moved. He swept the boots and three unfinished soles from the display slab. Tavra closed the drawer under her bench with her heel. Inside lay an illegal score knife, two strips of scaled leather, and a blackened sole fragment she had carried out of Nareth twelve years ago.

Dorel's central stone lurched half a handspan.

The stalls complained in timber creaks. Vendors caught jars and hanging pans. Nobody screamed. A walking market taught balance before letters, and Dorel had completed this nine-day circuit for three generations. Its people knew the pause after a shift, the heartbeat in which awnings swung and water found a new side of every bucket.

Then the imperial road beyond the spice arcade kicked sideways.

A paving slab rose on edge. Another shot beneath a produce cart and threw it into a rack of onions. The rack burst. Yellow bulbs rolled among boots while the cart's left wheel climbed empty air. A child in a red cap stood under the falling axle, too astonished to move.

Tavra moved before caution found her.

She vaulted the bench, and her left knee locked on landing. Pain flashed white through the joint. She let the locked leg take her weight anyway, caught the child by the coat, and flung both of them toward the gutter. The axle struck behind her.

One shaft cracked against the raised slab.

The road kicked again.

This time the motion ran along the paving in a visible fold. People fell in sequence. Canvas roofs snapped taut. The old held route, pinned for sixty years against Dorel's circuit, tried to resume some deeper turn and found the market standing in its way.

"Clear the road!" Tavra shouted. "Not uphill. Crosswise, toward the blue awnings."

A road-company inspector near the well stared at her. His silver license cords bounced against his chest. "Who gave that order?"

"Your paving did."

She dragged the child to his mother, then limped back toward the produce cart. Its carter lay beneath the broken shaft. One boot had twisted between two slabs. Every tug made the fold in the road tighten around his ankle.

Kel knelt beside him. "The leather's caught."

"His foot is caught."

"I can cut the boot."

"And let the road take the foot when it releases?" Tavra crouched. The carter's sole bore a licensed holding score: six square cuts around a center nail, suitable for a route that agreed to remain straight. Under her fingertips the leather shivered. The score kept demanding stillness while the stone beneath it turned.

The inspector pushed through the crowd. "Leave him. Company dancers are coming."

Tavra looked down the road. No salt crew, no anchor cart, no drum. By the time licensed help crossed the morning congestion, the man's ankle would share the paving's shape.

"What's your name?" she asked him.

"Baret." Sweat shone above his beard. "Don't cut the boot. Cost me two weeks."

"You can bill me."

"With what address?" Kel muttered.

Tavra held out her hand. Kel placed the ordinary cobbler's knife in it. Too broad. She could cut away the score, but a blank sole would slide when the fold released. What they needed required a responsive turn, shallow at the heel, open under the outer toes. A licensed cutter would need a measured field and an approval stamp. Tavra needed thirty breaths.

She heard the central stone knock once beneath the market.

"Bench," she told Kel. "Lower drawer. Bring the blue-wrapped knife and the thin lizard strip."

Kel's eyes widened. He had dusted that drawer for two years without opening it. "You said it held tax receipts."

"I lied. Move."

The inspector caught Kel's arm. Tavra rose enough to put her shoulder between them.

"A responsive score inside a civic hold requires College license," he said.

"So arrest me after he keeps his foot."

"You could throw the whole market out of measure."

"The market already left your measure."

Something in her voice made him release Kel. Perhaps he heard training. Perhaps he merely feared the next kick. Kel ran.

Tavra slit the boot's welt while Baret bit on his sleeve. She peeled the upper from the sole without shifting his heel. The paving had gripped three iron nails. She left them where they stood and cut around them, opening a crescent of leather.

Kel returned with the score knife wrapped in faded blue cloth. Its narrow point fit Tavra's hand with an intimacy she hated. He also carried scaled marsh-lizard leather, supple across one grain and stubborn across the other.

"Watch the road, not me," she said.

"I can watch two things."

"That pride will cost you fingers."

She laid the strip over Baret's damaged sole and cut directly against her own palm. One line accepted the road's southward torque. A second gave his heel permission to rise. She stopped before closing the curve.

Kel leaned closer. "You left the release open."

"Good. You can see."

"Bad cutting."

"Useful cutting."

The company inspector crouched opposite her. His anger had thinned into alarm. "That's a center release."

Tavra made the final notch. "No. It borrows the beginning of one."

She bound the strip over Baret's sole with waxed cord. The road pressed upward. Her old training mapped the force before thought: outer edge, heel, knee, hip, surrender. She put both hands around Baret's boot.

"When I turn your foot, let it go loose."

"You ever tell a frightened man to go loose?"

"Often. They never listen."

She turned the boot.

The new score took the paving's torque and guided it under Baret's heel. His leg rolled safely outward. The trapped nails tore free. At the same instant Tavra's own body answered as if she stood at center. Her left knee filled with crushing cold. She dropped against the slab, keeping hold until Kel pulled Baret clear.

Stone struck stone beneath her kneecap.

Not sound. Memory.

Nareth came back as weight rather than image: salt ground black with rain, a hillside folding where no score allowed it to fold, Serad counting across the drumbeat, Eda ten years old in a gallery too far away to reach. Tavra crushed the memory down and forced her locked leg straight with both hands.

The road's raised slabs settled crookedly. One by one, market people stood.

Baret stared at his rescued foot. "I still have toes."

"Spend them carefully."

Kel helped Tavra up. She tried to shake him off and failed because her knee refused the next degree of motion.

The inspector had seen that too. More dangerously, he had seen the knife.

"You trained at center," he said.

"Many fools have."

"Name and license."

"Tavra Ilen. License surrendered."

Recognition changed his face. Nareth had become a word people used when a road company cut corners or a hillside cracked after rain. Most did not know the score-cutter's name. Inspectors did.

He looked at the open responsive cut on Baret's sole, then at the child Tavra had pulled clear. Duty and gratitude fought without either winning.

"You will remain in Dorel," he said at last. "The circuit office will report the violation."

"Of course."

"You don't sound obedient."

"My knee hurts."

The first imperial horn sounded at the northern approach before he could answer.

Dorel's market quieted by degrees. A courier in white road leathers rode through the tilted spice arcade with two College outriders behind him. Their horses wore broad holding soles that slapped the paving without yielding to its new angle. The courier passed the damage, the injured carter, and the inspector as if all belonged to ordinary weather.

He stopped at the central notice post. Kel had already brought Tavra her walking

stick, an act she resented because she needed it.

"Don't stare," she told him.

"You are."

"I'm older. It looks deliberate."

The courier broke a red wax seal. "By authority of Chancellor Miren Asto and the Imperial College of Measures, let every licensed company, sole court, civic drummer, and anchor keeper receive notice."

He nailed a cream sheet to the post. The hammer blows carried through the disturbed road.

"On Stillday, twenty-four days hence, seven anchor companies shall join in the Dominion Measure. The measure will secure the imperial routes against destructive movement, preserve grain passage, end seasonal loss, and establish a common ground for every province under Meren's protection."

A murmur passed through the market. Dorel had lost two winter caravans when the western road walked into marshland. Permanent grain passage sounded like mercy when announced beside broken produce and a frightened child.

Tavra heard the missing word in the notice: release.

Every honest measure named its release.

The courier continued. "Principal center-dancer Eda Ilen of the Fifth Measure will carry the sevenfold joining under the direction of Master Chorearch Serad Vale."

Kel's hand tightened around Tavra's arm.

For one breath, Tavra felt no pain. The market narrowed to the name on the courier's tongue.

Eda.

Not an apprentice assigned to the outer line. Not a supporting center among six others. Principal center for seven anchors spread across Neme's imperial roads.

The courier praised her balance, her service, her unprecedented capacity to hear two anchors at once. Tavra knew that capacity. At eight, Eda had crossed a courtyard while masons reset stones under both ends, adjusting each foot to a different slope without spilling her bowl. Tavra had laughed then and called it cleverness. Serad had watched from an upper arcade.

Sevenfold joining would not divide the counter-motion cleanly. It would seek the body most able to answer. Eda's talent would make her a deeper vessel, not a safer one.

The pain returned to Tavra's knee with a pulse.

The courier began taking declarations from Dorel's civic officers. One by one they named warehouses, well depths, bridge stones, and the number of days each route had failed during the last decade. The promise fed on particulars. A miller called out that his north cart had vanished with the road two winters before. A

widow near the dye stalls raised three fingers for sons lost when a pass closed around their company. Tavra could not dismiss those voices as imperial ignorance. A held road brought flour before hunger. It carried healers. It let a family bury its dead in ground they could find again.

That had drawn her to the College at twenty-four. Serad had never needed to lie about the lives a measure saved.

The road-company inspector approached while the courier's clerk copied Dorel's losses. He had removed his silver-corded glove. A fresh scrape crossed his palm from catching someone during the kick.

"I should detain you," he said.

"You mentioned that."

"I also watched the cut work." His glance moved to Baret, who tested his foot between two friends. "The company manual says a trapped limb inside a civic hold should remain weighted until an anchor team arrives."

"Then the manual owes Baret some toes."

"You knew where the paving meant to turn."

"I felt where it pushed."

"Those aren't the same skill."

"No. That difference matters."

He studied the crooked road. "Will it kick again?"

Tavra pressed her stick tip between two slabs. The pressure had spread into a broad southern pull. "Not before evening, unless your company tries to force these stones straight. Mark the damaged reach. Let it keep the bend until the circuit carries Dorel past the strain."

"That leaves the imperial route misaligned by half a street."

"Half a street costs less than another market."

The inspector looked toward the courier, then lowered his voice. "If I record your advice, I record your presence."

"You already chose that."

His mouth tightened. "I chose duty."

"So did I, once."

She regretted the words because they sounded like absolution. Nareth had taught her that duty could describe the hand holding a knife without answering where it cut.

Kel guided her back to the stall. She sat because refusing would turn necessity into theater. From the notice post came applause, uncertain at first, then stronger as merchants understood the promise of roads that never left their warehouses.

"You knew her," Kel said.

Tavra unwrapped the illegal knife and wiped road grit from its point. "Yes."

"The courier said Ilen."

"Yes."

Kel waited. He had learned that silence often made Tavra answer where questions failed.

"My daughter," she said.

The words felt less like confession than a tool found rusted in a wall.

Kel sat on Baret's abandoned onion crate. "You told me you had no family."

"I told you no family would come looking."

"That isn't better."

"No."

Across the market, the inspector spoke urgently to one of the College outriders. The rider looked toward Tavra's stall.

Kel followed her gaze. "Will they take you?"

"They'll ask about the cut. Then about Nareth."

"What happened there?"

"Too much for a market morning."

"That means you won't say."

"It means I need you to close the stall."

Tavra bent over her left knee. The joint had loosened enough to move, but a pale line now showed beneath the skin, narrow as a score cut. She pressed it and felt cold answer from inside the bone. The small rescue had not caused all of that. Years of hidden counter-motion had waited for a road to recognize her.

Eda would stand under seven anchors in twenty-four days.

Tavra opened the drawer. Beneath receipts and spare buckles lay the fragment from Nareth: black sole leather, stiff with old salt, its surviving cuts ending at a scorched edge. She had kept it to remember her guilt accurately. On sleepless nights she told herself evidence differed from attachment. In truth, she had never stopped trying to solve the score alone.

Kel saw the fragment before she covered it.

"Pack food for two days," Tavra said. "Then take the stall key to Mistress Venn. Tell her the lease is paid through autumn."

"You're leaving."

"I'm going to the College."

"Twenty-four days away on a held road, if it holds."

"Then I'll arrive impolitely."

"What do I do?"

"Stay in Dorel. Finish Baret's other boot with a plain flex sole. Do not copy what I cut today."

Kel stood so fast the crate tipped. "You break license law in front of me, tell the empire your name, announce a daughter you buried in a sentence, and now I should finish a boot?"

"Two boots. People limp when the soles disagree."

His face closed. Tavra knew that expression because Eda had worn an earlier version whenever Tavra converted fear into instruction.

She softened nothing. Soft words offered after an order still left the order intact. "The riders will connect you to me. Coming would make you leverage."

"Staying makes me ignorant leverage."

"I can protect you here."

"You protected your daughter by leaving too, did you?"

The question struck more accurately than accusation required. Tavra gripped the bench until the fresh cut in her thumb opened again.

At the notice post, the College outrider turned toward them.

Kel looked ready to apologize. She did not let him. "Pack the food," she said. "We'll argue after I'm out of their sight."

"We?"

"A poor choice of pronoun."

"Sounded like an honest one."

The market road shifted under the stall, gentler now but no longer following its imperial line. Jars chimed along the shelf. Tavra wrapped the Nareth fragment in blue cloth beside the knife.

She had spent twelve years arranging her life so no one else would stand where her decisions could hurt them. Eda had stood there all along, only farther away.

Tavra rose with the stick in one hand and the hidden score in the other. Her left knee bent after a delay. Across Dorel, the courier's notice snapped in the wind, promising a continent that would never move again.

She stepped out before the outrider reached her stall. By nightfall she would need a route, a horse she could not afford, and a lie good enough to pass a College post. Those problems had edges she knew how to cut.

Getting Eda out would require something harder.

Tavra would have to reach her before Stillday and ask a daughter she had abandoned to trust her feet.

Chapter 2 — The Measure on Her Knees

Tavra fed the first forbidden score into the stove and watched the leather curl without catching fire.

The strip had been oiled too well. Its cut lines blackened, closed, then opened again as heat tightened the grain. She held it deeper with the stove tongs until smoke crawled through the workshop and stung her eyes.

Outside, boots crossed the market lane in disciplined pairs.

College outriders had dismounted at both ends of the cobblers' row. Their horses blocked the northern ramp while the circuit inspector led two white-corded officers from stall to stall. Dorel's late-afternoon trade continued around them with studied unconcern. Nobody wished to be remembered as the neighbor who watched an arrest.

Kel dropped the rear shutter. "They asked Mistress Venn whether you keep a room."

"She told them?"

"She charged them for the answer."

"Good woman."

Tavra put a second score into the stove. This one carried the heel release for a brewery stair that rose during wet months. Cutting it had earned her four jars of small beer and a winter of trouble if the College found it. She had kept too much. Every solved sole became evidence because she could not bear to destroy proof that she still understood the work.

Kel seized the tongs before she reached for a third. "No."

"We discussed your fingers."

"We discussed your habit of lying and calling it instruction." He held the tongs beyond her reach. "Which seems larger."

A knock sounded at the front shutter.

"Tavra llen," called the circuit inspector. "By temporary order, you are to remain available for inquiry."

"Available," Kel whispered. "Polite arrest."

Tavra limped to the bench and began choosing tools. Two awls, three knives, heel nails, linen thread, wax, a folding rasp. She put each into a roll of goat leather. Her left knee had stiffened during the hour since the road kicked. Bending it sent a cold seam up her thigh.

The inspector knocked again. "We know you are inside."

"So does half the market," Tavra called. "It's a shop."

"Open the shutter."

"When my stove stops smoking."

Kel opened his mouth. She raised one finger. The front shutter's bar would not stop an officer, but procedure might hold them for a few minutes while they fetched a civic witness. Empire loved rules most when rules slowed somebody else.

She pointed to a loose plank behind the sole rack. "Pry that up."

Kel did not move. "What's under it?"

"The part you'll hate."

"That narrows nothing."

Tavra pulled the plank herself. Pain forced her onto her right knee. A shallow cavity lay beneath the floor, lined with felt against Dorel's constant movement. Inside rested a cedar box and a pair of center shoes wrapped in funeral cloth.

Kel crouched opposite her. "You said your knees came from quarry work."

"I worked with stone."

"That answer deserves to be hit with something."

"Choose something light. We're rushed."

The center shoes had once been white. Nareth mud had entered every stitch, leaving the leather the brown-black of dried blood. Tavra had cut away most of the score before deserting. One surviving section matched the fragment from her drawer.

She opened the cedar box. Paper records filled the upper tray: false market permits, Kel's apprenticeship terms, three letters from Eda returned unopened during Tavra's first year in Dorel. Beneath them lay copied foot diagrams and a map of Nareth's northern road.

Kel reached toward the letters, then stopped himself. "She wrote to you?"

"I didn't earn the right to read them."

"So you kept them for twelve years."

"Eleven. The first year she sent nothing."

The front shutter shook under a heavier knock.

"Civic witness present," the inspector called. "Open by count of ten."

Tavra took the Nareth papers from the box and pushed the rest toward the stove.

Kel blocked her arm. "You don't get to burn my apprenticeship because you're frightened."

"The paper ties you to an unlicensed cutter."

"The whole market ties me to you. Baret's foot ties me to you. My hands tie me to you." He snatched the apprenticeship sheet from the tray and folded it into his shirt. "There. Evidence escaped."

“Kel.”

“No.” His voice broke, anger carrying it through. “If I’m leverage, tell me what they can use.”

The inspector reached six.

Tavra gathered the center shoes and cedar box. “Back door.”

They slipped into the narrow service lane as the count reached nine. Dorel had moved a quarter street south since morning. The back steps no longer met the neighboring dye house, leaving a gap above a drainage run. Kel crossed first. Tavra lowered herself with the stick, left leg straight, and nearly fell when the market stone rolled beneath her heel.

Kel caught her elbow.

“Don’t,” she snapped.

“Fall, then.”

She accepted his grip. Behind them wood cracked. The officers had entered the shop.

They reached Mistress Venn’s storeroom through a curtain of wet blue cloth. The dyer looked once at Tavra’s bundle, once at the College cords visible through the lane, and pointed toward a ladder without asking. Her generosity had limits, but her hatred of inspectors possessed admirable stamina.

The roof walk carried them over three stalls. Dorel merchants built upper planks for days when the circuit’s inner lanes pinched shut. Tavra’s knee made every rung a negotiation. By the time they reached the abandoned cooper’s loft, sweat had soaked her collar despite the cold.

Kel barred the hatch. “Now tell me.”

Below them, officers searched the dye vats with poles.

Tavra sat against a barrel hoop and unwrapped the center shoes. “The Dominion Measure will join seven anchors. The notice calls Eda principal center. Do you understand counter-motion?”

“I understand that moving stone puts pressure into a dancer.”

“Not pressure. An answering movement. If a field rises, the center’s body receives the descent. If a road turns, joints carry its unspent torque. A short measure bruises. A hard hold puts stone into cartilage.” She touched her left knee. “Seven anchors will seek seven answers. If Serad has written a single center beneath them, Eda will carry their refusal to move.”

Kel’s gaze dropped to the pale line under her skin. “More stone than any body can bear.”

“Yes.”

“Will it kill her?”

Tavra looked through a crack in the loft wall. The market’s central post had

advanced past the bakery, carrying the Dominion notice with it. "I don't know how quickly."

It amounted to the only honest answer she had given him all day.

Kel ran a thumb over the cut-away sole of one center shoe. "And Nareth?"

"The College held a city road against a hillside movement. I led the center company. Serad's score said the hill would settle east. The ground changed after we began. I felt it. I followed the score anyway."

"What happened?"

"The road stayed open. A hillside district moved into the lower cut. Houses went under."

"How many?"

"Eighty-six dead. More injured. Eight hundred displaced before winter." The figures never blurred. Tavra had polished them through repetition. "My company received the counter-motion. Two dancers died before morning. Others failed over the next years. My knees began turning during the hold."

Kel sat back. He had expected a secret that made sense of her. She watched him discover that knowledge could make a person less tidy.

"You saved the road," he said.

"We obeyed a wrong score."

"Both can happen."

"That sentence built the College."

A boot scraped the roof planks outside. Tavra wrapped the shoes again and waited. The sound passed toward the spice arcade.

Kel lowered his voice. "Why keep the Nareth score?"

"Because the surviving cut proves the release changed after Serad sealed the company copy. He ordered us to finish the original hold. The road's actual movement required a turn."

"Evidence?"

"Of a mistake. Not of intent."

"Does Eda know?"

"No."

"You left without telling her any of this?"

"She was ten."

"She's twenty-three now."

Tavra folded the funeral cloth too sharply. "I sent explanations."

"You just showed me her unopened letters."

"I wrote. I never sent them."

Kel stared at her until she heard how absurd the distinction sounded.

From the lane below came the inspector's voice. "Search the upper walks."

They had minutes. Tavra repacked the Nareth score fragment inside the cedar box and bound it against her ribs. She gave Kel the tool roll.

"You'll go down through Venn's front stall when the officers pass. Carry those back to the shop."

"And you?"

"South ramp. A grain cart leaves at dusk for the imperial junction."

"The southern route has riders on it."

"I saw."

"Then why?"

"Because they expect me to avoid it."

"That is not strategy. That's pride wearing a hat."

Despite herself, Tavra almost laughed. "A very small hat."

Kel put the tool roll over his shoulder and picked up the wrapped center shoes. "I'm coming."

"No."

"You can barely climb a ladder."

"My knee will loosen."

"If you tell it firmly?"

Tavra took the shoes from him. "The College will use you to stop me."

"They can use Dorel. Your customers. That child's mother. Everyone already knows your name." Kel stepped close enough that she could see soot from the stove along his cheek. "You keep deciding who gets risk. You did it at Nareth. You did it with Eda. You're doing it now."

"I am trying to keep a fifteen-year-old out of imperial custody."

"You're trying to feel clean about leaving."

Her hand tightened on the shoes. The controlling impulse came with perfect clarity: choose his route, narrow his knowledge, move him into safety, and call the result care. Serad would have admired the construction.

Tavra drew a breath. "You may come as far as the southern ramp. You decide there whether to return to Venn. If you continue, the riders may arrest you. The road may fail. I cannot promise I'll protect you."

Kel considered, suspicious because consent from her arrived shaped like another instruction. "And you'll tell me before you cut any score I have to stand on?"

"Yes."

"That sounded painful."

"It was."

They left the loft through the roof vent as College officers entered below. Evening had lowered across Dorel. Cooking smoke flattened along the market roofs, and the walking stone's southward drift had pulled the outer stalls into a crescent. Tavra chose the inner roof line where awnings hid them from the road.

The route forced them down through the poultry court, where Dorel's movement had wedged two roof walks against a chimney. Kel went first and returned to brace Tavra's locked leg as she descended. She hated each necessary touch. Not him, never him. She hated the accurate report her body delivered through his hands.

At street level they found the market preparing to walk through night. Stall keepers tied crockery in straw and reset bridge planks between sections that would separate during the next turn. Nobody waited for an imperial company to tell them how. A potter marked tomorrow's expected slope on her shelves with chalk. Three children carried a basket of eggs together, changing leaders whenever the lane tipped. Dorel had survived because its people treated stability as temporary work.

Tavra watched Kel read the adjustments. She had taught him leather grain and nail angles, but not the reason Dorel's boots needed different flex on circuit days. Teaching enough to make him useful had felt safer than teaching enough to let him disagree.

They paused in the covered yard behind Mistress Venn's second dye stall. Kel divided bread, hard cheese, and dried pears between two packs while Tavra examined the Nareth fragment under a shuttered lamp. Heat from the stove had not reached it. The black cuts still forked at the broken edge: Serad's finished hold turning inward, the field's needed release turning south.

"What happens if you show that to Eda?" Kel asked.

"She may recognize Serad altered the company record."

"May."

"She may throw it in my face."

"That would also be a choice."

Tavra wrapped it again. "You've become devoted to that word."

"You made it scarce."

A market bell rang twice from the north. Officers had closed the licensed gates. The southern ramp remained open because grain traffic could not stop without a chancellor's seal.

Kel fastened the tool roll beneath his coat. "If I go back now, Venn can hide me in the indigo carts."

"Yes." Tavra made herself continue. "If you come, we'll leave the held road before dawn and cross country toward Kesta. Food will run short. The College may post your name as an accomplice. I don't know when you can return."

“Better.”

“What?”

“That sounded like risk instead of an order.” He looked north, toward the shop hidden beyond three moving rows. Grief pinched his mouth. “I’m coming to the ramp. I’ll decide there, like you said.”

Tavra wanted to praise him for caution and realized praise might push as surely as blame. She handed him the lighter pack instead. “Keep the rasp dry.”

They joined a line of porters crossing a cloth bridge onto the southern market wedge. Behind them, College whistles moved through Dorel. Ahead, the held road shone pale and straight beyond the last wandering stalls.

At the southern ramp, a grain cart waited with six sacks under waxed cloth. Its driver accepted Tavra’s last silver piece and asked no name. Kel climbed beneath the cloth before she could revise their agreement.

Tavra settled beside him. The cart rolled down from Dorel onto the held road with a jolt that drove cold through her left knee. She felt the route’s rigid score through the wheel rims. Company work had forced the paving straight after the morning kick. Torque gathered along the edges like a twisted strap.

They passed the last market stalls at dusk. Ahead, three College riders stood across the southern route. White cords caught the failing light. Behind the cart, another pair emerged from Dorel’s ramp.

The driver swore. “You said no trouble.”

“I said no name.” Tavra pushed back the waxed cloth. “Stop before their horses enter the strained paving.”

“That advice sounds expensive.”

Kel crawled beside her. “Can we turn the road?”

“Not without salt and an anchor. Also not if you enjoy having legs.”

The riders ahead spread into a capture line. Their horses shifted in matching steps, trained to close any gap. Tavra measured the distance to the drainage verge. Too far for her knee. She could cut the grain cart’s brake strap, send it into the lead horse, and create confusion. The driver might die. Kel might fall under a wheel.

Every solution her fear offered spent somebody else before asking.

She raised both hands instead.

The lead rider approached. “Tavra Ilen, surrender your knives and the Nareth score.”

Kel whispered, “How do they know about the score?”

“Someone remembers what I kept.”

Tavra climbed down slowly, favoring her left knee. If she drew the officers close, Kel might escape under the cart. She had not asked whether he wanted that plan.

There was no time to ask without exposing him.

A low drumbeat sounded from beyond the drainage ditch.

The lead horse's right foreleg stepped early.

A second beat came late enough to irritate the ear. The rear horses answered their riders' trained pressure, but each animal received a body half a count out of place. The capture line buckled.

The College riders cursed and tried to reset. A third beat landed where no imperial cadence permitted it, between command and response.

Someone in the dark played a military march with its spine broken.

Tavra knew enough cadence work to recognize deliberate sabotage. No rhythm compelled the riders. Their own years of training betrayed them as the drummer offered the cues they had learned to obey, then withheld the expected landing.

The grain-cart driver saw his opening. He snapped the reins. The cart shot between two turning horses. One wheel clipped a roadside marker and threw sparks across the drainage stones, but the axle held.

Kel grabbed Tavra's coat and hauled. She caught the rear board, dragged her bad leg clear of a wheel, and rolled among the sacks as a rider seized empty air behind her.

The broken cadence followed them down the road. Three beats, a gap, then one hard stroke that turned pursuit into a scatter of conflicting steps.

From the ditch rose a woman with a double-faced field drum strapped across her chest. She ran beside the cart without giving her name, one hand beating the outer skin while the other steadied the rim.

Tavra had never seen her before. She recognized a deserter's cut-down uniform and the practiced cruelty of the cadence.

The woman struck one final displaced beat, vaulted onto the cart, and looked directly at the cedar box under Tavra's coat.

"If you still have the Nareth score," she said, "stop trying to reach Kesta by an imperial road. They own every straight mile between here and the border posts."

Chapter 3 — A Drummer Without a Regiment

Ossa struck the late beat and watched five trained bodies remember obedience faster than danger.

The lead rider's knee closed against his saddle. His horse read the pressure and veered. Two others followed, each correcting for a command Ossa never completed. Their capture line folded inward while the grain cart broke through.

She hated how little music it took.

Three beats had once moved a regiment from sleep to marching order. Five could turn frightened civilians toward a ravine if the cadence officer wore the right cord and did not look over the edge. Ossa used four now, each damaged at the point of expectation. The riders fought for balance rather than following her, but the difference lived in intention, not muscle. Their bodies still answered before thought.

She ran from the ditch, vaulted onto the cart, and stopped the drumhead with her palm.

Tavra Ilen lay among grain sacks with one leg held too straight. The apprentice crouched beside her, young enough that anger had not learned concealment. Ossa had last seen Tavra twelve years ago across a Nareth salt field, white center shoes planted while a hillside came apart beyond the lamps.

Tavra looked older. Guilt had not improved her.

"If you still have the Nareth score," Ossa said, "stop trying to reach Kesta by an imperial road. They own every straight mile between here and the border posts."

The cart driver twisted around. "Who are you?"

"Someone improving your fare."

"You brought soldiers."

"They arrived first."

Behind them, the riders recovered their count. Ossa heard the change in hoof rhythm before she looked. Three had regrouped. One held back with an injured horse. Their officer called a standard pursuit cadence by slapping his thigh.

Ossa drew her short beater from the drum rim. "Driver, left at the split stone."

"That track goes into fallow ground."

"Yes."

"My axle won't."

Tavra pushed herself upright. "The held road carries torque from Dorel. If the riders close on us here, their horses will give it a center line."

Ossa understood no half of that and believed the urgency in Tavra's voice. "Choose," she told the driver. "Axle or arrest."

He chose the axle.

The cart left the paving at the split stone. Its wheels dropped into ruts hard enough to throw Kel against a sack. Tavra caught him with one arm and bit down on whatever her knee did in answer. Ossa knelt at the rear board, listening to pursuit.

Hooves changed timbre on the dirt. The riders had followed.

Fallow terraces crossed the slope ahead in dark bands. Without a held road, the land kept its own small movements. Furrows slanted away from last season's boundaries. Low walls ended where stone had walked through them. The grain cart could not outrun College horses here.

Ossa counted the pursuers' breaths. Seven-beat recovery, taught at every imperial remount school. She could fracture it with the cadence that dropped weight onto an unexpected outside stirrup. One rider would fall. A neck might break.

Pel had called that pattern clever the first time she demonstrated it.

She put the short beater away.

"What are you waiting for?" Kel asked.

"A method that doesn't kill them."

"They plan to arrest us."

"Arrest survives the evening."

Tavra's eyes sharpened. "There's a dry irrigation cut beyond the third terrace. Get them to commit downhill. The cut should divide their formation."

"Should?"

"The land moved since this field had water."

"Comforting." Ossa turned to the driver. "Angle toward the black willow. Do not follow my drum. Follow her hand."

She pointed at Tavra.

The driver looked offended by the abundance of commanders, but he turned. Ossa played no command cadence. She gave the pursuing riders a clean, familiar count and let them gain.

Six lengths. Five. Four.

Tavra raised her left hand at the willow. The cart swerved right. Its front wheels crossed a shallow gully hidden under weeds. The rear axle slammed down and bounced free.

The riders met the cut at speed. Their lead horse jumped. The second refused. The third turned across the fourth. Men cursed, leather snapped, and the pursuit dissolved into a knot of animals without a single broken neck.

Ossa ended her count.

The cart climbed the next terrace and vanished behind the slope. Only then did the driver slow. One rear wheel listed inward.

"I said my axle wouldn't," he told them.

"You were correct," Ossa said.

He abandoned them beside a roofless threshing shed after taking back Tavra's silver from the fee she had paid. The wheel had not broken, merely cracked, but he described the distinction at considerable volume. By the time his cart limped north, full dark covered the fallow fields.

Ossa waited until the cart's uneven squeal faded. Then she crossed back to the terrace and brushed their deepest tracks with a thorn branch. It would not fool a route runner, but College pursuit expected cadence officers to think in straight advances and score-cutters to seek paving. She led them twice around a collapsed wall, stepped through an old sheep path, and left one clear boot print pointing east.

Kel watched from the shed. "Will they follow that?"

"For ten minutes if they are tired. Five if they are clever."

"And if they know you?"

"Then they will distrust every print and lose longer." Ossa tossed him the branch. "Confusion works best when the other person remains free to choose badly."

Tavra had taken the pause to examine the cart ruts. She pointed toward a low seam where weeds leaned south. "This field moved after harvest. Your false trail crosses newer ground. The print may face east when the seam carries it north."

"Can we use that?"

"We can hope the riders don't."

Ossa revised her estimate. Tavra's knowledge might prove useful in ways no command packet could contain.

Kel watched it go. "We've lost the food."

He carried one pack. Tavra carried the cedar box and leaned on her stick. Ossa had her drum, a water flask, and two onions stolen from Dorel during the morning confusion.

"We've retained half the food," Ossa said. "And gained onions."

"Are they tactical onions?"

"All onions become tactical after midnight."

Tavra did not smile. "Name."

"Ossa Marr."

Recognition reached her more slowly than it had reached Ossa. "Hadrin."

"Among other failures."

"You were cadence officer for the Twenty-Second Road Regiment."

"I stopped."

"After you drummed a refugee ridge into Pel Cut."

Kel looked between them. "You know each other?"

"No," Ossa said. "We know reports written by people who kept their licenses."

Tavra's weight shifted onto the stick. "Why follow Dominion supplies?"

"Because supply carts speak more honestly than proclamations. The College sent anchor cradles east, west, and south over the last six weeks. Seven teams. Permanent-house provisions. Winter rations for crews assigned through next spring."

"The notice calls the measure a Stillday joining."

"The notice lies by duration."

Ossa entered the threshing shed and checked its floor. Packed earth, no scored paving. Three walls remained. The roof beams had burned years ago. Safe enough for a short argument.

She set down the drum. Its outward skin showed repairs from seven provinces: goat at the center, river lizard along one edge, a Hadrún patch darkened by rain. The inward face stayed hidden against her coat.

Kel collected dry stalks for a small fire. Tavra lowered herself onto a fallen beam with both hands braced around her knee.

"You knew they wanted permanent holds," she said.

"I knew they provisioned seven."

"Where?"

"Two western grain roads, the Kestan approaches, Hadrún's north valley, the capital basin, and two I haven't placed."

"Anchor orchards," Tavra said.

Ossa heard the thought gather tempo. Kesta carried its local anchor stones in the root balls of walking fruit trees. Pin those orchards and imperial surveyors could nail a border around a country that survived by refusing one.

"Likely," she said. "That is why I need your score knowledge."

Tavra's answer arrived without pause. "No."

Kel dropped a bundle of stalks. "You don't know what she's asking."

"She wants me to read College supply scores and tell her how to break them."

"I want you to prove what they do," Ossa said. "Breaking comes after people know the cost."

"People die while proof travels."

"People also die when former centers decide alone."

Silence tightened the shed.

Ossa had meant the words to wound, and she disliked herself for the accuracy. She knelt by the drum before Tavra could answer. Three buckles released the outer shell. She turned the instrument carefully and exposed the inner drum skin.

Imperial command marks ran around the underside in faded red: march, close, center, brace, advance. Ossa had scraped away her regiment number after deserting, but the cuts remained visible where dye had entered the hide. Newer writing crossed them in charcoal.

Kel leaned over. "Orders?"

"Copied from convoy slips and cadence packets." Ossa rotated the drum. "Here. Seven anchors. Seven crews supplied past Stillday. Center provisions routed to the capital. Look at the duration mark."

Tavra bent close. She did not touch the skin. "No release allotment."

"None."

"A temporary joining would carry salt for unbinding and replacement soles for every center."

"The convoys carry neither."

Kel traced the air above a row of marks. "What does this one say?"

Ossa's throat tightened. "Conditioned compliance authorized."

"For dancers?"

"For anyone trained to a military count."

"That isn't magic."

"No. It works more reliably." She fastened the skin flat against the drum rim so the wind would not tear it. "Command cadence takes a practiced response and arrives before refusal. A body can resist if it recognizes the pattern in time. Most do not."

Tavra studied her. "You used it in Hadrun."

"Yes."

The fire caught. Its first smoke moved through the roofless beams.

Ossa heard again the march on Pel Ridge. Refugees had crowded the moving shelf after their valley road vanished. Command believed the ridge could be shifted toward a supply route. The civilians refused to step onto the salted field. Ossa's colonel ordered the march cadence. Road laborers, veterans, and frightened reserve dancers moved because their muscles knew the count. The ridge answered too quickly and folded into the ravine.

Her brother Pel had served on the outer drum line. He fell still holding his beater.

Before the order, Pel had argued with her beside the cook wagon. Refugees had occupied the ridge because the grain route below belonged to the same army

asking them to move again. Ossa had repeated the colonel's assurance that the shifted shelf would meet the road gently. Pel asked whether anyone had tested the ravine wall. She told him cadence officers did not inspect stone.

"Then perhaps don't make stone dance," he had said.

She had called that barracks wit. An hour later, the command passed down the drum line. Pel heard her first stroke, knew exactly what she meant to play, and raised his own beater. Military habit moved through both of them. He might have refused. So might she. That possibility kept guilt from becoming a story about innocent tools.

When the ridge broke, Ossa crawled through salt mud toward his drum. The outer skin had split. Underneath, the command skin remained whole, every red mark legible while bodies lay where the count had driven them. She cut that inner hide free before deserting, then burned it on the second night because she could not bear the orders against her back. The strip she carried now came from a different drum, but her hands knew every mark.

Tavra said, "Nareth happened five years before Hadrin. You knew what College holds could do."

"And you knew before Nareth. Every center knows where counter-motion goes."

"I did not know the hill would bury houses."

"I did not know the ridge would split."

They faced each other across the drum, each carrying an explanation built from ignorance and obedience.

Kel fed another stalk to the fire. "You can both be guilty without making guilt a contest."

Ossa looked at him. "How long have you apprenticed under her?"

"Long enough to repair poor joins."

Tavra rubbed her left knee. "If those orders are genuine, the Dominion Measure has no planned release."

"They're genuine."

"You copied them."

"I also took this."

From inside her coat Ossa withdrew a narrow command-skin strip. She had cut it from a new imperial drum three nights ago while its cadence officer slept beside a convoy fire. The hide smelled of oil and horse sweat. A College seal branded one end.

She handed it to Tavra.

The score-cutter turned the strip under firelight. Her thumb stopped at seven small anchor marks joined by a continuous red line.

"Permanent anchor holds," Tavra said.

The phrase landed quietly. Kel sat back from the fire.

Tavra read the routing signs twice. "The Kestan crew performs a public demonstration on Day Five. It says survey confirmation follows."

"Demonstration first, seizure after the crowd applauds."

"Eda may lead it."

"Then you have two reasons to reach Kesta."

Tavra looked up. "You knew who she was when you found me."

"I knew Serad named Eda Ilen principal center. I guessed blood might move you where conscience had not."

Kel inhaled through his teeth.

Ossa accepted the ugliness of the sentence. She had followed Tavra for three days after finding the Dorel stall in a former-regiment registry. She needed the Nareth fragment, and Tavra needed pressure. Manipulation did not become clean because its purpose opposed an empire.

Tavra folded the command-skin strip and held it out. "Keep it."

"You can read it better."

"That doesn't make it mine."

A small refusal, perhaps aimed at the wrong problem, but Ossa heard strain behind it.

She did not take the strip. "Carry it until Kesta. You can compare its anchor cuts to Nareth. If I keep both evidence and drum, one arrest ends the proof."

Tavra considered, then placed the strip beside the cedar box rather than inside it. Separate custody within the same coat. Not enough, but conscious.

"What bargain?" Tavra asked.

Ossa sat on the opposite end of the fallen beam. "I get you to Kesta off held roads. You read the command-skin and help me show orchard keepers what the seven anchors will do. After that, we gather copies and testimony before we strike anything."

"I go to Eda."

"You speak to Eda. You do not abduct her, drug her, cut her soles without consent, or decide that your body should replace hers before she answers."

Tavra's expression hardened at the final clause. Ossa had guessed correctly.

"You don't set terms between me and my daughter."

"No. I set terms for my help."

Kel stared into the fire, wisely pretending not to listen.

Tavra shifted her bad leg and failed to hide the pain. "If the demonstration begins before we arrive, evidence comes second."

"Lives come first. Your authority does not."

"And if delay puts Eda at center?"

"We ask who stands in the field and tell them the cost. Then we act with those who choose."

"That takes time."

"Command always sounds efficient."

The words struck both of them. Ossa had spent seven years trying to build a life in the half beat between instruction and response. Tavra appeared to live in the same half beat while insisting she owned it.

A horse whinnied on the northern slope.

Ossa smothered the fire with dirt. Pursuers had found the abandoned cart. Voices carried across the terraces.

"We leave now," she said. "There's a shepherd's descent west of the burned mill."

Tavra tried to stand. Her left knee stopped halfway. Kel moved to help and waited until she nodded before taking her arm.

Ossa noticed. So did Tavra.

They crossed the fallow fields without drumbeat. Ossa led by remembered convoy routes, keeping stone walls between them and the riders' lanterns. At the burned mill she found the descent: a narrow animal track down a slope that had walked away from its own switchbacks.

Kel peered into the dark. "That isn't a road."

"Excellent," Ossa said. "The College may overlook it."

Tavra tested the first drop with her stick. "Where does it end?"

"Near the old clay pits. From there, three days to Kesta if the low hills hold."

"Hills don't hold."

"Then we have established the flaw in my schedule."

Lantern light appeared at the burned mill behind them.

Tavra tucked the inner drum skin strip inside her coat. "I accept until Kesta. Evidence and Eda. Neither outranks an immediate life."

Ossa waited.

Tavra's jaw tightened. "And I tell you before I put you in a measure."

"Better."

Kel made a small approving noise.

They descended single file. Ossa went first, choosing footholds. Kel followed with the tool roll. Tavra came last because she refused the safer order and because arguing would spend time they lacked. Behind them, College riders reached the

top of the animal track.

Ossa lifted no beater. She let the pursuers hear loose stones, uncertain footing, and their own breath. The broken imperial cadence had won them one escape. Repeating it would turn method into habit, then habit into command.

At the clay pits, the land opened west in unheld folds. No paving marked the way to Kesta. Orchard lights moved faintly along the far horizon, present in one place now and likely elsewhere by dawn.

Ossa adjusted the double-faced drum against her ribs. Its outer skin carried the public sound. Its inner drum skin carried the empire's intention. Tavra carried the strip that could prove seven anchors, and Kel carried enough tools to make any pursuit complicated.

Behind them, hooves entered the descent.

They left the imperial road and ran toward country that refused to stay found.

Chapter 4 — The Village That Moved at Noon

Ruhan put his shoulder under Aunt Seli's kitchen before the sun reached the bell pole.

The house had begun leaning at breakfast. By second cup, its downslope wall rested against two orchard poles and its brick oven pointed toward Kesta's northern grazing shelf. Seli refused to remove the soup until the last possible moment.

"It improves with travel," she said through the window.

"It improves with not landing on me."

"Then lift evenly."

Ruhan bent his knees. Six neighbors took the other carrying rails. At his nod they raised the timber frame off its stone feet. Nobody drummed. Nobody salted a field. The ground beneath Kesta's hamlet had developed a noon rise, and the households answered with poles, rollers, practiced backs, and arguments inherited across generations.

"Left front short," called Mina from the roof.

Ruhan shortened his step. The kitchen cleared the oven pit just as the shelf rose another finger. Crockery rattled inside. Seli leaned through the window holding the soup pot level with both hands.

They carried the house forty paces toward a patch of red grass where the slope would settle by evening. Children ran ahead placing flat stones under the new feet. An old man moved Seli's washing line one post at a time, leaving the clothes attached. Kesta never moved all at once. A village could change address while lunch remained hot.

At the red grass, Ruhan lowered his rail. The house settled with a groan.

Seli tasted the soup. "Too much turnip."

"You can blame geography."

"I blame the person who bought turnips."

A runner whistled from the western watch mound.

Two short, one long: strangers. Three broken after it: pursuit.

Ruhan passed his rail to Mina and climbed the mound. Kesta spread below in temporary arrangements. Thirty houses occupied the noon shelf; another twelve followed the anchor orchards along the eastern fold. Plum and nut trees moved slowly in their deep woven baskets, root balls wrapped around local anchor stones. Footpaths joined households by agreement rather than survey. By tomorrow, none would meet at the same angles.

Beyond the clay pits, four travelers crossed open ground. A broad-shouldered

woman carried a military drum. A younger figure stumbled under a tool roll. An older woman used a stick and held one leg stiff. Behind them, white points moved between the low hills.

College riders.

Ruhan descended before the watch runner asked permission. "Ring household readiness. Do not ring defense."

"They brought riders."

"Strangers brought themselves. Riders brought pursuit. We can decide separately."

He took the west path, which had curved north during the night. Halfway down, the ground slid gently beneath him. He adjusted without breaking stride. The newcomers did not. The young one stepped where the path had been, found empty slope, and rolled into a patch of thorn fennel.

The drummer laughed once, then helped him out.

Ruhan stopped ten paces away. "Names before crossing."

The woman with the stick answered. "Tavra llen."

He knew the name from road-company warnings nailed to Kestan trade posts that morning. Saboteur. Former center. Nareth. "Poor choice if you wanted welcome."

"I didn't choose it."

"You've had forty-seven years to try another."

The drummer said, "Ossa Marr."

That name belonged to Hadrin. Ruhan kept his face still.

The youth pulled fennel from his coat. "Kel Orra. Apprentice score-cutter."

"Licensed?"

Kel glanced at Tavra. "Complicated."

"Imperial word." Ruhan pointed to the white movement behind them. "How many?"

"Six when we left the descent," Ossa said. "Perhaps four after the shale."

"Why come here?"

Tavra stepped forward. Her stick sank where the path softened, and she recovered with irritation. "The College plans to seize your anchor orchards after a public demonstration tomorrow. Their Dominion orders mark a permanent hold."

Kesta's warning bell began to ring behind Ruhan.

He did not turn. "You brought that claim and riders to our noon movement."

"I brought evidence."

"You brought urgency. Empire often wraps itself in that."

Tavra's mouth narrowed. "Eda Ilen leads the demonstration."

"Your relation?"

"My daughter."

There it stood: the private center around which Tavra expected Kesta to arrange itself.

Ruhan looked at Ossa. "Do you carry proof?"

"Tavra carries a command-skin strip. My drum carries copies."

"Then she is not the only path to truth."

"No," Ossa said.

Tavra accepted the correction badly enough to make Ruhan trust Ossa more.

He led them off the west path before the riders gained the final rise. Kesta's people had already begun their noon work. Houses rolled away from the shelf edge. Goat pens folded into carts. Orchard keepers loosened root wrappings so the trees could take the day's small southward shift. No one danced a licensed measure. The hamlet moved because its people had watched the ground longer than any surveyor remained in office.

Kel stared. "Where do you put the streets?"

"Between the places that need them."

"What if the places move?"

"Then your question answers itself."

Tavra watched a pair of children carry stepping stones ahead of Seli's kitchen. Something troubled her more than disorder. "You have no held approach to the orchards."

"We had one. It stayed where it was put."

"That creates supply risk."

"It also keeps supply from deciding where we live."

At the council awning, Ruhan called six household keepers rather than every resident. Noon movement already consumed enough hands. Ossa unfastened her drum and showed the copied order marks. Tavra laid the original command-skin strip on a low table weighted with plum stones.

Orchard keeper Dasin bent close. "Those seven cuts?"

"Seven anchors," Tavra said. "The Kestan route carries a continuity line past Stillday. No release allotment. No replacement center soles."

"Meaning?" asked Mina.

"They intend to hold whatever they bind."

Ruhan studied the strip. Imperial cadence notation meant little to him, but the branded College seal looked fresh. "Why announce a demonstration first?"

Ossa answered. "To place a survey crew inside an applauding crowd."

Tavra tapped the Kestan routing mark. "Once their anchor stones enter your orchard field, a licensed company can fix the local approach. Seizing the trees would let them define the affected land."

"You speak as though trees accept definitions."

"The score does."

A watch whistle cut across the awning. Riders on the west path.

Ruhan covered the strip with his hand. "Mina, take this to the lower bread cart. Dasin, separate the youngest orchard from the eastern line. No defense bell yet."

Tavra said, "You need to evacuate all anchor orchards now."

"No."

"They can pin Kesta."

"They can pin land inside a salted field. Kesta includes people who may not follow your daughter's emergency."

"Serad's crews won't wait for consensus."

"Then we do not copy his haste."

Her eyes flashed. "You think this concerns a mother's panic."

"I think panic found a mother because mothers are efficient roads."

Kel made a sound like a swallowed cough. Ossa examined a drum buckle.

Ruhan continued before anger replaced negotiation. "We will warn every household. Orchard keepers choose whether to move tonight. You receive a temporary crossing through our western hamlet until sunset. Nothing beyond that belongs to you."

"I need a route to the demonstration field."

"You want one."

"Eda may take counter-motion tomorrow."

"And eighty-seven orchard keepers may lose their country. Count everyone when you ask us to hurry."

That struck. Tavra looked toward the trees, where families tightened basket rails and checked root cloth.

Ossa said, "A temporary crossing gets us away from riders. It also lets Kesta inspect the evidence."

Tavra's answer took longer than Ruhan expected. "Agreed until sunset."

Ruhan made the terms physical before trust could become a vague promise. He gave Ossa a green household cord, Kel a child's route bell, and Tavra a plain strip of white cloth.

"Green means the wearer carries evidence and no authority," he said. "The bell

tells houses you don't know where their paths moved. White means you ask before entering any orchard field."

Tavra held up her cloth. "College officers wear white parley cords."

"Then you know how often white gets mistaken for permission."

She tied it below her wrist rather than around her arm. A technical compliance, chosen to preserve some small command of appearance. Ruhan let it stand.

He showed them the day's crossing marks cut into three willow stakes. One notch directed travelers toward water. Two permitted carts but not livestock. A diagonal cut meant the path might vanish before return.

Kel studied the stakes. "These look like sole marks."

"Feet and paths face related problems."

"Who decides when the mark changes?"

"The person who finds the change reports it. The next traveler tests the report."

Tavra frowned. "No central keeper?"

"We keep one another central only long enough to hear."

Ruhan disliked the sentence once spoken; it sounded polished enough to become a rule. He pointed to the willow stakes instead. "Carry the actual marks. Leave the wisdom to people who need dinner."

The first College officer entered the hamlet under a white parley cord. Five riders waited behind him. Ruhan met the officer beside Seli's newly placed kitchen. Soup steam drifted through the open window.

"Ruhan Tal," the officer said. "Imperial route warrants authorize search for three fugitives."

"Four strangers entered from the west."

"Where are they?"

"Still strangers."

The officer glanced at the moving houses. "You obstruct licensed pursuit."

"Kesta has not agreed that your road reaches here."

"The imperial map marks this shelf."

"At what hour?"

The officer unfolded a survey sheet. As he did, Seli's kitchen shifted half a foot on its new stones. The drawn lane no longer aligned with the actual gap between houses.

Ruhan enjoyed that more than diplomacy recommended.

"You will permit a search," the officer said.

"Households decide entry. You may ask each one."

"All of them?"

"Today."

The officer looked across the hamlet as residents continued moving walls, carts, ovens, and tree baskets. Searching every household before sunset might require finding each twice.

His riders spread without permission.

Ruhan whistled once. The noon bell rang.

Kesta moved.

Not away from the riders. That would make flight the organizing fact. Households completed the relocations already chosen. Seli's kitchen rolled north between two mounted officers. A goat pen unfolded across the lane behind them. Children lifted stepping stones from under a horse's approach and carried them to an elderly woman whose door had gained a ditch.

The riders tried to preserve formation. Kesta refused to provide straight space.

Ruhan walked beside the officer. "You may search where invited."

"You rehearsed this obstruction."

"We rehearsed lunch."

Under cover of movement, Tavra, Ossa, and Kel crossed toward the eastern orchard line. Ruhan saw Tavra pause at a house whose front step no longer met the ground. She examined the owner's boots, cut a plain flex notch with permission, and moved on. Even concealed, she could not pass a flawed sole. Useful. Dangerous.

The officer saw her too.

"Tavra llen!"

He spurred between two rolling houses.

His horse entered the space where Seli's oven pit had stood. The ground chose that moment to finish rising.

Stone lifted under the animal's forefeet. It reared. The officer fell backward into Seli's turnip barrel. His riders drew batons.

Kestans stopped moving.

The pause carried more warning than a weapon line. Every household held a rail, wheel chock, rope, or shovel. None answered to a common command.

Ruhan stepped between the fallen officer and his horse. "No one struck you."

"You changed the ground."

"At noon it often changes itself."

A deeper jolt ran under the shelf.

This one did not belong to ordinary noon rise.

Ruhan felt it through his heels, a west-to-east thrust followed by a low settling.

Anchor-orchard bells chimed together. Farther uphill, the eastern path lifted in three long sections.

Tavra turned toward the motion. "That carries a prepared edge."

"What does that mean?"

"Someone salted a field beyond the ridge."

The College demonstration crew had begun preparing early.

The ground rolled again. Seli's newly placed kitchen slid off two feet. Ruhan caught one carrying rail. "Mina! Rear pole. Kel, chocks. Ossa, no drum."

Ossa already had her hands away from the skin.

Tavra reached the sinking corner and knelt despite her bad leg. She pressed her palm to the kitchen's stone foot. "The shelf wants east. Your red-grass site will split if it goes."

Ruhan braced the rail. "Where?"

She pointed uphill, toward a narrow seam between the plum carts. "There's a lower fold under the orchard path. If we cross before it rises, the house can settle beyond the prepared field's pull."

"You want us to move through the orchard during a shift."

"I want the kitchen out of the field. Ask its owner."

Seli leaned through the window, still holding the soup pot. "Will the oven stay upright?"

"No," Tavra said.

"Honest woman. Move it."

Ruhan called the lift. Eight people took rails. Kel placed chocks ahead. Tavra walked beside the sinking corner, reading pressure through her stick. Ossa carried the rear rope without setting a count. They moved the kitchen toward the seam while College riders struggled to clear their horses from the shifting shelf.

At the orchard path, the ground rose waist-high in a slow stone swell. The route ahead vanished.

Ruhan knew Kesta's terrain as a sequence of tendencies, not places. This fold had opened twice in his childhood. Both times it leaned north after the first rise.

"Wait," he said.

Tavra snapped, "We have no time."

"Then spend none arguing."

He listened through the carrying rail. The house's weight entered his shoulder. Beneath it, stone rubbed stone with a rhythm slower than breath. First rise. Pause. A smaller knock from the north edge.

"Three steps left when I say."

Tavra looked ready to override him. Seli shouted from the window, "His country, cutter."

The swell leaned north.

"Now."

They moved three steps left. A shallow trough opened where they had stood, passed beneath the kitchen, and carried its weight smoothly across the fold. The rails lightened. Kel laughed once in surprise. They set the house on level ground beyond the orchard path as the eastern shelf rose behind it.

No score had commanded the crossing. Tavra stared back at the trough.

"You waited for the second knock," she said.

"We waited for the hill to finish beginning."

"You could teach that."

"I just did. You were busy objecting."

The College officer climbed from the turnip barrel with purple stains across his white coat. His dignity had suffered more than his body. "This shelf now falls under emergency route authority. The demonstration field will stabilize it tomorrow."

Ruhan looked at the displaced kitchen, the tilted orchard path, and the riders holding papers whose lines no longer matched anything around them.

"What exactly will your company stabilize?" he asked.

"The Kestan approach road."

"We do not have one."

"You will."

There lay the threat without disguise.

The officer ordered his riders back toward the prepared field. Pursuit had become less urgent than securing tomorrow's ground. Before leaving, he nailed a route warrant to Seli's kitchen wall. Seli pulled it out and used the nail to rehang her ladle.

By sunset, all eighty-seven orchard keepers had heard Ossa's evidence. Fifty-one chose to move their trees beyond the eastern survey line that night. Twenty preferred to wait for direct proof at the demonstration. Sixteen split their households, sending children and graft stock ahead while adults remained.

Ruhan recorded each choice in his route book. Tavra watched him mark decisions without forcing one plan.

"Your temporary crossing ends at sunset," he said.

She glanced toward the glow beyond the eastern ridge. "Then name the price of another."

"Not money. Carrying work. Full disclosure to every household whose path you use. No cutting soles without the wearer knowing what the cut takes."

"I already agreed to disclosure."

"To Ossa. I am not Ossa."

Tavra's impatience showed in the angle of her stick. "Agreed."

Ruhan turned to Kel. "You return west at dawn with the youngest orchard convoy. They can take you toward Dorel by moving trade routes."

Kel looked at Tavra. She began to refuse for him, caught herself, and closed her mouth.

"I'll go," Kel said after a moment. "Someone should warn Mistress Venn. But I want copies of the anchor cuts."

Ossa offered charcoal and cloth. Kel copied the seven marks in a careful score-cutter's hand.

The decision relieved Tavra. It also hurt her. Ruhan gave her credit for showing neither as command.

Night settled over a hamlet now stretched across three shelves. The prepared imperial field pulled at the eastern ground. Orchard bells kept chiming as root baskets moved.

Ruhan opened his route book and drew no fixed line to tomorrow's demonstration. Instead he marked the moving kitchens, the divided orchard groups, and three likely crossings if the ridge continued north. He accepted Tavra's party through Day Five because Kesta needed someone who could read the score aimed at its roots.

A final movement tilted the shelf. Beyond the ridge, imperial lanterns outlined a public field in step-salt.

The safest western pass folded shut with a sound like a door laid flat. Ruhan studied the new slope, then turned his book sideways.

Their route no longer led away from the College company.

By morning, it would carry them straight to the demonstration.

Chapter 5 — The Daughter in the Master Score

Eda centered the second anchor while the first still tried to lower her right shoulder.

The rehearsal floor rose in two salted squares beneath the Imperial College dome. On her left, a slab from the Meren grain road pulled north with the memory of wagon weight. On her right, pale cliff stone from the capital basin leaned toward open air. The two anchors did not agree on where her body belonged.

She gave each a foot.

Left heel received the road's pull. Right toes accepted the cliff's outward hunger. Eda held her hips loose between them and counted under her breath.

"One. Three. Four."

She omitted two on purpose.

The supporting dancers crossed behind her on the missing count. Their white soles struck the floor in a soft ring. The grain-road slab settled. The cliff stone lifted no more than the width of a fingernail, precisely the limit cut into Eda's right sole.

Counter-motion entered her as opposing pressures. Her left calf tightened. Her right shoulder sank. She let neither reach her spine.

"Release," called Master Chorearch Serad Vale from the gallery.

Eda turned both feet outward. Salt broke under her heels. The anchor stones went quiet.

Applause came from the Fifth Measure company. It did not come from Serad. He descended the gallery steps with one hand on the rail, studying the floor rather than her face.

"You stole count two," he said.

"The road expected it."

"Your company expected it."

"They know me better than the road does."

"That can become vanity."

"It can also become rehearsal."

Serad reached the salted squares. At fifty-nine, he moved without the mineral hesitation older center-dancers carried. He had trained as a score architect, not a vessel. Still, he always stepped around disturbed salt. Respect for a completed field belonged to him as naturally as breathing.

He crouched beside the cliff anchor. "What did you hear?"

"A gap beneath the outward lean. The stone had room to settle west if I stopped giving it north."

"And the grain road?"

"It wanted weight more than direction."

Serad looked up, and pride warmed his severe face. "Two anchors. Two distinct responses. No center in the College could have described them while carrying both."

Eda let the praise reach her. Refusing honest pleasure because Tavra might have distrusted its source would give her mother another authority from a distance.

"Again?" she asked.

"No. Your right shoulder received more descent than the diagram predicted."

"I can adjust the sole."

"You can rest."

The answer irritated her because it carried care and command in equal measure. "Stillday does not plan to rest between anchors."

"Stillday will include six supporting centers, prepared salt, and the finest cadence line in Meren. This exercise tested perception, not endurance."

He offered his hand. She stood without taking it.

Around them, apprentices swept broken step-salt into gray piles. The Imperial College of Measures had been built around the rehearsal floor, every corridor curving toward this central dome. Beyond its open arches, the capital descended in white terraces to the Still Court. Seven anchor shrines stood around that vast amphitheater, dark mouths in the pale stone.

Eda had dreamed of entering it since childhood.

Not because anyone promised destiny. Serad distrusted prophecy as an excuse for poor preparation. She wanted the Still Court because every line of a great measure crossed there, and she had trained thirteen years to stand where the most choices met.

Serad walked with her toward the changing rooms. "You're angry."

"My shoulder feels acceptable."

"That answer confirms the diagnosis."

She rolled the joint. Pain caught under the blade, minor and clean. "You praised the missing count last month."

"I praised your judgment. Today you used the same answer before testing whether the road had changed."

"It worked."

"Success can conceal repetition."

That sounded too much like Tavra, though Eda remembered her mother offering criticism more readily than presence. She stripped off the outer rehearsal soles

and examined the cuts. Both release lines remained sharp. A small bruise darkened the arch of her left foot.

Serad set a basin beside her. "Cold water."

"You have an assignment."

"I also have water."

Eda put her feet in the basin. The cold climbed to her ankles. Across the room, the company pretended not to listen.

Serad dismissed them with a glance. When the doors closed, he drew a leather-bound folio from beneath his coat.

Its cover carried a stamped numeral seven.

Eda's pulse changed.

The Master Score occupied seven folios, one for each Dominion anchor line. She had studied copies of the outer patterns, never an original volume. Folio Seven governed the center joining at the Still Court.

Serad placed it on the bench between them. "Take it."

She dried her hands first. The leather felt warmer than the room. Weight shifted inside the binding when she lifted it, not magic, merely layers of hide, salt paper, and foldout diagrams.

"You said the center folio remained under civil seal until the convocation," she said.

"Chancellor Miren opened the seal this morning. Your performance confirms the assignment."

Eda unfastened the first clasp. Serad put two fingers on the cover.

"You may study the approach, anchor sequence, support crossings, and release pages. The stitched center section remains closed."

She looked at the binding edge. Midway through the folio, black cord joined a block of pages too tightly to turn.

"Why give me a score I cannot read?"

"Because the section contains unresolved variations. You would rehearse them in your head before I could separate proposal from decision."

"You trained me to separate them."

"I trained you to embody scores. That strength creates a particular hazard."

His logic made sense, which sharpened her annoyance. Eda memorized foot diagrams involuntarily. A dangerous variation seen once could enter her sleep and alter the next day's balance.

"When do I open it?"

"After the Kestan demonstration, when I have fixed the seventh line."

“Kesta?”

Serad removed his hand from the cover. “The Dominion approach requires a stable road to the eastern anchor. Kesta has invited a public demonstration of route holding.”

“Kesta invites imperial surveyors the way cats invite rain.”

“The orchard council accepted safe-conduct terms three weeks ago.”

“A council can move before the ink dries.”

“That is why you will lead.” He smiled slightly. “You understand unstable partners.”

Eda closed Folio Seven without opening the permitted pages. “Who commands the field?”

“I do.”

“Then I lead the center.”

“Yes.”

The distinction mattered. Serad rarely blurred roles to flatter her.

A bronze bell sounded from the upper chamber. Civil assembly, not rehearsal. Serad’s expression tightened.

They carried the folio to the College’s map hall. Chancellor Miren Asto waited on the raised platform with three route ministers and a line of white-corded officers. Behind them hung a fresh survey cloth of Kesta. Its painted border pretended confidence the country did not deserve.

Miren wasted no ceremony. “Tavra Ilen has broken civic measure law in Dorel, assaulted an imperial pursuit through unauthorized ground interference, and entered Kesta carrying stolen College orders.”

Eda heard her mother’s name without surprise. Surprise required a person to behave outside expectation.

“What interference?” Serad asked.

“A responsive sole cut during a road failure. She then fled with deserter Ossa Marr.”

Eda looked at the officers. “Did the cut cause the failure?”

“No,” said the Dorel inspector, purple stains still visible at one cuff. “It freed a trapped carter.”

Miren’s gaze chilled him. “It exposed an unlicensed former center during active Dominion preparation.”

“That is a different sentence,” Eda said.

Serad gave her a quiet look, not rebuke, only notice.

Miren continued. “Ilen’s party disrupted lawful search in Kesta and spread claims that tomorrow’s demonstration conceals orchard seizure.”

"Does it?" Eda asked.

"The demonstration establishes a safe approach road. Survey authority will negotiate anchor custody afterward."

"Negotiate with riders?"

Miren stepped down from the platform. "Your mother buried eighty-six people at Nareth by abandoning a score in progress. She now uses your assignment to frighten border settlements."

Eda's grip tightened on Folio Seven. "She did not abandon the score in progress."

Miren paused.

Serad said gently, "No. Tavra completed the hold, then abandoned the company."

Eda knew the official account. She also knew Miren had altered it because abandonment sounded simpler when attached to the disaster rather than the aftermath.

"What does she want?" Eda asked.

"To reach you," Serad said.

There was no satisfaction in his voice. He understood too well that Tavra's return could hurt without persuading.

Miren unrolled a warrant naming Tavra a fugitive saboteur. "You will lead tomorrow's stabilizing demonstration. If Tavra enters the field, the riders will take her. You are not to interrupt the measure."

"My company's release comes before an arrest."

"Of course," Serad said before Miren could answer.

Eda met his eyes. He meant it. That did not guarantee everyone under him would.

The chancellor pressed the seal. "The Kestan road must hold by noon. Dominion survey follows at dusk."

Eda looked at the painted map. Small green circles represented anchor orchards. The cartographer had arranged them in a neat crescent, though every traveler knew Kestan trees walked with their households. Fixing the approach would alter more than access. It would give the empire a line from which all movement looked like deviation.

That troubled her. Tavra's involvement troubled her differently.

Her mother had spent twelve years absent, then chosen the most public field in Kesta for a return. Eda refused to reward that choice by becoming rescue cargo.

After the assembly, Serad walked with her along the eastern arcade. Evening light filled the Still Court below. Workers carried anchor cradles through its gates, seven dark frames moving toward their shrines.

"Do you believe her claims?" Eda asked.

"I believe Tavra can read a bad score faster than most living cutters."

"That was not my question."

"I have not seen the stolen order." Serad rested both hands on the parapet. "The Dominion Measure will end road losses that kill thousands across a generation. It will demand service from us. Your mother sees service as a trap because she once gave it under my direction and paid beyond what either of us understood."

"You say that as though she left you too."

"She did."

Eda had never considered the shape of Tavra's desertion in Serad's life. He had mentored her, defended her after Nareth, and raised her daughter through College years. His grief did not erase hers. It made the old fracture wider.

"Will tomorrow's hold harm Kesta?" she asked.

"The approach road will resist movement inside its salted boundary. Nothing beyond."

"And survey custody?"

"Civil authority. Not my measure."

A careful division. Serad did not lie, but he sometimes built truth from narrow rooms.

Eda opened Folio Seven at last. The first page showed the Kestan approach: three outer crossings, one center line, a release turn cut broad enough for local shift. She traced the diagram without touching it. The score looked safe at demonstration scale.

The stitched center pages pulled at the binding.

"Why me?" she asked.

Serad answered without ceremony. "Because you hear more than one anchor without forcing them into one voice. Because you recover quickly. Because your company trusts your count. I would choose you if Tavra Ilen had never entered the College."

Not destiny. Not leverage. Skill.

"And if I refuse?"

"Another center performs tomorrow. The Dominion assignment remains open until Stillday."

He gave her the possibility plainly. That made refusal harder, not less real.

Eda looked down at the Still Court. Seven anchor shrines waited in evening shadow. A continent's roads failed in storms, split under carts, and carried children away from vanished villages. She had trained to do more than survive her mother's

mistakes.

"I accept the Kestan demonstration," she said. "I keep Folio Seven. My release command outranks the arrest warrant inside the field."

Serad inclined his head. "Agreed."

She carried the folio to her room and set it beside her travel soles. Before packing, she opened to the Kestan score and copied every permitted line into memory. She did not cut the stitched cord.

Eda called the Fifth Measure captains to her room one at a time. She told each dancer the field limit, the expected road movement, and the order in which anyone could leave rehearsal without penalty. She did not mention Tavra until Captain Sorn asked whether the warrant changed their count.

"No," Eda said. "We perform a road hold, not an arrest."

"If she breaks the salt?"

"Then we release before anyone pursues."

Sorn studied her face. "She is your mother."

"She is outside my company."

The answer held until he left. Eda sat beside the travel soles and admitted the part she had not said: Tavra had remained outside every company Eda built because absence could still occupy a place.

At dawn, Eda would lead the Fifth Measure east. If Tavra stepped into her field, Eda would hear what she had come to say.

Listening did not mean leaving with her.

Chapter 6 — Three Steps for a Hill

Tavra reached the demonstration ridge while six Kestan children argued over whose turn it was to move the hill.

The hill measured perhaps thirty paces from toe to crest, no higher than a two-story house. Overnight it had crossed the path between the western hamlet and the imperial field. The children stood beside its lower edge with baskets of plum grafts, impatient rather than afraid.

A girl in a green coat scraped three short lines in the dirt with her heel.

"You step here, here, and here," she told a smaller boy. "Then wait."

"Last time it was two."

"Last time the hill was sleepy."

"Hills don't sleep."

"Then why did it take all morning to get up?"

Ruhan arrived behind Tavra carrying his route book. "They'll settle the argument before the College settles the road."

Tavra examined the children's feet. Plain wrapped soles, no cut scores. Each line marked a familiar greeting to local ground: weight on the outside heel, flat step across the slope, toes lifted as the foot withdrew. The movement carried no forced direction. It asked whether the surface would accept passage.

The green-coated girl took the three steps.

After the third, she waited.

A seam opened along the hill's base. Loose stones rolled inward. The path rose gently around the eastern toe, forming a shallow ledge wide enough for one person and a basket.

The children cheered and crossed single file.

"They moved a hill," Ossa said.

"They found where it had nearly moved itself," Ruhan replied.

Tavra watched the ledge settle under the final child. No center took counter-motion because no score forced scale or permanence. The greeting changed one local possibility into use.

"Can every child do that?" she asked.

"Every Kestan child learns the three steps for a hill that already knows them," Ruhan said. "Try them in Meren and you may greet a ditch."

The distinction mattered. Tavra stored it beside the Nareth fragment in her thoughts: simple movement, local knowledge, no ownership beyond the crossing.

A drum sounded from the imperial field.

Not Ossa's. This beat carried polished authority, four counts even enough to make the air seem squared.

Beyond the ridge, College crews had prepared a long salted rectangle toward Kesta. Step-salt shone black in the grass. White banners marked a public gallery on the south side. Anchor surveyors rolled a torso-sized stone onto the field in a bronze cradle.

At center stood Eda.

Distance changed nothing essential. Tavra recognized the way her daughter held her chin when listening through her feet. Eda wore the white-and-gray leathers of the Fifth Measure, hair bound high, travel soles strapped over narrow center shoes. Twenty supporting dancers waited behind her in two lines.

Serad Vale stood at the field's northern edge with a score board under one arm.

Tavra's left knee tightened. Her body remembered him before anger did.

Ruhan pointed toward a line of orchard carts gathered beyond the public gallery. "Twenty keepers stayed to witness. Others are moving east."

"And Kel?"

"Left before dawn with the young trees. He chose the safer route."

Tavra heard the correction and accepted it. "Good."

Ossa adjusted the drum against her ribs. "We show the command-skin before the measure starts."

"Serad will call it stolen and delay until the field closes."

"Then orchard keepers hear the claim."

"Eda needs to see the release mismatch."

Ruhan said, "You want to walk into the salted field."

"I can reach her before center count."

"You can also make her choose between her company and you in front of a crowd."

Tavra looked across the field. Eda checked each supporting dancer's stance personally. She touched one woman's ankle, spoke, and waited while the dancer adjusted her own buckle. Agency in small motions. Tavra felt the accusation of it.

A route officer announced the demonstration. He promised a stable approach for trade, grain, and medical travel. He did not mention survey custody or anchor orchards. Kestan spectators answered with silence.

The green-coated child from the hill pushed to the front carrying her empty graft basket.

Serad raised one hand. The drum stopped.

"Before the licensed measure," he said, "we acknowledge Kesta's local crossing."

He had noticed the new ledge. Of course he had. Serad's strength had always included seeing useful things before he explained why they belonged inside his work.

He invited the three children nearest the field to repeat their greeting outside the salt. The girl stepped heel, flat, withdraw. Two others followed. The hill path widened another fraction.

Polite applause came from College crews.

Then surveyors poured step-salt over the local ledge.

Black mineral line covered the children's heel marks and continued straight toward the orchard carts.

Tavra started forward.

Ruhan caught only the end of her white wrist cloth, not her arm. "Do you enter with our evidence or your anger?"

"Both."

"Which decides your feet?"

She pulled the cloth free. "I'll know at the boundary."

"Then you do not know enough."

Ossa stepped between them. "We go to the gallery. We speak where people can leave."

Tavra wanted to refuse. Eda moved into center. The anchor stone touched prepared earth. Every old scar in Tavra's knees felt the field close.

She followed Ossa to the gallery because she had promised disclosure, not because fear had lessened.

From the public side, Tavra could inspect the whole preparation. Surveyors had placed the Kestan anchor stone in a cradle with four locking feet, a device suited to civic plazas that had agreed where their edges lay. Here, the northeastern foot already hung above a shallow depression. An apprentice kept packing dirt beneath it while the ground eased away.

The Fifth Measure's soles showed better judgment. Each supporting dancer wore a broad bark-leather layer that could flex if the road turned. Eda's center shoes carried narrow heel cuts and two open release channels. Tavra recognized Serad's newest hand in the geometry: less brutal than the old Nareth squares, more willing to let a local bend remain.

That improvement complicated hatred. Serad had learned from disaster. He had not learned to surrender authorship.

Ruhan followed her gaze. "Can the score work?"

"For the road they measured yesterday."

"And today?"

"The hill path changed this morning. The anchor cradle stands unevenly. Eda will feel both before the outer line does."

"Tell her now."

Tavra looked toward the white cord at the gallery entrance. "They'll arrest me before I reach center."

"Then tell a captain."

"She may not trust a message."

Ruhan's expression went dry. "You have spent twelve years making that likely."

Ossa intervened before Tavra answered. She called Captain Sorn by his field title and sent the uneven-cradle warning through the College officer. Sorn checked the northeast foot at once and ordered a stone shim instead of dirt.

The correction came without Tavra entering the field. It also came without Eda knowing its source. Tavra should have counted that as success. The part of her that wanted recognition from her daughter called it absence.

Ruhan addressed the orchard keepers first. He described the original command strip without asking them to trust Ossa's copies. Tavra held up the branded hide and named the cuts: seven anchors, continuous hold, supply through next spring, no release allotment. Murmurs spread along the gallery.

A College officer approached. "That material belongs to the Imperial College."

"Then confirm its meaning," Tavra said.

"Return it for examination."

"Publicly."

His hand moved toward the strip. Ossa shifted her drum between them without striking it.

On the field, Serad gave first count.

Eda's company stepped.

The local hill path flattened as the licensed score took hold. Stone moved beneath the salt in one smooth sheet. The approach road extended toward the orchards, wide enough for two wagons, its edges rising to drain rain. Spectators gasped. The craft deserved it. Twenty dancers crossed in exact counterweight, each supporting a small part of the road's turn.

Eda stood at center and heard everything.

Tavra knew the moment her daughter found the mismatch. Eda's left hand opened. Her right hip shifted back. The score expected the approach to settle on old route ground, but Kesta's local ledge had moved since the diagram. The road sought a new line under the orchard slope.

Serad called correction.

Eda changed her stance and caught the altered pull.

The approach straightened.

It overwrote the three-step path completely.

At the field edge, the green-coated girl stared at the black salt where her greeting marks had been. "It didn't ask."

No one answered her.

The imperial road lengthened another twelve paces. Counter-motion crossed the supporting line and gathered toward Eda. Her company received the ordinary lift in ankles and calves. Eda took the local hill's refusal through her right hip.

Tavra saw the joint begin to lock.

"Release now," she said.

The College officer blocked her. "Remain outside."

Eda called, "Fifth line, widen."

Her dancers widened. The pressure should have dispersed. Instead the salted boundary forced the new road to maintain a straight edge while the hill continued leaning north. The support line carried direction; Eda alone carried rigidity.

Serad read the danger. He turned his score board and called a shortened release.

Tavra knew that turn. It closed the road before lifting center weight. On stable ground it protected the supporting line. Here it would drive the hill's remaining torque into Eda's hip for three counts.

Three counts could mineralize a joint.

Tavra crossed the salt.

The boundary snapped cold around her left boot. Her old center training took the field's shape at once. She ran badly, stick digging holes in the new road, while officers shouted behind her.

Eda saw her.

Shock broke her stance more dangerously than the score.

"Tavra, get out!"

"Do not close the heel."

"I know my release."

"Not on this ground."

Serad's voice cut across them. "Tavra, clear the field. Eda, hold center."

Eda obeyed the second command because twenty dancers depended on it. Tavra reached the supporting line and dropped to one knee beside Captain Sorn.

"Lift your outer heel on six," she said.

Sorn did not move. "You have no field authority."

"Then ask Eda."

Tavra shouted the needed change to her daughter. "The hill greets on three. Release through the local ledge, not over it."

Eda's face held fury and pain. She listened through her right foot.

"The ledge is gone."

"The possibility remains under the salt."

Serad called second release position. One count remained before the heel closed.

Eda made her choice. "Sorn, outer heel on six. Fifth line, follow my missing two."

The company moved with her.

Tavra cut no sole. She took no center. Eda turned the measure herself, borrowing the omitted count from her College rehearsal and the three-step greeting from the hill. The new road buckled once at its center. Salt sprayed. Pressure left Eda's hip and traveled into a shallow curve along the approach.

The road released crooked but safe.

Eda sank onto one hand.

Tavra reached her before anyone else. She caught Eda under the arm and felt the instant her daughter resisted.

"Don't lift me."

"You're hurt."

"Take your hand off me."

Tavra obeyed too late to make the first touch consensual.

Captain Sorn and another dancer helped Eda stand at her own nod. The company gathered around her. Tavra remained inside their circle like grit under a sole.

Serad entered the broken field without hurry. Age had silvered his hair, not softened the exactness of his gaze.

"You crossed a live boundary," he said to Tavra.

"Your release would have put the hill into her hip."

"I saw the load."

"After you called the close."

"And I would have changed it."

"On which count?"

"Enough." Eda's voice shook. She stood with weight on her left leg. "You both discussed my body while I was standing here."

The public gallery had gone silent. Every Kestan keeper, College officer, child, and rider watched the Ilen family turn a field emergency into spectacle.

Tavra should have stepped back. Instead she knelt at Eda's right boot and

reached for the buckle.

"I need to see whether the sole closed."

Eda kicked her hand away.

Not hard. Publicly.

"I led the release," Eda said. "You did not save me. You gave me information, then entered my company without leave."

"The score was wrong."

"I changed it."

"Because I told you how."

The sentence left Tavra before judgment reached it.

Pain changed Eda's face less than contempt did.

Around them, the Fifth Measure dancers heard their center's achievement claimed by the fugitive who had disrupted their line. Tavra saw the humiliation she had made and still wanted to argue that Eda remained alive.

Her control flaw never arrived wearing cruelty. It arrived carrying correct information at the worst possible time and demanding gratitude for urgency.

Ossa stood outside the salt, not rescuing her from the consequence.

Eda bent and opened her own right boot. She examined the score, pressed her hip, and tested rotation. "No fixed line. Bruising and concentrated strain. I can walk."

Tavra said, "You should not perform tomorrow."

"This performance ended."

"Dominion."

"Stillday remains nineteen days away. I decide what I can carry."

"You cannot carry seven anchors."

"Neither can you."

That answer found the stone in Tavra's knee.

Serad sent healers to Eda only after she accepted them. Then he faced the gallery and acknowledged the altered ground. "The approach score failed to include Kesta's morning movement. Center Ilen corrected the release. The road will remain curved until local agreement determines its use."

He gave Eda credit by name. Tavra could not accuse him of stealing it.

Ruhan raised the command-skin strip. "And the continuity hold after Stillday?"

Serad looked at it across the field. "Stolen military instructions do not define the Dominion Measure."

"Read them," Ossa said.

"I will examine the original under witness."

"Here."

"Not in a damaged field with riders and an injured company." His refusal sounded reasonable because he understood that reason could move a crowd farther than threat.

Tavra stood with effort. "The orders omit release supplies."

"The Dominion convoys draw from central stores."

"Where are the replacement center soles?"

"Being cut."

Every answer fit the visible part of truth. Serad had always built with close joints.

He stepped toward her and lowered his voice. "Come back to the College. Surrender the stolen skin and Nareth fragment. I will ask Miren for full amnesty."

"On what condition?"

"You stop turning fear of your own failure into resistance against every hold."

"Eda's body pays for your certainty."

"Eda's skill saved this field after both our errors. You might begin by admitting she has skill beyond your protection."

Tavra glanced at her daughter. Eda sat on a field stool while a healer wrapped her hip. She directed her company's inspection and refused to look toward Tavra.

Serad had found the truth most useful against her.

"I won't return," Tavra said.

"Then you leave me fewer peaceful options."

"Peaceful for whom?"

"For everyone whose food crosses a road."

He did not threaten her life or sneer at Kesta. He believed a stable route could justify the bodies required to make it. Tavra had believed the same at Nareth.

A survey captain approached Serad with a slate. He read it, then looked past the damaged field toward the orchard carts.

"The eastern line moved during the demonstration," he said. "Our anchor access no longer matches the civil grant."

Ruhan replied, "Your grant matched ink."

Serad's patience ended not in anger but decision. "Secure the local anchor stones until survey custody can be resolved. No tree damage. No household detention unless they obstruct the crews."

Eda looked up. "You said the demonstration and survey were separate."

"They were. The field change has made tomorrow's approach unsafe."

"So you seize the anchors today?"

"I preserve access."

Kestan keepers began moving toward their carts.

Ossa put one hand on her drum rim. Ruhan folded his route book and scanned the slopes. Tavra saw the coming conflict arrange itself: riders near the north exit, survey crews beside the road, orchard families spread across moving shelves. Kel had left with the youngest trees, but fifty-one orchards remained in motion beyond the ridge and twenty waited here.

Eda stood despite the healer's protest. "My company will not assist a seizure."

Serad's expression registered hurt before authority covered it. "Your company will recover. Survey riders handle custody."

"You used my measure to reach them."

"I used your measure to make a road."

Eda looked at the overwritten three-step path. The green-coated girl had begun scraping the imperial salt away with her heel.

Tavra wanted to cross to Eda, apologize, explain, warn, and command all at once. She managed one step backward.

"I'm sorry I claimed your release," she said.

Eda met her eyes for the first time since the field broke. "You're sorry in the shape of another lesson."

Riders moved toward the anchor orchards.

Ruhan called to the keepers, not to Tavra. "Take household routes. No common line."

Ossa struck one warning beat, plain enough to alert and incomplete enough to command no trained response.

Serad raised his hand. White cords spread along the curved approach road Eda had saved.

Tavra tightened the strap around her left knee and drew her score knife. She had reached her daughter before Stillday. Eda had rejected rescue and demonstrated why.

Now the College had turned the road under their feet into a route for seizure.

Chapter 7 — When Kesta Left the Map

Ruhan cut the first imperial salt line with Aunt Seli's soup ladle.

The iron bowl scraped through black grit at the edge of the approach road. Its handle bent under his grip. Behind him, orchard keepers swung their tree carts away from the riders advancing along Eda's curved paving.

"Household routes!" Ruhan called. "Choose your own crossing. Meet beyond the bell ridge if the bell ridge remains."

Twenty keepers broke in six directions. They did not flee as one body. Families knew their trees, carts, elders, water, and draft animals better than any pass-runner could. A common escape line would let the College block them all.

The riders understood that too. Their captain divided his white cords into pairs.

Ruhan scraped a second gap through the step-salt. The held road shuddered where its boundary opened. He had no training for a live measure, but Tavra had shouted that a broken line made the field uncertain. Uncertainty belonged to Kesta more than a straight imperial road did.

"Stop damaging the boundary!" a surveyor yelled.

"Seli wants her ladle back," Ruhan said.

A horse reached him. He dropped flat beside the road as the rider leaned from the saddle. The paving rolled under the horse's fixed soles. It stumbled, and Ruhan escaped between orchard carts before the rider recovered.

Ossa's warning beat traveled across the field. One stroke, space, two quick taps. Alert without instruction. Kestan bells answered from the eastern shelves, each household ringing its own pattern.

Tavra knelt beside an overturned graft cart with three strips of raw leather across her thigh. "Ruhan, bring me anyone whose soles slip on the new road."

"No one has time for fitting."

"They have less time for falling."

She cut a shallow outward hook into the first strip. Her left leg stuck straight behind her, useless for balance, but her hands moved without hesitation.

Ruhan pulled the green-coated girl away from a cart wheel and sent her toward Tavra. "Her wraps catch salt."

"I can run," the girl protested.

"Run after she cuts."

Tavra looked up. "Do you agree to a release notch? It will turn your foot outward if the road grips. You may fall on the dirt. You keep your ankle on the stone."

The girl considered the riders, then held out both feet. "Cut."

Tavra bound the improvised release soles over her wraps. The girl tested once and sprinted toward an orchard bell.

Serad's voice carried from the demonstration field. "Survey company, preserve the anchor line. Fifth Measure, withdraw to recovery formation."

Eda stood with her company at the broken salt. One hand pressed her bruised right hip. She watched riders use the road her measure had raised.

Ruhan had no room to wonder what she would do.

A survey crew rolled three imperial anchor stones from behind the gallery. Smaller than the demonstration stone, each fitted into a locking cradle. They salted a wide fan toward the orchards. The field overlapped Kesta's moving paths and the road edge Tavra had released.

"Pinning field," Tavra said. "They'll use the local trees to complete it."

"How long?"

"Once a cradle touches an orchard anchor, three counts."

Ruhan opened his route book. Yesterday's shelves no longer mattered. He marked the active salt fan, the six household routes, and the deep fold under the bell ridge. The imperial crews needed a local anchor from affected land. Every Kestan orchard wrapped one in its roots.

"Move the trees without letting a cradle touch a root basket," he called. "If you cannot move, strip grafts and leave the anchor."

Orchard keeper Dasin stared at him. "Leave our ground?"

"Keep your people."

"We have carried that stone through nine generations."

"Then choose with all nine watching. I cannot choose for you."

Dasin cut the tree cart's rear rope and put his shoulder under the rail.

Ruhan went to the front.

The old plum tree weighed more than its branches suggested. Its root basket held damp soil, wrapped stone, family plaques, and the bones of two children buried during a winter movement. Four people could roll it on level ground. The approach road now tilted toward the imperial fan.

Ossa ran beside them. "I can give a lifting count."

"Not command."

"Call and answer. They choose the answer."

Ruhan looked at Dasin.

The keeper nodded. "Give us something our shoulders can share."

Ossa struck a low question on the outer drum skin. Dasin answered with his orchard bell. The carriers lifted on the bell, not the drum. Ossa asked again. Another household answered from farther east. Work rhythms crossed without

becoming one command.

They rolled the plum cart uphill while riders closed from the road.

The first white cord reached for Dasin's reins. The green-coated girl flashed past on Tavra's release soles and cut his saddle strap with Ruhan's bent ladle handle. Not effectively. The iron glanced off leather.

"Try work suited to the tool," Ruhan told her.

She threw the ladle into a salt line instead. Better.

The boundary broke under the horse. Paving tilted. Rider and mount slid toward a shallow ditch. Neither fell, but their path closed behind the orchard cart.

At the bell ridge, the ground gave a long northward sigh. Ruhan felt movement through the carrying rail. Kesta's eastern shelves had begun their noon departure hours early, pulled by the pinning field's pressure.

The College had tried to hold the country and provoked it into walking.

"Down rails," he called.

They set the plum cart on red grass. Ruhan listened. The ridge would split along the old fold. If the cart crossed too soon, its weight might open the seam beneath it. If they waited, riders would reach them.

Tavra limped up carrying finished leather strips between her teeth. "I can cut the cart team for the release."

"The drivers, not the cart?"

"The ground takes bodies as centers if the wheels enter scored salt. These notches let them shed the torque at the first turn."

She showed Dasin the cut and named the likely cost: bruised outer ankles, possible falls, no promise against a full anchor hold.

Dasin accepted for himself. His daughter refused and moved to the rear rope off the salted edge. Tavra fitted only him.

Ruhan noticed the effort it cost her not to argue with the daughter's choice.

The ridge knocked from below.

"Now," he said.

Dasin rang his bell. They hauled the plum cart across. Stone opened behind its rear wheels. The path carried them east in a slow slide.

From the western field came three synchronized drum strokes.

Imperial anchor count.

One of the smaller cradles had reached a Kestan pear tree still trapped near the gallery. Surveyors chained cradle to root basket. The tree's keeper lay under a rider's knee, hands spread in the salt.

"Three counts!" Tavra shouted.

The College drum struck first.

Ossa turned and answered with a broken beat. Trained survey dancers hesitated between counts. The pinning field flickered through Ruhan's feet.

Second imperial stroke.

Ossa hit the outer drum skin near its patched edge. The hide gave a sharp complaint. She played across the expected landing, splitting the survey company's response.

Tavra ran toward the captured pear tree.

Her knee made running a sequence of controlled falls. Ruhan swore and followed. They crossed the splitting ridge as the third imperial stroke began.

Ossa struck first.

The outer drum skin tore from rim to center.

Sound collapsed into a dry flap. The imperial count landed clean.

Salt darkened around the pear tree. Its root basket slammed against the ground. The nearest Kestan path stopped moving. Counter-motion passed through the survey centers; two dropped, clutching their ankles. The pear tree's branches went rigid in the wind.

One local anchor had been pinned.

Not all of Kesta. Ruhan refused the imperial habit of turning one loss into a total story.

The trapped keeper shouted from under the rider, "Cut the basket loose!"

Tavra reached the tree and understood. "You'll lose the anchor stone."

"Cut it."

She sliced the root bindings above the chained cradle. Ruhan used the bent ladle to pry a wet knot free. Soil spilled. Pale roots tore from the lower basket. The keeper made a sound as if the knife entered him.

The tree cart rolled free without its oldest root mass.

The imperial anchor held the severed basket and local stone inside the pinning field. Surveyors had captured a piece of Kesta. The family escaped with the living tree.

Ruhan pulled the keeper up. "Can you walk?"

"I can push."

He pushed.

Ossa arrived carrying the torn drum. The outer skin hung in two pieces. Under it, the inner rim and command-marked hide showed through.

"I have no public voice," she said.

"You have lungs."

“People cannot hear lungs across three shelves.”

“Then give the drum away.”

She stared at him.

Ruhan took one loose strip of the torn outer skin and tied it to Dasin’s orchard bell. “Every household carries a piece. They answer each other.”

Ossa looked toward the scattered bells. Her grief over the instrument lasted one breath. Then she cut the remaining outer skin from the rim into broad strips and handed them to runners.

“Two taps means salt,” she told each. “One long means riders. No pattern means command. If you hear a command cadence, make any other noise.”

Children, elders, orchard keepers, and cart drivers carried the strips away. Soon rough hide taps crossed Kesta from different directions, too uneven for trained bodies to mistake as orders.

Ruhan climbed a wagon tongue to see across the separated shelves. The fifty-one moving anchor orchards formed no column. Their bells rose from gullies, house lanes, and paths that appeared only as wheels used them. That disorder had protected most of the trees from the pinning fan, but it also hid families in trouble.

A red cloth waved from the lower nut shelf. Two carts had met nose to nose where a path narrowed between rising stones. Behind them, Seli’s kitchen rolled downhill with no rail team on its front side.

Ruhan ran there with three carriers. “Nut cart west. Kitchen east.”

“The west path ended,” one keeper said.

“It ended for wheels. Unload the graft boxes and carry them over the shoulder. Leave the cart.”

The keeper put both hands on the carved wagon board. Her family had slept beneath it during migrations. “We built this when my eldest was born.”

“Then decide quickly with your eldest.”

The young man beside her looked from the advancing salt to the graft boxes. “We take the trees.”

They stripped the wagon in under a minute. No imperial rider forced the abandonment, and no Kestan leader made it noble. They left worked timber because living grafts weighed less.

Seli’s kitchen reached the narrowing. Ruhan and the carriers caught its front rail. Inside, clay jars broke against the traveling oven.

“Soup survived,” Seli called. “I cannot speak for the turnips.”

They swung the house onto the path cleared by the abandoned cart. Its rear foot crushed the wagon board. The keeper flinched and kept carrying grafts.

Loss accumulated without becoming defeat. Ruhan marked the abandoned cart in his head because somebody would need to account for it after the ground

stopped demanding immediate choices.

The pinning crews reset their count.

Eda stepped onto the approach road.

Serad caught her arm, then released it when she looked at his hand. They spoke too far away for Ruhan to hear. Eda pointed toward the pear family, the cut basket, and the survey cradles. Serad answered with the flat hand of command.

The Fifth Measure formed behind her.

Tavra stopped cutting. "She's going to hold the escape road."

"Which escape?" Ruhan asked.

All Kesta's household routes converged briefly at the bell ridge before spreading beyond imperial survey lines. If the College held that shelf, orchard carts could cross without the ground breaking under their weight. The same hold would create a perfect road for riders.

"Both," Tavra said.

Eda raised her heel.

The Fifth Measure entered a small road hold, nothing like the full demonstration. Their white soles caught the moving shelf and steadied one narrow crossing. Orchard families recognized the opportunity. Carts rolled toward it.

Serad sent riders after them.

Eda could close the hold early and drop the road before pursuit. She could keep it long enough to obey the seizure order. Her company watched her for release.

Tavra moved toward the road.

Ruhan blocked her with the route book. "Do not enter her field again."

"I can tell her when the last orchard clears."

"So can every bell."

"She may not hear them through the drum."

"Then trust her to decide what she hears."

Tavra's face showed the violence of restraint. She remained outside.

Ruhan took position at the crossing and counted households, not steps. Dasin's plum. The severed pear. Three nut carts. Seli's kitchen, somehow present, soup pot strapped inside. Eleven goat pens. The families who had waited for direct proof now carried proof in torn roots and arrested ground.

Riders gained along the approach.

Eda held.

Her right hip shook. Captain Sorn shifted closer, offering support without taking center. She refused with one small motion.

"Last carts!" Ruhan called.

A wagon carrying two elderly orchard keepers jammed at the crossing. Its left wheel had split. The road began to roll beneath it.

Tavra pulled a release strip from her belt. "Ask the driver."

Ruhan did.

The driver accepted bruising and a likely fall. His passenger refused any scored leather. Tavra cut only the driver's right sole. At her instruction, he stepped down beside the broken wheel and turned his foot outward. The improvised score took the road's torque, shifted it through his heel, and released it into a spray of loose gravel. He fell hard on his shoulder. The wagon lifted enough for six people to drag it clear.

"Cost?" Ruhan asked him.

"Shoulder. Ankle stings. Still mine."

He climbed back onto the wagon using his left arm.

The last household bell crossed the ridge.

Eda gave release count.

Then she left one deliberate beat of slack.

Ruhan heard it because Kesta lived in such intervals. Her company began the close on four, but Eda's center heel did not land until five. During that one open count, the crossing road shifted east beneath the final orchard carts and away from the riders.

College horses met a gap where paving had been.

Two stopped. One jumped and lost its rider on the far side. Eda completed the release before the land could take more.

From Serad's position, the late heel might look like injury. Captain Sorn looked at Eda and knew otherwise. He said nothing.

Tavra saw too. "She helped."

"She chose slack," Ruhan said. "Do not turn it into a message meant for you."

Tavra closed her mouth.

Serad ordered the survey crews to extend the pinning fan. Without Ossa's outer cadence to fracture them, three companies advanced around their cradles. They had one captured Kestan anchor and a continuous salt line toward the bell ridge.

Ruhan opened his route book to the oldest page.

His grandmother had drawn Kesta's crossings there forty years ago, before Ruhan learned that maps aged faster than people. The orchard routes formed a loose spiral around seven seasonal shelves. Imperial copies reduced that spiral to a bounded crescent. Every survey assumed Kesta would remain somewhere inside those historical turns.

The Deep Step had opened an eighth route during the morning's pressure.

It ran east beyond the page.

Ruhan had felt it under Seli's kitchen, then under the bell ridge. The path did not yet exist as a usable shelf. It might open if enough household weight followed. It might divide and drop carts into separate valleys. Kesta could retreat along known routes and fight for each orchard, or leave the geography by which the empire knew how to seize it.

He climbed the bell ridge and rang the common emergency bell once.

Every household stopped long enough to listen.

"This route has no return mark," he called. "It leaves the survey cloth east of the anchor shelves. Ground is opening under movement. Carts may separate. Water is untested. Anyone may choose the northern seasonal route instead."

He pointed to both directions.

No speech about freedom. No demand that fear prove loyalty. Just paths and costs.

Dasin turned his old plum cart east. The pear family followed with their torn-root tree. Seli's kitchen took the new route because Seli claimed the northern path lacked enough turnips. Other households divided. Twelve chose the known seasonal track. Thirty-eight moved east. The remainder had already crossed beyond sight or traveled with the young orchards.

Ruhan marked each choice until the ground shook too hard to write.

The east shelf began to walk.

Not a dance, though thousands of practical steps contributed weight. House carts rolled. Orchard roots gripped and released. People carried bridge planks from rear gaps to front ones. The land moved because its old pressure had found a route beyond the imperial hold.

The College salt fan reached the bell ridge.

Tavra examined the advancing line. "If they close the captured anchor against this shelf, it will shear the new route."

"What do you need?"

"Three release teams at separate edges. Volunteers who understand they may take torque through their ankles. I can cut shallow soles."

"Not centers?"

"No fixed center. The cuts only keep the salt gaps open while the shelf passes."

It sounded like improvisation balanced over injury.

Ruhan called the terms. Nine experienced orchard walkers volunteered. Four refused after Tavra showed the cut depth. She accepted five, divided them among three edges, and cut each sole in public view. She named every likely cost. Ossa carried instructions by voice, not drum.

The first team stepped across a salt break. Their ankles rolled outward as the

shelf moved. One woman fell and crawled clear. The gap stayed open.

At the southern edge, Tavra took a place herself.

Ruhan caught the white cloth at her wrist again. "You did not name your cost."

"My knee already carries it."

"That is not disclosure."

She looked toward Eda, who watched from the released approach road under Serad's guard. "The cut may add torque to my left knee. It may lock permanently. If nobody stands there, the line closes against the orchard carts."

"Does someone else know the cut?"

"No."

"Then teach while you do it."

Tavra called one of the refusing walkers to observe from outside the salt. She explained the heel angle, the release, and the point at which to drag her clear.

Only then did Ruhan release the cloth.

Tavra stepped.

The salt break opened under her scored sole. The walking shelf pulled east while the imperial anchor dragged west. Counter-motion twisted up her left leg. She did not hide the scream. The observer repeated her instructions and hauled her out after one count.

The southern line failed to close.

Ossa's scattered drum-skin strips rattled across the moving country. No single rhythm controlled them. They sounded like rain on many roofs.

Surveyors tried to extend their field. The captured pear anchor held one small circle of ground, but Kesta's main shelf moved beyond its reach. Salt lines stretched, thinned, and broke. Imperial maps on the officers' boards showed orchard marks receding toward blank cloth.

Ruhan stood on the last known ridge as it separated from the approach road.

Eda remained across the widening cut. Her hand still pressed her hip. Tavra lay on the east shelf with two orchard walkers bracing her knee.

For a moment mother and daughter saw each other without a field between them, only moving distance.

Eda lifted one hand. Not pardon. Not invitation. Recognition, perhaps, or warning.

Tavra did not wave. She nodded once and let the orchard walkers carry her away.

Serad reached the edge beside Eda. He could have ordered a new hold through her company. Ruhan watched him judge her injury, the widening ground, the scattered civilians, and the insufficient local anchor. He did not spend Eda on a

failing seizure. He ordered withdrawal.

The choice saved his dancers. It also preserved the College for another attempt.

By late afternoon, Kesta had moved beyond every imperial survey line.

The new shelf divided twice. Families rebuilt crossings with house rails. One goat cart overturned; no one died. Three people carried ankle injuries from Tavra's cuts. The driver from the broken wagon could no longer lift his right arm above his chest. Tavra's left knee stayed locked, pale striations visible around the joint. Ossa's drum retained only the inner rim and command-marked skin. The pear family had lost its local anchor stone and half the tree's oldest roots.

Ruhan wrote all of it.

He did not write victory.

At sunset they gathered on a broad slope unrepresented in his book. Household fires appeared at different heights as the shelf continued moving. Twelve families had taken the northern route; runners would seek them when ground allowed. Kel and the young orchards remained west of the seizure, bound toward Dorel. Kesta existed in separated choices, not one rescued mass.

Tavra sat with her bad leg splinted between two willow slats. "You need a route keeper who knows where the College will search."

Ruhan closed the route book. Its eastern margin ended under his thumb. "I know where they will not."

Ossa tightened the exposed inner skin on her drum. It made almost no sound when tapped. "We still need proof beyond Kesta."

"The empire captured one of our anchors," Ruhan said. "Proof may travel toward us."

Tavra looked west, where the demonstration ridge had vanished below moving stone. "I go on. Eda chose to help, but she stayed with Serad."

"She also told you not to choose for her," Ossa said.

"I heard."

Ruhan believed she had. He did not yet believe hearing would alter her next fear.

He tore the obsolete eastern border from the imperial survey cloth taken off a fallen rider. Then he left his own book uncut. A wrong map could remain useful if its wrongness stayed visible.

"I'll guide you to the capital approaches," he said. "Not for Eda alone. Kesta needs the seven-anchor orders copied where seizure cannot bury them."

Tavra nodded. "Your terms?"

"Every route temporary. Every cost spoken. If I say the ground has changed, you listen before cutting."

"And if I say a score has closed?"

"I listen before walking."

That agreement could carry them as far as the next failure.

Night came slowly because the eastern shelf kept climbing into the last light. Behind them, the captured pear anchor held a small dead-still circle on an empty ridge. Ahead, no imperial milepost stood.

At the edge of firelight, he opened his route book to a blank page and wrote the day, the injuries, the divided households, and the direction of movement.

He drew no border around Kesta. On the page below, he listed the captured anchor separately from the living pear tree so no later account could confuse ground lost with a family ended.

Part II

Chapter 8 — The Unlicensed Turn

The road ended under Tavra's good foot.

One step carried her onto a shelf of gray stone. The next found only fern and morning air. She drove her stick into the slope, caught a root with her right heel, and stopped before her locked left knee pulled her after the vanished path.

Ruhan caught the back of her coat without asking.

"Necessary," he said.

"I know."

That did not make gratitude immediate.

Day Six had begun with Kesta moving south while Tavra, Ossa, and Ruhan meant to travel west. By dawn they left the separated household fires behind and followed a route Ruhan described as probable. It had remained probable for three hours. Now twenty paces of stone had walked into the ravine.

Ossa peered over Tavra's shoulder. Her drum, stripped of its outer skin, rested against her back like an open rib cage. "Can the road come back?"

"Everything can," Ruhan said. "Schedules struggle with the question of when."

Across the gap, the path continued beneath bent pines. The ravine measured eight paces at its narrowest. Too far to jump. Its upper wall showed fresh scrape marks where the missing shelf had descended.

Tavra lowered herself to sit. Her left knee had loosened enough to bend fifteen degrees, no more. The willow splints prevented sideways torque. She unwrapped her boot and pressed the sole against the exposed stone.

"What do you feel?" Ruhan asked.

"A road that did not fail."

Ossa looked at the gap. "You score-cutters have severe standards for failure."

"It turned downward because the old imperial hold kept its western edge too rigid. The release ran along this seam." Tavra pointed with her knife. "Our path continues below."

Ruhan studied the ravine. "Below contains a cliff."

"Below the visible shelf. Not the whole way down."

"You want us to descend onto a moving road we cannot see."

"I want you to recognize its torque before rejecting it."

His eyes narrowed. "Teach, then."

Tavra took a scrap of plain goat sole from her pack. She had cut most of the

emergency leather at Kesta, leaving pieces barely large enough for repairs. With charcoal she marked three lines: grain direction, likely bend, release edge.

"A scored sole tells the foot what the cutter expects the ground to do," she said. "You are not a dancer. Do not follow a cut. Read wear instead."

She handed him her right oversole. The outer heel showed fresh abrasion from the Kestan shelf.

Ruhan turned it in both hands. "This side took more weight."

"Because the shelf moved east while I faced north. See the crushed grain near the toe?"

"Twist."

"Torque. Follow it backward."

He aligned the sole with the scraped ravine wall. The wear pointed toward a narrow shadow ten feet down.

"A ledge," he said.

"The turned road."

Ossa leaned over. "Can we use it?"

"Without a score. We lower packs, then descend by roots. No dance."

Ruhan returned the sole. "You knew that before the lesson."

"Yes."

"You could have said ledge."

"You would have trusted my authority instead of reading the ground."

"I asked for a route, not conversion into an apprentice."

The accusation landed close to Kel's. Tavra had taught by manufacturing dependence, hiding the answer so Ruhan had to earn what she already possessed.

She refastened her boot. "The ledge begins under the white pine. It slopes west and may move farther before noon. That is the answer. The reading matters if I fall and cannot give you another."

"Better."

They lowered Ossa first because she had two working knees and the heaviest pack. Ruhan followed. Tavra descended last, left leg nearly straight, body sliding between roots. Each drop drove stone-cold pressure through her knee. At the hidden ledge, Ossa braced her from below only after Tavra asked.

The turned road carried them beneath the broken shelf and out through a pine hollow. By midday they reached open country beyond any maintained route. Here the Deep Step showed in long stone waves. Grass grew on surfaces angled like roofs. Old mileposts lay face down where their roads had left them.

Ruhan navigated by water stains and bird flight. Tavra watched his boots. His right sole had begun wearing inward, compensating for the slope. She mentioned it

without offering a cut.

"Can leather help?" he asked.

"A thin lift under the outside heel. No score."

"Cost?"

"Blister until the hip adjusts. Less knee strain later."

"Do it at rest."

Consent could sound ordinary. Tavra had spent years making it ceremonial by withholding the choice.

They stopped in the shell of an abandoned route house. One wall leaned against a boulder that had entered the building after construction. Tavra cut Ruhan's lift while Ossa rationed bread and dried pears.

Ossa put the original command-skin strip between them. "We need copies before the next imperial post."

"The next post will search leather," Tavra said.

"Then cloth, bark, memory."

"Memory changes under fear."

"So does leather under fire." Ossa tapped the Nareth cedar box. "Spread custody."

Tavra's hand covered the box by reflex. Ruhan saw.

"We agreed that Kesta's proof would travel," he said.

"The Nareth score differs from the command strip. It contains a release no one else can read safely."

"No one else can read because you have not taught them."

"It took me twenty years."

Ossa's fingers moved against her silent drum rim. "And that fact becomes your reason to keep every decision."

Tavra finished Ruhan's heel lift too sharply and shaved the leather thin. "The fragment stays with me."

"For now," Ruhan said. "But show us how to recognize if it changes hands."

A reasonable request. Tavra unwrapped the fragment, displayed the scorched edge, the forked southern release, and a nail hole shaped like a crescent. Ossa copied those features onto cloth. Ruhan drew them in his route book without reproducing the actual score.

Before packing it away, Tavra gave Ruhan three worn sole scraps from the route house floor. Travelers had discarded them years apart. One carried a square imperial hold, one had no score, and one bore a shallow seasonal release.

"Put them in travel order," she said.

Ruhan examined wear, mud, and nail rust. "The plain sole crossed first. Its outer edge wore on a north lean. The held sole came after someone flattened the route. The release sole came last, after the western side began rising again."

"How do you know west?"

He aligned the seasonal cut with water stains on the inner wall. "Rain entered from the old doorway. The wearer climbed away from it."

Tavra had expected him to miss the doorway's former position. "Correct."

"Surprised?"

"Annoyingly."

Ossa held up the copied cloth. "Can this lesson move us toward safety?"

Ruhan went outside and crouched by two faint tracks leaving the ruin. The southern track looked broad and easy, but its old wheel ruts ended against a fresh stone wave. The northern path climbed through scrub, narrowing after thirty paces.

He pressed Tavra's discarded scraps into each surface and compared their flex. "South looks usable because carts wore it before the ground lifted. North carries fresh inward twist. If the twist continues, it joins the western drainage."

Tavra tested his conclusion against pressure through the floor. "North."

"You knew?"

"I suspected. You found evidence I had not."

That mattered enough to say plainly. Ruhan marked the route without adopting a score-cutter's confidence. He had learned one reading tool, not a new profession.

They began repacking for the northern path. Tavra separated the sole scraps and labeled where each had been found, another record distributed beyond her memory.

Hooves sounded above the route-house roof.

Three, then three more.

College riders had found the broken road's lower exit.

Ossa extinguished their small lamp. "How?"

Ruhan pointed to the boulder supporting the wall. A fresh white mark crossed it: imperial trail chalk, likely made that morning. "Survey scouts use the abandoned house."

Tavra listened through the floor. The stone waves outside leaned north. Six horses approached from east; another pair held west, judging by vibration.

"College riders," Ossa said after peering through a roof gap. "White cords. Anchor satchels."

Not ordinary pursuit. Each pair carried a fist-sized local stone in a net bag. Small anchors for an ambush field.

"They expected us to use this hollow," Ruhan said.

"They expected me to seek old walls," Tavra replied.

Her habit had drafted them into a trap. She wanted to move immediately and explain later. The promise from Kesta stopped her.

"Costs first," she said. "They can salt both exits and hold the floor. If we run, crossbow risk. If we remain when they set anchors, the route house becomes center weight and may collapse. I can turn the outside road downhill before the field closes."

Ossa asked, "Cost to you?"

"Counter-motion into my left knee and right ankle. The knee may lock worse."

"Cost to us?" Ruhan said.

"Anyone on the road takes lateral force. Falls, ankle turns. If the cut exceeds the local bend, the road may split."

"Other options?"

Ruhan showed them a drainage hole under the fallen milepost. Too narrow for Ossa's drum, perhaps wide enough for a person crawling. It ended somewhere beneath the north stone wave.

"We can abandon the drum," Ossa said.

The command evidence lived on its inner skin.

"No," Tavra said too quickly.

Ossa looked at her. "My drum. My choice."

Tavra corrected herself. "If you choose the hole, copy the remaining orders first. It may take longer than we have."

A rider called from outside. "Tavra Ilen. Leave the route house unarmed. Your companions may petition separately."

Ruhan almost smiled. "Separately sounds unhealthy."

The first hiss of poured salt came from the east exit.

Ossa ran her thumb around the exposed inner rim. "We turn the road. The drum stays with me. I accept fall risk. I do not accept a command count."

Ruhan nodded. "I accept the heel lift and road turn. Tell me where not to stand."

Tavra laid the plan in full. She would cut a responsive hook into her own right sole, using the road-house threshold as a temporary anchor to catch the outside route's existing bend. Ossa would make noise without regular cadence. Ruhan would open the west shutter and throw the fallen milepost into the salt line when the road began to turn. They would exit north across dirt, never along the moving paving.

"No one follows my feet," Tavra said. "Watch the threshold. When it rotates, move."

Ossa repeated the plan back. Ruhan corrected the shutter's direction. Only then did Tavra cut.

The unlicensed turn required three strokes: a hook under the outer toes, a diagonal vent across the arch, and a heel line left deliberately open. Any College examiner would call it unfinished. Completion would force the road to hold its new direction. Tavra wanted one turn and release.

The second salt line hissed outside.

Survey dancers stepped into position. Their command officer began a four-count brace.

Ossa struck the bare inner rim with a spoon. Metal clanged against wood, ugly and irregular. She kicked a loose shutter. Ruhan slapped the wall with both palms. Noise filled the route house without offering trained bodies a rhythm.

Tavra planted her right foot on the threshold.

The score caught.

The old road's downward torque entered her sole. She turned her toes north and kept her heel light. Outside, paving answered with a grinding sweep.

Pain entered her right ankle first, hot and immediate. Her left knee took the road's resistance as deep cold. She saw Nareth salt for half a breath and refused the memory's count.

"Threshold," she gasped.

Ruhan watched the stone, not her. It rotated a handspan.

He threw open the west shutter and heaved the fallen milepost. It landed across fresh step-salt. The boundary scattered.

Ossa kept making unmusical noise.

The road turned.

Not far. Twelve paces of paving swung downslope like a gate. The east riders' horses scrambled backward. At the west exit, an anchor pair lost its prepared line when the paving moved under their salt. The route-house threshold tried to follow, but the boulder wedged it.

Wall mortar cracked above Tavra.

"Now," Ruhan said.

Ossa crawled through the north window with her drum. Ruhan followed, then turned to Tavra. She had to release the sole before lifting her foot. Her open heel line had filled with grit.

"Knife," she said.

He reached for her tool roll.

"No. Your heel." She pointed. "Press the outside edge of my sole. Not the cut."

Ruhan planted his lifted right boot where she indicated. He could recognize

torque now without performing the measure. His weight opened the vent. Tavra pulled her heel free.

The route released.

Counter-motion snapped through her left knee. She fell sideways. Ruhan caught her shoulder, and together they rolled through the window as the route-house wall collapsed onto the turned road.

A rider shouted for pursuit.

His horse refused the new angle. Others dismounted, but the broken salt and fallen wall blocked them. Tavra, Ossa, and Ruhan crawled across the north wave, staying on dirt until the old house disappeared behind stone.

They reached a scrub hollow before stopping.

Tavra's right ankle had swollen above the boot. Her left knee would not bend at all. Ossa's forearm carried a scrape from the window. Ruhan's heel lift remained in place, and his gait stayed even.

He knelt to inspect Tavra's splint. "You can't walk west today."

"I can with two sticks."

"You can fall west with two sticks."

Ossa sat opposite Tavra and laid the damaged drum between them. "You disclosed the immediate cost."

"You sound disappointed."

"I'm deciding whether disclosure arrived because you changed or because there was time."

Tavra unstrapped the responsive sole. Its open heel had torn wider but held. "Does motive alter the facts?"

"Motive predicts the next field."

Ruhan said, "You also drafted me into the release."

"I told you where to press."

"After your sole jammed."

"The alternative involved a wall."

"You knew jamming could happen."

Tavra had known grit could close the vent. She had assigned herself the risk and treated any necessary assistance as an emergency exemption. The pattern remained: take the central danger, then make everyone else responsible for preserving her.

"I should have named the jam," she said.

"And the chance I would have to enter your sole's torque," Ruhan replied.

"Yes."

Ossa leaned forward. "At Kesta you cut volunteers after naming bruises and falls. Here you chose the turn, assigned us jobs, and kept the failure branches in your head."

"We had riders pouring salt."

"We had enough time for a plan. You gave us the useful trunk and hid the branches."

Tavra looked at the swollen ankle, the locked knee, and the two people who had survived despite incomplete knowledge. Success tempted her to defend method. Nareth had survived in that temptation for twelve years.

"What do you require?" she asked.

"Not require," Ossa said. "Agree."

The correction cut cleanly.

Tavra placed the ruined responsive sole on the ground where all three could see it. "Before the next measure, I disclose every cost I can predict, including rescue roles if my part fails. I name what I do not know. If there is no time, I ask whether you accept acting without full information."

Ruhan said, "And if anyone refuses?"

"I find another plan or act alone without making them recover me."

"Acting alone can still put us in the aftermath," Ossa said.

Tavra's first answer rose ready: then leave. She let it die.

"Then you choose whether my solitary act remains compatible with traveling together."

Ossa considered the tempo of the words. "Acceptable until tested."

Ruhan drew the turned road in his book as a hinge, not a line. "Name today's unknown."

Tavra touched her knee. "I don't know how much more counter-motion this joint can take. I may lose walking capacity before we reach the capital."

Neither ally hurried to comfort her.

That absence felt honest.

They built a carrying sling from the torn route-house curtain, two pine poles, and Tavra's spare leather. She objected once to the knot, then explained why it would slip rather than seizing the rope herself. Ruhan changed it. Ossa took the front pole. Tavra kept the score knife within reach but not in her hand.

Before lifting, Ossa made her drink and checked the right ankle for heat. Ruhan loosened the willow splints without removing them. Tavra described which touch caused stone pressure and which merely hurt. The distinction let them adjust the sling so her left leg rode straight while the swollen right ankle remained above the lower strap.

"This adds time," Tavra said.

"It returns time later," Ruhan replied. "A route can be shortened by not dropping the passenger."

Ossa tested the front pole against her shoulder. "A military innovation we shamefully overlooked."

Their care neither cured nor reduced the meaning of the injury. It changed what travel remained possible.

At sunset, they found the west route by reading wear on Ruhan's altered heel and water stains under the stone waves. The road they had turned remained behind them, blocking pursuit for a few hours rather than forever.

Tavra lay in the sling and watched unheld country pass above her. Every dip demanded a change in grip. Ossa and Ruhan discussed each change before lifting.

For the first time since Dorel, Tavra traveled without deciding where every foot would land.

The discomfort did not feel like freedom. It felt like dependence, which might have been the necessary beginning.

Chapter 9 — A Bridge Performed in Rain

Rain erased the crossing while Ruhan stood inside its first footprint.

The gorge dropped on both sides of him, black water far below. Three local slabs formed a narrow platform from the eastern bank. Beyond them, seven more lay tilted beneath the current, remnants of a seasonal bridge that had returned to the riverbed during spring movement.

Ruhan stepped backward before the final patch of step-salt dissolved around his boot.

"The boundary's gone," he called.

Ossa lowered Tavra's carrying sling onto the bank. Rain drummed against the command-marked inner skin of her instrument, producing a faint papery rattle. Tavra pushed herself upright, one hand on the locked left knee.

"How much salt remains?"

Ossa opened the oilcloth packet. Gray slurry coated the bottom. "Enough to season an unpopular dinner."

Ruhan knelt at the edge. The old crossing route had connected two red-stone shelves over the narrowest reach of the gorge. Since the last Kestan atlas mark, the western shelf had moved six paces downstream. No bridge could join the old points now.

"The pass road lies west," he said. "If we turn north, the next ford takes two days."

"College riders take less," Ossa said.

Hoofprints had appeared twice that morning on parallel shelves. Pursuit no longer pressed close enough to hear, but riders with held-road horses would gain once the rain stopped.

Tavra examined the gorge through narrowed eyes. "The submerged slabs still belong to this bank."

"Belong is a large word for wet stone."

"Their grain matches. The old measure lowered them but did not carry them away."

Ruhan saw what she meant. The water broke in pale lines over rectangular shapes. Existing terrain, not summoned matter. A temporary arch could rise if the slabs accepted the western shelf's new position.

He looked at Tavra's legs. "No."

"You asked no question."

"I saved time."

Ossa crouched beside them. "Costs first."

Tavra did not protest. "Scale: ten slabs, perhaps twelve. Distance: fourteen paces. We do not hold against the river, only raise and join long enough to cross. Counter-motion will press downward through whoever stands at center. My knee cannot receive it safely."

"Can anyone else?" Ruhan asked.

"Ossa can carry rhythm and one outer line. You can set and catch the local anchor without dancing. I can center from the sling with my left leg unloaded."

"That sounds like carrying downward pressure through the rest of you."

"It is."

"Likely injury?" Ossa asked.

"Bruising through pelvis, shoulders, and right leg. My left knee may take spill despite the sling. If salt washes out, slabs can separate before release. Anyone on the bridge falls."

"Unknowns?"

"The western shelf's present torque. How deep the anchor pocket runs. Whether the old bridge score left unfinished movement in the slabs."

Ruhan pointed north. "Alternative costs two days, more food than we carry, and probable rider contact. I choose the bridge if we can mark an exit not dependent on visible salt."

Ossa looked at the exposed drum. "I choose it if my count follows Ruhan's anchor calls. No command pattern."

Tavra accepted both conditions. "Then you each choose your own shoes. I cut no score for Ruhan. He handles the anchor on dirt."

They spent the next hour assessing local stone in rain. Ruhan found a fist-sized piece under the eastern ledge that matched both bank and submerged slabs. The old anchor pocket lay three feet from the water, a round hollow packed with leaves. He cleared it by hand.

Ossa built a boundary from what the weather would not immediately carry: charcoal mixed with wax under overhanging stones, rope along the exposed bank, willow pegs driven into dirt. Only the final lines required step-salt. She saved the remaining paste in a covered cup.

Tavra cut two soles while seated in the sling. Her own received shallow downward vents along the right heel, each left open toward the river. Ossa's outer soles took broad flex lines and no center marks. Tavra showed every cut before binding them.

Ruhan studied the worn route marks around the gorge. "The west shelf leans upstream."

Tavra handed him a sole scrap. "Confirm."

He pressed it against wet stone. Water ran diagonally across the leather, but

grain crush from past travelers angled the other way. "Upstream now. Downstream when the bridge last stood."

"The slabs will twist during the rise."

"How do we let them?"

"Build the arch crooked."

Ruhan almost laughed. "Empire has damaged my expectations. That sounds sensible."

He selected two rope lengths, one for the anchor and one as a crossing handline. They tied the handline to living willow roots on both banks using a thrown stone and Ossa's stronger arm. The rope sagged into the gorge but would rise with the slabs.

Before closing the field, Ruhan crossed the eastern bank twice to inspect what their work might disturb. A fish seller's abandoned smoking rack stood above the flood line. Three wicker traps remained tied beneath it, all empty. Farther upstream, a goat track descended to the only accessible water for half a mile. Raising the slabs would narrow the current and flood that track until release.

"We have no one here to ask," he said.

"Then name the absent users," Tavra replied. "And leave evidence of the change."

Ruhan cut a warning mark into the smoking rack: temporary raised stone, crossing direction, expected release before dark. Kestan practice used no fixed symbol for a bridge performed under pursuit, so he added words in Meren trade script. He disliked deciding for unknown travelers. The best available repair involved making the decision visible and short.

Ossa tested sound against the gorge. A rim tap returned from the west wall a half count late. Any repeating cadence would echo into false instructions.

"I'll vary material as well as interval," she said. "Wood for lift, stone for angle, palm for release."

Ruhan repeated the meanings until he could distinguish them through rain. Tavra then asked them to rehearse without movement. He called first weight. Ossa struck wood. Tavra shifted no foot. They repeated with the anchor lean, interruption, and forced release.

On the third rehearsal, Ruhan called angle while Ossa struck lift.

"We would have raised the wrong edge," Tavra said.

"Again," he answered.

They continued until each mistake appeared during practice rather than over water. The delay cost fifteen minutes. It also revealed that Ossa watched Tavra's heel whenever Ruhan's voice softened, a remnant of expecting the center to outrank the caller. She changed position so Tavra fell outside her direct sight.

Ruhan wrapped the anchor rope around his forearm, then removed it. A sudden pull could trap the limb. He tied a sliding waist loop instead and kept the free end in his left hand. His right hand remained available to guide the stone.

"Recoil can still reach the wrist," Tavra warned.

"I accept ordinary pull, not a locked anchor. If the stone rises more than half out of the pocket, we release."

Ossa touched the sagging handline. "If it parts?"

"We crawl the slabs or return east. Nobody jumps from the arch because riders arrive."

Their plan now held limits, users, signals, and exits. It did not hold the weather.

Rain thickened. The river climbed against the lowest visible stone.

Tavra said, "We begin now or take the ford."

Ruhan placed the local anchor in its pocket without locking it. He could pull it free if the measure tightened beyond their disclosure. Ossa stood at the outer line with a wooden spoon over her bare drum rim.

Tavra remained in the sling, poles braced across two bank stones. She planted only her right scored sole. Her left leg rested straight above the mud.

"Ruhan calls," Ossa said.

He tested the anchor. It leaned upstream, matching the western shelf.

"First weight."

Ossa struck the rim once.

Tavra pressed her right heel down.

The nearest submerged slab lifted through brown water. It rose flat, hesitated, then turned upstream half a pace. River poured off its edges.

"Second weight," Ruhan called.

Another irregular tap. Tavra shifted to the outer vent. A second slab rose beside the first, lower and angled. Their edges met without locking.

The arch began as a stair leading into rain.

They raised four slabs before counter-motion reached Tavra's shoulders. Her arms shook against the sling poles. Ruhan asked whether to release.

"Continue two," she said. "Then reassess."

Not command. Her threshold.

At six slabs, the crossing reached the gorge's center. The western shelf remained eight paces away. Water struck the unfinished edge and sprayed over their rope.

Ossa's count never repeated. Spoon against rim, palm against wood, boot against dirt. She watched Ruhan, not Tavra.

"Anchor turns," Ruhan said.

The local stone rotated in its pocket. Upstream torque pulled at the rope around his left forearm. He loosened the line and let the anchor face west.

Tavra felt the change. The raised slabs slewed. Their crooked joins tightened into an arch pointing toward the moved shelf.

"Better," she gasped.

A hoofbeat answered from the eastern path.

Riders appeared through rain above the gorge. Four College whites, then two survey dancers carrying salt horns. The lead officer raised a crossbow.

"Hold position!" he called.

Ruhan shouted back, "An excellent phrase for another landscape."

The officer dismounted. "Break the measure and surrender the stolen College property."

"Breaking it drops six slabs," Ossa said.

"Then release safely."

Tavra spoke without looking up. "They'll take the anchor when we do."

Ruhan had chosen the bridge knowing riders might reach them. He had not chosen to fight trained officers while holding a local stone.

"New cost," he said. "Rider pressure before completion. Options?"

Ossa kept irregular sound moving. "I can fracture their approach count, but that risks the outer line."

Tavra said, "Raise the next four fast. Higher bruising. Greater chance the arch overshoots."

Ruhan watched the river and west shelf. "Do it. I accept anchor recoil. Ossa?"

"I accept outer-line slip."

Tavra breathed once. "I accept more center load. Release if my right heel stops answering."

Ruhan called three rapid weights.

Ossa struck wood, stone, wood.

Slabs seven through nine rose in sequence. The arch steepened toward the western shelf. Tavra's right hip drove into the sling. She cried out but kept her heel responsive.

The riders spread along the bank. One survey dancer poured fresh step-salt across their retreat route, trying to capture the bridge field inside an imperial boundary.

Rain blurred his line as quickly as he laid it.

The final submerged slab stood on edge beneath the water. Its broad face

caught the river. When Tavra lifted, it did not rise. It swung.

Ruhan felt the anchor jerk.

"Broken response!" he called.

The local stone tore halfway from its pocket. He threw both hands around it. The rope snapped taut.

His right wrist folded backward.

A crack traveled up his arm.

Pain erased the gorge for one breath. He kept the anchor from leaving the pocket because if it went, nine raised slabs would lose their relation to the bank.

"My right wrist," he shouted. "Cracked. I cannot hold another recoil."

Disclosure while the injury still happened. Tavra heard him.

"Release or transfer?" she asked.

Ossa moved toward the anchor.

"No," Ruhan said. "Her outer line goes if she leaves." He looped the rope around his waist and held the stone with his left hand. "One count. Then release whether the last slab lands or not."

Tavra looked at him, waiting for certainty he did not have.

"One," he said.

Ossa struck the drum rim with her palm.

Tavra turned her right foot upstream.

The edge-on slab rolled under water. Its top broke the surface like a shoulder. Instead of forcing it flat, the score let it remain angled. The stone met the ninth slab and leaned against the western shelf.

A crooked final step. Usable.

"Release," Ruhan called.

Tavra opened her heel vents. Ossa stepped out of the outer line. Ruhan pulled the local anchor free with his left hand.

The arch settled under river weight. It had no hold left beyond the natural brace of slab against slab. It might stand five minutes or fifty.

The lead officer fired.

His bolt struck the sling pole near Tavra's shoulder.

Ossa seized the front pole. Ruhan took the rear with his left hand, right arm tucked against his chest. They lifted Tavra onto the first slab.

"Go," she said.

Riders reached the eastern boundary. Their fixed soles slipped where rain had turned step-salt into gray oil. One fell. The others abandoned formation and followed on foot.

The bridge rose steeply to its crooked center. Water drove through every join. Ossa climbed backward at the front, hauling the sling. Ruhan pushed with his left shoulder. His right wrist pulsed in time with his heart.

At the sixth slab, the third join shifted.

"Keep moving," Tavra said. "No holding step."

They climbed. The handline rose beside them, slick but intact. Ossa took it at the arch crest. Ruhan could not grip with his right hand, so he hooked his elbow over the rope and shoved the sling pole along his hip.

The first rider stepped onto the eastern slab.

Counterweight changed.

The arch flattened a fraction. Water swept over Ruhan's boots. He saw the rider hesitate and recognized the same imperial expectation he had once held: that a road built for crossing should remain available to everyone long enough to be called a road.

This bridge had been performed for one passage and one escape. It carried no promise beyond consent of bodies and stone.

Ossa reached the angled final slab. She jumped to the western shelf and pulled. Tavra's sling scraped across the edge. Ruhan stepped after it.

His heel caught the handline.

The broken wrist struck stone. He nearly blacked out. Tavra caught his coat from the sling and Ossa dragged both of them onto the shelf.

Behind them, the lead rider reached the arch crest.

The first eastern join slipped free.

The bridge lowered one slab at a time rather than collapsing at once. The rider ran back. He jumped to the bank as the third stone descended. No one fell into the gorge.

The remaining slabs returned to the river, crooked arch becoming broken stair, then pale shapes under brown water. The angled western stone held longest. It rolled away after the others and vanished.

The handline tore from the eastern willow and streamed against their bank.

Ruhan lay on his back in wet grass, right arm across his chest. The gorge separated them from the College riders again.

Ossa cut two straight sticks for a splint. Tavra directed without touching until Ruhan asked her to inspect the wrist.

"Crack, perhaps two," she said. "No open break. Fingers?"

He moved them. Pain sharpened but they answered.

"Splint through the elbow. No carrying with that side."

"Route book?"

"Left-handed notes."

Ossa wrapped the wrist and forearm with the last dry cloth from inside her coat.
"You'll be slow."

"I was slow before. I disguised it with confidence."

He tested the splint by lifting his route book and nearly dropped it. The right hand could support no useful weight. Writing would require his left, climbing would require a rope around his torso, and any future anchor work needed another holder. He named each loss so neither companion could mistake stubbornness for capacity.

Ruhan drew the gorge crossing with his left hand. The line wandered. He marked the submerged slabs, the empty fish traps, and the temporary warning on the eastern rack. Even a failed-looking map could preserve obligations to people they never met.

Tavra lay under the rain with the crossbow bolt still buried in her sling pole. Center load had bruised her right side from shoulder to hip. Her left knee remained unchanged, which counted as luck rather than health.

They moved west only after every cost had been named. Ossa carried the drum and most supplies. Tavra returned to the sling. Ruhan took the rear pole on his left shoulder, right arm bound across his chest. The arrangement hurt all three and remained possible.

At dusk they found shelter beneath a rock shelf above the gorge road. Rain softened to mist. Ossa built no fire because riders might search the opposite bank until dark.

Tavra opened the cedar box.

Ruhan expected another lesson. Instead she took out the blackened fragment and placed it on his route book.

"The Nareth score goes with you," she said.

His right wrist throbbed. "Why?"

"Because I cannot retrieve it from you without your cooperation."

Ossa looked up from tightening the splint.

Tavra continued. "You are not a dancer. You can identify the fragment but cannot use it to improvise a measure. If I am captured or decide urgency excuses taking it back, custody remains outside my control."

Ruhan examined the scorched edge, forked southern release, and crescent nail hole. "Risk to me: riders search me. Risk to the evidence: rain, loss, my ignorance."

"Yes."

"Alternative custody?"

"Ossa already carries the command orders on her drum. One arrest should not take both."

Ruhan opened the oilskin pocket sewn inside his route book cover. "I accept until we place it somewhere safer. You may advise. You do not take it while I sleep."

Tavra's mouth tightened at the necessary insult. "Agreed."

He slid the Nareth score into the pocket and tied the cover closed with his left hand.

Across the gorge, lanterns searched a bank with no bridge. Between the travelers, custody had changed more permanently than the stone.

When they left at first dark, Tavra knew the fragment's route only because Ruhan chose to tell her.

Chapter 10 — The Stone in Tavra's Blood

The fever in Tavra's left knee boiled the rain cold before it reached her boot.

She lay in the carrying sling beneath the eaves of an abandoned barracks and watched water strike her trouser leg, steam faintly, then run down the willow splint. The joint itself felt buried under winter stone. Every heartbeat pushed heat around something that did not belong to flesh.

Ossa lowered the front pole. Ruhan set his left end down carefully, right wrist bound across his chest.

"We stop," he said.

"The roof has three holes."

"The next roof lies beyond two ridges."

"It may have four." Ossa unstrapped her exposed drum. "We honor the superior ruin."

The building stood above a road that had once served Nareth's northern work companies. Faded paint over the door showed a center shoe inside a pension wreath. One wall had sunk into the hillside. The bunks inside remained dry enough for splints and sleep.

Tavra recognized the barracks pattern: twelve beds, company stove, boot hooks near the entrance, a supervisor's desk facing everyone else. She had inspected places like it before Nareth and never asked why center-dancers slept on the ground floor while officers occupied rooms above.

Ossa cut away Tavra's knee wrapping. The skin had gone pale from kneecap to lower thigh. Narrow gray striations spread beneath it like mineral grain.

Ruhan touched nothing. "What can we do?"

"Cool it. Keep the leg straight. No ground-dance."

"That final instruction sounds directed at you," Ossa said.

"It is."

They used rainwater in folded cloths. Each fresh compress warmed within minutes. Tavra described numbness along the inner calf and stabbing pressure behind the knee. She did not call it ordinary pain. Naming the exact sensation gave the others something to monitor.

Ruhan searched the supervisor's desk with his left hand. Most drawers had swollen shut. One opened far enough to reveal mouse nests, broken chalk, and a brass key tagged ROOT STORE.

"Nareth workers kept roots?" Ossa asked.

"Road crews stored winter vegetables below barracks," Tavra said. "Sometimes anchor samples."

The key turned in a floor hatch behind the stove. Damp air rose from stone steps.

Ruhan held up his splinted wrist. "I can carry a lamp or climb. Not both."

Ossa took the lamp. Tavra should have remained on the bunk. Instead she fitted both sticks under her arms.

"No," Ossa said.

Tavra waited until the word stopped provoking an automatic answer. "The mark over the door belongs to Nareth's dissolved Third Company. I may know what records mean. I cannot climb safely. Will one of you brace me if I go?"

"Cost?" Ruhan asked.

"More swelling. Fall risk. No measure."

Ossa considered. "You go down seated, one step at a time. We stop if the fever rises."

They lowered Tavra into the cellar. The work humiliated her only when she treated dependence as a verdict. She sat on each damp step, moved her left leg with both hands, and let Ossa take her weight at the shoulders.

The root store filled two rooms. The first held collapsed bins and clay jars fused to their shelves. In the second, cedar document boxes stood on a raised platform. Water had destroyed the lower row. The upper lids still bore pension-office seals.

Ossa lifted one down.

Inside lay pension ledgers from twenty-nine years of Nareth road service. Each page listed a dancer, years at center, visible lithification on retirement, and later claims by family. Tavra turned pages while Ossa held the lamp.

Mera Sol: left ankle, two years after service.

Hadrik Ven: lumbar stone, six years.

Issa Pell: jaw and throat, eleven years, death during winter.

The official injury columns ended at retirement. Family claims continued in smaller script, often denied because deterioration occurred after active company duty.

Several pages included letters folded into the binding. A daughter asked why her father's pension paid for an ankle brace but not the quarry chair he needed when stone reached his hips. A widow enclosed a road-company commendation beside a burial invoice. The clerk had answered both in the same careful hand: service connection unverified after discharge.

Ossa found the pension formula on the back cover. A center earned more for each documented patch of bodily stone while employed. The policy rewarded dancers for visible damage, then treated later spread as private illness.

"They paid people to stay until the first proof appeared," she said. "Then stopped counting when proof grew."

Tavra remembered company inspections. She had encouraged dancers to display pale ankle lines because the marks improved retirement shares. At the time, she called that honesty about cost. The ledger showed a narrower transaction: the empire priced the injury it could use and abandoned the part that outlived service.

Ruhan read over her shoulder. "They knew bodies failed years later."

"Pension clerks knew claims existed."

"Twenty-nine years of entries make existence difficult to dismiss."

Tavra found names from her Nareth company. Three dancers she had believed recovered had later lost movement. One died seven years after the hold when stone reached her ribs. The claim carried a red denial mark: no direct service cause established.

Tavra put the ledger down before her hands tore it.

Ossa opened another box. Route maps filled it, each overlay showing the same northern hold across successive years. Wells disappeared from later surveys. Orchard symbols thinned. Marginal notes mentioned poor root yield, dry cellar walls, and spring relocation requests rejected because the road remained strategically necessary.

"No one joined the records," Ossa said.

"They joined them," Tavra replied. "They filed the join under separate offices."

Ruhan searched the collapsed bins. His boot struck something that rang like fired clay.

He cleared rotten wood with his left hand.

Fossilized roots filled the lowest vegetable bed.

They had not rotted. Every fine branch remained, rendered in gray stone from thick crown to hairlike tips. Soil around them had hardened into a solid block carrying the shape of old moisture. Tavra touched one root and felt no life, only the smooth record of where life had once tried to grow.

The permanent hold above had fixed more than a road. Counter-motion had entered the ground below it, locking water paths, soil spaces, and root growth.

She had known bodies paid. She had built her resistance around Eda's body, her own knees, and dead centers. The cellar expanded the cost beyond any center's skin.

"If Dominion joins seven holds," Ruhan said, "how much land does this repeat?"

"I don't know."

"Can Serad?"

"He can know projections if survey offices gave them to him. These ledgers prove Nareth. We need the capital archive for scale."

A faint knocking came from behind the fossilized soil block.

Ossa lifted the lamp. "Water?"

Tavra pressed her palm to the stone. Cold vibration tapped in irregular bursts. A spring still pushed through its old channel, trapped behind mineralized soil.

"Leave it," Ruhan said at once.

Tavra did not argue. "If we release it, the cellar may flood. The foundation may shift. Counter-motion enters whoever cuts. If we leave it, we preserve evidence undisturbed and the spring remains trapped."

"Other way to document?" Ossa asked.

"Draw the roots, take a small sample, copy the ledgers. We do not need the spring to prove the hold."

The knocking grew stronger as rain fed the hillside.

Ruhan examined the wall. "Foundation already shifts. Water has nowhere else to go. If pressure breaks it later, the whole platform and records may wash out."

They listened. Tavra wanted to cut because a trapped thing called to every old center reflex. Want did not decide.

"I can make a hand-width release toward the collapsed bins," she said. "No salt. The root block serves as local anchor. Likely cost: downward compression in my left knee because the spring rises. Unknown: how much pressure accumulated over twelve years."

"You said no ground-dance," Ossa replied.

"Yes."

"Does evidence justify breaking that limit?"

"No. Protecting the records might. We can move the boxes first and let the wall fail without a scored release."

Ruhan weighed the routes. "A natural break could strike any direction. A narrow channel gives us an exit. I accept moving records, then release, if Tavra does not center alone."

"No one else can take this through an injured body," Tavra said.

"I mean we control whether you continue. Ossa holds your shoulders off the floor. I pull the records. One cut only. If the channel does not open, stop."

Ossa agreed after repeating the limit.

They carried the pension ledgers upstairs first. Ruhan tucked two route overlays under his coat. Ossa moved the remaining dry boxes. Tavra waited beside the fossilized roots with no knife in hand until they returned.

For the release, she cut a shallow crescent into a scrap sole and bound it over her right boot. She showed them the single channel. No hidden branch.

Ossa braced her from behind. Ruhan stood at the cellar steps, ready to call retreat.

Tavra placed her right heel against the mineralized soil.

The spring struck the score.

Water found the crescent and drove through. A fist-wide channel opened toward the collapsed bins. Mud and stone fragments burst across the floor.

Counter-motion entered Tavra's left knee.

The fever vanished into cold.

Stone seemed to pour upward through the joint, not as liquid or thought, but as an impossible deepening of weight. The gray striations under her skin widened. Her leg locked from ankle to mid-thigh.

"One cut," Ruhan shouted. "Release."

Tavra lifted her right foot.

The channel remained open without further dance. Spring water rushed through the fossil bed and out beneath the collapsed wall. The barracks shifted half an inch. Dust fell from the ceiling, then stopped.

Ossa dragged Tavra toward the steps. She could not feel the inner side of her left calf at all.

Upstairs, they wrapped the knee in cold cloth again. It no longer heated the compress. Pale mineral lines reached above the joint like roots climbing the wrong body.

"You chose after disclosure," Ossa said. "That does not make the cost wise."

"I know."

"Do you?"

Tavra looked at the ledgers stacked beside the stove. "I still thought taking it into me would simplify the choice."

Ruhan sat with his splinted wrist across his knees. "It simplified nothing. Now we have evidence and another person to carry."

The statement held no cruelty. Tavra accepted it without asking him to make sacrifice beautiful.

By late afternoon, they had copied six ledger pages, the delayed-failure totals, and three route maps. Ossa wrapped the original pension ledgers in barracks oilcloth. They left most boxes in place above the now-draining cellar and marked the building for road-company veterans who might know the names.

Ruhan added a custody list inside his book using his left hand. Ossa carried the wrapped originals. Tavra kept the root sample in a padded boot pouch where a fall would not grind it. Each item had a holder and a second person who knew its markings. The arrangement slowed departure, but no single capture could erase both documents and witness.

Tavra asked Ruhan for the Nareth score. Not its return, only sight of the scorched edge.

He opened the route book and held the fragment where she could compare its release turn to the spring crescent. The same principle appeared in both: do not oppose stored movement; give it a narrow exit and stop before the new direction becomes a hold.

"You keep it," she said.

"I intended to."

At dusk Ossa spread their two possible routes on the floor. Southeast led toward Eda and the returning Fifth Measure. West led to the capital archive through old road-company settlements.

Tavra's fear chose southeast before anyone spoke.

She looked at the fossilized-root sample beside the ledgers. Reaching Eda without proof of continental cost would repeat the demonstration field: correct warning, private urgency, no shared basis for choice. Serad could call her frightened. Eda could call her controlling. Both would be right.

"We go west," Tavra said. "Capital archive. We copy the pension and soil records before I approach Eda again."

Ossa watched for hesitation hidden as command. "Reason?"

"Dominion will kill land beyond its centers. I know Nareth proves it. I do not know the scale. Evidence must travel where my custody and Eda's belief cannot decide whether it survives."

Ruhan closed his book over the Nareth fragment. "West requires the veterans' road. My wrist cannot climb the direct pass."

"Then we ask the road-company settlement for shelter and a route."

Not demand. Ask.

They left the abandoned barracks at nightfall carrying ledgers, copied maps, a root sample, and injuries no stable road had ever listed honestly. Behind them, the released spring ran out under the wall and cut its own shallow course downhill.

Tavra traveled in the sling. Her left knee held stone from ankle to thigh, colder now than rain.

For the first time, she turned away from the shortest road to her daughter because rescue without the whole cost would only build another hidden center.

Chapter 11 — The Choir of Bent Ankles

Ossa heard the veterans before she saw their lamps.

A heel dragged across stone somewhere beyond the shuttered tollhouse. Another foot answered with a soft double tap, toe and outer edge, followed by the padded drop of a cane. None of it kept a marching count. The sounds overlapped like rain beginning on different roofs.

She raised one hand. Ruhan stopped beside her, cradling his splinted right wrist against his coat. Tavra took another step before her left knee refused. The old score-cutter caught the tollhouse wall without speaking.

“Road-company refuge,” Ruhan murmured. “Or a convincing imitation.”

The door opened inward. A broad woman with a white braid held a splitting maul at waist height. Her right boot had been built up by three finger-widths. Pale stone showed through the skin above its collar.

“You brought a drum,” she said to Ossa.

“I brought what remains of one.”

“That answer has buried people.”

“So have I.”

The woman studied her, then Tavra’s locked knee. Recognition changed her grip before it changed her face. “Ilen.”

Tavra kept her palm against the wall. “Hessa Dorn.”

“You look worse than your pension drawing.”

“I never drew one.”

“Of course not. You left the rest of us to prove we deserved ours.” Hessa lowered the maul. “Inside. Riders crossed the east shelf at dusk. If they ask, I’ll say your footprints continued north. If they search, I’ll use the maul and regret the floor.”

The refuge occupied the old tollhouse cellar, where imperial barrels had once waited for seals. Twenty-three former road workers sat among wool pallets, cookpots, and racks of altered shoes. A charcoal brazier warmed the damp without clearing it, and every cup bore a former company number scratched nearly away. Their bodies carried the work in separate dialects. One man’s ankles leaned inward as though still bracing a crowned road. A woman called Seni walked with her left foot always seeking lower ground. Two brothers shared a bench because one could rise but not turn and the other could turn but not rise. Nobody looked away from Tavra’s knee or pretended not to understand its pale shine.

Ossa set her drum beside the door. Its naked frame, missing the outer skin lost in Kesta, looked less like an instrument than an accusation.

Hessa pointed Tavra toward a pallet. "Sit before your pride adds another joint to the ledger."

"The spring released," Tavra said. "Counter-motion entered the knee."

"We heard."

"You couldn't have."

"Stone travels slowly. Workers' news does not."

A boy of perhaps twelve brought heated bricks wrapped in cloth. Tavra accepted one under her thigh, careful not to bend the knee farther. Ruhan declined help with his wrist until the boy stared him into surrender. Ossa remained standing. In a room full of damaged centers, the straightness of her own ankles felt indecent.

Seni ladled root broth into cups. "Show us what you found."

Ruhan looked to Tavra. Tavra looked at Ossa, a small turn of the eyes that tried to make a decision without appearing to command it.

Ossa shook her head. "His custody."

With his left hand, Ruhan removed folded pension pages from inside his coat. Tavra had copied the names at the Nareth barracks, while the original ledgers remained hidden under a split floor stone. He laid the copies on a flour board. Beside them he placed a cloth bundle holding chips from the fossilized roots.

The room tightened around the table without anyone calling a count.

Hessa picked up a root chip. "Pear?"

"Fig," Tavra said. "The cellar owner planted it after the holding. The root reached the old salt field and hardened."

A narrow veteran named Brin rubbed one thumb over a pension name. "I carried road seventeen with Laro Ves. College said lung fever took him."

"His widow wrote mineral cough in the margin," Ruhan said. "Six years after retirement."

"She wrote to the pension office seven times."

No one offered comfort. The veterans began naming injuries instead. A knee from the western grain rise. Three fused toes from a harbor shelf. A shoulder that had received a quarry road's sideways drag. A jaw that clicked whenever the southern causeway tried to sink. Each account entered the room on its own tempo. Ossa listened for the habit she had once used to bind separate bodies into one obedient unit. She refused it. Their pauses belonged to them.

"College called mine age," Hessa said, tapping the built-up boot. "Age arrived in one afternoon after we held a tax bridge."

Seni lifted her trouser hem. Stone traced both shins in pale forks. "They called this hereditary."

"My mother climbed until she died," said Brin. "I had to be carried from my last measure."

The accounts did not form harmony. They rubbed against one another, rough and unresolved. Ossa understood then why the College preferred ledgers. A column could flatten every limp into service years. This room gave each cost a gait.

Hessa opened a cabinet whose shelves held the shoes the veterans had worn on their last assignments. None resembled a keepsake. Salt had furred the seams. Leather scores had split where the ground refused their intended limits. Each pair carried a brass pension tag, though several tags bore fresh chisel marks where the College had revised a service category.

"Those marks arrived after retirement," Hessa said. "A center gets full stone credit. A brace gets half. A worker whose joint hardens after release gets no credit unless three licensed witnesses saw the first discoloration."

Seni drew out a child-sized pair. "Maro Quill entered as a water carrier at thirteen. By fourteen he could feel a bridge settling before trained feet noticed. They put him beside the center without licensing him, so his pension record calls him auxiliary labor."

"What happened to him?" Ruhan asked.

"He lives above the western lime pits. His spine bends toward every bridge he hears."

Tavra examined a separated sole. The old score had routed pressure toward the wearer's heel instead of the official center mark. "Somebody altered this after cutting."

"I did," Hessa said. "The bridge began taking the crew sideways. Our cutter followed the approved diagram. I added a spill channel with a nail."

"You saved the line."

"I saved six bodies and lost my license. Then the company listed the alteration as proof that my ankle damage came from misconduct." Hessa returned the shoe to its shelf. "That is how the College keeps every outcome useful. Obey, and the road proves the system. Improvise, and the injury proves the worker."

Ossa knew the same arithmetic from military discipline. A cadence officer who kept a line received honor. One who broke count to save a stumbling marcher accepted responsibility for every later gap. The rule made obedience appear safer by assigning all visible blame to refusal.

Brin lifted his trouser cuff again, this time exposing a stamped iron ring above the ankle. "Pension examiner sealed that on me after my fifth year. Said it would measure whether the bend progressed."

The ring had sunk into mineralized flesh. Ossa swallowed against the remembered sight of marching irons, though this device carried the neat College flower instead of an army number.

"Does it come off?" she asked.

"With the foot."

Nobody smiled.

Ruhan turned one of the revised brass tags over in his good hand. "Could these prove concealment?"

"They prove alteration," Tavra said. "Miren's clerks will claim correction. We need the earlier entries beside the later ones, plus bodies willing to testify."

"You keep saying bodies," Seni replied. "Try names."

Tavra's face tightened. "Maro Quill. Brin. Hessa Dorn. Laro Ves." She looked around the cellar and continued until she had repeated every name offered. Some took her more than one attempt. Nobody rescued her from the work.

Ossa watched the old reflex in Tavra strain toward a plan. The score-cutter wanted to arrange testimony, match injury to route, turn suffering into a shape that officials could not evade. Yet she closed her mouth and waited for Hessa to decide what the cabinet meant.

Hessa shut the doors. "We did not keep these for an imperial hearing. We kept them because new crews deserve to know what the diagrams leave out. If your archive route opens, take the pension pages. These shoes stay with their owners."

"Agreed," Tavra said.

The answer came promptly, but it came without correction. Ossa marked that small restraint and refused to praise it aloud.

Hessa pushed a second board across the table. Seven charcoal circles crossed a map of imperial routes. Dates crowded their edges.

"Scheduled anchors," she said. "Permanent crews have been moving stones under repair warrants. We unload the carts. We know the difference between granite from a bridge and anchor stone wrapped in wet felt."

Tavra leaned forward. "Seven holds."

"Seven we've seen. The capital counts as another sort of knot." Hessa touched three circles. "Rehearsal orders put these companies in place within ten days. The notices promise double pension credit."

"Paid in stone," Seni said.

Ossa recognized the routes. Hadrin lay beneath the southern circle, where grain roads crossed the ridge Pel had died upon. She had known the command skin named seven anchors. She had not known the College had recruited retired workers to train their replacements.

"You asked why we opened the door," Hessa said. "Not for Tavra. Half this room still wants to throw her into a ditch."

"Choose a soft ditch," Tavra muttered.

A few mouths tightened. Not laughter, but room enough for breath.

Hessa continued. "We opened because riders came last week asking which of us

could still keep a rehearsal count. They offered arrears. Then workers at Jalen sent the dates. Your evidence gives the dates their purpose."

Ossa touched the inner rim of her drum. The erased command cuts remained under her fingertips. "There is something your evidence needs."

Tavra's head turned sharply. She knew what Ossa intended. That knowledge almost stopped her.

Ossa carried the drum to the center of the cellar. "Seven years ago, at Hadrin, I held cadence for the imperial forced march."

Brin's cup struck the table. Seni put one hand over his before he could rise.

Ossa did not soften the words. "Refugees occupied a ridge marked for a grain road. The order said move them east. The ground had turned south during the night. We marched anyway."

"You marched people?" Hessa asked.

"Trained road crews. The command cadence took their practiced response before fear could break it. They drove the ridge. The civilians had nowhere level to go."

Her brother's face did not come to her whole. Pel returned as details: a damp curl against his temple; his left thumb taping the drum rim before every parade; the foolish red laces he wore because regulation dye bored him. The ravine had taken those details apart.

"My younger brother, Pel, served in the third line. He heard the ground slipping and left his mark to pull two children clear. I struck the recall. Then I struck command again when the captain ordered me to recover the line."

Silence reached no clean count.

"How many?" Seni asked.

"Forty-one civilians found. Nine workers. More remained beneath the ridge. Pel remained there."

"And you deserted," Brin said.

"Afterward."

"Convenient."

"Yes."

He stood with Seni's help. His left ankle could not flatten, forcing his weight onto the outside edge. "My daughter carried that grain road for five years after your company made it. You let her train on ground packed with bodies."

"I did."

Tavra started to speak. Ossa held up a hand without looking at her.

Brin came close enough that Ossa smelled broth on his breath. "Did you know?"

"Not her name. I knew companies maintained the road. I chose not to learn

who.”

His palm struck her cheek. The blow had little force. His balance cost him more. Ossa could have caught his elbow before he stumbled, but Seni reached him first.

“No command from you,” Brin said. “Not here.”

“None.”

“Not even a clever broken beat that lets us pretend your choice belongs to us.”

“None.”

She returned to the wall and sat on the floor beside her stripped drum. Shame often tempted movement: flee, confess faster, offer a plan, make usefulness purchase permission to remain. She kept still while the room decided whether to expel her.

The veterans argued for nearly an hour.

Some wanted the evidence carried directly to civil courts. Hessa answered that Chancellor Miren’s clerks had redirected injury petitions for eleven years. Others proposed breaking anchor stones. Tavra warned that an unscored break could leave stored torque in every dancer attached to the field. Brin wanted to warn active crews and let them choose. Seni asked how warning mattered when refusal cancelled grain rights and pension years.

Ossa said nothing until Hessa addressed her.

“You know command schedules. If a company delays rehearsal without breaking its anchor, what happens?”

“Depends on the delay.”

“That sounded like the beginning of an order.”

Ossa placed both palms on the floor. “Then ask a narrower question.”

Hessa considered. “How much time can one crew steal?”

“If the first center reports an uneven salt line, inspectors grant half a day. A drummer who loses tension can claim another quarter. Anchor survey takes longer if three witnesses dispute the local stone.”

Brin stared down at the map. “Different excuses.”

“Different choices,” Ossa said. “A repeated failure exposes coordination. Separate defects look like ordinary road work.”

“A choir of bent ankles,” Seni said, “each missing a different note.”

This time the room did laugh, quietly and without kindness.

Tavra shifted the heated brick under her thigh. “Delay does not stop the Measure.”

“No,” Hessa replied. “It gives you time to reach the archive. It gives active crews time to see these names.” She tapped the copied pension ledger. “After that, they decide.”

"You risk every pension in this cellar."

"We already spent our bodies earning promises the College edits after death."

Ruhan bent over the schedule. "The east wall reaches its inward step tomorrow near dawn. If we enter with the refuse carts, the wall carries us toward the archive quarter."

"Gates inspect carts," Tavra said.

"Gates do," Hessa answered. "A moving wall has other habits."

She brought out a mason's rubbing. It showed an old relief: a stair, six hands raised beneath a broken cliff, and a thin boy on the highest step.

"College workers receive this story before their first center training," she said. "Oris. Sixty-three years ago the town moved under winter rock. Six hundred dead. Serad Vale survived on a temple stair. He tells apprentices that unheld ground killed his family because nobody accepted authorship."

Ossa had heard shortened versions in barracks: Oris as warning, Serad as the boy who learned to keep roads faithful. "He believes it."

"Belief can build an honest grave," Hessa said. "He took a disaster and made it permission."

Tavra studied the rubbing. "He showed me the stair after Nareth. Told me my failure proved the ground punishes hesitation."

"What did you tell him?" Ruhan asked.

"I believed him long enough to leave my daughter in his College."

The admission landed differently from Ossa's confession. No blow followed. Hessa rolled up the rubbing and returned it to its tube.

"Oris explains his hands," she said. "It does not place ours inside them."

Before dawn, the veterans made their choices one by one. Seni would miscut a replacement heel at the northern rehearsal yard. Brin would visit his daughter and show her Laro Ves's pension entry. The brothers would file competing claims over an anchor's quarry origin. Hessa would send no central instruction. She marked each volunteered delay on separate scraps, then burned the list after everyone had memorized only their own part.

Ossa watched discipline take shape without cadence. It looked untidy. People repeated questions. Two withdrew. One changed from sabotage to warning. Nobody matched breath.

Hessa gave Ruhan a clay token stamped with a mason's open palm. "Show this at the washerwomen's shrine inside the east wall. Leave the Nareth score there if pursuit closes. The shrine moves with the old masonry, not the gate schedule."

Ruhan tucked the token into his left sleeve. "Who retrieves it?"

"The wall decides where the shrine passes, but washerwomen decide who reaches inside."

Tavra tried to stand. Her left leg buckled. Ossa moved, then stopped before touching her.

"May I?"

Tavra's annoyance flared. Beneath it, something loosened. "Under the right arm. Don't pull the knee."

Together they raised her. Ruhan shouldered the evidence bag with his sound hand. The Nareth fragment remained wrapped against his ribs, outside Tavra's reach by her own prior choice.

At the cellar door, Brin blocked Ossa. Morning had thinned the dark behind him.

"I do not forgive you," he said.

"I didn't ask."

"You came here intending to use us."

"Yes."

"Are you still?"

Ossa listened to Seni file a heel in the rear room, each stroke deliberately uneven. "No. I am going where you gave us leave to go."

Brin stepped aside.

The fugitives entered the grey road toward Meren. Behind them, twenty-three damaged workers began missing twenty-three different beats, and not one belonged to Ossa.

Chapter 12 — The Capital's Moving Walls

The eastern wall took its hidden step while Eda stood beneath it.

Mortar whispered above the gatehouse. A carved lion shifted half a thumb-width out of alignment with its paws. Six apprentices in grey rehearsal coats bent together, soles grinding into salted boards, and forced the stone back before the waiting dignitaries could notice.

Eda noticed. She felt the correction through the platform under her right foot: a lateral pull, a pause, then counter-motion driven down through six young bodies. The smallest apprentice trembled at the knees.

Master Chorearch Serad Vale continued his welcome to the provincial delegation. "Meren has held this approach through three reigns. What moves beyond our walls need not disturb the grain scales within them."

Polite hands struck polite palms. Eda kept hers at her sides.

The capital had never seemed fixed to her. As a child, she had learned its secret corrections by sleeping against College floors. The north wall leaned inward during wet months. Western stairs added a shallow rise every seventh morning. The east gate preferred to travel south whenever the distant chalk country turned. College measures cancelled these motions before citizens reached breakfast.

Yet the correction beneath her carried twice its usual force.

The smallest apprentice lost her heel mark. Another caught the shift, taking extra weight through his hip. His mouth opened without sound.

Eda stepped away from Serad's line of honor and onto the salted board.

"Center," the supervising cutter hissed. "Return to position."

"Your fourth brace has no exit channel." She pointed to the apprentice who had caught the load. "Release him on my count."

"We are under display order."

"Then display competence."

Eda set her left sole beside the damaged mark. She did not enter center. She offered a short outer brace, enough to divide the pull while the cutter carved a release notch with shaking hands.

"One," she said. "Weight inward. Two. Fourth brace, lift. Three. Let the wall have the finger-width."

Stone moved overhead. The lion's shoulder separated from its painted outline. Several dignitaries looked up.

The apprentice sagged into his neighbor's arms. Eda felt the wall settle in its preferred place, no longer pretending perfect alignment.

Serad finished his speech without raising his voice. When the delegation passed

under the gate, he came to stand beside her.

"You exposed a visible deviation," he said.

"I prevented a broken hip."

"The relief will be reset tonight."

"By different apprentices?"

"By a rested company." His gaze went to her improvised brace mark. Genuine approval warmed it, which made her anger harder to keep simple. "Clean judgment. You felt the secondary pull before I did."

"You were speaking."

"I was watching you choose whether to intervene."

The answer could have meant trust. It could also have meant a test built from somebody else's joints.

Eda stepped off the board. "Why has the east correction doubled?"

"Worker disruptions on the outer holds. Nothing dangerous."

"The wall moved against six centers."

"Six braces. The designated center stood inside the gate."

The apprentices carried a seventh dancer past on a litter. His bare feet had gone grey to the ankle.

Serad watched Eda watch him. "Counter-motion stains. He will recover."

"Will he?"

"The infirmary has treated worse."

That reply did not answer her question. Eda had spent sixteen years understanding the difference between assurance and measure.

A civil secretary arrived with Chancellor Miren's ivory seal. Serad glanced toward the gate, where masons already hung canvas over the displaced lion.

"Miren wants both of us," he said. "She has received news from Jalen, and Tavra has crossed the capital boundary."

Her mother's name still found the old hollow under Eda's ribs. She stepped around it.

"Then we should not keep the chancellor waiting."

Meren built its government on a hill that migrated in a narrow circle beneath the city. The Still Court crowned its upper shelf; ministries occupied terraces below. Porters adjusted ramps each morning while official plans continued to show straight stairs. Eda climbed beside Serad and counted fresh wedges hammered under the civil archive.

At the second terrace, a survey crew had opened the pavement around an older foundation. The exposed stones leaned west in a graceful course that no imperial

mason would have designed. Painted measure marks crossed them in layers: red from the previous reign, black from Serad's first wall stabilization, fresh white from this week.

Eda stopped to read the cuts. "This foundation has shifted six times since spring."

Serad did not slow. "Minor corrections."

"Each correction crosses the last one."

"Which proves the necessity of consolidation."

It proved that stone continued to move beneath every claim of completion. Eda crouched beside the trench. A mason had chalked a private warning on the lowest block: LEFT FOOT SLIPS AT THIRD COUNT. The official score assigned no dancer to that position.

A foreman recognized her coat and hurried over. "Center, the trench has not been cleared for inspection."

"Who wrote this warning?"

He looked toward Serad's retreating back. "A wall tender."

"Name."

"Lemi Sarn."

"Where is she?"

"Infirmary. The block took her foot yesterday."

Eda traced the crossing measures without touching them. Every new hold forced the next correction into less accommodating stone. The capital's hidden labor did not preserve one fixed arrangement. It accumulated restraint until workers had to drive each change through the scars of older changes.

"Why not release this course and rebuild the terrace one stride west?" she asked.

The foreman stared as though she had suggested moving the palace into a ditch. "Property seals follow the current wall."

"Stairs can turn."

"Tax rooms cannot."

Behind them, a porter dropped a wedge under the archive ramp. The moving wall beside him travelled a hair's breadth and pinched the wood hard enough to split it. He swore, replaced the wedge, then painted over the crack before an official could see.

Eda rose. "Send me Lemi Sarn's injury report."

"To the Fifth Measure?"

"To me."

The foreman bowed without promising. By the time Eda caught Serad at the

next stair, two clerks had covered the chalk warning with a clean slab.

"You delay for local defects while the road web approaches disorder," Serad said.

"Local defects carry names."

"And leadership carries scale. You will need both if you mean to surpass me."

He intended the words as confidence in her. Once, that confidence could have lifted her through a week of bruised rehearsals. Today it felt like another score laid beneath her feet, flattering in the direction it allowed.

They crossed the terrace as a file of laborers hauled the split ramp away. A delivery cart waited below because the new angle no longer met its wheels. Citizens flowed around it with the practiced irritation of people trained to call constant adjustment stillness.

Chancellor Miren waited in a receiving room whose windows had been bricked twice and reopened twice as the wall shifted. She stood over a table crowded with grain tallies. Her silver hair had escaped its pins.

"Three rehearsal companies have reported defective salt," Miren said before greeting them. "Two anchor surveys dispute quarry origin. A drummer at north Jalen claims damp skin after nine dry days."

"Worker mischief," Serad replied.

"Mischief that has delayed southern grain guarantees."

"Replace the crews."

"With whom? Retired centers are refusing recall. If I strip active road maintenance, market routes will wander before your convocation." Miren turned to Eda. "Your mother has help among company veterans."

Eda examined the tally nearest her. The delayed routes did not yet show shortage, only uncertainty. Red circles marked contracts that would fail if roads shifted beyond agreed toll stations.

"What evidence did she show them?" Eda asked.

Miren's mouth thinned. "Pension complaints from Nareth. Dead workers acquire remarkable political usefulness when someone needs a crowd."

"Were the complaints false?"

"Authenticity does not make them relevant to present route stability."

Serad moved one grain marker back into line. "Tavra uses old grief to disrupt a measure she has not read."

Eda thought of the apprentice's grey feet. "You could publish the full injury allowances."

Miren gave a dry breath. "And invite every road company to calculate private risk while the continent changes under them?"

"That sounds like asking them to know what they carry."

"It sounds like government ceasing while thousands bargain with weather." Miren's finger pressed on the Hadrún tally. "Two missed deliveries empty capital reserve bins within sixteen days. I cannot feed districts on moral clarity."

Eda understood that arithmetic. She did not accept the missing column.

"What happens to Hadrún if its roads hold beyond their seasonal release?"

Miren looked to Serad. He answered with care. "Local strain. We have designed spill measures."

"Where does the spill go?"

"Into prepared centers."

That answer matched the College doctrine she had mastered. It also matched the grey feet on the litter.

A wall bell sounded three uneven notes. Servants caught the picture frames before the room shifted north. Miren braced the grain table with both hands. Nobody commented on the movement.

Serad waited until the floor settled. "Accelerate eastern and southern rehearsals. Full company tomorrow."

"Stillday remains fourteen days away," Miren said.

"Worker delays make gradual preparation unreliable."

Eda looked at him. "You want my Fifth Measure on the east field."

"At dawn. Then southern transfer."

She heard the unspoken sum: Tavra near the wall, workers delaying, time narrowing. "I need Folio Seven tonight."

"You have its assigned sections."

"The east field touches two anchor lines. I need the center transitions."

His expression softened into the patience he had used when she was thirteen and furious over a failed turn. "After rehearsal. Not before."

Miren dismissed them to separate duties. Eda left by the service stair rather than descend beside Serad. Halfway down, the stair carried her east.

The movement came gently, one old block sliding against another. A seam opened behind a hanging prayer cloth. Cool air touched her wrist.

Eda stopped.

The College listed no shrine in this wall. The cloth showed washerwomen raising wet sheets, its blue pigment polished by generations of fingers. Behind it, a narrow cavity moved with the masonry. A clay lamp burned inside.

Someone breathed beyond the opening.

Eda entered sideways. The passage turned twice and widened into a chamber

no larger than a laundry stall. Water bowls lined one shelf. Offerings of buttons, soap, and broken shoe buckles crowded another. A man stood at the far wall with a wrapped strip of leather in his left hand. His right wrist lay splinted against his chest.

She recognized him from Kesta: Ruhan Tal, the pass-runner who had guided Tavra beyond the survey lines.

He recognized her at the same moment. His left hand dropped toward his belt knife.

"You would lose that exchange," Eda said.

"I have lost exchanges on better ground."

"The wall carries this room toward a guard post in four minutes."

"Then we should be quick."

His route calm irritated her because it declined the fear her uniform deserved. She saw mud dried to his hem, exhaustion around his eyes, and a mason's clay token on the shelf.

"What are you hiding?"

"Something your wall has agreed to keep."

"Walls do not agree."

"Washerwomen do. This wall shrine belongs to their route."

He slid the wrapped leather behind a loose votive stone. Eda crossed the chamber before he could replace it. She caught his left forearm, turned him toward the wall, and took the bundle. He did not draw his knife. With only one working hand, he could not safely contest her without dropping both balance and secrecy.

The wrapping smelled of cellar earth. Inside lay a torn sole-score, dark with old oil. Nareth marks ran across it.

Eda's grip loosened.

Tavra's trial records included diagrams of the failed holding, but none carried the original cuts. This fragment showed a release turn severed by a later command incision. The official copy had presented that turn as Tavra's unauthorized alteration. Here, the older leather told a different sequence: release first, imperial override crossing it afterward.

"Nareth score," Ruhan said. "Your mother kept the fragment."

"She kept evidence while letting the College call her a coward."

"She kept evidence while hiding from you. Those choices can both condemn her."

Eda looked up sharply. She had expected defense, perhaps worship of the fugitive cutter who turned roads. Ruhan offered neither.

"Why give it to you?"

"She could no longer trust herself not to trade it for your safety."

The words struck harder than an accusation. They sounded exactly like Tavra: seeing control clearly only after arranging everyone around it.

Footsteps entered the outer passage.

Ruhan reached for the fragment. Eda kept it.

Through a mortar gap she saw two College guards stop beside the prayer cloth. One carried a hook for searching wall cavities. The shrine shifted another handspan toward them.

"Dancer?" called the nearer guard. "Did you enter there?"

Eda rolled the fragment once, memorizing the broken release and the command cut. She returned it to its cloth, placed it behind the votive stone, and pushed Ruhan into the shallow recess beside the water bowls.

"I dropped a hip clasp," she called. "Unless you wish to explain searching me to Master Vale, continue your wall check elsewhere."

The hook scratched the opening.

"Apologies, center."

Boots withdrew. Eda waited through twenty breaths. Ruhan remained close enough that his splint pressed her sleeve, but he did not mistake concealment for trust.

"You read enough," he said when the wall carried them away from the guards.

"Enough to know the trial copy lied about sequence."

"Enough to let us pass?"

"I let this shrine keep what belongs to Nareth. I have not joined Tavra."

"No one asked you to."

That irritated her more.

He took the mason's token and left the score hidden. "The wall returns here near sunset. Washerwomen will move the fragment deeper before then."

"You are walking away from it?"

"Custody does not always require a pocket." He glanced at her uniform shoes. "You might tell your College that."

Eda stepped aside. "The southern drain opens when this passage turns. Avoid the archive stair. Serad doubled its guard."

Ruhan paused. "Why?"

"Because the original score contradicts his record."

"That did not answer me."

"No. It is all you get."

He disappeared with the next shift, leaving the Nareth fragment behind the

votive stone. Eda remained until the passage opened onto a laundry court.

An elderly washerwoman waited on the other side with wet sleeves rolled above her elbows. She neither bowed to Eda's coat nor looked surprised by the hidden door.

"You frightened my runner," she said.

"He drew no weapon."

"He knows better than to cut someone in a room full of soap. Blood never leaves linen honestly." She handed Eda a basket of damp uniforms. "Carry these if you intend to stand in my court looking official."

Eda accepted the basket. "The shrine holds evidence from Nareth."

"The shrine holds buckles, prayers, two unpaid laundry chits, and whatever else women put there while walls pass useful places."

"Guards may search it."

"Guards search fixed holes. Ours moves." The washerwoman began pinning shirts to a line. "Your man with the broken wrist says the fragment must reach Hadrún after someone reads it."

"He does not belong to me."

"Good. Men carried as property wear out the handles."

Eda looked back. The opening had already narrowed behind stone. "Can you keep it from College inspection?"

"I can move it among six shrines. I cannot promise a seventh. That honest enough for a center?"

It offered less certainty than a College vault and more truth than Serad had given her all morning. "Yes."

"Then set those uniforms by the blue vat. When the wall reaches the dyers, someone will carry your evidence out in a soap barrel."

"Not mine," Eda said.

The washerwoman glanced at her. "Learning quickly."

Steam hung above rows of sheets. Across the yard, beyond three moving partitions, Tavra limped between Ossa and a cart stacked with ash barrels. Her left leg stayed nearly straight. Each step pulled her mouth tight. She looked older than she had at Kesta and more dangerous because Eda could now see the cost she had been concealing.

Tavra glanced toward the laundry court.

For one suspended moment, wall gaps aligned. Mother and daughter saw each other through the moving masonry.

Tavra took half a step forward. Eda raised one hand, palm out. Not welcome. Not alarm. A demand that Tavra leave this choice to her.

Ossa touched Tavra's shoulder. The ash cart rolled on. Stone crossed the sightline.

A College runner found Eda before she reached the Fifth Measure dormitory. "Master Vale orders full east rehearsal at first bell. All center transitions committed from memory. No folios on the field."

"Tell him I understand."

Inside her chamber, Folio Seven waited in its locked cedar case. The stitched center section made a narrow ridge under the leather cover. Serad had forbidden her to open it. That morning she had treated the prohibition as a test of discipline. Now it resembled the canvas hung over the shifted lion, a clean surface placed before inconvenient movement.

Eda set her smallest sole knife beside the stitches.

She did not cut yet. First she barred the door, filled the washbasin to conceal the sound, and removed tomorrow's rehearsal shoes from their rack. Then she placed Folio Seven between them and chose where the first thread would part.

Chapter 13 — The Dance of Open Ground

Tavra cut the first sole beneath a cabbage awning while College bells sealed the common.

The vendor kept selling around her. Copper weights struck the scale pan; a knife thudded through stems; customers argued over bruised leaves while Tavra braced the leather against her good thigh and opened a shallow turning channel. Every sound travelled through the market stones into her left knee.

The common wanted to widen toward the river. Imperial holds had denied that movement for eighty years. Pressure gathered under the western stalls, where paving blocks had begun climbing over one another like badly stacked plates. A conventional measure would drive the plaza flat and send the counter-motion through a trained center. Tavra had no center, no licensed company, and no right to spend the vendors' bodies.

She had forty minutes before the search closed every lane.

"Again," she told the cabbage seller. "Show me how you move the full basket."

The woman, Yali, planted her left foot and swung a reed basket from hip to scale. Her right foot followed without taking weight.

"You do that all morning?"

"Until cabbages learn to walk themselves."

"Any old injury in the left ankle? Stone staining? Pain after the market shifts?"

Yali's suspicion deepened. "You buying vegetables or feet?"

"Neither. I need one step you already take. I will tell you the cost before I ask you to take it."

Ossa stood at the awning edge with the stripped frame of her drum under one arm. Without its outer skin she could make only a dry rim knock, too weak to command and useful precisely for that reason. Ruhan watched the north arcade, his splinted right wrist pinned inside his coat. Ash from their cart streaked his cheek.

"Riders at the spice lane," he said. "Four, perhaps six behind."

"Then buy something fragrant," Tavra replied. "You look conspicuous when you merely lurk."

He came back with a fist of cloves he did not want.

Tavra turned the sole toward Yali. "This cut lets your basket swing take a finger-width of rise from the western stones and return it when you set the basket down. You may feel a pull in the calf. If the pull reaches the knee, stop. You take it once. No repetition."

"What happens if I refuse?"

"We find another route. The riders catch us sooner. Your stall continues leaning until the city company resets the common."

"So refusal may get you caught."

"Yes."

"And you will not call that my fault?"

"No."

Yali wiped her knife. "Put it on."

The altered sole strapped over her market shoe. Tavra marked the stone beside the scale with a pinch of step-salt, charcoal, and oil. Rain had not touched the capital for two days, but market washwater had already blurred old licensing lines. She left the new mark open on its river side.

At the next stall, a potter used a backward heel press to stop his wheel. A fishmonger shifted a tub by taking weight through the outside of her right foot. Two porters lowered bales with matching movements, but Tavra accepted only one of them. Matching bodies tempted matching demands. The other porter swore at her and left.

She explained each cut separately. Direction. Limit. Likely strain. Stop signal. Exit.

Some vendors refused after hearing the risk. One agreed until his daughter objected, then removed the trial sole. A flour seller wanted payment. Ossa gave her the last silver College button cut from the inner drum skin. Nobody received a lecture about courage.

Tavra's knee burned as she crouched. Pale mineral lines had climbed above the kneecap during the night. She hid none of it. When people asked what ground-dance could do to a body, she pulled up her trouser leg.

"This," she said. "At a scale far beyond one market step, held too long and released too late. Your cut cannot take that load unless I lie about the boundary. Look at the salt. If anyone closes the river gap, step out."

A bread seller named Omel studied the marks. "Who receives what we return?"

"The ground does, if I cut the exits correctly."

"If you do not?"

"The western participants take bruising. I take the central spill through this knee."

"That sounds like a center."

"It is a last fault, not a design."

Ossa heard the evasion. Her mouth flattened.

Tavra amended it. "I do not know whether a fault will open. This has worked across one road turn, not a plaza. I believe the separate steps keep the load small. Belief does not make it safe."

Omel nodded once. "Now I believe your warning."

At the center of the common, the imperial anchor rested beneath a bronze fountain. Tavra did not touch it. She salted a loose crescent around the fountain and left three gaps wide enough for a handcart. The trial needed local stone to answer, but binding the civic anchor would alert every College dancer in Meren.

Ruhan unfolded a scrap of his atlas on a fruit crate. The page showed no stable streets, only yesterday's wall movements and places where residents had refused passage. "If the common widens, the south arcade narrows."

"How much?" Tavra asked.

"Enough to trap a loaded cart, not a person. Unless the dyers' wall arrives early."

"Can you keep that lane empty?"

"I can ask. I cannot keep."

"Ask."

He went toward the dyers, cloves perfuming his escape.

Ossa tapped the drum rim twice, spaced too far apart for trained feet to mistake as command. "Search at west lane."

Tavra counted participants. Eleven. Too few for the common's full breadth, enough to test the western rise. Each wore one added sole. No two cuts matched. A flower seller's toe pivot angled pressure toward the open salt. Yali's basket swing would meet it without mirroring. The potter's heel stop lay third, but only if he chose to take it after seeing the first stones move.

Tavra climbed onto the fountain lip. Her left leg could not bend enough to sit. "Listen before you decide. One simple step each. Take only the movement we agreed. If your mark cracks, do nothing. If another person falls, do not repeat your step to help. Ossa will knock once to begin and then make no count. You may leave now or after any movement."

A butcher unstrapped his sole and walked away. College bells sounded from the spice lane.

Ten remained.

"This is not a hold," Tavra said. "We let the common move a little and return what it cannot carry. We are crossing it, not curing it."

"Your speech is longer than my step," Yali called.

"Most honest warnings are."

A rider entered the west lane. Behind him, two civil watchmen tried to keep customers from surging toward the narrow exits, but neither dared cross Tavra's fresh salt. The crowd had already begun making its own routes between stalls.

Ossa struck the rim once.

Yali swung her cabbage basket.

Her left sole pressed the cut. The paving block beneath her dipped, not down but riverward, passing its stored rise into the open line. She set the basket by the scale. The stone eased half a finger-width and stopped.

Nobody else moved.

Tavra felt the plaza waiting through her bad knee. Not alive in thought. Responsive in weight, carrying old directions beneath imposed flatness.

The potter chose his heel press. His wheel slowed. Three blocks turned around the fountain, opening a seam that breathed dust.

The rider shouted.

The fishmonger put her shoulder to the tub and took her outside-foot step. Water slopped silver over the paving. A ridge travelled under two stalls, low enough that cups rattled but did not fall.

Participants acted from their own work, not Tavra's count. A porter lowered his bale. Omel leaned into the oven peel. The flower seller pivoted away from a customer. Between movements came uncertain pauses that no licensed company would tolerate. Those pauses saved them. Stone settled, offered another fraction of torque, and found a different foot.

The rider urged his horse onto the common. Its front shoes struck the loose crescent and skidded. He dragged the reins hard, turning the animal before it fell.

"Illegal measure!" he called. "Clear the field!"

"Already clearing," Yali said, and handed a cabbage to a customer.

A second rider reached the fountain from the north. Behind him marched College braces in blue-soled shoes, trained to flatten any local deviation. Tavra saw their intended route in the set of their shoulders. If they entered together, they would force every loose block back into imperial alignment and pour the common's released pressure into the nearest active cuts: the vendors.

"Ossa, no second beat."

"I heard your rules."

Tavra jumped down. Her knee failed on impact. Pain drove white through her vision. She caught the fountain basin and stayed upright.

"Those who stepped, remove the added soles," she called. "Now. Trial finished."

The flower seller fumbled her strap. Ossa went to help, then held out the knife handle and let the woman cut it herself. Yali kicked free of her sole before the first brace crossed the salt.

A College officer pointed at Tavra. "Take the cutter. Hold the common."

His braces entered on a command count.

Their first unified step struck the plaza like a lid. The western stones drove back against their climb. Pressure ran toward the fountain and split around Tavra's open gaps. Two streams escaped beneath empty handcart lanes. A third met a salt clot

where spilled fish water had gathered charcoal into paste.

The clot closed the release.

Counter-motion hit Tavra's left knee.

She dropped to both hands. Mineral cold shot into her thigh. The common tilted riverward by the width of a fingernail, then stuck between the vendors' partial release and the College hold.

Ossa grabbed her coat. "Can you stand?"

"Wrong question." Tavra forced air into her lungs. "Break the fish-water clot."

"With what?"

"Your heel. No score. Scuff it, don't step through."

Ossa looked at the College braces closing. "Cost?"

"Bruised heel if the pressure catches. Broken ankle if you cross the line."

That answer took a heartbeat they did not own. Ossa chose. She dragged her heel through the wet salt and jumped back.

The release opened. Stone flexed under the advancing braces. Their shared alignment lost its flat reference. One dancer lifted early; another compensated; the command count frayed without Ossa striking anything.

Tavra hauled herself upright by the fountain. "Participants out by the south arcade. Do not take another step from the trial. Ordinary walking only."

Yali supported Omel. The potter abandoned his wheel. Ten vendors left by routes they chose, carrying no obligation to save the fugitives.

Tavra stayed long enough to watch the last added sole come free. A strap had tightened around Omel's swollen instep, and Yali's cabbage knife could not reach it without cutting skin. Tavra opened the leather from the outer edge while the baker gripped the fountain lip.

"Calf?" she asked.

"Pulled."

"Knee?"

"Mine, still."

"Any cold under the bone?"

"No." Omel watched the College braces struggle across the loosened paving. "Was that success?"

"The plaza moved. You remained standing. The release nearly closed and my knee took the spill. Call it a useful warning."

"You promised a crossing, not a victory."

"I promised risk. I hoped for victory."

"That hope belongs on the warning next time."

Tavra cut the last strap. "Yes."

Omel tested his bare market shoe and limped once toward the arcade. Yali took his oven peel in addition to her basket. Neither waited for Tavra's thanks.

A child crouched beside the discarded trial soles, reaching for the flower seller's scored leather. Tavra swept them all into a produce sack.

"Why can't I try?" the child demanded.

"Because these cuts belong to other feet on ground that has already changed."

"My feet are better."

"Almost certainly. They are still not hers." Tavra handed the sack to a refuse collector sheltering beneath the fountain. "Put these in your stove. Do not sell them."

The collector weighed the leather. "Good goat."

"Bad fire if College catches you with it."

He tucked the sack under ash. That destroyed Tavra's only record of the experiment. Her craft instinct recoiled. A master cutter kept patterns, marked corrections, built improvement from repeatable cuts. Yet a copied sole might recruit an absent body into a second trial without warning. She memorized principles instead: separate work movements, open edge, single use, no shared count. The precise cuts could die.

College braces spread in pairs across the common. Their officer had learned from the first unified failure. Two dancers approached each raised seam from opposing angles, reducing the plaza section by section. It worked. Every forced flattening sent a narrow tremor through nearby stall legs.

"They will put it all back," Ossa said.

"For today."

"And load their centers doing it."

Tavra watched one brace's lips pale with each correction. The experiment had shifted cost, not abolished it. By leaving, she preserved the volunteers and abandoned trained dancers still caught under orders. Every route out carried somebody's body behind it.

She approached the nearest open salt gap and drove her knife into the charcoal paste. One short cut toward the river widened the exit without forming a new score. The next College correction bled part of its pressure away. A fish stall settled crooked rather than flat.

The officer saw her. "She is altering the field!"

Three braces broke toward the fountain.

"That purchased perhaps two corrections," Tavra said.

Ossa caught her under the arm. "Then spend them moving."

They hauled Tavra behind a row of hanging rugs as College braces recovered their count. The fabric slapped their faces, carrying dye and market dust. A cutter's hook tore through the rug one handspan behind Tavra's shoulder.

At the rug seller's bench, an old man sat calmly restringing his awning. "Your plaza rise snapped my red line," he told Tavra.

"I'm sorry."

"Sorry does poor knot work." He tossed her a cord. "Pull."

She looped it around her wrist and leaned while Ossa secured the upper spar. The delay cost ten breaths. It restored the awning over two customers who had never agreed to a measure and still had to live with its result.

"Enough," the seller said. "Now run badly somewhere else."

Tavra obeyed.

Ruhan appeared atop a dyer's cart. "South lane clear. East wall arrives in nine minutes."

"Then we need eight."

"You need a knee."

"I misplaced one years ago."

He jumped down, landing on his left hand and boots while protecting the splint. Together he and Ossa took Tavra under the arms. They moved behind a row of hanging rugs as College braces recovered their count.

The common no longer lay flat enough for cavalry. The loosened paving had formed shallow ramps between stalls. Vendors who had refused the trial continued trading from these new levels, shouting prices over the pursuit. None joined the measure. None needed to. Their carts and awnings turned the changed ground into obstacles.

Tavra cut left behind a spice booth. A rider reached for her collar. Ruhan threw cloves into the horse's face. The animal sneezed and shied, carrying its furious rider into a display of copper pans.

"Worth the price," Ruhan said.

They crossed the pottery row. Behind them, the College officer ordered his braces to hold every seam at once. A center screamed as the common transferred three generations of denied movement into his shin.

Tavra stopped.

Ossa pulled her forward. "He entered under command."

"He still has a leg."

"You cannot release their measure from here."

"I can cut the anchor spill."

"You cannot reach the anchor."

Tavra hated her for being right. The fountain stood behind two lines of braces. Any return would recapture the vendors in the field. She let Ossa drag her on.

At the southern arcade, a squad closed the lane. Ruhan turned toward the dyers' passage, but the moving wall had arrived early. Masonry slid across its mouth.

"We wait for it," he said.

"We get arrested by it," Ossa replied.

A blue-soled dancer dropped from the wall stair between them and the common. Eda landed with her weight perfectly divided, Folio case absent, right hand empty.

Tavra's body recognized her daughter's balance before her mind found speech.

"Go," Eda said to Ossa and Ruhan.

Ossa shifted her grip on Tavra. "Unlikely."

"The officer wants Tavra. The dyers' wall opens a drain in thirty breaths. Take it when it does."

Tavra looked at the squad behind Eda. "You are giving them a route."

"I am giving him one." Eda nodded to Ruhan. "You stay."

Ruhan read the wall, then Tavra. "Your choice."

That phrase hurt more than the knee. Tavra removed her arm from his shoulder. "Take Ossa. Get the pension copies south."

Ossa's expression promised a later quarrel. She obeyed now because the evidence mattered beyond Tavra. They slipped between rugs as the wall opened a dark drainage slot.

Eda faced the College squad. "Search the common. The fugitive drummer entered the drain."

"What about Ilen?" the captain asked.

"I will bring her."

Her rank carried them away. When the last blue sole vanished, Eda seized Tavra's coat and pulled her into an alcove formed by the moving wall.

"Do not mistake that for rescue," she said.

"I wouldn't dare."

"You always dare."

The wall carried them east, hidden for perhaps a minute. Its movement pressed Tavra's shoulder against warm brick. Eda stood close enough that Tavra could see a twitch beneath her right eye, the sign that had appeared whenever a childhood exercise frightened her and she refused to admit it.

"You let Ruhan leave the shrine," Tavra said.

"He showed me the Nareth fragment."

Tavra's pulse changed. "Then you saw the release."

"I saw an imperial cut laid across it. I did not see twelve years of context. Give me that without deciding what I should do afterward."

The demand left no place for a protective lie.

Tavra put her weight against the wall. "Serad ordered the Nareth road held while the hillside had already begun to migrate. My first score included a release toward the empty quarry. His command revision crossed it and sent us forward. I felt the change before the third count."

"You continued."

"Yes."

"Why?"

"I believed breaking company would collapse the city road. I believed Serad had information I lacked. I believed skill meant carrying doubt without showing it."

"Houses went under."

"A hillside district. The official count named eighty-six dead. Residents said more seasonal workers lived beyond the census."

Eda's jaw worked once. "And your knees?"

"Took the road's lateral counter-motion after the hillside slipped. I cut the release too late. It saved part of the lower street and buried the rest faster."

"You kept the score."

"A fragment. Enough to prove sequence, not enough to clear me."

"Then you ran."

"Yes."

"From Serad?"

Tavra made herself answer the sharper truth. "From you. I looked at ten-year-old Eda and saw every company that might use her to reach me. Serad offered College custody and protection. I told myself leaving removed the danger."

"You never asked what I wanted."

"No."

"You never wrote the truth."

"No."

"You let me build my life around your silence."

"Yes."

Eda stepped back. The alcove narrowed around them as the wall continued its route. "Do not make agreement from my anger."

Tavra closed her mouth.

At last Eda asked, "What did you do on the common?"

"A limited release. Local work steps, each separately cut. Ten participants. Nobody repeated."

"You used untrained people."

"With disclosure. Some refused. They left."

"And if your spill gap had failed?"

"It nearly did. Fish water closed one line. Counter-motion entered my knee."

"So you built another plan where your body pays for every error."

The accuracy found bone. "I left a fault path."

"You left yourself beneath it. That differs in wording."

A guard's voice sounded beyond the brick. Eda waited until it passed.

"The method let the plaza flex," Tavra said. "Small scale only. It did not require one trained center."

"It required you to design every sole."

"Yes."

"Then you still owned the choices before anyone stepped."

Tavra looked toward the moving seam. She had thought disclosure solved command. Yet every participant had entered a shape only she understood. "I don't know how to cut what I don't own."

"Learn."

The word carried neither pardon nor invitation.

Tavra reached inside her coat and removed a narrow strip of uncut leather. She incised six words with the point of her knife, using the wall as a brace.

NO CENTER WITHOUT AN EXIT.

Eda read it. "A maxim did not save Nareth."

"I wrote it afterward."

"Of course you did."

"I am not asking you to flee with me."

"You came to Meren to remove me from the Dominion Measure."

"I came to keep you alive."

"By choosing my exit."

Tavra held out the leather. "Then take only the words. Decide whether they matter."

Eda did not accept the strip. "Say it."

"No center without an exit."

The wall opened onto a service yard. Eda stepped into sunlight and pain flashed across her face. Her right hand went to her hip.

Tavra saw the slight catch in her next turn. "You're hurt."

"Stress from the common. I intercepted the College hold before I found you."

"Let me see."

"No." Eda lowered her hand. "You do not get my body because you recognize damage."

The rebuke stopped Tavra more effectively than a guard.

Eda took the leather strip at last and slid it under her wrist cuff. "I return to Serad. I have questions he will answer only if he believes I still choose him."

"Do you?"

"I choose to read before either of you closes the ground around me."

She pointed to a refuse stair descending from the yard. "That reaches the river kilns. Ossa will wait two turns beyond the smoke gate. The shrine keeps the Nareth fragment. Do not retrieve it until the washerwomen move it."

Tavra accepted the route without improving it. "Your hip needs rest."

"It needs information."

Eda walked toward the College arcade. The right hip shortened every seventh stride, a stress line hidden from anyone who did not know her measure.

At the top stair, she paused without turning. "The common is still moving."

Tavra felt it through the injured knee: the plaza easing around the imperial hold, no longer flat, not yet safely released.

"I have to finish it," she said.

"You have to ask."

Eda continued uphill.

Tavra descended toward the kilns, where Ossa and Ruhan waited beyond the smoke gate. She would need the vendors who had already paid one step, but she would not ask them for another. The changed common required different feet, different choices, and a release she had not yet designed.

Behind her, market bells resumed at mismatched heights. The plaza had survived its first small freedom. It had also kept the cost of Tavra's mistakes, and this time she carried the knowledge toward other people instead of hiding it.

Chapter 14 — What the Dominion Measure Costs

The first stitch refused Eda's knife.

Serad had chosen waxed tendon, not ordinary book thread. Its fibres gripped the blade and drew the leather covers tighter when she pulled. She held Folio Seven against the floor with her left foot, eased pressure off her injured right hip, and sawed through one strand at a time beneath the sound of running water.

Her washbasin overflowed. Water spread across the tiles and carried scraps of black wax under the bed.

At the fourth stitch, the hidden section opened.

No title marked the first page. A foot diagram filled it from edge to edge: Eda's center position at the Still Court, seven radial anchor paths, and a dense field of counter-motion channels converging on both hips, spine, jaw, and heels. The notation carried Serad's hand. She knew his cuts as she knew her own balance, each limit drawn with spare confidence, each release tapered to preserve the outer companies.

The center diagram had no release.

Eda turned the page.

A table paired duration with bodily conversion. Eight hours: likely mineral invasion of both femoral joints. Twelve: partial fixation of the lower spine. Twenty: cardiac encasement probable. The planned hold did not end at twenty hours. A notation in Miren's clerk hand read CONTINUANCE ASSUMED AFTER CIVIL TRANSFER.

Permanent.

Her right hip clenched. She sat before it could fold, keeping the folio above the water.

Serad had told the College the Dominion Measure would secure the principal roads through one unstable season. Public notices promised a convocation hold, followed by staged release. These pages described no release. They treated her death as a timing uncertainty.

She read every line twice.

The next projection concerned companies. Seven anchors required four hundred trained centers and more than six thousand braces, cadence workers, salt crews, and cutters. Best case losses listed twelve hundred lasting joint conversions, three hundred severe mobility impairments, and fewer than ninety immediate deaths. Median projections doubled each figure. A margin note advised pension reserves sufficient for dependants but excluded unlicensed support labor from the estimate.

Eda thought of Lemi Sarn's foot beneath a foundation block. Auxiliary bodies did not disappear from the ground merely because a table excluded them.

She turned another page and found maps.

Hadrún's seasonal release valleys appeared under crosshatched grey. Kesta's recorded anchor orchards carried fixed circles despite having moved beyond those locations. The southern fig country showed spring paths narrowed into straight channels. Beneath each map, soil estimates projected progressive mineral binding.

Three provinces would lose root penetration within six years. Springs would fail earlier on high shelves. Grain output would rise for two fixed seasons, then decline as held soil hardened around old water routes. Serad's summary called that decline "acceptable regional exhaustion under central reserve mitigation."

Eda read the phrase until its elegance became obscene.

A packet stitched to the final map held witness extracts. Retired centers described stone cough, fused ankles, mineral lines entering the pelvis years after service. One copied report named Nareth fig roots turned to stone beneath a cellar. The date preceded Tavra's discovery by four years.

They had known.

Eda spread the provincial maps across her floor and matched their marks to the center table. The damage did not appear as one dramatic collapse. It arrived through ordinary failures spaced far enough apart for officials to rename them. A spring at first produced half its usual water. Fig roots stopped reaching beyond the old salted boundary. A release valley kept one grain road beautifully level while hillside soil above it hardened into plates. Each local report could be blamed on age, poor rain, or improper cultivation. Only the hidden folio placed them in one choreography.

A second packet carried relocation plans. Hadrún households would receive numbered plots beside the new western channels. Kestan families appeared as "unsettled orchard labor" because the imperial survey recognized no moving province. The proposed settlements stood on fixed shelves distant from the anchor orchards that organized Kestan kinship and burial. Administrators had calculated roof tile, grain allowance, and cart capacity. No column measured what happened when a walking country could no longer walk.

Eda found her own name in the center provisions.

EDA ILEN: ceremonial remains subject to survivability. If mineral conversion prevents removal from Still Court, center platform to be sealed and incorporated into civic monument.

A monument. Serad had planned language for her body after the score finished using it.

Below that entry, another hand had proposed delaying public notice of center death until road compliance reached ninety percent. Serad had crossed out the sentence. In the margin he had written: NO FALSE REPORT. HONOR COST OPENLY AFTER COMPLETION.

The correction carried his integrity and its limit. He would not lie once truth could no longer interrupt him.

Eda searched for alternate center names. Three appeared beneath hers, each less suited to simultaneous anchors. Relay projections raised deaths in the outer company. One model divided the work among seven provincial centers but rejected it because "independent release discretion compromises unity." The objection did not concern bodily impossibility. It concerned seven people retaining seven choices.

Her anger became cold enough to read with.

She copied figures onto scrap in her own shorthand. Four hundred centers. Six thousand supporting workers. Three provinces. Seven anchor fields. She separated confirmed injuries from projected ones and marked every uncertain range. If she carried the evidence beyond the College, she would not turn Serad's omissions into omissions of her own.

The Nareth witness packet included a letter from a cellar keeper. The writer described digging around a fig tree whose roots rang under the shovel. An inspector had taken samples, closed the cellar, and offered tax forgiveness in exchange for silence. The letter ended with six names of dancers who had coughed pale grit after the old holding. Two names matched the pension copy Ruhan had shown at the shrine.

Eda folded the letter open beside the Nareth foot diagram she remembered. Tavra's fragment proved sequence. This report proved consequence. Neither absolved Tavra's obedience or abandonment. Evidence did not need to make her mother innocent in order to make the College guilty.

At the bottom of the packet, Serad had added one sentence: NARETH LOCALIZATION UNRELIABLE; CONTINENTAL HOLD REMOVES REPEATED EDGE STRAIN.

He had looked at fossilized roots and concluded that the answer required a larger boundary.

Not every outcome carried certainty. Serad marked wide ranges, disputed assumptions, routes that might shift less than forecast. He had not falsified the arithmetic inside the hidden folio. He had simply confined it where the bodies affected could not read it.

A knock struck her door.

"Center?" called her chamber attendant. "First bell in half an hour."

Eda closed the folio over her hand. "I need a hip wrap."

"Should I call the infirmary?"

"No. Bring linen and heated salt."

The attendant hesitated, then left.

Eda lifted the page that carried her likely death and held it beside her rehearsal

shoe. Its outer sole bore the center sequence she had memorized. Inside, beneath the removable felt, a thin leather shoe lining could take a copy. She needed a rubbing, not words alone. Any accusation Serad made against Tavra could survive paraphrase. His own cuts needed to stand against him.

She dried the floor, closed the stitched section without repairing it, and wrapped Folio Seven in an ordinary rehearsal cloth. Then she went to find him.

Serad waited in the east practice court while the Fifth Measure warmed through ankle turns. Dawn had not reached the lowest windows. Lamp flames leaned whenever the wall corrected behind them.

He saw her shortened right stride at once. "You are injured."

"Stress line. The common shifted under a College hold."

"Did Tavra cause it?"

"The company entered an unstable field."

His concern sharpened. "Sit. I will assign another center for the east rehearsal."

"No."

"Eda."

She placed the wrapped folio on the scorer's table and opened it to the hidden center diagram.

Every warm-up step stopped.

Serad dismissed the company with one gesture. "Outer court. Continue turns under Cutter Solen."

When the doors closed, he looked at the severed tendon. "You opened a restricted section."

"You planned my corpse in twelve-hour intervals."

His eyes returned to her face. He neither denied the page nor pretended surprise. "Those projections assume uninterrupted load at median resistance."

"Your score requires uninterrupted load."

"The outer holds may settle early."

"Then why omit release?"

"Because a premature center exit would cast seven anchor loads back through the companies."

"So I remain until completion."

"Yes."

"Define completion."

He took a breath. "Stable transfer to the civic holds."

"Permanent transfer."

The wall shifted. A rack of practice shoes tapped against its pegs.

Serad came around the table. His left hand hovered near her shoulder and stopped before touching. "I intended to tell you after the southern rehearsal."

"After you had fixed the full sequence into my trained response."

"After you understood the scale well enough not to mistake fear for judgment."

"I understand the scale. Four hundred centers. More than six thousand company workers. Median losses above three thousand. Three provinces with roots bound out of soil."

"You read estimates without their administrative provisions."

"Pensions?"

"Resettlement. Grain reserve. Water works. Replacement routes for communities whose current practices cannot continue."

"Current practices." She put one finger on the Hadrin map. "You mean living there."

"I mean seasonal releases that endanger every downstream grain contract. I mean orchards wandering beyond winter supply roads. I mean towns waking on the wrong side of a pass."

"And you mean Eda dying at your center."

Pain entered his face without spectacle. "I mean preventing Oris from happening in a hundred places at once."

She had heard the College version since childhood. A boy on a temple stair, snow packed around the bodies below, six hundred dead because no company held the town. Yesterday the story had explained Serad's hands. Today those hands had drawn her heart inside a table.

"Did your family consent to the ground moving?" she asked.

"No."

"Then you answer one unchosen disaster with another."

"I answer repeated disaster with finite cost." His voice remained level, but his fingers pressed the table edge. "You have crossed held roads all your life. You ate grain carried over bridges that would not exist without centers. Stability already costs bodies. The empire hides too much of that cost, yes. I have fought Miren over pensions and service limits for twenty years. The Dominion Measure ends the repetition."

"By making the damage permanent."

"By paying once."

Serad opened a cabinet beside the practice court and removed a roll of current route notices. He did not choose only dramatic reports. He showed her a village that had lost winter access when a pass turned three days early, a bridge company crushed during an unscheduled bank rise, and grain carts stranded while two provinces disputed which moving road carried an old treaty obligation.

"These arrived this month," he said. "Forty bridge workers dead. Seven villages on reduced ration. Two border companies armed because their markers no longer meet. Motion has costs whether the College touches it or not."

Eda read the notices. The seals appeared genuine. Grief did not become false merely because Serad used it.

"Where are the local proposals?" she asked.

"One village requests a seasonal ferry. Another asks for an anchor company it cannot pay. The provinces request judgment against each other."

"Then fund the ferry."

"And next season? Another pass, another ferry, another emergency levy. The empire spends its strength chasing ground that will not keep faith."

"Ground never signed your treaty."

"People did. Children cannot eat the philosophical distinction."

She set the notices beside the provincial maps. His evidence showed urgency, not inevitability. Every disaster in his hand became an argument for one permanent answer because he had already discarded answers that left authority divided.

"Your projections count what current motion may kill," she said. "They reduce what your hold will kill to provisions. That does not make one set of bodies more finite."

"Who chose the people who pay?"

"I did."

The directness struck her. Serad did not retreat into committee language. He claimed authorship exactly as his teaching required.

"You chose me," she said.

"You can hear two anchors at once. No other center can adjust seven transitions with your accuracy."

"That explains why I can do it. It does not give you my answer."

"I know you."

"You trained me."

"I raised you when Tavra left."

"And therefore?"

His calm broke at the edge. "Therefore I know you would not abandon thousands to preserve one body, even your own."

Eda felt the trap close through praise. He loved the part of her that reached for impossible work. He had fed it, disciplined it, given it rooms where her skill mattered. Now he treated that cultivated courage as consent already owed.

"You never asked," she said.

"I am asking now."

"No. You are asking after schedules, anchors, public promises, and trained responses make refusal catastrophic."

"The catastrophe exists whether we discuss it kindly or not."

"The alternatives in this folio all begin with permanent hold."

"Because temporary holds have failed."

"Tavra let a plaza flex yesterday."

His expression closed. "She recruited market workers into an illegal field and injured you."

"She disclosed the risk. People refused and walked away."

"An uncontrolled trial on a common cannot answer continental famine."

"No. It proves your alternatives are incomplete."

Serad turned toward the high window. Beyond it, Meren's roofs stepped down to roads held straight through districts that would otherwise migrate apart. "When I was fourteen, Oris moved three hundred strides before dawn. The temple stair stayed because one old dancer held it alone. She died under me. Every adult who survived spent years arguing which local custom had failed. No one had possessed enough authority to hold the whole town."

Eda waited.

"I promised never to leave that scale of choice to frightened fragments again," he said. "You call that arrogance because Tavra has shown you ten vendors and an open salt line. I call it memory with responsibility."

"Your memory does not own my hips."

"No." He faced her again. "The people on these routes do."

A rehearsal drum sounded in the outer court. Eda's body prepared for the next turn before thought. She let the trained response begin, then held her heel down. The refusal sent pain along the new stress line.

"What happens if I walk out now?"

Serad answered after too long. "I assign centers in relay. Loss projections rise. Control precision falls. The Measure proceeds."

There it stood: her choice permitted only if she accepted blame for whoever replaced her.

Eda closed the folio. "Then you do not have a center. You have a hostage who can improve your figures."

"I have a center who has not yet let anger finish speaking."

She could denounce him in the outer court. Guards would close the College before she reached Miren. The hidden pages would return to Serad's vault. Tavra's fugitive account would compete with an institution holding every road notice.

Anger offered a clean exit and a useless one.

Eda eased her weight onto the injured hip until her face went still.

"What provisions exist for Hadrún water?" she asked.

Serad watched the change in her. Hope and caution arrived together. "Three new channels from the western snow shelves. Reserve wells at each district seat."

"And the centers' families?"

"Full hereditary pensions, not service review."

"You will publish the body projections before Stillday."

"Miren will not."

"I asked what you will do."

He looked down at the closed folio. "I will argue for publication after the southern anchors confirm resistance. Premature figures could cause the very refusal that makes them worse."

Not publication, then. Another later.

Eda nodded as if arithmetic had steadied her. "Postpone the east rehearsal one hour. Wrap my hip. Show me the full center transition tonight. If I enter, I enter knowing the sequence."

Serad's shoulders loosened by a fraction. "Agreed."

He believed skill had reclaimed her from anger. That belief hurt because she had once shared it.

Back in her chamber, Eda locked the door and removed the heated salt wrap. The stress line burned deep in the right hip, narrow now, dangerous under repeated load. She placed thin paper over the hidden page and rubbed charcoal across it with the flat of her thumb. The center cuts emerged in reverse.

She transferred the rubbing onto calfskin shaved nearly transparent. Every line had to remain exact: seven anchor paths, the sealed center, the projected duration table, the three province marks. Sweat darkened her collar. Twice she stopped when corridor steps passed.

The calfskin fit beneath the felt of her left shoe. Eda lifted the shoe lining, spread a film of cobbler's paste, and pressed the copy flat. She replaced the felt, then walked six careful steps. Nothing shifted.

She repaired Folio Seven with fresh tendon from her score kit. Her knots differed from the originals. Serad might notice if he searched closely. She rubbed black wax into them and scuffed the cover against the floor.

At first bell plus one hour, she entered the east field in full rehearsal shoes.

Serad waited beside the anchor board. "Your hip?"

"Finite," she said, using his word.

Pain crossed his face again. She let him mistake her cruelty for acceptance.

Eda took center position. Beneath her left foot, the copied page moved with her body. Above it, the official score directed every turn. She bowed to Serad, placed her heel on the opening mark, and began to learn exactly where his measure could be broken.

Part III

Chapter 15 — Across the Backward Mountains

The ledge moved east while Ruhan climbed west.

His left hand held a root no thicker than a cord. His boots scraped shale. The splinted right wrist rested useless against his chest, wrapped in oilcloth against the morning mist. Below him, Ossa pressed her back to the cliff, and Tavra stood on a shelf that had been broad when they reached it.

Now the shelf narrowed under her bad leg.

"Higher," Tavra called. "There's a seam above your shoulder."

"I see it."

"Then use it."

"It is travelling toward Meren."

"So are the riders."

Ruhan reached anyway. His left fingers caught the seam. The mountain took another slow eastward step. Rock dragged under his nails and pulled his shoulder wide. His broken right wrist struck the cliff.

Pain removed the world.

He dropped to the shelf between Ossa and Tavra. Loose stone followed, ticking against their coats before falling into cloud.

Ossa crouched over him. "Can you move the fingers?"

Ruhan tried. The splint answered with heat and three reluctant twitches.

Tavra looked up the route he had failed to take. "If we cut a brace into the shelf, I can hold it long enough to reach the upper path."

"No," Ossa and Ruhan said together.

Tavra scowled. "I was describing an option."

"You were dressing an order as weather," Ossa replied.

The backward mountains rose between Meren and Hadrin in three long spines. During late summer they travelled east, opposite anyone fleeing the capital. Imperial maps showed two held passes, both guarded now. Ruhan had chosen an unheld shepherd route recorded six years earlier. The mountain had since folded it upward and carried it half a day from his page.

The obvious response involved climbing faster than the range moved. His wrist had ended that argument.

He sat against the cliff until nausea eased. Then he used his left hand to unfasten the atlas from his pack.

The cover had swollen with rain and travel. Inside, pages overlapped in no proper scale. Charcoal ridges crossed notes from Kestan orchard walkers, Hadrún shepherds, fugitives, tax crews, and one offended beekeeper. Many marks did not describe passage. They described refusal.

NO CATTLE AFTER FIRST FROST.

ASK LERU AT THE RED CAVE; NO ARMED COMPANY.

SOUTH SPINE CLOSED WHILE THE DEAD ARE MOVED.

IMPERIAL SURVEY TURNED BACK HERE.

Between those refusals, Ruhan had recorded permissions with equal care. A widow near the salt caves allowed travellers to use her roof only when they carried news from the east. Hadrún shepherds opened a spring route after lambing and closed it before first ice. Kestan orchard walkers shared a night field with anyone who left no fixed marker. None of these agreements survived as a broad line. Each belonged to a season, a host, and a question asked at arrival.

Tavra tapped a faded arrow. "This one reaches the western descent."

"It reached it four years ago for a funeral party."

"Could we use the same cut?"

"There was no cut. The village stopped its release dance for one hour while the mourners crossed."

"Why record it if nobody can repeat it?"

"So the next traveller knows whom to ask and what the village once considered possible."

Ossa settled beside them, keeping watch uphill. "Military maps mark wells, bridges, forage. We called that complete enough to move a regiment."

"Complete for the regiment," Ruhan said. "Less complete for the people whose wells became forage."

He showed them a page where an imperial road ran in confident black from Kesta to the mountain foot. Around it clustered small notes: bridge refused tax carts after flood; orchard families crossed north; burial shelf moved; road company held an empty approach for eleven months because its destination had walked away.

"A fixed map records the success of whoever forced the line to stay," he said. "My aunt taught me to record where a line stopped deserving belief."

Tavra examined the empty margin beyond the three-tooth crag. "And this blank?"

"Could mean no route. Could mean a route whose keeper never spoke to us. Could mean my aunt spilled soup over the page."

Ossa rubbed the stained paper. "Lentil."

"Then one uncertainty has yielded."

The brief humor eased nothing about the cliff, but it returned their attention to what they actually knew. A pass had crossed beneath the crag after moonset in one late summer. The mountain now moved in the same season and direction. They could wait where that old account began, or gamble their bodies on an upper seam already travelling away.

Tavra lowered herself with one leg straight. "Your atlas says the pass existed."

"It says a shepherd crossed six years ago."

"You drew a line."

"I drew his account."

"Lines imply routes."

"Only to people who think ink gives orders."

Ossa leaned over the page. "What do the blank places imply?"

"That nobody I trust has spoken for them."

The shelf moved another finger-width east. The upper seam moved with it, widening the distance from Hadrun.

Ruhan turned pages until he found a note written by his aunt Savi. Her hand sloped downhill even on level paper.

WHEN THE GREY SPINE WALKS EAST, WESTBOUND FEET SLEEP. PASS ARRIVES AFTER MOONSET BELOW THE THREE-TOOTH CRAG.

He looked through the mist. Three broken pinnacles showed above them, dark teeth against white sky.

"We climbed past the route," he said.

Tavra followed his gaze. "The pass lies below?"

"It will."

"When?"

"After moonset, according to a woman who disliked clocks."

"We lose a day."

"We gain a mountain."

"College riders gain the same day."

"Riders think as you do. They will climb."

Her face shut around the insult. Ruhan let it stand. Tavra could read pressure through leather better than anyone he had met, yet pursuit still made her treat terrain as a problem that yielded to superior effort.

They descended.

Going down one-handed required Ossa to manage Ruhan's safety cord. She tied it around his waist without using a military knot. Tavra moved last, lowering her straight left leg from ledge to ledge while mineral stiffness held the knee. Twice

she tried to hurry. Twice the mountain shifted and made haste irrelevant.

At dusk they reached a bowl beneath the three-tooth crag. No pass opened there. A wall of slate blocked the west.

Ruhan found an old shepherd hearth under an overhang. He checked for recent use, then left a strip of dried meat beside it in case the unknown owner returned. Ossa gathered thorn brush. Tavra studied the slate wall.

"You expect that to move," she said.

"I expect my aunt saw it move once."

"That distinction could kill us."

"So could pretending it will obey because we are urgent."

They lit no fire. College riders showed at sunset on the upper shelf, small figures moving against cloud. As Ruhan had guessed, they climbed west. Their lead cutter salted a brace line into the rock. Six horses strained while dancers forced a temporary ramp upward.

The range accepted the pressure and returned it elsewhere.

A distant crack rolled through the bowl. Slate rose between the riders and their lower supports. One horse screamed. The imperial line scattered before the unfinished measure trapped them.

Tavra watched from the overhang. "They need a release."

"They brought cutters," Ossa said.

"They brought a plan."

Ruhan opened his atlas across his knees. With his left hand he marked the failed ascent, the riders' number, and the hour. He did not draw a route through their danger. A record of refusal could save the next traveller from mistaking force for access.

His right wrist throbbed inside the splint. The bridge injury had embarrassed him at first. A pass-runner without two hands could not climb his usual lines, catch an anchor, or lower another traveller securely. He had treated the splint as a delay between his competent past and its return.

Tonight the limitation had corrected his reading. With two sound hands, he might have reached the upper seam and led all three into the riders' broken measure.

Ossa noticed him looking at the splint. "Regretting the bridge?"

"Regretting that it needed to break me before I listened."

"Tavra may have a lecture for that."

"She charges too much."

Across the bowl, Tavra had sat with her knife but no leather. She traced possible cuts on her palm and erased them with her thumb.

Ruhan went to her. "What are you designing?"

"A way to take pressure off the pass when it opens."

"You have not seen it."

"That limits the detail."

"It should limit the cutting."

Her left knee remained extended beside her. Pale lines showed even in moonlight. "If the pass arrives carrying torque, somebody receives it."

"Or we wait until it finishes arriving."

"And if riders descend first?"

"We ask the pass keeper."

"There is no keeper."

"Then we do not invent one in your body."

She looked at him for a long time. "Eda said something similar."

"Your daughter sounds exhausting."

"She learned from a master."

The dry answer almost became a smile.

After moonset, the bowl tilted.

No drum announced it. Pebbles rolled east. The slate wall lowered by spans as the grey spine travelled beneath them. What had seemed a barrier revealed its upper surface, a broad sloping back worn by old hoof marks. The pass had not opened. It had arrived under their feet.

Ruhan woke Ossa and Tavra. "No salt. No score. Follow the old marks only while they remain."

They packed in darkness. Ossa took the evidence bag. Tavra tried to take Ruhan's atlas so he could balance, but he handed it to her only after she asked.

The crossing required stillness more often than movement. They walked twenty paces while the slate levelled, then stopped when its eastward travel steepened the west edge. Ruhan listened through his soles for the low grinding that meant one layer slid beneath another. Each time it deepened, they crouched and let the range carry them.

Behind, lanterns descended from the failed imperial ramp. Riders had discovered the bowl.

Ossa touched her drum rim. "I could knock them into expecting a count."

"They may charge early," Tavra said.

"They may wait."

Ossa removed her hand. "Then they choose their mistake."

Halfway across, the old hoof marks divided. One branch climbed toward a

narrow west notch. The other descended into fog.

Tavra held up the atlas. "Your aunt marked no fork."

"She crossed before it formed."

"Which way?"

Ruhan studied lichen, droppings, and the fresh scrape of slate. The upper path looked safer because it looked like a pass. No recent hoof had polished it. The lower branch carried crushed thyme.

"Down."

Ossa peered into fog. "Based on?"

"Sheep."

"Finally, an authority Tavra cannot outrank."

They descended. The fog thinned after thirty steps, exposing a shelf that moved west relative to the spine beneath it. For several minutes, walking down carried them toward Hadrún faster than climbing could have done.

The riders took the upper notch.

A command drum sounded once. The notch rose with the backward mountains, carrying the imperial party east. Their lanterns dwindled above the cloud until rock hid them.

Dawn found Ruhan's group on red soil.

A line of low stone posts marked no border. Each bore a seasonal date and an arrow showing where Hadrún's grazing release had last passed. Three people waited beside them in felt-soled boots. The eldest held a shepherd's staff cut with sole-court witness marks.

"I am Dena Cor," she said. "You crossed on Savi Tal's sleeping route."

Ruhan glanced at his atlas. "You know my aunt?"

"She owes me two jars of plum salt." Dena looked at his splint. "And now you owe the mountain a better note."

He opened to the crossing page. Instead of drawing the lower shelf as a permanent line, he wrote: ARRIVED AFTER MOONSET ON DAY THIRTEEN. SHEEP TOOK LOWER FORK. UPPER FORK REFUSED RIDERS. ASK AGAIN.

Dena read over his shoulder. "Incomplete atlas."

"Accurately."

Her companions searched Ossa's evidence bag but did not take it. Tavra presented the copied pension names and described the fossilized roots beneath Nareth. Ossa named the seven anchor schedule and offered her Hadrún confession before Dena could ask.

"The original Nareth fragment?" Dena said.

"In a Meren wall shrine," Ruhan answered. "Washerwomen route it through soap

barrels. A message should reach your western court by tomorrow."

"You ask us to hear evidence we cannot yet touch."

"We ask for a room and witnesses. Touch it when it arrives."

Dena studied Tavra. "Imperial notices call you traitor."

"They are early," Tavra said. "I have not yet testified."

"Hadrún prefers charges after breakfast." Dena turned toward the red valley road. "Sole courts gather at the kiln hall tomorrow. You may speak. They may hand you to the College. They may copy your evidence. I promise only the hearing."

Tavra shifted against her rigid knee. Every instinct in her face wanted a promise of outcome.

"A hearing is enough," she said.

Dena started down the valley. Ruhan followed with his atlas open in his left hand. Behind them, the pass rose into morning and removed the route by which they had come.

Chapter 16 — The Score-Cutter's Treason

Tavra stood trial with her boots on the table.

Dena Cor had ordered them removed before the kiln hall filled. Thirty-seven score-cutters sat in a broken circle around the evidence boards, their benches arranged by no rank Tavra recognized. Hadrún sole courts placed the accused person's shoes where every cutter could inspect wear, hidden channels, false stitching, and the history a mouth might edit.

Her left boot leaned outward from years of sparing the lithified knee. Fresh cracks crossed the heel after Meren's common. The right sole turned inward under load. Neither offered dignity.

Dena struck her staff once. "Tavra Ilen, former center of the Imperial College, unlicensed cutter, named in a capital notice for treason against roads and civil grain. Do you accept this court's witness rules?"

"What are they?"

"Answer what you know. Name what you infer. Say when memory may favor you. Any cutter may challenge craft claims. Any Hadrún resident may challenge consequence. We cannot pardon imperial treason. We can decide whether your evidence deserves copying."

"I accept."

A grey-haired cutter opposite her lifted Tavra's left boot. "You have altered this sole since Kesta."

"Three times."

"Unmarked alterations."

"I had no court stamp."

"You had a knife."

Tavra looked at the shallow release channel she had cut beside the mountain bowl. "Then I failed to mark them."

Murmurs moved through the benches. She had expected argument about the Dominion Measure. Instead, the court began with her habits.

Another cutter found salt burned into the toe seam. "This line routes central spill toward your injured knee."

"Yes."

"Why?"

"To keep it from other feet."

"Did they choose that arrangement?"

"They chose their own steps. I kept the fault path."

"That does not answer."

"No. They did not choose where the final spill went."

The cutter returned the boot to the table. "Record that."

A clerk pressed charcoal to paper.

Ossa sat behind Tavra with the evidence bag between her boots. Her stripped drum frame rested against the wall. Ruhan had removed his wrist splint at dawn for the first time since the bridge, but swelling forced it back on before the hearing. He stood near the kiln door and watched routes instead of testimony.

Outside, Hadrund companies gathered in the red dust. Imperial notices had reached them before breakfast. Tavra's name hung on the kiln gate beneath a promise of grain suspension for any district sheltering her.

Dena pointed to the copies from the Nareth barracks. "State their source."

Tavra described the abandoned worker quarters, split floor stone, pension ledgers, and fossilized roots beneath the cellar. She distinguished what she had seen from what the margin notes claimed. She named each copied worker. Seni's correction followed her from the refuge: names, not bodies.

A miller rose from the public benches. "My grain road uses a hold from the same year. Are my fields poisoned?"

"I do not know."

"Can you test?"

"Dig beyond the oldest salt boundary. Check fine roots before thick ones. If they ring under a knife or snap like fired clay, stop digging and keep the sample."

"Will release cure it?"

"No. Stone already inside dead root does not become living wood."

The miller sat with that answer.

Dena lifted Ossa's copied anchor schedule. "Permanent holds. Seven. Does this prove a continental plan?"

"It proves seven companies received permanent anchor instructions," Tavra said. "Their routes join at Meren. The command skin names coordinated commencement. I infer the Dominion Measure intends to bind the joined web beyond a seasonal hold."

"You do not possess the Master Score."

"No."

"You have not read its center."

"No."

"Then keep inference separate."

"Yes."

A commotion sounded outside. Ruhan opened the kiln door only wide enough for a woman carrying a soap barrel. Steam and lye smell entered with her. Two Hadrun witnesses rolled the barrel to the evidence table.

The washerwoman from Meren's court had sent no name. Inside wet linen lay a votive buckle, a mason's clay token, and the Nareth fragment wrapped in waxed cloth.

Tavra's breath stopped.

She had not touched the leather since giving it to Ruhan before the rain bridge. Even wrapped, it carried the shape of twelve years hidden beneath her Dorel bench. Possession had felt like punishment and insurance together. Now thirty-seven cutters leaned close.

Dena did not hand it to her. "Identify without touching."

"Layered goat leather. Inner left sole from the Nareth lead center pair. Torn below the quarry release."

"How do you know?"

"I cut it."

The court unwrapped the fragment. Oil had blackened the edges. Serad's later command incision crossed Tavra's release turn at a harsh angle, both histories occupying the same leather.

Dena chose three examiners who had not spoken. They traced sequence by depth, blade direction, and wear. The oldest, Saro Pell, looked up after a long silence.

"Release cut first," he said. "Cross-cut made after fitting, likely while the sole remained on the shoe. Different blade. Heavier right hand."

Tavra's mouth had gone dry.

"Give your Nareth testimony," Dena said.

She began with the third count.

The hillside had started moving south before Serad's revised score allowed change. Tavra felt the road pull across her knees. She signalled uncertainty with the permitted shoulder turn. Serad, observing from the command platform, gave forward continuation.

"Did command cadence compel you?" a cutter asked.

"No. I knew the response. I obeyed it. I could have broken my mark."

"What did you believe would happen?"

"That the city road would buckle under occupied houses and kill more people."

"Was that possible?"

"Yes."

"Certain?"

"No."

She described cutting the quarry release into her sole before the measure, anticipating some lateral shift. Serad's field cutter crossed it after the first alarm and bound the company forward. Tavra still had one chance: turn her heel hard enough to tear the sole and break center. She did not.

The road held. The hillside district travelled into the lower retaining wall. Houses folded against stone. Tavra cut release at last, directing part of the road toward the empty quarry. The delayed turn accelerated the lower collapse while preserving the main street.

"How many deaths?" asked the miller.

"Official count, eighty-six. Seasonal workers lived outside the census. I do not know their number."

"How many company injuries?"

"Thirty-one recorded. More appeared years later."

"What entered you?"

Tavra pulled her trouser leg above the left knee. Pale stone branches reached into the thigh. "The road's lateral counter-motion. Both knees took it. The left has worsened since a spring release four days ago."

Saro Pell examined the lines without touching. "And then?"

"I kept the fragment. I let the College publish the crossed release as my unauthorized sabotage."

"Why?"

"Because exposing the sequence also exposed that I had felt the shift and continued. I wanted proof without testimony."

Dena's staff rested across her knees. "Proof that could accuse Serad without requiring you to accuse yourself."

"Yes."

"What did you do with your daughter?"

The question did not belong to craft, yet consequence sat within the rules.

"I left Eda in College custody. She was ten. I told myself my presence endangered her. I did not ask."

A younger cutter spoke from the circle. "Why should your late honesty guide Hadrún now?"

"It should not guide you. Examine the leather. Dig your salt fields. Ask active centers what their orders say. My confession cannot make those facts cleaner."

"And if we copy it, you gain a defense against treason."

"I gain a more accurate charge."

The clerk's charcoal paused.

Tavra faced the public benches. "I broke license law. I concealed evidence. I obeyed a command after local ground invalidated the score. If treason means refusing the College now, I accept it. If loyalty means repeating Nareth across seven provinces because roads carry grain, then loyalty describes a larger burial."

Dena struck the staff before applause could form. "No speeches to purchase a verdict."

Tavra sat.

The sole court divided.

Licensed cutters argued that publication would trigger company refusal before replacement routes existed. Hadrin independents answered that the College had used grain access to prevent informed choice. One elder feared every village would improvise dangerous releases after seeing Tavra's fragment. Saro proposed copies limited to craft courts. The miller demanded public names because his children worked a grain hold.

Dena called four working cutters to the center and gave each the same problem: a seasonal Hadrin road due for release in nine days, ordered into permanent rehearsal tomorrow, with three hill villages dependent on its grain carts. Their answers revealed the split more clearly than speeches.

The first would obey long enough to bring stores through, then break the anchor after winter. Tavra warned that months of held torque could kill the release company. The cutter replied that hunger also killed without waiting for craft purity.

The second would refuse immediately and send carts over a shepherd shelf. Ruhan asked whether the shelf keeper had agreed. The cutter knew no keeper and had assumed the route lay unused.

The third proposed a false rehearsal: salt the field, march the company, leave the anchor unbound. Ossa noted that trained inspectors would hear the empty counter-beat before the second turn.

The fourth, a young bark-sole cutter named Imri, placed both hands on the Nareth rubbing. "Copy everything. Let each road crew decide whether its ground resembles this one."

"And if they lack skill to judge?" Saro asked.

"Then send judges, not commands."

"Thirty-seven cutters cannot reach seven provinces in six days."

"Thirty-seven copies can."

A licensed woman named Bera raised Tavra's right boot from the evidence table. "This workmanship proves why unrestricted copying is dangerous. Ilen can cut a spill line by feel. Most village repairers cannot. A fragment showing one release turn may look like permission to cut it into every held road."

"Then copy the limits beside it," Imri said.

"Words do not create skill."

"Secrecy does not create it either."

Dena turned to Tavra. "If an ordinary cutter copies your Nareth release onto another sole, what happens?"

"The cut may do nothing. It may route pressure into the wearer's knee. It may open stored torque toward occupied ground. Nareth's turn belongs to Nareth's old quarry angle."

"Should we conceal it?"

"No. Mark it as evidence, not instruction. Include depth, sequence, location, and failure. Leave out no cost."

Bera held up the boot. "You ask us to trust labels while imperial roads fail."

"I ask you not to confuse withholding with safety. The College withheld the fossilized roots and repeated permanent cuts elsewhere."

A grain factor from the public benches demanded leave to speak. Dena nodded.

"My contracts feed two towns," he said. "If crews refuse the grain road, carts stop. Does anyone in this hall accept responsibility for empty bins?"

Silence followed.

Tavra recognized the old temptation to fill it with a comprehensive plan. She resisted until Dena addressed her by name.

"I accept responsibility for bringing evidence that may contribute to refusal," Tavra said. "I cannot accept choice for the crews or promise a route I have not walked. Hadrun already practices seasonal releases. Ask each valley what temporary crossings it can offer, what loads they carry, and for how long."

"That takes time."

"Yes."

"People may go hungry while councils talk."

"Yes."

"You have no answer."

"I have no answer that removes cost by putting it in a hidden center."

The factor swore and sat. Dena did not rebuke him.

Saro set three sheets beside the fragment. "I propose a layered copy. First sheet: verified cut sequence and examiner marks. Second: named testimony, including Ilen's failures. Third: warnings against reuse and questions each crew must answer before refusing. Craft courts receive all three. Public boards receive the testimony and anchor schedule, not a sole pattern detailed enough to imitate."

Imri objected that limiting the cut preserved guild power. Bera objected that any public image invited imitation. For another half hour, they argued over blade-depth notation, witness names, widow privacy, and whether the imperial seizure notice

itself belonged in the packet.

Tavra listened as her evidence ceased to be hers. Every change annoyed her. Some improved accuracy. Others protected people she had not considered. When Dena asked whether the court might black out the cellar keeper's address, Tavra said yes without demanding another route to credit.

Ossa remained silent until asked about timing.

"Companies rehearse within six days," she said. "Separate delays have slowed them. Secrecy now does not preserve deliberation. It preserves command."

A cutter pointed at her stripped drum. "You used command at Hadrún."

"Yes."

"Why trust your distinction?"

"Do not. Ask the workers who hear the cadence in their sleep."

Outside, horses entered the kiln yard.

Ruhan called, "College at both valley roads. Twelve riders, eight on foot."

Dena stood. "This court has not reached decision."

The kiln doors burst inward.

College agents wore civil grain sashes over cutter coats. Their captain held a sealed seizure order. "By authority of Chancellor Miren, surrender Tavra Ilen, all Nareth material, and instruments used to obstruct imperial roads."

Dena read the seal from where she stood. "This hall recognizes craft custody during hearing."

"Craft custody does not supersede treason."

"Then wait outside and dislike us lawfully."

The captain signalled.

Agents crossed the public benches. Hadrún cutters did not form a fighting line; many had knives, none designed for battle. They lifted evidence boards and passed them hand to hand toward the rear kilns.

Tavra reached for the fragment. Dena caught her wrist. "Court custody."

An agent vaulted the table and swept the leather into a document tube. He kicked Tavra's boots aside, then drove toward the door under cover of two short-bladed guards.

Ossa moved before any drum sounded.

She rolled her stripped frame across the floor. It struck the agent's ankles. He stumbled, but one guard turned and slashed. Ossa raised her left arm. Steel opened the forearm from wristward muscle to elbow, shallow at first and deep near the middle.

Blood hit the Nareth testimony.

Ossa caught the document tube with her right hand. The injured left arm failed when she tried to turn. Tavra took the tube, shoved it inside her coat, and dragged Ossa behind the brick evidence plinth.

"Grip?" Tavra asked.

Ossa flexed her fingers. Two moved. The others curled late. "Weak."

Tavra tore linen from the soap barrel and bound pressure above the cut. "Not tight enough to kill the hand."

Blood welled between the first wraps. The blade had opened muscle along the outside of the forearm without severing the main wrist cords. Tavra could judge that much, no more.

"Sensation?" she asked.

Ossa touched thumb to each fingertip. The third missed twice. "Present. Slow."

"Can you hold the drum?"

"With the right."

"Can you strike?"

"Not while you ask foolish questions."

Tavra added folded linen directly over the deepest point and made Ossa press it with her sound hand. The command-skin material tucked inside the stripped frame remained dry. Ossa's future work depended on a grip now pooling blood into white cloth. Injury changed more than pain; it changed which promises a body could keep.

A Hadrin healer crawled behind the plinth with a jar of boiled thread. "I can close it here or after we leave."

"After," Ossa said.

"Here lowers blood loss."

"After lowers capture."

The healer looked to Tavra, expecting command from the older cutter. Tavra shook her head. "Her arm."

Ossa chose a tight temporary pad and delayed stitching. The healer tied the wrap to survive running, then marked the time in charcoal on Ossa's sleeve so whoever treated her later would know how long the cut had remained open.

"Your bedside manner has improved," Ossa said.

"Lying down would improve yours."

Another agent reached them. Ruhan hooked the man's knee with his staff, using the left hand while his splinted right arm stayed against his chest. The agent fell without breaking the wrist again.

At the rear kilns, cutters fed copied pages through drying vents to waiting apprentices outside. Each apprentice ran in a different direction. The court had

reached its decision through attack.

Dena climbed onto the table. "Copy all testimony. Copy the fragment face and cut depth. Original leaves by south ash."

Tavra pulled the document tube free. "You said court custody."

"It remains court custody. You will carry it to the ash door because my knees object to heroics."

"Give it to Ossa," Ossa said through clenched teeth. "Tavra needs both hands to move."

The judgement cut Tavra's pride and preserved the evidence. She placed the tube under Ossa's right arm and tied it across her ribs. Ossa's left forearm hung bound against her body.

They escaped through a kiln mouth while wet clay jars shattered in the hall. Heat struck Tavra's face. Workers pulled them over a low ash wall and into a cart trench.

At the grain road, imperial criers had already nailed fresh notices to every post.

TAVRA ILEN, SCORE-CUTTER AND FORMER CENTER, CONVICTED IN ABSENCE OF TREASON AGAINST THE STABILITY OF MEREN.

No trial had occurred in Meren. The notice listed shelter penalties, grain suspensions, and authority for immediate seizure.

Dena tore one down and handed it to the clerk. "Copy that too."

Around the valley, apprentices carried charcoal rubbings of the Nareth sole. Some went to licensed shops. Others went to mills, road barracks, and seasonal release houses. Nobody waited for Tavra to tell them where.

Ossa leaned against the ash cart, blood darkening her bandage. The original rode under her sound arm. Tavra's boots remained somewhere inside the occupied kiln hall.

Barefoot on warm red soil, Tavra watched her treason leave in thirty-seven different hands.

Chapter 17 — A Province Off the Beat

The imperial drummer lifted both sticks, and Ossa's wounded hand closed on an answer it could no longer give.

Pain opened along her left forearm. The healer's stitches pulled beneath linen. She forced the fingers flat against her thigh before trained memory could raise them to match his count.

Across Hadrún's eastern grain road, three hundred company workers stood inside fresh step-salt. Their center lines faced a torso-sized anchor stone newly lowered from an imperial cart. Grain wagons waited behind them, wheels loaded deep into red dust. On the road post, Chancellor Miren's order snapped in the wind.

FULL REHEARSAL REQUIRED. DISTRICT ACCESS TO IMPERIAL GRAIN SUSPENDED UPON FAILURE OR REFUSAL.

The order allowed no distinction between a crew that could not safely hold and one that would not. Children watched from the mill roofs. Storekeepers had already begun counting flour sacks.

Dena Cor stood outside the salt with Tavra and Ruhan. Tavra wore borrowed kiln sandals with uncut soles. Without her altered boots, every uneven patch jarred the left knee. Ruhan's right wrist remained wrapped, though the splint had been shortened to let his fingers move.

Ossa stood among Hadrún drummers she had met that morning.

"Cadence officers to opening mark," called the imperial inspector.

The company drummers looked at Ossa. She shook her head once. Not yet. The choice belonged at the moment each of them could see its consequence.

The inspector read the penalty aloud. Grain toll seals would close at sunset. Company pensions would enter review. Any drummer breaking assigned count faced military seizure. Any cutter altering rehearsal soles faced the treason provision already applied to Tavra Ilen.

"Questions?" he asked.

A center named Jori raised her hand. "Duration of final hold?"

"Today's rehearsal runs forty counts."

"The final hold."

"Dominion provisions follow after successful alignment."

"That does not answer."

"Questions relevant to today only."

Ossa heard anger ripple through breath. An angry company accelerated. Command training had always used that fact: provoke, then give rhythm somewhere to go.

She stepped onto an overturned grain basket, keeping both feet outside the salt. "You have copies of seven permanent anchor orders," she called. "You have Nareth names. Do not move because I speak. Read your own soles."

The inspector pointed. "Seize the deserter."

No one approached her. His eight guards could arrest one person. They could not safely cross an active field while three hundred trained bodies remained uncertain.

Jori knelt and removed her left shoe. The sole carried a new center cut, deep enough to bind past rehearsal release.

"This has no forty-count exit," she said.

Other workers checked. Cutters began naming hidden continuance marks.

The imperial drummer struck his sticks together. "Opening positions."

Conditioned bodies shifted. He had not touched the drum, yet shoulders squared and heels found marks.

Ossa climbed down from the basket. "We have little time. Local drummers, gather your own crews. Ask who wants instruction in a safe miss. Anyone may choose ordinary rehearsal instead. Anyone may leave the field, though the inspector has named the cost."

A young drummer with blue cord around his rim stared at her bandaged arm. "You cannot demonstrate."

"Correct."

"How do we trust a miss we cannot see?"

"You test it without salt."

They moved behind the grain wagons. Six local drummers each brought fewer than fifty workers. Ossa refused a single assembly. One command could seize one crowd; six conversations made seizure harder.

Before teaching footwork, she asked every group to name the sound that most compelled them. The answers differed. Older road crews reacted to the deep opening stroke. Former military braces moved at the stick click before any skin sounded. Mill teams had trained under handbells and watched a foreman's shoulder instead of a drum. One company followed the intake of breath beside them.

"Then there is no single safe miss," Ossa said. "Anyone promising one has failed to listen."

She sent the groups far enough apart that their practice rhythms overlapped without aligning. The blue-cord drummer clicked his sticks and half his workers stepped before he struck. Another group heard that motion and nearly followed the wrong crew.

"Stop," Jori called.

Everyone froze.

"Freezing puts weight into the locked leg," Ossa said. "Walk out of the practice patch. Ordinary feet."

Several people looked ashamed as they dispersed.

"Do not be embarrassed by conditioning," she told them. "It kept road lines from trampling one another for years. We are not proving you weak. We are finding where the response enters before you decide."

A broad brace named Kesh raised his heel. "Mine starts in the jaw. I bite when the sticks lift."

"Can you open your mouth before the count?"

He tried and laughed at how foolish it felt. On the next signal, his heel remained down.

A woman from the mill team turned her back on the foreman's shoulder, then lost balance because she could not see adjacent workers. Her crew moved into a crescent so she could watch feet instead. Jori's center line practiced saying each person's own name at count three, not in chorus. Their voices collided and prevented a unified trained breath.

The imperial inspector sent a clerk to record participants. Dena placed Hadrún witnesses beside him and recorded the recorder's name. He objected that civil officers needed no witness.

"Today everyone does," Dena said.

Ossa watched fear change the crews' choices as penalties became personal on paper. Nine workers left when the clerk wrote their company numbers. Five who had planned ordinary count shifted toward a missed beat after reading their soles. Two refused to state a choice in advance.

"You may decide on the field," Ossa told them.

"How do we coordinate if we do not declare?" asked a cutter.

"We do not coordinate beyond safety. Give them open spill and room. Their refusal belongs to the beat when it comes."

That answer frightened her too. Military work removed uncertainty because uncertainty among weighted bodies could maim. Yet advance commitment here would let the inspector identify every gap and command around it. They needed enough preparation to avoid collision, not enough to make refusal predictable.

One test almost failed. A southern crew tried missing count four while two workers returned early on the same foot. Their shoulders collided. One fell across another's ankle.

Ossa stopped the practice and knelt beside them. Her left arm throbbed uselessly in the sling while Jori checked the ankle.

"No damage," Jori said.

The fallen worker sat up furious. "Your miss made us less safe."

"Our version did," his drummer replied before Ossa could. "We choose another or take ordinary count."

They moved their gap to eleven, the place where their seasonal release training already expected outward weight. The next trial held.

Ossa used her sound right hand to draw foot marks in dust. "The opening cadence conditions weight on count four. Do not miss four by freezing. A fixed leg takes the next worker's motion. On three, soften the heel. Let four pass through the empty shoe. Return on five only if your neighbor remains balanced."

"That shifts the road," Jori said.

"Yes. A little."

"How much?"

"I do not know. Each crew's ground differs. Your cutters must open local spill before anyone chooses."

Tavra limped between groups and inspected soles only when invited. Hadrún cutters broke the continuance channels, not the anchor lines. A complete break before stored pressure entered could let the inspector replace them. A missed count after engagement would make the anchor fail to capture the road.

A mill worker named Seli crossed his arms. "If the grain road shifts, those wagons may not reach the western towns."

"If it holds permanently, your valley roots may harden," Tavra said.

"May. Hunger this week carries less uncertainty."

Dena answered from beside him. "The north shepherd route can take half loads for three days. Western villages have offered flour from release stores. Not enough for ordinary ration."

"So my children eat less because Meren hides costs."

"Yes," Ossa said. "Refusal does not clean that."

Seli looked at the rehearsal field, then the wagons. "I take ordinary count. My family cannot carry another promise."

"Your choice," Ossa said.

Some people cursed him. She turned on them. "No. If you punish refusal of your refusal, you have learned only a new cadence."

Seli joined the inspector's full-count line. Twelve followed him. Thirty-seven left the field entirely. The remaining workers practiced the softened heel on bare dust.

Ossa moved among local drummers. Her injured fingers twitched whenever they struck the opening phrase. She kept the left arm in its sling. She could advise breath, show stick angle with her right hand, and hear when a miss became a stumble. She could not embody the pattern for them. That limitation denied her old authority and made space for six local versions.

One crew chose to miss count four. Another chose count eleven, where its seasonal release normally began. Jori's center line chose to divide: alternating dancers would leave an empty heel on four and five, reducing the chance that one weak ankle caught the whole gap. No crew copied another exactly.

The inspector's drum sounded across the field.

"Salt lines close in ten minutes."

Tavra came to Ossa. "The western spill crosses the wagon lane. If the road turns sharply, first carts tip."

"Tell the carters."

"They may pull wagons off now."

"Tell them that too."

The carters argued. Four unloaded sacks beside the field. Nine moved wagons to the northern track. Three remained because their contracts penalized deviation. Nobody had time to resolve it.

Dena climbed the road post. "This district has received temporary crossing offers from five valleys. Ration drops by one fifth if the grain road closes for more than two days. Children, infirm houses, and road crews receive full shares first. These terms last three days, then must be agreed again."

The specificity quieted people more effectively than courage could.

At noon, the rehearsal began.

The imperial drummer struck opening cadence. Three hundred bodies took first weight. Anchor stone sank a finger-width into red soil.

Ossa heard every trained breath align. The sound once had filled her with power: not vanity alone, but relief that hundreds of risks could move under one reliable count. Hadrún had taught her what reliability could carry into a ravine.

Count two passed cleanly.

At three, local heels softened.

Four arrived.

Jori's line let the beat pass through empty shoes. The movement did not look like rebellion. It looked like a company breathing at the wrong moment. The anchor shuddered.

The imperial drummer increased volume. Conditioned shoulders jerked toward recovery. Ossa's left hand clenched hard enough to pull a stitch.

"Choose again," she called. "Every beat."

On five, half Jori's line returned. The others waited. A second crew missed its chosen eleven. Farther south, another drummer dropped count four entirely and entered on six.

The province went off the beat one road at a time.

Ground responded. The eastern grain road slipped north by half a cart width. Wagons left on the lane tilted; one spilled sacks without overturning. The northern shepherd track widened as seasonal release pressure found it. A held bridge downstream rose at one end and lowered at the other, still passable to people but not loaded teams.

The anchor stone tried to follow all these directions. Its salted boundary cracked.

"Full hold!" the inspector shouted. "Centers, receive!"

Seli and the ordinary-count line obeyed. Counter-motion drove into their ankles because the larger company no longer matched them. Ossa saw Seli's knees buckle.

"Release ordinary line!" Tavra shouted to the imperial cutter.

He froze between order and visible injury.

Jori stepped out of her own missed count, crossed one pace, and cut Seli's heel strap with a work knife. His sole tore free. The interruption spilled his load into open salt instead of bone. Other local cutters followed, asking names before cutting each worker out.

The imperial drummer beat command harder. Ossa's body tried to answer. She had once believed trained response could only be defeated by a stronger competing rhythm. Instead, local drummers set down their sticks. Without a rival cadence, workers heard the command naked.

Some obeyed. More missed.

The anchor rose from the ground.

Not dramatically. Red soil loosened around it, and the stone tipped onto one edge. It had failed to capture the grain road. The road continued north, carrying three empty wagons around the mill and leaving the imperial cart stranded inside a broken salt oval.

Cheers started near the roofs. Ossa raised her right hand.

"Count your costs first."

Seli had a bruised ankle and could stand. Two braces suffered knee strains. A carter broke three fingers when sacks shifted. No one had taken mineral staining. The western towns now faced reduced grain. Imperial guards retained their weapons and fury.

Dena sent runners to count what remained usable. Of the sixteen grain wagons, nine could reach the northern track if unloaded to half weight. Three stood stranded beyond the road's turn. One had lost a wheel. The rest could return east, though the inspector threatened seizure if carters changed destination.

The carters formed their own circle beside the spilled sacks. They agreed to divide loads by the three-day terms Dena had named, but two refused western travel without written protection from contract penalties. A mill clerk drafted the protection on the back of Miren's rehearsal order. Local witnesses signed before

Dena did.

Families from the roof line came down with baskets. Ossa expected a rush toward free grain. Instead, Jori placed Seli at the first scale because his choice for ordinary count had helped cause his injury and had not removed him from the district. He protested that others would call it reward for obedience.

"It is treatment for an ankle hurt in our field," she said. "Your politics can wait behind the bandage."

The decision drew argument but held. Children carried split sacks away from damp ground. Millers marked every measure removed from imperial contract stock. Nothing about the work resembled liberation. It resembled a province accepting the account after refusing the command.

The inspector ordered his guards to stop distribution. None moved. Their ration came from the same wagons.

Dena ordered the public evidence boards raised before he could restore authority.

Saro Pell read the Nareth examination aloud: original release, later cross-cut, eighty-six official dead, thirty-one recorded company injuries, delayed stone sickness in named pension files. The miller split a root sample over the board. Its interior shone grey. He held up the fossilized roots from the old salt boundary and named the field where he had dug them that morning.

Then Dena displayed seven permanent anchor orders.

"This court distinguishes proof from inference," she said. "These orders say permanent. They join at the capital. The public convocation notice says seasonal. Both statements cannot govern the same measure."

A courier from the kiln hall pushed through the crowd. She carried a calfskin scrap folded inside laundered linen. No signature marked it. Black wax from Meren sealed the edge.

Dena read the contents privately, then gave it to Saro. His face changed.

"Anonymous evidence," he told the crowd. "Not yet authenticated. It claims to copy center projections from the Master Score: four hundred trained centers, more than six thousand supporting workers, lasting injury above three thousand at median resistance, permanent root binding across three provinces, and no exit drawn for the principal center."

Tavra went still. "Eda."

Ossa heard hope trying to become certainty. "You do not know."

"No." Tavra took the correction. "I do not."

Dena placed the anonymous extract beside verified testimony rather than over it. "Believe its numbers only after examination. Believe the permanent orders because thirty-seven cutters copied them under witness. Meren intends a lasting hold and has told the public otherwise."

Bell crews carried the statement outward.

Hadrún used grain bells to announce road openings from valley to valley. Today each station rang the permanent orders, the evidence distinctions, and the refusal result. Drummers relayed between hills where bells did not reach, but each local caller used different phrasing so no military cadence took hold. By late afternoon, the message crossed the backward mountains through worker stations still delaying rehearsal.

At Meren, civil recorders received Hadrún grain reports. Miren would hear that her seasonal notice contradicted permanent field orders. She would hear it beside the immediate cost: grain delayed, ration reduced, anchor not captured.

Ossa's bandage had bled through. She sat while the healer reopened the wrap and stitched the pulled section. Around her, people argued over wagons, flour priority, and whether the anonymous figures deserved ink on public boards. Refusal had not united them. It had made their disagreements possible after command failed.

Near sunset, every imperial road bell struck one sustained note.

The inspector looked toward Meren. Color left his face. Around him, even the guards stopped pretending this remained an ordinary rehearsal dispute.

"That signal belongs to Stillday," Dena said.

A second note followed, low enough to shake flour from the mill eaves, then three anchor calls months of rehearsal had taught every company to recognize.

Serad had answered Hadrún's missed beat by beginning the Imperial Stillness early.

Chapter 18 — The Imperial Stillness

The Hadrun grain bell missed its fourth stroke, and Serad returned to the stair at Oris.

For an instant he stood fourteen again with snow packed inside his shoes. His mother lay below the temple with one arm around his sister. The town had moved three hundred strides in darkness. Houses met the winter cliff before anyone agreed who could order a hold. An old center named Vessa took the temple stair alone and kept it level until six children climbed above the slide.

She died with both feet mineralized to the step.

Memory never gave him the whole town. It kept pieces selected by a frightened boy: snow on his sister's eyelashes; temple tiles standing at an angle against the new slope; a man arguing that the cliff could not move before midwinter because his father's calendar said so. The adults had possessed local knowledge. Shepherds knew the high shelf had cracked. Masons knew the temple stair sat on older stone. The town cutter knew no licensed center could arrive before dawn. Each fact remained true and insufficient while families slept below the cliff.

Vessa had come from a funeral company. She wore mourning soles meant to lower a burial shelf, not hold a temple. Serad remembered her cutting those soles with a kitchen blade while people shouted six incompatible routes. She asked for volunteers. Three stepped forward. Two fled when the first house struck the cliff. Vessa did not condemn them. She took the stair because children had already reached it and no wider agreement could form in time.

After rescue, officials turned her choice into a town myth. They carved Serad at the top of the stair, though two other children had stood above him. They erased the names of those who ran. They described Vessa as appointed center, though nobody had appointed her. Serad knew every correction to the public story. He had used the story anyway because institutions required a line clean enough to teach.

At twenty, he returned to the relocated Oris households. One survivor struck him for proposing a fixed winter shelf. Another took both his hands and begged him never to let a town move unheld again. The shelf measure he designed lasted nine seasons, saved three harvest roads, and stiffened twelve workers' feet. He recorded the injuries, increased their pensions, and built release allowances into every later score.

The improvements had seemed to prove that authority could learn. One cost named, one cut corrected, one larger field prepared. Yet each correction required another body willing to stand where uncertainty converged. The Dominion Measure grew from that accumulation, not from delight in command. He wanted to finish the sequence of preventable repairs.

Hadrun's bell pulled at the oldest terror in him because it carried disagreement

as virtue. He could admire the courage of refusal and still hear roofs breaking beneath it. Ossa Marr had taught crews to miss one beat safely. She had not answered what happened when seven provinces missed seven different beats beneath shared grain roads.

Then the Still Court came back around him: seven anchor boards, three hundred waiting company officers, lamps burning in the afternoon, and Hadrún's broken report echoing under the dome. Ink still shone wet where a clerk had written the first refused field beside the western board.

Permanent orders exposed. Eastern grain road shifted. Provincial crews refusing command. Public bells carrying unauthenticated center projections.

A clerk waited at Serad's elbow. "Master Chorearch?"

"Ring the Stillday signal."

The clerk's face changed. "Convocation stands eight days away."

"I know the calendar."

"Chancellor Miren has not transferred civil authority."

"Ring it."

The great bell sounded above Meren. Its note entered the floor through the capital foundation anchor. Dust loosened from the painted dome and settled on seven boards whose stones had been quarried years apart. Companies across the road web would hear what apprentices had rehearsed for three years: readiness, convergence, permanent engagement.

Serad did not confuse the decision with legality. Miren could strip his office if the roads remained connected long enough for her order to reach every station. Hadrún's message had already damaged that connection. One province refusing rehearsal could become seven provinces improvising under public fear, each shifting grain, bridges, and borders without knowledge of the others.

Fragments, arguing while the cliff descended.

He crossed to the western board. "Call anchors one, two, and five to active hold. Remaining stations prepare, no engagement."

Deputy Chorearch Leth did not touch the cords. "Those fields have not completed final body review."

"They completed technical review."

"Center complements remain below projection."

"Use brace reserves."

"Brace reserves increase local conversion."

"Yes."

Leth swallowed. "The Fifth Measure has not assembled. Eda remains under hip treatment."

"She does not enter today. Three anchors can settle through regional centers."

That truth cost him less to say than it should have. Eda's skill belonged at the final convergence. He had delayed telling her the full price, then persuaded himself delay protected judgment. Her questions that morning had exposed the cowardice inside that kindness.

He still believed she would choose completion once anger ceased to govern her. He also knew he had arranged the alternatives until refusal carried other bodies.

Both things could be true. Leadership rarely offered clean truths; it required choosing which contradiction killed fewer people.

The Still Court doors opened. Chancellor Miren entered without ceremonial staff, followed by six civil guards and two grain ministers. Dust streaked the hem of her robe.

"Cancel the signal," she said.

"It has reached the first stations."

"Then ring false commencement."

"Crews would break preparation at different counts."

"You began without my seal."

"You ordered grain penalties against Hadrin. Their refusal made gradual alignment impossible."

"I ordered rehearsal, not permanent engagement."

"Hadrin has published the permanent field cuts. In six days every anchor crew either defects, sabotages its sole, or locks itself before its neighbors. We cannot manage seven independent failures."

Miren put a public broadside on the board. It carried the sole court's distinction between proven orders and anonymous projections. "Did you author permanent instructions?"

"Yes."

"Did you tell my office the convocation hold would release by season's end?"

"I told your office civil transfer would begin after convergence."

"That language allowed my clerks to write seasonal."

"You asked for a notice that preserved markets."

"I asked for an accurate limit."

Serad looked at the grain ministers. "How many days in reserve after the Hadrin road shift?"

The elder minister answered reluctantly. "Capital bins, fifteen at ordinary ration. Western districts, between three and eight. Temporary crossings may extend them."

"May."

Miren's anger sharpened. "Do not turn my caution into your authority."

"I am turning a closing interval into a decision."

"You have no center."

"I have three hundred regional centers at their marks."

"You do not have Eda's consent."

"Eda does not enter today."

"And on convergence?"

Serad did not answer with a lie. "She has read the center cost. She requested full transition access and returned to rehearsal."

"Request is not consent to death."

"No."

Miren stared at him. She had supported fixed roads for twenty-two years, signed pension restrictions, and moved villages from unstable shelves. Her objection did not make her innocent. It made the remaining difference between them decisive.

"Delay one day," she said. "Let civil messengers authenticate Hadrun's evidence. Let me publish rations before you freeze the alternative roads."

"One day gives every field time to cut its anchor."

"It gives people time to understand."

"Oris had an entire winter of arguments. The cliff required one hour."

"This is not Oris."

"No. It is larger."

He signalled Leth. The deputy pulled three anchor cords.

Far bells answered in sequences: north chalk, western pass, southern fig terraces. Each station reported salt complete, anchor present, center line under command. Serad placed both palms on the Still Court board.

The board contained stones from every field. It did not show him distant scenes. It transmitted direction and resistance through joined anchors, the way a shoe sole transmitted ground without explaining what stood upon it. Reports supplied what touch could not.

"Anchor one," Leth called. "Opening count."

Drums began below the court and travelled outward by company relays. Serad felt the north chalk road resist first. Its natural motion carried east and slightly upward. The permanent score opposed both directions, routing counter-motion into one hundred twelve centers along the field.

Resistance climbed.

"Center six uneven," a caller reported.

"Shift two braces inward," Serad said.

"Brace two already at skin limit."

"Use reserve fourteen."

The western board stirred. Anchor two caught a road junction near the backward mountains. The field wanted to shorten toward Hadrun. Serad held the score's fixed length and felt pressure travel into the station stone.

He left Leth at the boards long enough to descend into the lower court. Fifty-two capital braces worked there as the central relay, each wearing soles that carried only a fraction of distant resistance. They knelt in concentric arcs around the foundation anchor. No one performed spectacle. Sweat darkened collars. Heels shook. Cutters moved between rows, widening spill channels whenever mineral pallor appeared above a shoe.

A brace called Nemei caught Serad's sleeve. Protocol required her to address an officer, not the architect, but every officer nearby had entered count.

"My sister centers at north chalk," she said. "Bell report named uneven six. Which six?"

"I do not know yet."

"Can you find out before second engagement?"

"Yes."

Serad sent a clerk to the north board and waited beside Nemei until the answer returned. Center six belonged to a quarry company, no family name yet transmitted. Not her sister.

Relief crossed Nemei's face, followed by shame.

"Do not apologize for wanting one person spared," Serad told her. "Return only if you can carry your assigned share."

"Will another body carry it if I leave?"

"Yes."

She closed her eyes. "Then I stay."

He could have named that consent. The word felt dishonest when replacement stood behind it. Still, if every worker left because alternatives carried pressure, the anchor loads would not vanish. They would break through fewer bodies or escape into occupied roads.

At the next arc, a cutter showed him grey rising through a young man's heel. "Release him?"

The board above signalled anchor one nearing bite. Removing the brace would increase strain on four neighbors.

"Ask him," Serad said.

The young man heard the choice and chose release. Serad ordered two reserves to take the load before the cutter opened the sole. Both reserves received the projected strain and entered voluntarily after hearing it. The exchange cost three

minutes and pushed north chalk closer to uncontrolled engagement.

Compassion had duration. Duration had bodies. This did not make compassion wrong, but it did prevent Serad from treating delay as harmless.

When he returned to the upper boards, Leth reported the north line within one count of permanent bite and anchor five requesting postponement for root resistance.

"Five may postpone four counts," Serad said. "One proceeds. Two maintains."

A runner entered with Eda behind him.

She had wrapped her right hip beneath the rehearsal coat. Her stride remained even by discipline, though Serad saw the shortened turn.

"You started without me," she said.

"I kept you out of the early load."

"You kept me out of the decision."

Miren gave a humorless laugh. "He has been generous that way today."

Serad did not release the board. "Three anchors only. We cannot wait while field cuts spread."

"The public learned because you hid permanence," Eda said.

"The public learned numbers no one has authenticated."

"They learned your orders."

"And Hadrin moved the grain road. Western towns lose ration tonight."

Eda stepped close enough to read the anchor gauges. "Anchor two carries lateral strain into a pass release."

"It carries into prepared centers."

"Not all of it. The pass has changed since survey."

He followed her finger. The western station stone pulled in irregular bursts rather than smooth resistance. A local fold had entered the salted field.

"Send suspension," Eda said.

"Suspension leaves torque in anchor two and anchor one. Release requires both to reverse together."

"Then reverse both."

"North chalk has already taken permanent bite."

The phrase silenced the court.

Anchor one had passed the point where ordinary release could restore prior motion. Its road lay fixed. Soil around the station would begin accepting that arrangement as strain, then as mineral binding.

The Imperial Stillness had begun.

A north runner arrived forty minutes later, boots chalk-white. "Province station

reports movement ceased across the primary shelf. Survey poles have held exact marks through two local turns."

Relief moved among company officers. Decades of drifting toll lines, collapsing retaining walls, and winter routes lost before harvest had ended on that shelf.

"What of centers?" Serad asked.

"Eleven grey ankles. Two knee conversions. No deaths."

Below median projection.

"What of springs?" Eda asked.

The runner hesitated. "Upper spring stopped after hold. Lower channel runs at one third."

Miren gripped the board edge. "A province cannot drink survey poles."

"The spring may find a fixed channel," Serad said.

"Your own projections say high springs fail first." Eda's voice remained quiet.

Serad heard accusation and fact. "Send water crews. Open reserve cisterns. Do not release the anchor."

Miren ordered her grain minister to record the command under civil protest.

Anchor five engaged across the southern fig terraces. Its centers reported heavy root resistance, then steadied. Anchor two continued to jerk beneath Serad's hands.

A western bell rang casualty sequence.

One. Pause. Four. Pause. Road closure. Pass collapse.

Leth sent three runners to meet the written report. They returned after dark. The first carried a broken field gauge. The second had blood on his sleeve that belonged to someone else. The third read while a clerk copied.

"Anchor two fixed the eastern shoulder ahead of local completion. A westbound pass continued moving and closed against the held shoulder. Twenty-six travellers caught between shelves. Four confirmed dead, nine fractures, remaining bruising and exposure. A fugitive party used a kiln drainage cut to escape before full closure."

Serad's hands remained on the station stones. "Names."

"Two dead identified: Mara Ven, carter; Olin Sef, apprentice cutter. Others pending. Injured include Dena Cor, shoulder dislocation. Tavra Ilen, right ankle fracture. Ossa Marr, reopened left forearm. Ruhan Tal, no new injury reported."

Eda made no sound. Her body changed around the silence.

"Where is Tavra?" Serad asked.

"Taken toward an abandoned glaze kiln beyond the field. Hadrin residents blocked pursuit."

"Was the pass inside the latest station survey?"

"No. Survey used last year's held approach."

Leth's face had gone grey. "We fixed against an absent road."

"We fixed the junction the grain web requires," Serad said.

Even to him, the sentence carried the cold of a ledger.

The report continued. Springs above the western pass had dropped within two hours. A release channel ended against newly fixed stone and flooded three kiln yards. Local road crews refused assistance until imperial centers left the anchor field.

Serad looked at the names again. Tavra's right ankle. Eda's mother, injured by his early order. Oris memory offered no absolution. The children on the stair had not asked Vessa to die, and Vessa's act had not granted him ownership of every later body.

He knew that. He had always known it in private.

Outside private knowledge lay the roads. North chalk no longer moved. Releasing anchor two alone would cast its stored counter-motion into centers already carrying the fixed junction. Releasing all three might reopen the northern shelf violently, with cistern crews and residents now walking on the assumption of stability.

"What remains reversible?" he asked Eda.

She read the board despite the pain in her face. "Anchor five has not taken full bite. Two may release if one shares the return. One cannot safely return tonight."

"And if we release five and two?"

"Western pass may reopen. Southern terraces resume. North remains fixed. The joined score loses convergence."

"The remaining provinces act independently," Leth said. "Hadrund refusal spreads."

Miren faced Serad. "Take the partial outcome. One fixed shelf, one ecological crime. Do not multiply it."

He imagined six days from now: anchor crews cutting their soles, grain roads shifting under frightened hoarding, border companies claiming passes before neighbors could respond. He imagined Oris repeated not because land moved, but because every authority waited for agreement while danger narrowed.

He also imagined Eda's name on the center provision he had approved.

"Release five," he said.

Eda's shoulders lowered a fraction.

"Hold two. Prepare convergence of the remaining anchors within six days."

Her relief vanished.

Miren stepped back as if he had struck her. "You saw the spring report."

"Yes."

"You saw Tavra's injury."

"Yes."

"And you continue."

"I reduce the interval in which uncoordinated holds can fail."

"You make every refusal more dangerous, then call danger consent."

Serad signed the continuance order. His hand remained steady because he had trained it to remain steady while other bodies shook.

Anchor five began release. Anchor two stayed fixed against the closing pass. Across the western board, pressure settled into a hard, continuous pull.

Six days remained for the other anchors, Eda's center, and every road Serad still believed he could save.

Chapter 19 — The Step Nobody Owned

Tavra carved a master score while Dena pulled her broken ankle straight.

The pain made the cuts beautifully simple. Seven outer steps. Three spill channels. One central body receiving whatever the others could not return. By the time the Hadrún healer wrapped clay splints around the right ankle, Tavra had designed a smaller Dominion Measure on the back of a kiln invoice.

She stared at it until the lines stopped looking like rescue.

“Burn that,” she told Ruhan.

He took the invoice with his left hand. His right wrist, freed from the full splint at last, remained swollen and weak. “Any final wishes for your masterpiece?”

“May it heat tea.”

He fed it into the glaze kiln. Flame took the center first.

That design joined four others already burned. Tavra had begun the first while kiln workers carried her in from the closing pass. It assigned trained cutters to every salt gap and placed Ossa’s drum at the outer boundary. Ossa had glanced at it once.

“You made my silence a command position,” she said.

The second replaced cadence with hand signals. Ruhan pointed out that every participant still watched Tavra. The third divided authority among five local centers, each chosen by sole courts. Dena asked what happened when a village refused the court’s center. Tavra added a withdrawal clause, then saw that withdrawing one center collapsed pressure into the remaining four.

The fourth score looked different enough to deceive her for an hour. It used no named center. Each participant routed surplus to the next sole clockwise, with the final spill returning through an open edge. On paper, nobody owned the measure. In practice, the clockwise rule forced every person to accept the next body before seeing who stood there. Tavra had replaced a central master with a circle that could not say no after beginning.

She cut that page into bandage strips.

Failure exhausted her more than drawing. Every design started from a real danger: unmatched feet colliding, salt exits closing, untrained hands cutting too deep, a field changing after agreement. Each danger invited a rule. Rules accumulated into one author, even when she removed her name.

“Maybe the College is right about one thing,” she said.

Ossa watched the fire through the stripped drum frame. “Choose carefully. I have one usable hand and can still hit you with it.”

“Complex ground-dance needs somebody to see the whole field.”

"Seeing does not grant ownership."

"No. It grants the duty to warn."

"Then warn."

"And when warnings conflict?"

"People choose which risk they carry."

"While stone moves under them?"

"Sometimes." Ossa lifted the bandaged forearm. "Command exists because danger does not wait. That fact made it useful. It did not make what I did at Hadrin clean."

Tavra reached for another invoice. Ruhan put the blank paper beyond her arm.

"You are resting until you can describe the problem without solving it," he said.

"I can describe it."

"Try."

She looked toward the dry settling trough outside. "Anchor two has prevented the kiln field from taking its ordinary evening slope. Water cannot reach the drain. Stored pressure remains low but grows. People need the field to move without driving its hold into one person."

"What part do you not know?"

"The final direction. The number of safe feet. Whether the shed foundation shares the hold. Which exit will remain open under runoff. How quickly local pressure changes."

"Who knows those things?"

"Different people."

Ruhan returned the invoice. "Then a score written before they speak begins with false ground."

Tavra did not draw. The blank page irritated her until irritation became an admission: she had treated uncertainty as empty space awaiting her craft. Kesta treated it as a place where another person might possess the next fact.

The abandoned works stood beyond the western anchor's fixed field. Three long sheds surrounded a yard of cracked firing stone. Springs above the pass had failed, leaving the settling troughs dry. Hadrin residents carried water from a lower channel while imperial patrols watched the main road.

Tavra lay on a door removed from its hinges. Her right ankle throbbed inside clay and willow slats. Her left knee would not bend past a shallow angle. Standing had become impossible between them.

Ossa sat nearby while a healer changed the dressing on her left forearm. The cut had reopened during the pass collapse. Her grip closed halfway and stopped. The original Nareth fragment remained in its document tube beneath her sound

arm.

"Again," Tavra said.

Ossa did not hand it over. "What will you do differently?"

"Remove the center."

"You said that about the first three."

"The first had a reserve center."

"You."

"The second divided center among cutters."

"Chosen by you."

"The third rotated spill."

"Back to you at the final turn."

Tavra resented accurate listeners.

Around them, Dena's people prepared for the fixed field to worsen. Kiln workers shifted unfired pots off shelves that had stopped settling with the season. A miller dug beside a dry trough and found moist soil one armspan down, trapped where the held stone prevented its old upward seep. Every consequence offered Tavra another reason to hurry and another excuse to make the choice alone.

"Give me the fragment," she said.

Ossa considered. "For how long?"

"Until you ask for it back."

"Where does it remain?"

"On the board between us."

"Who may alter it?"

"Nobody."

Ossa slid the tube into the open.

Tavra unwrapped the Nareth leather without lifting it from the board. Court examiners had cleaned no oil from its surface. Serad's cross-cut still drove through the earlier quarry turn. She traced beside the grooves with a blunt awl.

For twelve years she had treated the Nareth release as proof of sequence. Now she read it as failed craft.

Its direction belonged to an empty quarry west of the old road. Its depth assumed Tavra's weight, her left-foot dominance, and the hillside's first southward pull. None of that could move into another field. Copying the cut would repeat the College's central error: mistaking one diagram for authority over changed ground.

Under those particulars lay a simpler act. The release did not force motion opposite the hold. It cut one edge free and let stored pressure choose the quarry because the quarry offered room.

"An exit without a destination," she said.

Ruhan looked over from the kiln. "That sounds like a destination with better manners."

"The cut names no final position. It names where the score stops claiming."

Ossa leaned closer. "Can a sole do that without routing everything into its wearer?"

"One sole cannot."

"Then stop drawing one."

Tavra took a fresh sheet and divided it into sixteen sole shapes.

Ossa closed her eyes.

"What?" Tavra demanded.

"You removed one master shoe and drew sixteen obedient shoes."

"They need compatible exits."

"Do they need your compatibility?"

"Yes, unless you want broken legs."

"Those are not the only choices."

Dena entered with her left arm bound against a dislocated shoulder. "Arguing again? Good. The spring is still dry, so nobody has won."

She set thirty-seven court rubbings beside the fragment. Each examiner had copied the cuts slightly differently. Tavra's first instinct called twenty-nine of them errors. Then she saw what variation revealed. Where every rubbing agreed, blade sequence stood certain. Where they diverged, oil wear or torn leather made certainty false.

"Layer them," she said.

Ruhan pinned the sheets against a kiln window. Daylight passed through thin paper. The common release turn appeared dark where all copies agreed. Its final direction spread into a fan of disputed charcoal.

Tavra marked the shared portion only. "We know the release opens here. We do not know its exact last angle."

"The court report already says that," Dena replied.

"I ignored the uncertainty because I remembered cutting it."

"Memory giving itself a craft stamp."

"Yes."

Outside, two children greeted each other on the sloped kiln yard. Each touched one heel down, turned the toe toward the safer side of the crack, and stepped away. The motion pulled Tavra back to Kesta.

Kel had copied the village children badly at first, too eager to make their three

steps match a score. A Kestan girl had laughed and reduced the greeting until he could manage it: one foot offering a direction, the next person choosing whether to answer. No joined measure. No center. Local knowledge carried in a step simple enough to refuse.

"One-step greeting," Tavra said.

Ruhan followed her gaze. "Kesta uses dozens."

"Show me one for approaching uncertain ground."

He stood at the yard edge. With his good left side forward, he placed one foot near a crack and rolled weight only to the ball, leaving the heel free. "This asks whether the next surface carries downhill."

"Who answers?"

"Whoever comes after, or nobody."

Ossa tapped the kiln brick with one right fingertip. "No opening count."

Tavra looked from the Nareth fragment to Ruhan's uncommitted heel. "The sole needs only the shared opening. Each person cuts the last angle after seeing the ground."

"Untrained people cannot cut under load," Dena said.

"Then cutters prepare several simple endings. The participant chooses one after the field moves."

Ossa's stare sharpened. "Still your endings."

"Then local cutters make them."

"Still cutters."

"Ground-dance requires scores."

"It requires scored leather. It does not require one class to keep every knife."

Tavra almost rejected that as unsafe. Kel's quick hands returned to memory, learning shallow sole marks at Dorel without ground-dance training. Ordinary people could not design a complex measure. They could cut one disclosed notch under supervision before stepping.

"Too deep and it catches," Tavra said. "Too shallow and it does nothing."

Dena picked up a bark scrap. "Give us limits, not a pattern."

They worked through afternoon.

Tavra taught knife depth by layers: score through the oil skin, stop before the pale fibre. Dena changed the explanation to a bend test because kiln workers knew clay, not leather. Ruhan insisted every trial sole carry three visible exit choices and one uncut refusal edge. Ossa rejected any drum phrase repeated enough to become command. Local drummers offered isolated sounds: rim knock, hand clap, kiln paddle on brick, or silence.

Each contribution made Tavra's original diagram less recognizable.

The trial field lay behind the glazing shed where anchor two had fixed a patch of clay soil. Before the hold, kiln workers said the ground tilted a little south every evening, helping rainwater drain. Now it stayed level. Water from washing pots pooled against the wall.

Tavra could not inspect it standing. Workers carried her on the door and set her outside the salt boundary. She read the field through a plain leather pad beneath her left palm. The held pressure felt thin compared with a road, but continuous. Enough to bruise a few feet if released badly.

Dena invited twelve residents. Tavra objected to the word invited until Dena threatened to hit her with the good arm.

They explained the trial separately.

"The field may tilt," said kiln worker Mavi. "Pots could fall."

"We moved them," another answered.

"My house wall joins that shed."

"Then you may refuse and ask us to choose another patch," Dena said.

Mavi refused. Two others left because permanent patrol notice threatened their grain share. Nine remained: four kiln workers, a miller, two carters, a shepherd, and the healer who had set Tavra's ankle.

Nobody called them dancers.

Before cutting leather, each participant received a blank and made a practice notch in waste bark. Tavra demonstrated depth on her own strip from the door. She could not reach their hands and therefore could not correct by taking the knife away. Dena bent each sample until fibres showed. Ruhan asked the maker to explain which boundary route had led to that notch. If the explanation named Tavra's instruction rather than a local feature, the sample returned to the waste pile.

The carter with the largest feet failed three times. His knife pressed through the pale fibre whenever his injured fingers tightened. He chose to let the kiln worker beside him cut the trial sole after both agreed where the notch should end.

"Does that make it her step?" he asked.

"It makes the cut hers and the choice to wear it yours," Dena said. "If either of you dislikes that division, stop."

They continued.

Mavi watched from beside the shed and challenged the salt boundary before anyone laid it. The proposed southern gap crossed her handcart lane at an angle likely to trap a wheel if the ground tilted. She required it widened by half a cart. Tavra had not known the cart carried glaze jars at dusk because no imperial map marked work hours.

That correction altered two participant notches. Both were recut with fresh

leather rather than patched. The discarded soles went into a marked basket so nobody could later mistake them for usable patterns.

Each chose a shallow greeting sole cut from local bark leather. Each sole opened at one shared point modeled on the Nareth release, then offered different outward notches. Participants selected the final notch after walking the field boundary in ordinary shoes. Ruhan recorded which routes they refused. No mark indicated a central position.

Tavra described the known cost. "Likely calf pull. Possible ankle bruising. If more than two people answer the same movement, pressure may gather. Take one step only. You may remove the sole before or during the trial. If the field does not move, we accept failure."

"What happens if it moves too far?" the healer asked.

"Open salt on all four sides lets pressure leave. Trained cutters stand outside with release knives. I am not a fault path."

Ossa looked at her.

Tavra corrected herself. "Nobody has agreed to serve as a fault path. If pressure gathers, everyone exits. We do not save the trial."

That passed.

Step-salt outlined an uneven circle with gaps at every path residents needed. Tavra's craft instinct wanted clean arcs. Mavi, watching from the shed, demanded another gap for a handcart although she had refused participation. They opened it.

"Who begins?" asked a carter.

"No one," Ossa said. "Stand outside until you choose."

For several breaths, nobody moved.

Tavra felt urgency claw at her. Anchor two remained fixed. Serad had six days. Eda remained inside Meren. She could tell the shepherd his chosen notch best matched the field. She could begin the trial with one sentence.

She bit the sentence closed.

The miller entered first. He placed his greeting foot and rolled weight toward a notch pointing at the dry trough. The ground gave a faint scrape.

He stepped out.

No drum followed.

A kiln worker chose a different edge. Her one step opened a hairline crack beside the pooled washwater. The shepherd waited until the water seeped into it, then selected his uphill notch. Pressure changed beneath Tavra's palm.

The field began to tilt south.

Not smoothly. One corner stayed fixed against the glazing shed. Two carters entered at once, saw each other, and both withdrew before taking weight. The healer chose silence as her signal and stepped toward the stubborn corner. Clay

trembled under her heel.

A sharp pull crossed the field. Three participants gasped.

"Out if you choose," Tavra called.

One left. Two remained without repeating.

Dena asked, "Need a release cut?"

Tavra examined the pressure through her palm. The old answer would have sent a cutter in to correct the corner. "Ask the people beside it."

Mavi, still outside, knelt by the shed. "That foundation has a drain stone under the plaster. We blocked it last winter."

"Will you open it?" Dena asked.

"My wall. My choice." Mavi took a hammer to the plaster, not a scored sole. The old drain gap appeared.

Water ran.

The stubborn corner lowered without another step. Released pressure left through the salt gaps and drain rather than entering a center. The yard settled on its old southern tilt. Nothing dramatic moved beyond it. Nine people stood with bruised calves, muddy shoes, and no mineral pallor.

The held field had returned to motion.

Tavra waited for triumph and found inspection instead. One greeting sole had split too deep. The shepherd's notch had contributed nothing. Two salt exits had merged under runoff, which could prove dangerous at larger scale. Participants argued whether the drain opening, not their steps, had done the decisive work.

"All of it did," Tavra said, then stopped. "That is inference. We would need another field to know."

"What do we call the packet?" Dena asked.

"Do not make a master copy," Tavra said.

"A name is not a master copy."

"It can become one."

Ruhan wrote on his atlas margin: OPEN: NINE STEPS, ONE DRAIN, FOUR SALT GAPS USED, THREE REFUSALS, NO CENTER. ASK AGAIN.

Ossa read it. "Open Measure."

The phrase moved through the circle without a proclamation. A measure with boundaries open to ground and choice. A practice whose final shape could not be cut before local people entered it.

Tavra looked at the rejected diagrams burning in the kiln. "Then mark every copy incomplete."

Dena ordered the trial sheets divided among participants. Tavra kept none.

At dusk, workers carried her door back inside. Her right ankle had swollen against the clay splints. The left knee burned from reading the field through her palm. Neither pain dimmed the calculation she had avoided all afternoon.

The new practice could distribute release. It could not enter the Dominion center quickly enough to spare Eda. Someone trained would still have to take that position while others broke the anchors.

Tavra asked Ossa to close the kiln door.

"When we reach Meren," she said, "Eda leaves center. I take her place."

Ossa's wounded hand rested on the document tube. "Did today teach you nothing?"

"It taught me not to own everyone's step."

"You still think you own hers."

"No." Tavra looked at the splinted ankle that could not bear weight, then at the score knife beside her. "I think I can offer a replacement she may refuse."

"And if she refuses to leave?"

Tavra had no answer she trusted.

Outside, the kiln yard continued its slow southward settling. Workers moved the water trough to follow it while nine trial soles travelled away in nine separate hands.

Chapter 20 — When Eda Chose the Drum

Eda pressed her burned thumb into the chalk mark and made it crooked.

The apprentices circling the eastern anchor copied every line she drew. They had been trained to regard precision as safety, and none of them looked closely enough to see that her third curve opened toward the release aisle instead of the center. Their soles whispered over the black floor of the Still Court. Each foot landed with the careful confidence of a body taught that obedience and balance meant the same thing.

Serad watched from the first gallery, one hand resting on Folio Seven.

The Court had no roof. Dawn had not reached it, but the administrative hill threw back enough lantern light to reveal the seven salted fields arranged around the central disc. Three anchor stones already sat in their iron cradles. Their holds had begun two days ahead of the public promise. Eda felt them through the right hip, three quiet pressures that never eased when she shifted her weight.

“Again,” Serad called.

Eda raised two fingers. The eastern company reset.

She gave them the opening count with her heel. Sixteen trained bodies moved. Their first turn drew counter-motion toward her, a familiar pressure entering along the scored channels of her soles. On the fifth beat she shortened her left step by half a thumb. The error traveled outward. It did not break the measure. Instead, it sent a thin share of strain into the empty release aisle and left a pale crack in the salt.

One apprentice glanced down.

“Keep your eyes level,” Eda said.

The girl obeyed. Eda hated how quickly she did it.

By the twelfth beat, the eastern anchor had shifted in its cradle. No more than the width of a fingernail, but Serad saw. He descended the gallery stairs without haste.

“Your hip,” he said when the company halted. “You are protecting it.”

“I am using it.”

“You opened the fifth line.”

“Salt settled into an old seam.”

Serad crouched and touched the crooked mark. His fingertip came away black. “The floor under this Court has been held since my predecessor’s childhood. It has no old seam.”

“Then we have made one.”

A few apprentices looked at Eda. She kept her shoulders loose. Serad could

punish insolence, but he could not punish a center for describing the ground under her feet. Not in front of people who would have to trust her body at dawn.

He stood. "Clear the field."

The company filed into the north passage. Eda remained inside the salt. Leaving without a release would drive the unfinished turn into their ankles. She drew the strain back through her right side, waited until pain shone white behind her eyes, then stepped out on the heel.

Serad caught her elbow.

"You have slept four hours in three nights."

"You advanced the rehearsal."

"I advanced necessity." His grip gentled without loosening. "The Hadrun roads have ceased receiving command. Two grain trains are stranded. Three towns have opened arguments over crossings that kept them alive all winter. You know what follows when a road becomes a vote held during hunger."

Eda looked toward Folio Seven. He had tied its cover shut with red cord, though he no longer pretended its center pages held nothing. "I know what follows when the person counting leaves bodies out of the number."

His face tightened. Not anger. Hurt would have been easier to dismiss if it had been false, but Serad had praised her first clean center, sat beside her fever bed after a hill measure, and taught her how to fall without feeding a fracture into the ground. His care had always contained a use. That did not make the care imaginary.

"The body projections account for every trained participant," he said.

"They account for us as material."

"They account for a cost I would carry myself if skill permitted."

"No. You would choose it yourself. That changes the count."

He released her arm. "Rest until second bell."

"Will the western company rehearse?"

"They can work without a center."

"That is not what I asked."

Serad's gaze moved to the cracked salt line. "I will center them."

His shoulder had begun to slope since the first anchors engaged. He believed this answer proved something. Eda could not decide whether it proved love, vanity, or merely the habit of putting his own body at the top of an arithmetic he had written for everyone else.

She bowed as a Fifth Measure center should. Then she walked to the robing chamber without limping until the door shut behind her.

Inside, she took off her right shoe.

The lining had rubbed a raw stripe along her arch. Beneath it, cut into a thin piece of goat leather, lay the copied page from Folio Seven. She had written small enough to preserve the seven counter-motion columns, the estimates for the center company, and the projected sterility of three provinces. A line of sweat had blurred the figure beside Nareth, but the words permanent root fixation remained clear.

She put the leather against her ribs. The robing chamber had one narrow window above head height and two guards outside. Three weeks earlier she would have considered those facts proof that leaving could not be done. Tavra would have treated them as a sole problem. Ossa would have listened for a weak beat. Ruhan would have asked why anyone assumed the door deserved to remain where it stood.

Eda had spent years refusing to become her mother's copy. She saw now how refusal could imitate its object. Tavra fled the College because every corridor told her where to put her weight. Eda had remained because Tavra's leaving told her the same thing.

A drum sounded beneath the western gallery.

Not the broad public voice of a complete field drum. This beat came thin and dry through the stone, struck on a rim or an inner skin. Two quick taps, a rest, then one.

Eda held still.

The cadence belonged to no current College instruction. It did belong to an old correction sequence, one Ossa Marr had used when apprentices crowded a center's blind side. Eda remembered Ossa at seventeen, unsmiling beside a practice drum, making the whole company repeat a turn because Eda had landed beautifully and dangerously.

Two quick. Rest. One.

A question.

Eda crossed to the water basin and lifted its bronze cup. The guards heard her drink. She set the cup down on the second beat, dragged it once against the basin after the rest, then struck it twice.

Not yet. Eastern passage.

Silence followed.

She wondered whether she had imagined the rhythm. Then a heel crossed the corridor outside in Ossa's old walking cadence, deliberately uneven. The sound passed the door and faded north.

Eda retied the shoe. Choosing Ossa felt like stepping onto a bridge built by someone who had once used rhythm to march people into death. It also meant trusting a woman who had confessed what she had done and changed how she carried the drum. Serad had confessed costs only after Eda found them, then

preserved the score.

At second bell, a guard escorted her back to the Court.

The western company had taken their marks. Serad stood at center with Folio Seven open on a stone lectern. Sweat darkened the collar of his gray practice coat. His left shoulder shook once before he quieted it.

"You will observe," he said.

Eda looked at the western anchor. "The cradle has turned."

"A settlement correction."

"It points inward."

"The foundation lines converge here."

Every Court score converged at the central disc, but this cradle pointed beneath it rather than toward it. A second pull waited under the marked ground, faint as a held breath. Eda tested the floor with her heel. Serad shut the folio.

"Gallery," he said.

She climbed six steps. From there she could see the whole western field and the eastern release aisle she had opened. She could also see the service gate behind the drum alcove. Its hinges had been removed for dawn's processional banners.

Serad began the count.

The company turned. His first landing came true. So did his second. He carried the three engaged holds in his shoulder and still found enough balance to receive the western anchor. Admiration rose in Eda before anger could stop it. Skill remained skill even when put to a cruel purpose.

On beat eight, the hidden pull beneath center tightened.

Serad's knee bent. He corrected. The company continued.

Eda counted the intervals. The extra anchor answered every sixteenth beat, too deep to hear through ordinary soles. Folio Seven's hidden center sequence had not described it. Serad had added a restraint after she opened the stitched pages. A center trying to use the public release would remain attached to the foundation.

No center without an exit.

Tavra's maxim had irritated Eda because it arrived disguised as craft law. Now Eda understood the error beneath her anger. An exit given by Tavra could become another mother's order. An exit cut by Eda belonged to her choice.

She descended the gallery.

Serad saw her movement and snapped, "Stay back."

The command cadence entered her before thought. Her trained body halted.

From beneath the eastern passage came two quick taps.

Ossa struck again, not louder, only wrong against Serad's count. Eda's conditioned muscles reached for both rhythms and found they could obey neither

without choice. The instant of confusion opened a space no command owned.

Eda stepped into it.

She crossed the edge of the western salt and took the empty seventeenth position. The apprentices faltered when they saw her. She gave them a training signal with her left hand: continue the figure, follow local center.

"What are you doing?" Serad demanded.

"Correcting the cradle."

"You are not scored for this field."

She set her right sole across the inward line. Pain bit the stress line in her hip. "Neither is the foundation anchor."

His face changed. He knew she had felt it.

Eda turned on the cracked edge of her sole. The copied leather stayed warm against her ribs. The western company completed beat twelve. She had four beats before the hidden pull tightened again.

At thirteen, she drove her heel into the cradle's inner rim.

At fourteen, she took Serad's share of the western counter-motion for one breath. His body rose as the pressure left it.

At fifteen, she kicked the anchor stone sideways.

The cradle rang.

At sixteen, the eastern crack she had prepared opened across the floor.

Counter-motion poured into the unused aisle. Salt jumped in a black sheet. Every apprentice staggered, but none fell. Eda released on her left heel and shouted, "Out by pairs. Do not run."

Serad lunged for the anchor. The western stone had not broken, and the measure had not failed. It had merely ceased to point inward. He could restore it after the company cleared.

That distinction kept Eda from becoming the killer his notices would name.

She reached the drum alcove. A gray-haired cleaner held the service gate open. Ossa did not stand there. Eda had expected her, and the disappointment nearly cost a step.

The cleaner shoved a folded practice coat at her. "Your drummer says the north lane is too obvious."

"Which drummer?"

"A bad one, by the sound of her."

Eda put on the coat and pulled its hood over her hair. Behind her, Serad called her name once. No rank. No command. The sound carried the same fear he had shown when an apprentice fell from a practice ridge years ago.

She chose the gate anyway.

The service road climbed behind the College kitchens, narrowed between archive walls, then descended toward the kiln quarter. Eda walked until the Court bells began. At the first crossing, a vegetable cart blocked two College riders. At the second, three washerwomen argued over a wheel placed squarely in the lane. Each delay looked ordinary. Together they made a route.

At the dye court, she found six eastern apprentices waiting beside vats of blue wool. The youngest still wore rehearsal shoes dusted with salt. Eda reached for the alley knife hidden in her sleeve, then saw that none of them carried binding cord.

"You ordered us out by pairs," the youngest said. "We went out."

"You should return before Serad counts the company."

"He counted us all morning." A broad dancer named Pellis pulled up one trouser leg. A dark mineral bruise crossed his ankle. "He did not count this."

Eda knew each of their placements. Pellis held the weak side of every western turn. Laro lost breath after long figures but concealed it by volunteering for salt work. The youngest, Anet, landed late whenever a drum sounded beyond her sight. Eda had corrected those faults until the dancers could hide them from anyone who did not know where to look.

"Leaving now may cost your licenses," she said. "Your rooms belong to the College. Your meal chits stop if your names enter the discipline book. The road companies may refuse unlicensed feet."

"We know," Anet said.

"No. You know the words. Tonight you may have nowhere to sleep."

Pellis looked toward the ringing Court. "Will you?"

Eda could have lied and turned their courage into cover. Instead she said, "I have a route for this hour. Nothing past it."

Two apprentices stepped back. One began crying without noise, wiped her face, and headed toward the College. Eda did not call her coward. Three more followed after a whispered argument. Anet and Pellis remained.

"You may leave us too," Eda said.

"That sounds different now," Pellis replied.

It did. Serad used consequence as a wall around every offered choice. Tavra sometimes used love the same way. Eda had no clean country to invite these dancers into, only a kiln yard and a measure still being invented.

"Go to the southern bathhouse," she said. "Ask for the woman who repairs furnace shoes. Tell her the western cradle points inward. Do not mention me. If she has no safe bed, you decide again."

Anet nodded. Pellis did not. "And you?"

"I decide again at the next crossing."

They separated before a rider entered the dye court. Eda ducked behind

hanging wool. Blue water dripped onto her practice coat, marking it with stripes no Fifth Measure center would wear. When the rider passed, she followed the dripping color toward the moving wall.

Ossa waited beneath a stair where the moving wall had left a wedge of shadow. Her drum hung from one strap. The outer face remained open to the air, and the inner skin carried old cuts that had once meant forced pace. Her bandaged left forearm rested against the rim.

"You kept me waiting," Ossa said.

"You chose the wrong gate."

"I chose three. You chose one of them."

Eda stopped an arm's length away. "Did Tavra send you?"

"No."

The answer came without decoration.

"Did she know you were coming?"

"She knew I meant to listen near the Court. She did not know what I would hear." Ossa tilted her head toward Eda's coat. "You left center?"

"I left Serad's center. I may enter another."

"Your mother will dislike that distinction."

"My mother dislikes distinctions she cannot cut into leather."

Ossa's mouth shifted. "She has improved by one distinction since yesterday."

"What distinction?"

"Asked and told."

Eda wanted proof before hope. "Take me to her."

They moved with the wall's afternoon adjustment. Ruhan waited at the wall shrine, his stiff right wrist tied close under his coat. He opened a rear panel and showed Eda a crawlspace behind the civic stones.

"The capital believes a shrine stays sacred by staying put," he said. "This one has traveled farther than most couriers."

"Where does it go?"

"Today? Kiln quarter. Tomorrow is an ambitious question."

The passage smelled of old wax and stone dust. Eda crawled with her right leg extended where she could, though the hip still caught. Ossa followed, dragging the drum carefully. Ruhan closed the panel behind them.

They emerged in a kiln yard after sunset.

A circle of scuffed earth lay between stacked bricks. Its salt line had been swept away, but the ground inside had softened into a shallow, uneven roll. People had practiced there recently. Not College dancers. The footprints varied too much in

size and skill, and most showed one step followed by withdrawal.

Tavra sat beside the kiln with her fractured ankle splinted forward. Her left knee looked swollen beneath the trouser cloth. She had a cutting board across her lap and a child's plain work shoe braced against it. A small field beyond the yard moved in a slow ripple, no longer held flat.

For a moment neither of them spoke.

Eda had rehearsed this encounter in locked rooms. In some versions she threw Folio Seven at Tavra. In others Tavra apologized with such precision that the twelve lost years rearranged themselves. The actual woman looked exhausted, gray at the mouth, and fiercely alert to Eda's weight.

"You're limping," Tavra said.

Eda laughed once. "I crossed half the capital by a shrine that thinks it is a corridor, and you begin with my gait."

Tavra set the shoe down. "You're here."

"I left."

"Did Ossa pull you out?"

"No."

"Serad release you?"

"No."

Tavra absorbed both answers. "Then you chose."

"That should not surprise you as much as it does."

"It does not surprise me."

"It frightens you."

"Yes."

The honesty checked Eda's next accusation. Tavra had once hidden fear under departure. Now she sat without a road and named it.

Eda took the copied page from inside her coat. "Folio Seven. Center projections, province loss, all seven anchor columns. The line beside Nareth blurred."

Tavra reached for it, then stopped before touching. "May I?"

Eda placed it in her palm.

Tavra read. Ossa crouched nearby, favoring her left arm. Ruhan watched the yard entrance. The kiln workers who had practiced the one-step circle gave them distance without pretending not to listen.

At the column for the capital foundation, Tavra's thumb went still. "He tied the center release to this?"

"He added a second anchor under the Court after I opened the folio. I felt it during rehearsal."

"Can you cut free?"

"I opened one aisle today."

"That is not an answer."

"It is mine."

Tavra looked up. The old reflex crossed her face before she spoke: measuring Eda's hip, the route, the cost, arranging all of them into a plan without asking. "I can take your place. The center sequence began from my Nareth work. My body already carries the corresponding joins."

"No."

"If I wear the copied cut and enter before dawn, Serad may accept the substitution long enough for you to reach the foundation anchor."

"No."

"The counter-motion will recognize an experienced center."

"It will break you before the second folio."

"That may still leave enough time."

Eda crossed the yard and knocked the cutting board from Tavra's lap. The child's shoe fell into the dust. Tavra flinched, not from anger but because twisting to catch it sent pain through her ankle.

"You do not get to turn dying into an apology," Eda said.

"I am trying to keep you alive."

"You keep saying that as though it answers who decides how."

"The projections say your soles will take the first burn. Your hip is already stressed. The center column ends in a blank because they do not know whether any body can survive it."

"And your answer is to put your body in the blank."

"I know how to release an anchor."

"So do I."

"You know the center."

"Yes." Eda's voice rose. "I know it better than you do now. I know Serad's revisions, the apprentices, the Court floor, the foundation pull. You know Nareth. You know cutting. You know how to listen when ground changes. Why must your skill erase mine before you can call it protection?"

Tavra's hands closed around the copied page. Eda saw how carefully she kept from tearing it.

"Because I left you there," Tavra said.

The yard seemed to contract around the words.

"I left you with him. Every time I imagine you at center, I see the morning I

walked out and told myself the College would keep you fed. If I stand aside now, it feels like doing it again."

"You cannot repair abandonment by taking away the door I choose."

"I know."

"Do you?"

Tavra bent to retrieve the small shoe. Her ankle prevented her from reaching. Eda picked it up first and set it on the board.

"I know enough to hear the question," Tavra said. "Not enough to stop wanting the wrong answer."

That sounded closer to truth than an apology polished for forgiveness.

Eda sat on an overturned brick opposite her. "I will go back to the Still Court."

Tavra's face emptied.

"I will enter center because companies are already attached to three holds. If I vanish, Serad will put an injured apprentice there or carry it himself until he falls. I will not save myself by passing the load to someone who has less choice."

"Then let me enter beside you."

"No. You cannot stand."

"I can cut from the ground."

"Good. Cut the capital anchor." Eda pointed to the copied column. "Not my role. Yours."

Ossa leaned over the leather. "The count reaches the foundation every sixteenth beat."

"I can break Serad's command cadence there," Eda said. "Not forever. Long enough to open the exit."

Ruhan came closer. "The wall shrine reaches the administrative slope before dawn if the wall keeps its usual turn. I can bring cutters through. I cannot promise the wall will cooperate with an imperial schedule."

He unfolded a strip from his incomplete atlas. Instead of a line, it showed three possible approaches and two broad blank spaces. One route crossed a bakery court; another depended on a retaining stair that might move before dawn. The last stopped at a question mark beside the foundation sheds.

"Why leave this empty?" Eda asked.

"Because I have not walked it today." Ruhan tapped the blank with his stiff knuckle. "A route I pretend to know becomes an order for somebody whose feet meet the mistake."

Eda studied the unfilled paper. Serad's folios had no blanks. Tavra's copied page preserved columns precise enough to conceal whom they spent. This uncertain strip offered less comfort and more honesty.

“Do not promise the wall,” Tavra said. “Give us the route while it exists.”

Eda looked at her mother.

Tavra drew a slow breath. “You enter center with an exit you cut. I reach the foundation anchor and release it when you ask. Ossa breaks the conditioned count. Ruhan opens a route for those who choose to come. No substitution.”

“No hidden cost.”

Tavra placed the copied page flat between them. “No hidden cost.”

“And if I tell you to wait, you wait.”

Pain and fear moved across Tavra’s face. Neither disappeared. “I wait.”

The words did not heal the years between them. They made a plan possible inside those years.

Eda took the child’s shoe from the board. A single curved score crossed its sole, simple enough for an untrained foot to follow. The heel mark opened outward.

“No center without an exit,” she said.

This time the maxim did not belong to Tavra. Eda set the shoe beside the copied page, and together they began cutting two different routes toward the same dawn.

Chapter 21 — The City That Would Not Hold

The grain wardens had chained Veyr's storehouse doors before breakfast.

Ruhan arrived while two bakers argued through the bars with a clerk holding the imperial order. The road beyond the square ran straight east between planted stones, pale and empty under a hard morning sky. Three grain carts waited on the far ridge. Their drivers had been forbidden to cross until Veyr renewed its civic hold.

A city could starve within sight of flour. Ruhan had seen mountains do less cruel things by accident.

He set his incomplete atlas on a rain barrel and studied the square. The civic anchor stood in a waist-high shrine between the storehouse and the eastern road. Step-salt boxed it inside a field broad enough for forty trained dancers. Imperial crews had left the lines ready, along with an order that gave Veyr until noon.

"We hold, they open the stores," said Council Speaker Jorren. "We refuse, the grain goes south."

A woman in a miller's apron pointed at the locked doors. "That grain belongs to us already."

"The seals belong to the road office."

"Then feed your children wax."

The crowd answered with rough approval. Jorren flinched. He wore no College badge, only a city cord and the sleepless look of someone asked to choose which neighbors would hate him by dusk.

Tavra sat on a cart at the edge of the square, her right ankle splinted and her cutting board across her knees. Ossa stood beside her damaged drum. Every movement of her left arm came carefully. Two Hadrin cutters laid plain shoes on a blanket, none paired for a full measure.

Ruhan watched people notice the insufficiency. A trained company had soles for every foot and a center prepared to carry the ground's answer. Tavra had brought single shoes, scraps of felt, three jars of salt, and a practice that had moved one small field outside a kiln.

Jorren saw it too. "You promised an alternative."

"I promised a trial," Tavra said.

"Trials happen after the stores open."

"Then hold the road."

The square quieted.

Tavra did not soften her voice. "Use the imperial score. Put your road company at center. Renew the hold. You will have grain today and more stone in their joints

tomorrow. The soil beyond the eastern marker will keep hardening. I won't call that choice ignorance after Hadrún read the ledgers."

A road-company veteran pushed through the crowd. His ankles bowed outward above polished boots. "And your trial?"

"The road may move."

"How far?"

"We do not know."

"Will the storehouse remain reachable?"

"Its final position remains unknown."

"Then what do you know?" the veteran asked.

Tavra turned one unfinished shoe so its shallow groove caught the light. "We know this cut asks one foot for less than a common stair. We know a participant can withdraw before weight crosses the hip. We know an open salt boundary releases torque better than an imperial box. We know the anchor may answer unevenly, so trained cutters must stand at every gap. We know nobody in the field should be promised safety we have not earned."

"You brought uncertainty to a hungry city."

"Serad brought certainty with the injuries written on hidden pages."

The veteran touched one bowed ankle. "My company knows those injuries without pages."

"Then help us recognize the first bad turn."

He studied her for a long moment. "I will not center."

"I am not asking you to."

"I will watch the north edge. If your salt begins closing behind anyone, I break it."

Tavra offered him the shoe. "Agreed."

Murmurs rose. Ruhan heard fear change direction. Tavra had learned to disclose cost, but her bluntness could leave people staring at an empty place where confidence ought to stand.

He opened his atlas to the page he had drawn while entering Veyr. "The storehouse has three approaches. East road, dye alley, river stair. If the anchor flexes by less than a house length, two approaches remain. If it moves farther, we negotiate a crossing after the trial."

"Negotiate with whom?" Jorren asked.

"The people standing on each side of it."

"That is not a road office."

"No. A road office has chained your breakfast."

The bakers laughed first. Jorren did not, but his shoulders lowered.

A courier came running from the western lane, one plain shoe tied to his chest. He had changed horses twice and lost one sleeve to briars. Tavra cut the cord while he drank from a public ladle.

Inside the shoe, a shallow curve crossed the sole from outer heel to first toe. The cutter had left the leather thick around it, safe against unintended turns. Kel's name appeared in tiny letters beside a repair mark.

Tavra pressed her thumb into the groove. Something in her face eased. "He widened the release."

"Is that good?" Jorren asked.

"It means a frightened foot can stop early without catching its weight."

The veteran picked up the shoe. "A child cut this?"

"An apprentice," Tavra said. "No ground-dance training."

Jorren looked from the shoe to the waiting carts. "Tell them what happens if it fails."

Tavra nodded to Ossa.

Ossa struck the bare rim once. Its thin note reached the whole square because everyone had stopped talking.

"This is not command cadence," she said. "I will give a starting interval, then each section keeps its own count. You may leave before the step. You may leave after placing your foot but before giving weight. If a leader tells you that departure breaks the measure, that leader is lying. A trained cutter will manage the salt. Tavra will receive only the anchor's immediate turn from a seated brace. No permanent center carries the field."

"What can it do to us?" called the miller.

"Bruise a sole. Turn an ankle. Drop you if your neighbors rush. A bad release can put torque into the road and throw loose stone." Ossa rested her weak forearm on the rim. "The College score would place greater known harm into fewer trained bodies. This trial distributes smaller risks among volunteers and returns the rest to the Deep Step."

Someone shouted, "And if the grain leaves?"

"Then we have not solved grain," Ruhan said. "We have only refused to purchase it with hidden bodies. The carts will still need a route."

People began choosing.

Some went directly to the salt field. Others backed away. A cooper demanded to read the Nareth projections before deciding. Tavra handed him the copied sheets carried by the sole courts, not Eda's original leather page. Three road-company dancers volunteered, then removed their licensed shoes and took plain wrappings so nobody would mistake their skill for a requirement.

Ruhan walked the boundary with Jorren. His stiff right wrist ached when he drove chalk pegs, so a baker's daughter pushed them for him. They marked gaps every eight paces. No part of the circle could close people in.

"The imperial field has one entrance," Jorren said.

"An entrance becomes a trap when everybody must use it to leave."

"You have an answer for every line."

"I come from a country that distrusts lines."

Training began in the square outside the salt.

Tavra demonstrated from the cart. She could not put weight on her right ankle, so she used two wooden models strapped at the knee. One showed Kel's curve. The other showed the release, a simple withdrawal that returned weight to the unmarked foot.

"Do not dance," she told them. "Take one ordinary step. Feel where your balance wants to go. If the score asks farther than your body agrees, stop."

A fish seller raised his hand. "How do I know what my body agrees?"

"You have been standing in markets longer than some licensed centers have been alive. You know when a board tips under a barrel. Use that knowledge."

The first practice line stepped on bare ground. Ossa gave no beat. People moved at their own pace, laughing when neighbors leaned into each other. Ruhan watched the laughter carefully. It could hide embarrassment and make a refusal harder. When a bent old woman missed the curve, he stopped the line rather than turn her mistake into entertainment.

"You did nothing wrong," he said. "The cut did not fit your foot."

Tavra looked at the sole, then shaved the outer groove wider. "Try it without weight."

The woman did. Her heel found the turn.

A second group practiced with Ossa's starting interval. She tapped three uneven notes and fell silent. Each cluster spoke its own count afterward. The square filled with overlapping voices. No cadence traveled far enough to command everyone.

Ruhan took six volunteers on a walk beyond the field. He made them trace the storehouse approaches without looking at the imperial road markers. A potter found a narrow passage behind the bathhouse. Two sisters who delivered charcoal knew a sloped yard broad enough for handcarts but not wagons. Jorren dismissed both routes as informal until Ruhan asked who used them every day.

"People without road seals," Jorren said.

"Then they already know how a city survives when its official road refuses them."

They added both approaches to a chalk board beside the salt. Residents corrected distances and named gates that locked after dusk. Each correction

changed the trial's meaning. They were not merely preparing to move stone. They were deciding how to keep bread reachable if stone moved beyond the plan.

At the practice line, a young father removed his wrapping after three attempts. His son begged him to stay because neighbors were watching.

"I lean too far on the cut," the father said.

Tavra inspected his stance. "I can deepen the heel."

"No. I do not want my foot in it."

She returned the wrapping without argument. "Then stand outside the west gap and keep children clear."

The man accepted that work. His son scowled until Ossa asked him to carry water to the cutters. Ruhan watched shame dissolve into other useful tasks. A field that honored refusal needed places for refusers to remain part of the city. Otherwise departure became exile by another name.

Before the live trial, Jorren read the known risks aloud from the storehouse steps. He also read the right to stop. The wording sounded stiff and legal, but people interrupted until every phrase made sense. One woman asked whether leaving after the anchor moved would endanger those who remained.

"It may change their balance," Tavra said. "That is why each section has a cutter watching. Your body does not become their property because they prefer the count unchanged."

By late morning, twenty-six people stood inside the field. More than twice that number watched from outside. The road-company veteran took the place nearest the anchor but wore no center sole. Tavra's cart sat just beyond the northern gap, with a broad scored board under her left foot. Two cutters held the board so she could receive a brief change without standing.

Ruhan walked to the eastern road. The grain carts remained on the ridge. Their drivers watched.

Jorren joined him. "If the road turns away, they cannot reach us."

"Ask whether they will move."

"They have orders."

"So do you."

The speaker rubbed both hands over his face. Then he lifted the city horn and called across the distance. "If our road shifts, will you bring the carts by another approach?"

The first driver cupped her hands. "Who pays the extra day?"

Veyr's miller shouted from the field, "I will."

"You do not own the mills," Jorren said.

"I own one. The other owners can decide whether to look cheap in front of breakfast."

Three mill owners began arguing. They reached terms before Ossa finished checking her rim ties.

Ruhan returned to the salt. He took no scored shoe. His work belonged outside, where he could watch approaches and call a halt if the city cut itself off.

Ossa raised her right hand.

"Beginning interval only," she said.

The rim sounded three times.

Voices answered from four sections, none together. People bent their knees. Bare heels and plain soles touched Kel's curved marks.

At first, nothing happened.

A child outside the field complained that everyone looked foolish. Then the civic anchor clicked against its shrine.

The eastern road lifted by a finger's width.

Tavra's left leg jerked. She gripped the cart rail but did not pull the motion inward. "Let it pass," she called.

The veteran nearest the shrine began a trained correction. His body knew how to seize the change and hold it. He stopped himself before the second foot landed.

Around him, one-step participants gave weight at different moments. Each small turn opened and released. The road shifted north.

Paving stones rose in a slow diagonal. A stack of empty baskets toppled. Jorren shouted for the southern section to hold.

Ossa struck her rim once, a warning rather than command. "No holding. Choose your release."

Four people stepped out. Their departure opened a gap in the local count. The fish seller looked ready to flee, then followed his own scored curve and withdrew cleanly.

The anchor rolled within its shrine.

Ruhan ran east. His right wrist knocked against his chest, but his feet found the moving seams. The grain road no longer pointed at the storehouse doors. It bent toward the dye alley, where a brick wall blocked the final approach.

"Clear the blue yard," he shouted. "We need a cart width."

Dyers hauled racks aside. A landlord protested until the first paving stone entered his courtyard. Ruhan knelt and felt the direction through his palm. The road wanted the lower grade by the river, not the storehouse square.

He could have called that wrong. An imperial map would have.

"Open the rear gate," he told the landlord.

"That gate enters my private court."

"For how long?"

The man stared at him.

"Name a term," Ruhan said. "Name a price. Refuse if you choose, and we find another route."

Behind them, the field voices broke into frightened fragments. Tavra called releases one by one. No single count controlled the whole circle. The road continued turning.

The landlord looked at the grain carts, the chained storehouse, and the paving seam approaching his wall. "Until sunset. No storage. City repairs the hinge."

Jorren, breathless from the square, said, "Agreed."

They unbarred the rear gate.

The road settled through the dye yard and stopped short of the river stair. It no longer ran straight, but it connected the eastern ridge to the storehouse by a turn through private ground. The distance grew by a quarter mile.

At the field, the last participant released.

Tavra sagged against the cart. Gray dust marked the cloth over her left knee. Ossa crouched beside her but did not touch until Tavra nodded. The civic anchor rested at a new angle. Soil inside the salt had cracked in soft ridges rather than flattening under a permanent hold.

Jorren looked along the altered road. "Did we succeed?"

A storehouse warden arrived with the imperial seal keys. "The order requires a renewed hold."

"No hold," Jorren said.

"Then the stores remain closed."

The miller held up a hammer. "The hinges are city iron."

Ruhan stepped between them before refusal became a broken door and a prison list. "The grain carts have a negotiated crossing. Let the drivers sell from the dye yard. The storehouse dispute can wait until people have eaten."

The first cart entered under the landlord's gate. Its wheels followed the new road without slipping. People cheered, but not everyone joined. Several stared at displaced market stalls and the cracked field. The Open Measure had not preserved the city unchanged. It had kept change from being hidden in one body.

By afternoon, residents had marked the dye-yard crossing for a single day. A committee of millers, tenants, dyers, and carters set another meeting before sunset. The landlord demanded his hinge repair in writing. Jorren wrote it.

Couriers began arriving before the second cart unloaded. Hadrún's northern valley offered cutters. Kesta offered pass-runners but no promise that its orchards would remain near the capital route. Dorel sent word through Kel's courier that bench workers had begun copying the simple curve.

One southern delegate asked Tavra to certify every copied sole. She refused.

The sole courts would teach the cut, publish failures, and destroy any wrapping that trapped a heel, but no signature would turn the practice into her possession. Another delegate demanded a fixed number from each district. Jorren pointed to the people who had left Veyr's field and said a quota would rebuild command before anyone reached Meren.

Ruhan recorded each offer in his atlas as a condition, not a border.

At dusk, representatives counted commitments around Tavra's cart. Seven provinces would send people and shoe-cutters toward Meren. Some offered hundreds. Others promised only whoever chose after hearing the risks. No one pledged a road permanently.

Jorren watched residents erase the imperial salt box and preserve the open gaps. "What do we tell the capital?"

Ruhan closed the atlas with his good hand. Beyond the square, the new road bent through blue-stained ground while the old straight course ended at a wall.

"Tell them Veyr still has a road," he said. "Then give them the terms for using it."

Part IV

Chapter 22 — The Last Rehearsal

Ossa tied Eda's wrists with a knot loose enough to fail under a hard turn.

They stood in the alley below the College laundry wall, hidden from the dawn watch by sheets stiff with frost. Ossa wore a scavenged cadence coat over her damaged drum. The imperial gray fit badly across her shoulders, and the empty outer face of the instrument made any close inspection dangerous.

"You should strike me," Eda said.

"No."

"A recaptured fugitive does not arrive clean."

"You crawled through a shrine, slept in a kiln, and crossed Veyr dye yards. Clean has withdrawn from the discussion."

Eda touched the bruise already darkening her jaw. She had made it herself against a door frame. "They will ask why I am walking beside you instead of behind."

Ossa pulled the cord once. "Because you bite."

"I do."

"You are enjoying this too much."

"I am returning to the man I escaped yesterday. Let me enjoy the useful parts."

Beyond the sheets, the administrative hill rang first bell. The Still Court answered with seven bronze notes. Eda felt three engaged anchors through her right hip. The hidden foundation pull came later, a pressure under the final note.

Ossa heard her breath change. "There?"

"Every sixteenth beat. Serad may have connected the western cradle to it, but I have not seen the physical join."

"Tavra says a join can be cut."

"Tavra says many things from a comfortable distance."

"Her ankle would dispute comfortable."

Eda looked toward the moving wall. Somewhere inside its morning course, Ruhan guided cutters and volunteers through the wall shrine. Tavra rode on a mill cart because she could no longer put weight on her right foot. Eda had asked them to wait for her signal. She had also asked Tavra not to substitute judgment for fear.

The second request frightened her more than the first.

Ossa marched her through the laundry gate.

The watch captain recognized Eda and reached for his whistle. Ossa slapped a

folded order into his hand before he could blow it. The seal came from an archive clerk who had resigned after reading Hadrún's ledgers. It named Ossa as a temporary recovery officer and contained enough correct language to survive a hurried glance.

"Found her near the west wall," Ossa said.

The captain stared at the open drum frame. "What happened to your skin?"

"She tried to eat it."

Eda lunged with convincing fury. Ossa caught the cord and dragged her sideways. The captain stepped back.

"Master Chorearch wants her at center," he said.

"Chancellor first."

"He said center."

Ossa leaned close. "Then you tell Chancellor Miren that a valuable prisoner crossed her civil gate without examination because a watch captain preferred College instructions. Give me your name for the report."

The captain sent two guards with them to Miren's offices.

Eda kept her head lowered through the administrative passages. Clerks carried document boxes toward the upper archive. Road officials argued over notices from Veyr, where a city had refused its hold yet received grain. Nobody looked stable enough to notice that Eda's wrist knot had shifted.

Miren occupied a long chamber overlooking the Court. She stood at the window in a red civil coat, one hand gripping the sill. Three sealed route maps lay open behind her.

"Leave us," she told the guards.

Ossa remained.

"You too, officer."

"Prisoner bites," Ossa said.

Miren turned. She had met Ossa during the Hadrún forced march inquiry, back when the empire needed one cadence officer's desertion to carry the blame for an entire command. Recognition traveled between them.

"You," Miren said.

Ossa cut Eda's cord.

Miren reached for the bell on her desk. Eda set a folded copy of the ecological projections over it.

"Read Nareth first."

"I have read the fugitive broadsides."

"Not Tavra's account. Yours." Eda opened the sheet to the province columns. "These figures came from Folio Seven. Compare the notation to Serad's route

maps if you think I copied them falsely.”

Miren did not touch the paper. “You fled the College during an emergency.”

“I left a rehearsal after releasing every apprentice in my field.”

“You destabilized an anchor.”

“By a fingernail. He restored it within an hour.”

“You expect that distinction to protect you?”

“No. I expect it to keep us talking about evidence instead of treason.”

Miren looked at Ossa. “And what do you expect?”

“For once, a civil ruler to read the cost before signing the bodies.”

The chancellor’s expression hardened. Ossa had put command into the sentence even without a drum. Eda stepped between them.

“Three provinces,” she said. “Springs fixed in stone. Root paths unable to renew. Soil turning sterile beneath permanent holds. Serad calls the loss finite because the grain roads survive at first. Ask what they carry after the fields die.”

Miren picked up the projections.

She read standing. Her finger followed columns for water and roots before it reached the center-body estimates. She returned to the first page, slower now.

“I saw earlier projections,” she said.

“Which ones?”

“Route disruption. Company casualties. A severe range, not this.”

“Did the earlier pages name soil?”

“No.”

“Did they name duration?”

“Fifty years.”

“The center pages say permanent.”

Miren crossed to a locked map chest and took out a folio bound in blue. Her civil copy ended before the suppressed columns began. Someone had replaced the missing section with a summary stating that normal seasonal release would resume after consolidation.

“Serad signed this,” she said.

“So did you.”

“On what I was given.”

Ossa made a contemptuous sound.

Eda held up one hand. “If limited knowledge excuses a signature, then what you do after full knowledge defines it.”

Miren read the Nareth figures again. “Can the Measure be stopped safely?”

"Three anchors already hold. Dropping every company without release would injure dancers and leave torque in the provinces. Serad knows that. He began early so cancellation would become dangerous."

"And your alternative?"

"Unproven at continental scale."

"Then you ask me to choose between certain roads and an experiment."

"I ask you to stop calling dead soil certain roads."

Below them, workers rolled the western anchor into rehearsal position. The sound climbed through the window frame.

Miren folded her civil copy closed. "I will issue withdrawal of civil authority from the Dominion convocation. No road warden, tax office, granary, or city guard will enforce attendance or supply the Court."

"Serad commands the College companies," Eda said.

"The College charter permits emergency measures without my seal when active ground failure threatens the capital."

"He has manufactured that condition through the early holds."

"I cannot dissolve the charter before dawn."

"Can you arrest him?" Ossa asked.

"With which guard? Half trained under College cadence, and the other half has families on held roads." Miren took up her bell, then stopped. "I can withdraw what remains mine. I can open civil salt stores and refuse him carts. I can publish these pages."

"That will not defeat him," Eda said.

"No." Miren met her eyes. "It will tell the capital that civil obedience has ended. I spent twenty years making such a sentence impossible to say. Do not mistake lateness for ease."

Eda did not forgive her. She believed her.

Miren rang for her chief clerk. By the time guards reached the door, the withdrawal order carried her signature and three witnesses. She gave one copy to Ossa.

"Take it to every public board," she said.

Ossa glanced at Eda.

"Go," Eda said. "I need you outside the Court before final count."

"You need a captor."

"Miren can provide one."

The chancellor called in four civil guards and ordered them to escort Eda to Serad. Nobody used binding cord.

Before they left, Miren opened the balcony doors and read her withdrawal order into the Court. Her voice lacked Ossa's reach, so clerks repeated each sentence from lower galleries. Civil salt stores would no longer provision the Dominion Measure. Granary offices would not punish cities for refusing attendance. Tax riders would not seize local anchors. City guards would protect departures from public fields instead of forcing bodies into them.

The words moved down the hill in layers. Some workers cheered. Others stood bewildered beside carts they had spent weeks loading. A civil salt clerk unlocked a wagon, handed one jar to a College surveyor who claimed an active hold required it, then hesitated with the second jar in both hands.

"Does withdrawal mean we let dancers fall?" he called.

Miren gripped the balcony rail. "No. Existing holds receive release supplies. No new field receives civil support."

Serad's deputy shouted from below that every jar already belonged to an active continental field. The clerk looked between authorities and began crying.

Eda descended to the wagon. "Mark each jar at issue. Put half beside the release passages, under civilian custody. Give none to an unopened anchor."

"By whose order?" the deputy demanded.

"By the difference between release and expansion."

The clerk accepted that because it named the work in front of him. He painted a black heel on the release jars. Miren added the distinction to her order before any official could convert confusion into obedience.

Withdrawal did not empty the Court. It broke a single command into arguments at every cart, gate, and storeroom. Eda saw danger in that disorder. She also saw people asking what their hands would support before they lifted anything.

Serad waited on the central disc with all seven folios open around him.

He looked first at Eda's wrists, then at the guards. "Where did you find her?"

Miren answered from the gallery. "She returned with evidence."

"You saw what she carried?"

"I saw what you withheld."

The companies had begun gathering in the passages. Serad would not argue where they could hear. He closed Folio Seven and said, "Chancellor, this Court remains under College emergency authority."

"Civil authority is withdrawn."

"Then remove your officers."

"I have."

Miren descended no farther. Serad watched her leave. The hurt on his face looked different from what Eda had seen after her escape. This fracture touched the order he had spent decades building, not a protégé he believed he might

retrieve.

When the civil doors shut, he faced Eda.

"Did your mother send you back?"

"No."

"Ossa?"

"No."

"Then why are you here?"

"Because three active anchors have bodies attached. If you center the full Measure without me, apprentices die first."

His breath left slowly. "You still understand necessity."

"I understand custody. Those dancers cannot leave safely until we release what you began."

"You will center?"

"I will rehearse."

Serad accepted the smaller promise because dawn approached and he needed her skill. He handed her the practice shoes kept beside Folio Seven.

Anet and Pellis stood among the eastern company. Eda had sent them to a bathhouse after her escape; now they wore borrowed work clothes under their rehearsal belts. Serad either had not learned they left or had chosen to restore useful bodies without public discipline.

Pellis met Eda's eyes. "Are we prisoners?"

Serad answered before she could. "You are licensed dancers under emergency call."

"That was not the question," Anet said.

A day earlier, she would have swallowed those words. Eda felt pride and fear together.

"No guard will stop you if you leave before we enter salt," Eda said. "After an anchor engages, release by your section cutter. Do not run across another field."

Serad's voice remained level. "Departure now transfers your place to an apprentice with less rehearsal."

There lay his strongest restraint, not a locked gate but the suffering of someone behind them.

Eda faced the gathered company. "He began holds early and arranged the burden so leaving would injure another person. That fact matters. It does not give him ownership of your feet. Anyone who stays should know the foundation anchor may prevent the center from using the public release."

The dancers looked toward Serad. He did not deny it.

Three left. Pellis stayed because his younger sister held an outer position in the southern company. Anet removed her licensed shoes, cut the imperial heel mark out with a salt knife, and put them back on.

"What does that accomplish?" Serad asked.

"It reminds me that a mark can be removed."

Eda had no promise that such reminders would survive counter-motion. She only knew command entered most easily when nobody named the door.

She checked the soles Serad had given her. The public release line remained where she remembered it. Under the arch, a new crosscut ran toward the heel, disguised as a reinforcement groove. She pressed it with her thumbnail. The groove carried the hidden foundation pull.

"Who cut these?"

"I corrected them."

"You are not a score-cutter."

"I know the Court better than any cutter alive."

"That confidence sounds familiar."

His gaze sharpened. "Put them on."

The final rehearsal used only four anchors, but Serad placed a complete company around each. Eda entered center. Her right hip took the first pressure before she finished the opening turn.

Serad counted from the lectern. His voice moved through trained bodies with the weight of years. Eda let the first twelve beats pass cleanly. On thirteen she tested the hidden crosscut by raising her left heel.

The foundation answered.

Pressure closed around both ankles, not enough to injure yet. The public exit on her sole pulled outward while the new groove drew inward. A center following the visible release would split the load across her pelvis.

Eda changed weight before Serad saw.

At sixteen, she let her right toe drag half a mark. The western company compensated. Counter-motion skimmed the central disc and revealed a darker stone seam beneath the salt. It ran from Eda's position to the lectern.

Not merely a cut in her shoe. A second anchor lay under Serad's folios.

She followed the next figure toward it. The apprentices interpreted her drift as part of rehearsal and widened their ring. Through the thin leather she felt a buried stone no larger than a fist, joined to the capital foundation by a scored copper cradle.

Serad had turned his place of authorship into the lock.

"Center," he warned.

"My exit catches."

"It will settle under load."

"It tightens under load."

"Continue."

Eda did. An open accusation would make him remove her and start with another dancer. She needed the hidden anchor exposed when Tavra arrived.

At the final turn, Eda drove her heel beside the dark seam. A hairline crack reached the lectern. Salt drained into it, leaving one corner of the buried cradle visible.

She released before the crosscut closed.

Pain traveled from her right hip to the base of her spine. She remained upright until the companies cleared, then took off both shoes and set them before Serad.

"I will not wear those at dawn."

"They keep the center from abandoning an active continental hold."

"They keep the center from choosing release."

"If you leave at the wrong beat, provinces tear against one another."

"Then tell me the right beat."

"Complete the Measure."

Eda looked at the crack under his lectern. "That is not an exit."

A bell rang from the western wall.

Not a Court bell. Three low strikes came through the administrative hall, followed by a pause and two more. Ruhan's signal.

Serad heard only stone settling. Eda had spent enough time with Ossa to hear the route inside the rhythm.

"The wall moved early," an anchor surveyor called from the gallery.

Serad turned toward him. "Stabilize it."

"No civil salt carts remain."

Miren's withdrawal had begun.

Eda carried her practice shoes toward the north passage. Serad blocked her.

"You remain in the center rooms until dawn."

"I need my own soles."

"I will send a cutter."

"No one else fits my hip."

He weighed the need for control against the need for skill. "Two guards."

Eda walked between them to the center rooms. At the first stair, the floor shifted sideways. Both guards caught the rail. Eda did not. She followed the motion down,

turned through the robing passage, and kicked the laundry door open.

The western service lane had narrowed to a crack between walls. At its end, the wall shrine stood open.

Ruhan crouched inside the displaced panel, his stiff wrist bound to his chest. Behind him waited Hadrún cutters, Veyr volunteers, and two apprentices from the dye court. They passed salt jars hand to hand through the moving cavity. Ossa's withdrawal notice had been pasted across the shrine face.

Tavra came last on a low grain cart. Her splinted ankle projected over the edge. She held Eda's copied page in one hand and Kel's sample sole in the other.

"You found it?" she asked.

"Under Serad's lectern. The second anchor runs into the foundation through a scored cradle."

"Can you expose it again?"

"At final count."

Tavra's mouth tightened. "Then I wait."

Eda heard the effort inside the promise.

Above them, the Court bell began striking an alarm. A herald's voice followed from the administrative gallery, carrying across the capital: by order of the Master Chorearch, the Dominion convocation would commence at dawn, one day before the revised public hour.

The cutters froze. People looked toward the paling eastern sky.

Ruhan measured the shrine passage. "The wall gives us less than an hour before it turns."

Eda stepped aside and opened the laundry door wider. One by one, the coalition entered the College through a sacred wall that had never agreed to stay where empire put it.

Chapter 23 — Seven Thousand Bare Feet

The first cutting hall ran out of leather before midnight.

Ossa heard the shortage travel through the old bathhouse as a change in knife rhythm. For two hours, cutters had worked in rough waves: scrape, turn, draw the shallow curve, pass the sole. Then one bench fell silent. Another followed. At the far end, a Hadrin cutter held up the last piece of goat hide, too narrow for an adult heel.

People waiting in the bathing galleries began talking all at once.

"We have felt," Kel called from somewhere near the door.

Ossa turned so fast the drum frame struck her hip.

Kel Orra pushed through the crowd carrying a pack taller than his back. He looked older than fifteen until he grinned at Tavra across the hall. Behind him came Dorel bench workers with rolls of furnace felt, bark leather, old market awnings, and every serviceable strap they had collected on the road.

Tavra sat at the central bench with her splinted right ankle extended under it. The copied Folio page remained folded inside her coat. When she saw Kel, she gripped the bench edge instead of reaching for him.

"You left Dorel," she said.

"You noticed."

"I told you to stay."

"You stopped being my master when the College named you traitor." Kel dropped the pack. "Then you became my master again in three provincial notices, but none agreed on the date. I chose the useful interpretation."

Ossa expected Tavra to cut his decision apart. Instead she asked, "Did you read the risk sheet?"

"Twice. Dorel's cutters read it aloud at every bench."

"Do you understand the capital field may turn a simple step against a foot?"

"Yes."

"Are you here to cut or step?"

"Cut." Kel's grin disappeared. "I have no ground-dance training. That fact has not improved during the journey."

Tavra nodded once. "Take the north bench."

It did not resemble an embrace. Ossa heard what it cost both of them.

The bathhouse served as only one of eleven cutting halls. Civil granaries, dye sheds, two temples, and a College pension office had opened their floors after Miren's withdrawal. Messengers ran patterns between them. No hall kept a

complete score. Each received Kel's one-step curve, Tavra's release notch, and a list of known failures.

Leather remained scarce.

Kel cut the last narrow hide into heel patches and sewed them onto cloth. A Dorel awning became strips wide enough to protect toes. People removed belts, boot tops, apron ties, and cart covers. When even those ran low, cutters mixed charcoal and oil into thick salt paste and marked the curve directly onto bare-foot wrappings.

"Those will blur with sweat," a licensed score-cutter warned.

"So redraw them before the field," Kel said.

"They will not hold a deep cut."

"They should not. Nobody outside the center companies takes a deep cut."

The cutter looked toward Tavra for correction. Tavra kept shaving a felt heel. "He is right."

Ossa moved between benches and listened for haste. A fast knife could close the release groove. A proud cutter could add a flourish that made one ordinary step into training. Twice she stopped work and burned whole batches whose heel marks trapped weight.

People protested the waste.

"Bad soles cost more than leather," she said.

A cutter from the eastern pension house challenged her beside the furnace. "You burned forty heel patches. Forty bodies may stand unmarked because you prefer purity."

"I prefer a foot that can withdraw."

"You were a cadence officer, not a cutter."

"No. I learned to inspect what commands did after they left my hands."

She brought Tavra over rather than win by rank. Tavra tested the rejected groove with a wooden foot. The model crossed the curve, reached the heel, and caught. Under strain, a frightened participant would turn inward toward the anchor instead of leaving.

"Burn them," Tavra said.

The cutter folded her arms. "Then name what we use instead."

Kel searched the supply heaps and found braided curtain cord. He laid two lengths across a felt strip, leaving a raised channel rather than cutting one. The first model foot slid. He resewed the outer cord at a shallower angle. On the third try, the heel released.

"It will rub skin," the pension cutter said.

"Line it with bath cloth," Tavra replied. "Mark each pair for inspection after

practice. We do not pretend a rushed substitute lasts beyond one use.”

The cutter watched Kel make the next wrapping, then sat beside him and improved the knot. Forty failures did not become forty identical repairs. Felt thickness varied. Ankles varied. One person’s missing toe required the curve to begin farther back. A woman with a stone-stiffened arch could not use wrapping at all, so she joined the disclosure readers.

Ossa listened as the hall changed tempo again. Scrape and cut gave way to stitch, test, reject, recut. Slower work produced fewer soles. It also produced no hidden trap in the heel.

Her left forearm trembled when she lifted the damaged batches to the furnace. She shifted them to her right hand. The inner drum skin at her side showed old command cuts in the firelight. She had once inspected cadence equipment with equal care because a clean command kept soldiers moving. Precision had never guaranteed innocence. It only made intention arrive accurately.

Near the eastern door, Ruhan arranged route groups by neighborhood rather than province. His stiff wrist prevented him from tying chalk cords, so children did it under his direction. Each group learned three paths away from the Court. Nobody could promise which would remain open after the ground moved.

“Do not call them retreat routes,” Ossa told him.

“What should I call a path people use to go away?”

“Exits.”

Ruhan considered. “Better word.”

Before dawn’s first gray, the cutting stopped for disclosure.

Ossa climbed onto the drained bath. She disliked height without a drum command to justify it. Faces filled the tiled chamber, stood on stairs, and crowded the doors. Messengers waited to carry her words to the other halls.

She struck the bare rim once.

“This sound asks for attention. It does not order silence.”

Conversation faded unevenly.

Ossa held up a wrapped foot marked with Kel’s curve. “One step. Outer heel touches first. Weight crosses only as far as you choose. Toe follows the curve. Then you withdraw through the open heel. No second step. No turn. No person here becomes a ground-dancer because the capital wants a larger body.”

A messenger repeated the instructions. Voices carried them out through the doors.

“The known risks are bruising, falls, turned ankles, cuts from moving stone, and counter-motion if your section closes badly. The unknown risk comes from scale. This practice has worked in a kiln field and at Veyr’s civic anchor. It has not been used against seven permanent holds.”

Someone called, "Will it save the center companies?"

"It may give them room to release."

"Will it stop the Dominion Measure?"

"We do not promise that."

"Then why step?"

Ossa looked at the command cuts inside her drum. "Because Serad's score gathers control into one count. The Open Measure can return part of that count to ordinary bodies who hear the cost and choose. If too few choose, we change the attempt. We do not fill the field by hiding what may happen."

A woman in a tax-office coat asked, "What happens to my district if I leave after the sections form?"

"Your section recounts. It may shrink or combine with another. You owe no replacement."

"What if my husband stays?"

"His choice does not purchase yours."

The woman left the bathhouse. Six people followed. Nobody jeered.

Others came forward to ask about the fossilized provinces, the center injuries, and the active anchors. Sole-court readers displayed copies of Nareth's root evidence. A College pension clerk named the bends in her own legs and described how permanent counter-motion deepened years after retirement. Ossa recited Pel's death and her part in the Hadrin march without turning confession into qualification.

When the questions ended, participants registered by section. The total changed with every messenger. Some names had been counted twice at different halls. Whole family groups withdrew after seeing the risk sheet. Late arrivals from Veyr replaced none of them automatically; each listened before giving a name.

No quota passed from province to province.

Ossa left the bathhouse for the avenue below the Still Court. Dawn had begun whitening the high walls. The administrative hill rose above residential roofs, its official stairs clogged with abandoned civil carts. College guards remained at the Court gates, but Miren's city guard kept side streets open for departure.

Ossa divided the avenue into listening sections.

In the army, she had built tempo from center outward. Every drummer repeated her beat. Soldiers far beyond her sight moved because the same cadence reached them through other hands.

Here she did the opposite.

She taught the northern section a four-breath interval, then handed its count to a miller from Veyr. She gave the river section no drum at all; its people chose a spoken pair of words in three local dialects. Kestan pass-runners refused a fixed

interval and agreed to begin when the shadow of the eastern wall crossed a chalk peg. Dorel cutters used the market stone's nine-day work song, slowed until it contained only one step.

A former cadence sergeant objected. "They will not land together."

"They should not."

"The anchor response will scatter."

"That is part of the release."

"You cannot coordinate a continental field with neighborhood songs."

Ossa removed a section of cord from her drum rim and gave it to him. "Then coordinate the six groups that ask you. Not the seventh. Not the street behind them. Your beat ends where consent ends."

He tied the cord around his wrist.

At every boundary, she placed a person whose task involved listening for refusal. They carried no drums. A raised palm, dropped scarf, or extinguished lamp would stop local count. One section chose two listeners because its alley curved out of sight.

Ossa tested the arrangement without warning. She sent a boy to drop a red scarf in the river section while its people practiced. The nearest speaker saw it and stopped. The next cluster continued for two breaths before noticing. Farther uphill, nobody noticed at all.

"In the army, I would strike a halt," Ossa told them. "One sound would reach every trained body. We are not rebuilding that power, so the signal must travel by people who accept the task."

They formed a relay of watchers between sections. Each watcher faced sideways, one eye on the local step and one on the neighboring exit. A deaf stonemason proposed raised lantern shutters for people who could not hear spoken counts. Two laundry workers tied white cloth to poles so a refusal remained visible above shoulders.

The second test stopped the river section cleanly. The northern millers kept moving because their own practice carried no red-scarf signal.

A civil clerk objected. "If one section halts and another continues, the field becomes uneven."

"It will already be uneven," Ossa said. "Bodies do not agree on a perfect beat. The cutters manage local torque. Eda and the trained companies manage the center. Our task here is to keep refusal from disappearing under scale."

They rehearsed a stumble next. One volunteer sat down in the path and covered her head. People flowed around her too quickly, eager to preserve tempo. Ossa made them repeat until neighbors protected the fallen body first and let their count break.

"Broken rhythm is not failure," she said. "Stepping on someone to preserve it is."

By the final practice, every section had its own stop sign and a named relief watcher. Those names remained local. Ossa did not collect them into a command list.

The arrangement looked untidy from the Court stairs. That pleased Ossa less than she expected. Part of her still wanted to hear one clean response travel through a crowd. She knew how to make it happen. Her body contained the old cadences even when she slept.

Kel found her rubbing the inner skin with her thumb.

"Does that command people?" he asked.

"It used to."

"Why keep it?"

"For evidence. For memory. For the work it may do when cut."

"Cut into what?"

"I have not reached that beat."

He looked over the avenue. Thousands practiced the same simple curve with different timings. Bare-foot wrappings flashed pale against charcoal marks. "Tavra says not knowing can be honest or lazy."

"She says many encouraging things."

"She said it while making me recut an entire pair."

"That sounds more like her."

A registrar ran up from the southern hall. "We lost four sections."

"Lost?" Ossa asked.

"They refused."

"Then say they withdrew."

"We fall below the disclosed muster."

The number mattered because each ordinary step could carry only a tiny adjustment. Too few steps would leave the center company holding most of the continental counter-motion. Too many bodies admitted without training would turn the Court approaches into a crush.

"How many heard the full risk statement and still wait?" Ossa asked.

The registrar gave a figure short of the field need.

"Recount duplicates. Do not recruit."

"We can ask the pension houses."

"They have received the same notice as everyone else."

"What if they missed it?"

“Send the written disclosure. No appeal from a uniform, no mention of duty.”

The registrar ran back.

Ossa climbed the avenue. She checked every local tempo without striking her drum. The miller rushed his fourth breath when nervous. A temple group had chosen words too long to shout under strain, so they shortened them. The Kestan shadow peg stood where an awning would cover it after sunrise; Ruhan moved it with their permission.

Near the upper gate, people began removing wrappings.

A rumor had spread that Serad meant to start before sections entered the outer salt. Some believed waiting near the Court made them trapped participants. Ossa ordered the side exits widened. She did not tell them the rumor lacked proof. Serad had already advanced one schedule.

“Anyone may go now,” she called. “The section will not close behind you.”

A broad lane opened through the crowd. Many left. Parents carried children away. Two College veterans removed their marked shoes and sat on a doorstep to help treat blisters rather than step.

Then new groups arrived from the lower city. Miren’s public evidence had reached neighborhoods after midnight. These people came without provincial cords, and some distrusted every person wearing one. Ossa made them hear the disclosure from civilian readers, not coalition officers.

Kel’s Dorel cutters arrived last from the western halls, carrying bundles of bare-foot wrappings over their shoulders. Tavra rode among them on the low cart. Her face had gone pale from the journey uphill.

“You should be inside,” Ossa said.

“So should you.”

“I can stand.”

“An enviable habit.” Tavra looked at the changing registers. “Where is the count?”

“Still moving.”

“Do not freeze it early.”

“I know.”

Tavra held Ossa’s gaze. They both heard the command hidden inside urgency.

“I am reminding myself,” Tavra said.

Kel unloaded wrappings onto the final tables. He did not step. He inspected heel marks, rejected blurred paste, and taught local cutters how to redraw the curve. His work filled gaps left by departures without making him a participant for symbolic effect.

The eastern sky brightened.

Registrars converged at the center of the avenue. They compared hall sheets, removed duplicate names, crossed out everyone who had withdrawn, and added only those who had heard the complete disclosure. Each section keeper confirmed that its waiting bodies matched the page.

The first count came short. A group from the river stair had not arrived.

Ossa sent no drummer after them.

The second count exceeded the field by nineteen because a dye hall had copied one line twice. Those names were checked in person.

At the third count, a woman raised her hand and withdrew. Two brothers followed. A Kestan runner arrived with three people who had completed instruction at the lower wall, but one chose blister work instead.

The tally moved until the people and pages agreed.

Seven thousand participants had heard the cost, practiced one step, and chosen to wait outside the Still Court. Many who had stood in the halls earlier had refused. Others had taken their places only after making a separate choice. The number described the present moment, not a debt owed at the next beat.

Ossa gave the final register to seven civilian keepers. She kept no complete copy.

Above them, the Court gates remained shut. Serad's command drums sounded inside, disciplined and perfectly aligned.

The old cadence tightened Ossa's shoulders before she recognized it. Her left hand tried to answer, though the healing forearm could not hold a full stroke. She let the reflex happen without obeying it. The two surviving straps crossed her ribs, bearing the drum like a piece of service she had not completed. At the Court, those straps could still transmit command into her stance. She touched the knife at her belt and left it sheathed for now.

The avenue did not answer as one body. A miller breathed his local interval. Kestan runners watched a moving shadow. Dorel voices hummed a market song. Between those tempos, exits stayed open.

Ossa rested her right hand on the bare rim and waited without raising it.

Chapter 24 — The Measure Begins

Serad began while the western public gate still stood closed.

Eda heard the first command stroke from the robing passage. The floor seized under her right foot. Apprentices waiting beside her pitched toward the Court, pulled by trained reflex before the herald finished announcing the opening.

“That is not dawn count,” Anet said.

“It is now,” Eda replied.

She shoved open the passage door.

Four companies already moved inside the Still Court. The three early anchors held their provinces in a pressure Eda had carried for days. A fourth rolled into engagement as its dancers turned. Beyond the galleries, crowds filled the eastern and southern approaches, but the northern sections remained outside the salt. The western gate trapped hundreds behind iron leaves.

Serad stood at his lectern. Folio Seven lay open beside the other six. He had removed Eda’s altered practice shoes and placed a fresh pair at the central mark.

“Center,” he called.

Ossa’s distributed sections had not reached their places. Tavra’s cart remained somewhere beneath the west gallery. Eda could refuse entry. She had cut that right into her own soles during the night.

If she used it now, the four active companies would keep turning until Serad chose another center. Anet stood behind Eda. Pellis’s younger sister held the southern anchor with a mineral bruise already rising above her shoe. Serad would spend them before surrendering the count, and the unfinished holds would carry torque back into provinces where people had no warning.

Eda crossed the salt.

She did not do it because he called.

At the central mark, she kicked his shoes aside and put on the pair Tavra had cut. The right sole fitted her stressed hip. The left heel contained an open release that no hidden groove crossed.

“You changed the score,” Serad said.

“I changed my shoes.”

“Same consequence.”

“No.” Eda tied the final lace. “One belongs to your Court. One belongs to my feet.”

The fifth command stroke landed.

She entered center by choice.

Before taking weight, she gave the companies three signals they had practiced without Serad. Palm down meant reduce force. Two fingers turned outward meant prepare local release. A fist against her ribs meant the foundation had closed and nobody should follow her exit blindly. Anet repeated the signals to the eastern ring. Pellis carried them south.

Serad watched the gestures. "Those are not in the folios."

"They keep dancers from guessing what happens inside center."

"The count tells them what happens."

"The count tells them what you want their feet to do."

A western cutter asked whether the new signals overruled his page. Serad said no. Eda said they carried bodily information the page could not know in advance. The cutter looked at the anchor already pulling against its cradle and chose to watch both.

That small divided loyalty mattered. A center usually received strain in silence while outer companies trusted the choreography. Eda made her pain public before it arrived. She pointed to her right hip and showed the existing stress. She touched both soles to indicate heat risk. She named the second anchor under the lectern while every nearby dancer could still leave the salt.

Two did. Serad ordered reserves forward. One reserve refused the open place. The other entered after Eda described the pressure already active in that field.

No clean rebellion formed. Bodies stayed for siblings, pensions, fear, skill, and belief in Serad. Others left for equally mixed reasons. Eda had wanted a simple line between command and choice. The Court gave her people standing with one foot on each.

Counter-motion rose through both soles. The first three anchors felt rigid, their stored pressure cold and deep. The fourth carried fresh movement from a Hadrin valley fighting the hold. Eda bent her knees and let that motion pass across her rather than locking it into the hip.

"Complete first folio," Serad ordered.

Companies turned in rings. Salt snapped under their heels. Every field pointed toward Eda, but she felt gaps where public sections had not arrived. Serad's early start made those absences dangerous. The master count reached for bodies that did not stand there and fed their share back into center.

Heat gathered under Eda's toes.

At the east gallery, Miren's withdrawal notices hung over empty civil seats. College surveyors had filled missing salt carts from private stores, but their lines ran thin. Outside, local voices tried to find their separate intervals against command drums.

Serad raised two fingers.

The fifth anchor engaged.

Its stone struck the cradle with a sound like a dropped mill wheel. Eda's right hip folded. She caught herself on the outer edge of her left foot. The correction dragged the fifth province half a pace toward stillness and pushed its answer into her arch.

The sole smoked.

She smelled leather before pain arrived. Then both feet burned from heel to toe. Tavra's scores opened release channels, but counter-motion entered faster than the cuts could pass it outward.

"Slow the fifth company," Eda shouted.

Serad's count continued.

The cadence drums around the Court answered each other. Their pressure did not move stone by itself. It moved trained bodies. Every dancer struck harder, and the combined impacts compressed the air inside the amphitheater.

Eda's left ear rang.

A command beat landed close to the center. Sound became a flat blow against that side of her head. She saw Anet call something from the eastern ring, but the words reached her only through her right ear. On the left, the drum reduced to a dull pulse without edge.

She touched no hand to it. A center who changed posture would redirect load.

"Sixth folio," Serad called.

Pellis broke formation.

He crossed one pace toward his sister, then remembered Eda's warning and stopped before entering another field. "Southern center is failing."

"There is no southern center," Serad said. "Eda carries all anchors."

"My sister is bleeding through her shoe."

"Maintain your line."

Pellis looked at Eda.

"Release her section by pairs," Eda said.

Serad struck the lectern with his palm. "Maintain."

The command drum repeated him. Pellis's body turned toward his assigned mark even as his face refused. He drove his own heel into the salt, spoiling the line under it. The broken mark gave his sister room to step out. Three dancers followed.

Their load reached Eda.

Her burned soles stuck to the leather. She screamed once, then converted the falling breath into a count the remaining dancers could use.

"Local release. East on four. South when clear. Do not cross fields."

Some obeyed her. Others followed Serad. The Court developed two counts, each

carried by trained bodies. Neither fully controlled the ground.

The sixth anchor dropped into its cradle.

Its answer entered differently from the others. Instead of weight, Eda felt absence: a spring route cut off so completely that the center pressure found no returning water. The empty channel pulled moisture from the Court salt. Black lines whitened around her feet.

A surveyor at the sixth field read the change as successful stillness. "Anchor settled," he called.

"No spring answer," Eda shouted.

Serad glanced at the field diagram. "Within projection."

"Say it aloud. The spring has stopped."

His jaw tightened. "The sixth watershed will require managed wells after consolidation."

Dancers near him heard. One missed her turn. Another completed it with tears on his face. Serad had not lied when pressed, yet the truth arrived only after the ground had already paid it.

At the western approach, a public section tried to enter around an abandoned salt cart. Its local count collided with the outer company's trained turn. Eda saw three people fall. Their section listener raised a white cloth. The nearby public voices stopped, but Serad's company continued across the blocked approach.

"Western outer ring, shorten by one pace," Eda called.

The company leader waited for Serad.

"Maintain field geometry," he said.

"A fallen body lies on your next mark."

The leader looked down, saw a woman covering her head beneath the raised cloth, and broke the circle. His dancers passed the interruption from foot to foot. Their field warped but did not collapse. Two civilians pulled the woman clear.

The leader returned to his line on a changed count. Eda felt the error arrive as a brief twist in her left knee, survivable because he had spent precision to protect a body.

"Record that correction," she told the nearest apprentice.

Serad said, "There will be no second performance."

"Then record what this one costs."

A seam opened along the eastern gallery. Masonry rose and settled. Outside, people shouted as the public approaches shifted. The northern gate finally opened, but sections could not enter in their planned order.

Eda felt Ossa before she saw her.

A broken rim beat came from the west passage, deliberately late against every

College drum. Then local spoken counts rose around it. Ossa entered beneath the gallery with her incomplete instrument at her hip. The two surviving straps crossed her chest. Each imperial stroke pulled at her shoulders through conditioned stance.

She fought the cadence step by step.

Eda gave her a sixteen-beat signal with two fingers.

Ossa nodded.

The seventh anchor began moving toward engagement.

Serad turned Folio Seven to the center sequence. "Full count."

College drummers lifted their sticks.

Ossa drew her knife.

She cut the lower strap first. The drum dropped sideways and wrenched her weak left forearm. She caught the rim against her thigh. The upper strap remained tight around her shoulder, carrying the command into her spine.

A drummer beside her shouted, "You will lose the instrument."

"I am trying to lose what it does."

She sawed through the upper strap.

The damaged drum fell onto the salt. Its inner command skin struck the ground and split along one erased order. Ossa did not pick it up. She kicked the bare rim toward a Veyr miller, who struck his own local interval and passed it down the section.

Without the command straps, Ossa's shoulders stopped answering Serad's beat. She raised empty hands and began speaking counts instead.

The seventh anchor engaged.

Every held road in Eda's perception drew tight. She could not see the provinces, but their differences entered her body: spring pressure under the left heel, root drag along the right calf, mountain weight across the hip, city paving against the spine. Serad's score tried to make all of them arrive as one fixed answer.

Her soles blistered inside the shoes. Skin separated with each shift. She smelled blood and hot felt.

Through her right ear, she heard public voices multiplying. Her left ear carried only thick impacts, as if water filled the skull.

"Now," Serad said.

The center sequence closed.

Eda took the visible release. Her heel moved outward exactly as Tavra had cut it.

The second anchor answered beneath the lectern.

Pressure snapped back through the foundation cradle and locked both of Eda's feet to the central disc. The hidden anchor did not need a groove in her shoes now.

With all seven provincial anchors engaged, Serad had bound her exit through the capital's own stone.

Eda's knees buckled. She caught herself on both hands. Salt entered her palms.

The trapped load showed her the capital foundation more clearly than rehearsal had. Residential streets branched away from the administrative hill in shallow moving shelves. Generations of small releases had let those districts adjust around wells, markets, and homes. The Still Court sat on a deeper shelf pinned by its buried anchor. Serad's new join dragged the living branches toward that central immobility.

He had called the capital one foundation. Under Eda's body, it felt like many grounds forced through one throat.

She signaled fist to ribs. Anet saw and warned the eastern company not to copy Eda's attempted exit. Pellis passed the warning south. On the left side of the Court, Eda heard none of their shouted replies. She saw mouths move and signals travel, but sound reached her as a low crush.

Panic rose when she turned her head and the world vanished on that side. She forced herself to face right, using the ear that still separated voice from drum. A center did not need perfect hearing to choose. She needed other people to stop assuming she heard them.

"My left ear is damaged," she called. "Visual signals only from west."

A western cutter raised both hands to confirm. The message moved by gesture around the ring. Nobody promised the hearing would return. Nobody told her to endure silently for the figure.

Serad left the lectern and came one pace toward her. "Do not fight the foundation. It carries the center safely through completion."

"It carries me nowhere."

"It prevents a release that would tear the road web."

"You began before the Open Measure sections were placed."

"Because Miren deprived the Court of supply and your coalition entered by force. Delay became failure."

"You made every refusal an emergency, then called emergency consent."

His face held no triumph. Sweat ran from his hairline. The active anchors loaded his injured shoulder even outside center. "I called it survival."

The mountain north of Meren entered Eda's hip.

Its mass arrived as a downward turn, slow but immense. The Dominion score ordered the range to hold above the city. The Deep Step beneath it continued moving. Opposed directions met in Eda's pelvis and spread fire through the stress line.

She looked at Folio Seven.

The page lay open under Serad's hand. Its center command matched the pressure around her feet: close heel, receive foundation, hold until continental stillness. She could not reach the folio without abandoning balance, but Tavra had copied the sequence into memory with her at the kiln. Eda knew where it entered her scored sole.

She pulled the salt knife from her belt.

Serad saw. "If you cut while loaded, the unfinished command may return through your legs."

"Then tell the drummers to stop."

"No."

The answer hurt because he gave it quietly.

Eda drove the knife into her left sole.

Hot leather resisted. She cut across the command line copied from Folio Seven, not the open release. The blade entered the blister beneath her arch. Pain erased the Court for one beat.

When sight returned, blood darkened the salt.

The severed score loosened the command around her left foot. The foundation still held through the right. Eda shifted weight onto the cut, accepting the wound because it belonged to a route she had chosen.

"East sections," she shouted. Her voice sounded crooked with half her hearing gone. "Do not take the public step. Open your exits first."

Local callers relayed the instruction. Some sections heard. Others did not. The crowd remained partly outside the salt, pressed by late-arriving groups and moving approaches.

Serad resumed the master count himself.

Ossa climbed onto a broken cradle with no drum attached to her body. She spoke a different count and pointed to the local keepers. They carried it away in fragments, not as an order to step but as room in which each section could decide.

Eda cut the right sole.

The knife found Tavra's release groove, deepened it, then turned toward the foundation pressure. She stopped before severing the last leather. If she left at that beat, the center load would transfer into Anet and the nearest company. Choice required timing, not merely a door.

"Tavra!" she called.

Her left ear gave back no answer. Through the right came distant wheels and a score-cutter's voice beneath the western gallery.

"I'm at the cradle," Tavra shouted.

Eda turned her face to bring the good ear toward the floor. "Do not release it yet. The southern company still carries the seventh return."

“How long?”

Eda counted bodies rather than beats. Pellis’s sister had cleared. Anet guided two apprentices through their heel release. The western leader pulled his company away from the fallen-body gap. Every safe departure changed what remained attached to Eda.

“Wait for my open hand,” she called.

A tool stopped striking below. Tavra had heard and obeyed, though the mountain pressure increased with every breath. That pause carried more trust than any rescue Tavra could have forced upon her.

Serad heard it too. “You are giving timing to a woman whose last unsanctioned release buried Nareth.”

“I am giving my timing to my mother.”

“She cannot carry this anchor.”

“She knows.”

Eda raised two fingers toward Anet, ordering no body, only warning that the next change approached. “That is why she asked.”

She could not see Tavra. She felt a cutting tool rest against the scored copper under Serad’s lectern.

The foundation anchor shuddered.

Dominion faltered. Three companies missed Serad’s next beat. A provincial road tore free enough to send a ripple through the Court floor. Galleries leaned outward, then returned.

Beyond the northern wall, stone cracked with a depth no drum could imitate.

Everyone looked up.

The mountain above Meren had not held. Its lower shelf began bending toward the administrative hill, carrying forest, old stairs, and a white line of winter rock down toward the city.

Serad gripped the lectern. Eda remained trapped at one foot, both soles burned, her left ear reduced to pressure.

Below them, Tavra struck the foundation cradle again.

Chapter 25 — The Mountain Takes a Knee

The grain cart lost a wheel beneath the western gallery.

Tavra fell against the sideboard. Her splinted right ankle struck stone, and pain tore through the joint before two cutters caught her shoulders. Above them, the descending mountain filled the open side of the Still Court. Its lower shelf moved through morning cloud, slow enough to watch and too fast for any city below it.

"Leave the cart," she said.

Kel crouched at the broken axle. "We can brace it."

"No time."

"You cannot crawl across that floor."

Tavra looked through the gallery arches. Eda knelt at center with one foot fixed to the foundation pull. Blood darkened the salt beneath both shoes. Serad stood beside the lectern, trying to restore the master count while companies broke into local releases.

"I can cut from the ground," Tavra said.

Kel and a Hadrún cutter crossed their arms behind her back and lifted. Her left knee carried no useful bend. The right ankle hung inside its splint. Every jolt sent a bright line up the calf. They moved her between salt jars and fallen masonry until the foundation seam reached the gallery wall.

The crack Eda had opened during rehearsal ran under the lectern. A corner of scored copper showed beneath black salt. Tavra could not reach it from the passage.

"Board," she said.

Kel brought the cutting board from her cart. They laid Tavra on it and slid her under the gallery rail. Her shoulders scraped stone. The Court floor shifted again, trying to roll them toward center.

Ruhan appeared at the lower passage and caught the board with his good hand. His stiff right wrist stayed bound against his chest. "Your route has become discourteous."

"It learned from me."

He tied a cord through the board handle and looped it around a pillar. "This holds until the pillar moves."

"Comforting."

Above them, the mountain shelf lowered another span.

Tavra dragged herself along the foundation seam. Kel followed with her knives, a salt wedge, and Eda's copied Folio page. The seam widened under the lectern into a shallow cavity. Inside lay the second anchor, a fist-sized piece of dark capital

stone clamped in copper. Seven scored channels joined it to the provincial fields. An eighth line cut downward into the deep shelf beneath the administrative hill.

Serad had made the foundation anchor perform two tasks. It prevented center release, and it held the Deep Step under the Court. Cut the wrong channel and the provincial torque would return through Eda. Break the downward line without receiving its counter-motion and the administrative hill might meet the descending mountain at full movement.

Kel handed Tavra the copied page.

She matched Eda's tiny columns to the cuts. One figure had blurred beside Nareth, but the foundation sequence remained clear. Serad had reversed Tavra's old release from the failed holding. At Nareth, she had opened a lateral path too late and displaced a hillside district. Here he had closed every lateral path in advance, forcing all release into the body at center.

The join carried his fear with impressive craftsmanship.

Tavra put two fingers on the copper. Pressure entered her lithified knee and stopped there. She changed angle. The mountain's descending weight came through the eighth line, while Eda's trapped foot pulled through the seventh provincial channel.

Two loads, one knot.

Tavra tested the knot with a pinch of step-salt. She drew a small open curve on the cavity floor and touched its end to the seventh channel. The salt blackened and blew toward Eda, confirming the center pull. When she connected the curve to the eighth line, the salt pressed flat under her thumb. The mountain load did not seek release sideways. It sought a body or the city shelf.

Kel held the copied page close to the copper. "Could the public sections take this part?"

"Not while the foundation remains closed. Their one-step marks return motion to the Deep Step. This channel blocks that return under the Court."

"Could we break the anchor stone?"

"The incomplete measure would leave every provincial line carrying torque. Roads could kick. Springs could split new courses under houses. Eda receives the first return because Serad tied her to it."

"What if we cut each province separately?"

"Possible with seven trained teams and time to read local response." Tavra glanced at the descending shelf. "We have neither."

She hated the narrowing. Serad had built it deliberately, but craft rather than fate created the trap. That meant no miracle waited outside the rules. The answer had to use the body positions, salt, scored copper, and anchor pressure already present.

Tavra widened the receiving curve on the board. A lying center would claim the

cut could pass harmlessly through old stone in her knees. An honest one had to name where the load would continue when those joints refused it.

Ossa reached the gallery without her drum. Cut straps hung from her coat. Her left arm lay tight against her ribs.

"Can you break it?" she asked.

"Yes."

"What happens?"

Tavra did not answer immediately. She traced the possible release with the point of her knife. A shallow cut could free Eda but send the foundation load into the city shelf. A deep cut could carry that load into a prepared center. No standing dancer could enter the cavity. Tavra already touched it at pelvis height from the ground.

"It needs a center here," she said.

Ossa looked at her legs. "No."

"Do not make Eda's argument badly on her behalf."

"What happens to you?"

"The counter-motion enters through the board and my hips. The old stone in my knees may keep it from reaching the chest."

"May?"

"I have not centered a foundation while lying down."

Kel's face had gone pale. "Will you walk?"

Tavra could have lied for speed. "Probably not."

"Will you live?"

"I think so."

Ossa swore.

"The other cut?" Kel asked.

"Frees Eda and lets the mountain continue into the administrative hill. It may break the deeper shelf. Residential branches could follow."

"How long can you hold the counter-motion?"

"Long enough to pause the descent. Not long enough to finish the Open Measure."

The distinction mattered. Tavra could not purchase victory with her body. She could only create time for other people to act.

Serad's voice crossed the Court. "Restore center geometry."

Eda looked toward the gallery but turned her right ear the wrong way. She could not hear Tavra from this angle.

Tavra asked Ossa to relay by hand. Open palm toward center. Point down to the

cradle. Two fingers for two loads. Ossa climbed where Eda could see and repeated the signals.

Eda answered with a fist to her ribs: foundation closed.

Tavra held up the copied page. Then she pointed at herself and the eighth channel.

Eda understood. Her face changed.

"No," she shouted.

Tavra waited. Her first impulse pressed against her teeth: tell Eda the mountain left no choice, cut before argument could become refusal, accept the injury because she had earned it. That impulse had put Eda inside plans for most of her life.

She made herself speak each cost.

"If I take the foundation counter-motion, your foot releases when you cut the last leather. The load enters my pelvis and spine. I expect permanent injury. The mountain pauses. The Deep Step stays trapped until the public sections release it."

Eda listened with her right ear turned toward the floor.

"If I do not," Tavra continued, "you remain attached or I cut you free into an uncontrolled foundation release. The shelf may strike the administrative hill and pull residential ground. Those are the choices I can see. There may be another."

Serad had heard. "There is. Restore the center sequence. Complete the hold."

Eda looked at Folio Seven beneath his hand.

Tavra did not answer him. "Eda, do you want me to take the anchor?"

The mountain groaned over the Court. Stone dust fell like dry rain. Kel crouched beside Tavra with tears running openly. Ossa kept both hands raised so local counts would not mistake her movement for command.

Eda bent over her trapped right foot. "Not yet."

Tavra lowered the knife.

The copper vibrated under her hand. Every instinct demanded that she call delay foolish. She could feel the eighth channel deepening toward rupture. A roof at the northern edge of the administrative hill folded under falling stones. People ran from it while the residential shelf tilted away.

Kel leaned close. "How long can we wait?"

"Until the channel splits without the knife, or Eda gives the time."

"Which comes first?"

"I do not know."

He looked frightened by the answer and stayed beside her. Ossa relayed Eda's release signals across the gallery. Tavra counted the companies leaving center, not to overrule her daughter but to understand what Eda protected with each

breath.

At the kiln, Tavra had promised to wait. The promise had sounded difficult in conversation. Here it required holding a blade still while a mountain moved. She understood at last that consent did not become optional when urgency made obedience more convenient.

Serad stepped from the lectern. The floor tilted. He struck his shoulder against the stone edge and fell to one knee. Folio Seven slid across the salt toward Eda.

She caught it.

With her knife, she cut the stitched center pages free from the binding. Serad reached for them but his bruised shoulder failed under weight. Eda tore the hidden sequence once across, then again through the foundation command. She pushed the pieces into the wet blood beneath her left shoe and ground them into the scored sole.

The other folios remained open on the lectern and floor.

"Now the page cannot tell another center where to close," she said.

The foundation pull tightened around her right foot.

Tavra kept the blade away from copper. "Your timing."

Eda signaled Anet. The eastern company released by pairs. Pellis carried the signal south. Ossa turned toward the public approaches and held up the white cloth that meant wait. The mountain continued descending.

"Not yet," Eda called again.

Tavra's old instinct screamed at every lost breath. She watched the eighth line instead. Its cut deepened as the descending shelf pressed harder. She placed the cutting board across her hips, braced its ends under two copper lips, and scored a receiving curve into the wood. Kel packed step-salt into the groove.

"This will split," he said.

"Yes."

He added a second board beneath it.

One by one, attached companies left the central pull. Eda counted them with her right hand. Her left foot had come free, but the right remained bound. When the final southern pair crossed its release, she opened her hand toward Tavra.

Eda chooses, Tavra thought, not as a slogan but as the fact governing her knife.

Tavra drove the blade through the seventh channel and into the eighth.

Copper snapped.

Eda tore her right foot free.

The foundation counter-motion entered Tavra through the boards.

Her pelvis lifted from stone. For an instant she felt every old injury separately: the locked left knee, the fractured right ankle, the pale lines in both joints. Then

the mountain's weight joined them. Pressure drove through both hips and climbed the spine in hard increments.

The first board split.

Tavra tried to release through her heels, forgetting she could not reach the ground with either foot. The counter-motion had nowhere else to go. It crossed the pelvis, compressed the lower spine, and turned sensation below her waist into white absence.

She did not feel the second board break.

Kel caught her head before it struck stone. Ossa shouted her name. Tavra could hear them, but her body ended at the ribs in a way no pain had prepared her to understand.

Above, Eda rolled out of center on both burned feet and collapsed beside the torn folio pages. Serad remained alive against the lectern, one shoulder hanging low.

The mountain slowed.

Its lower shelf stopped short of the administrative roofs. Forest trees leaned over the northern gallery. Broken stairs descended through open air and ended above the Court. The great mass had not returned to its old position. It had bent, paused, and placed its weight like a knee beside Meren.

People in the residential districts ran through streets that still lay on their own shallow shelves.

Tavra tried to move her left leg. Nothing answered. She tried the right. The same absence remained.

"Do not tell me it will return," she said before Kel could speak.

He swallowed and nodded.

Under the Still Court, the deeper shelf still strained against the trapped Deep Step. Serad's master count had broken, but the seven holds had not released. Outside, Ossa's public sections waited for a choice that could not come from Tavra alone.

Eda crawled toward the edge of center and reached one burned hand down through the cracked floor.

Tavra could not lift her body to meet it. She raised her own hand instead.

Chapter 26 — A Country of Dancing Stone

The second board had broken across Tavra's hips, but its scored half remained under her hand.

She gripped the splintered edge and pulled. Nothing below her ribs helped. Kel braced one foot against the cavity wall and dragged the wood free. The salt groove Tavra had cut to receive the mountain load remained visible, blackened at the center and open at both ends.

Above them, Serad found his feet.

His bruised shoulder hung low, yet his voice crossed the Still Court with the old precision. "Outer companies, return to marks. Drummers, master interval. Surveyors, close the foundation seam."

One College drum answered. Then another.

Ossa stood on the western cradle with no instrument attached to her body. She called to the public sections, but the Court broke her words into echoes. The seven provincial anchors remained engaged. Every unfinished line fed torque through the ground, searching for the center sequence Eda had destroyed.

Eda still lay within the central field. She had freed both feet from the foundation pull, not from the measure itself. Her burned soles bled through split leather. She turned her right ear toward each speaker because the left gave her only pressure.

The mountain shelf shifted overhead.

Its pause had bought minutes, not safety. Counter-motion still held in Tavra's pelvis and lower spine. She could no longer receive more. If the eighth channel rejoined under Serad's count, the load would return through Eda or break the administrative shelf down into the residential branches.

"Salt," Tavra said.

Kel emptied the last jar beside her. "Where?"

"Everywhere the seam can breathe."

"That is not a cutting instruction."

"It is the beginning of one."

Tavra laid the broken board along the foundation crack. The receiving curve crossed copper, stone, and old Court mortar. It had been designed for one body. She turned it outward. From the cavity, she could score an open line under the west gallery and into the public approach.

Her first cut reached only an arm's length.

Kel crawled ahead and copied the curve into the salt. A Hadrin cutter took it from him, preserving the open heel shape without deepening it into a command. The line passed beyond Tavra's sight.

"Do not close the ring," she called.

The cutter answered, "No ring."

Serad heard. "You will release seven provincial holds into an unprepared crowd."

"The crowd prepared while you started early."

"They prepared one step. They cannot receive a foundation."

"They will not. We are opening the foundation to the Deep Step."

"The Court shelf will move."

"Yes."

"It carries hospitals, granaries, homes."

"Not all of it." Tavra pressed her palm to the eighth channel. The movement she had felt before remained legible despite the injury. Residential ground branched from the deep shelf in seven shallow joins. Generations of market releases and wall adjustments had kept those branches flexible. The administrative hill alone had been pinned to the Court's foundation.

Serad had called the whole capital one body because one authority governed it. The ground carried a different arrangement.

"Ruhan," Tavra called.

He slid under the gallery rail with his atlas strapped to his back. Dust coated his hair. "I was beginning to suspect you had invented a route without me."

"Read the city joins."

"My wrist reads poorly."

"Use your knees."

He knelt along the seam and leaned into the changing floor. Tavra described the seven shallow branches. Ruhan marked them on a blank atlas page, then sent pass-runners to the gallery exits.

"Residential shelves still follow market lanes," he said when reports returned. "North branch flexes at the dye quarter. South branch follows the river stair. The administrative road crosses all of them at held joints."

"Can people leave the hill?"

"Three routes now. Perhaps two when the mountain moves again."

"Open them. No promise they stay."

Ruhan sent one runner toward the laundry lane, another to the river stair, and took the archive passage himself. He returned carrying a jail key ring and followed by six clerks who had discovered prisoners still locked beneath the tax court. Miren's withdrawal had emptied guard posts before anyone opened the cells.

"Custody records say nine," one clerk said.

"Then find nine bodies," Tavra replied.

The route runners reached the lower cells while cutters broke the held joint beside the stair. Seven prisoners climbed out. An eighth had been moved to a College room. The ninth name belonged to a woman released months earlier whose discharge had never entered the civil book.

"Do not leave the empty number unmarked," Tavra said. "A false prisoner can hide a real one later."

The clerk crossed the ninth line once, dated the correction, and kept the old entry readable. Ruhan directed the group down the laundry lane. Nobody required them to carry archive boxes as the price of rescue.

A pension dormitory stood closer to the Court. Several retired centers could not descend the moving stairs. Apprentices used salt boards as sleds, lowering each person along the open curve Tavra had started. The work slowed evacuation, but no one called their bodies an acceptable remainder.

Ruhan left with the pass-runners. He did not wait for Serad's permission to redraw the capital.

Tavra cut the board again. Her hand shook. She had always used the hips to steady a long incision. Without them, the knife wandered. Kel put his fingers beside hers, not over them.

"Tell me the pressure," he said.

"Light through the first curve. Deeper at the salt break. Stop before copper."

Together they extended the line.

At center, Eda pushed herself upright on one knee. She could not stand on the burned soles. Anet and Pellis moved toward her, but she waved them to the outer companies where releases remained incomplete.

Serad gathered the loose folios.

The torn remains of Folio Seven clung to Eda's bloody left shoe. Its hidden center pages could no longer be read, but the cover and public sequence remained attached to the other volumes by red binding cords.

Serad reached for them.

Eda planted her salt knife through the cords.

The binding snapped. Folio Seven separated from the Master Score. She tore its cover away from the surviving public pages and threw those pages toward the civil gallery, where Miren's clerks gathered them as evidence. The empty binding went into the open foundation crack.

"You preserve your accusations and destroy the craft that could finish safely," Serad said.

"I preserve what people must judge," Eda replied. "I destroy the part that claims one author must close every exit."

He stepped toward the crack. Eda held the knife between them.

Serad stopped. His shoulder prevented a fight, but his gaze went past her to the seventh cradle. "The mountain will resume. Your mother cannot receive it twice."

"She will not."

"Then someone centers."

Eda looked around the Court. Released apprentices tended dancers beside broken salt fields. Public sections waited outside, each with its own count. Ossa stood empty-handed. Tavra lay beneath the gallery, unable to move either leg.

"No one body centers this," Eda said.

Serad laughed without humor. "A sentence does not alter counter-motion."

"No. Feet do."

She turned her back on him and crawled toward the foundation seam.

Tavra saw the pain in every movement. "Stay at center."

"I left your part to you. Leave mine to me."

"You cannot stand."

"Neither can you."

Eda reached the dark line. She used both hands to cut a branching release through the central salt, joining Tavra's ground-level curve to the seven provincial fields. The cut did not invent a new score. It combined the Nareth release, Kel's open heel, and the gaps each local section had practiced.

Every branch ended before the public approach. No command line crossed into a participant's sole.

Ossa descended from the cradle. "They cannot hear Eda from the outer streets."

"You have a drum," Serad said.

Ossa looked at the split inner skin on the salt. "I had a command."

"You know how to carry a count across distance."

"I know how to give one away."

She retrieved the bare rim from the Veyr miller, struck one call for attention, then passed it back. The miller sounded his local interval. A Kestan runner raised a shadow cloth. Dorel cutters began their slow market song. Ossa moved between them speaking the same disclosure each time.

"The Court line is open. The mountain load remains. One step may return movement to the Deep Step. You may still leave. Your section stops for a refusal or a fallen body. Do not take a second step."

Her voice reached only the nearest groups. Section keepers repeated it in their own words. Some asked questions again. Nobody shortened the answers because the shelf moved overhead.

Serad climbed the lectern with one usable arm. "If the crowd steps out of sequence, provincial roads shear."

Tavra pressed her fingers into the seven channels. "They already carry local torque. Your sequence forces it into one answer. The open lines let each field return what it can."

"And what it cannot?"

"Stays for trained cutters to release."

"Years of unstable roads."

"Years of work."

"Famine does not wait for craft debate."

"Then grain routes receive terms first. Not permanent chains."

The argument contained no proof. The proof waited in bare feet outside.

Ruhan returned from the lower hill. "Administrative residents are leaving by the laundry lane and river stair. Still Court staff remain at east gate. The northern route is closing under the mountain shelf."

"How many homes stay on the deep shelf?" Tavra asked.

"Twenty-three along the judges' court. People are clearing them now. Hospitals lie on the south residential branch. Granaries split, two civil below and one College store above."

"Keep the south join open."

"We need cutters at three held crossings."

Kel sent the Hadrún workers. Ruhan drew temporary paths in chalk, dating each for the next hour only.

Miren appeared on the civil gallery with her clerks. "The administrative archive?"

"Moves with the hill unless you carry it out," Ruhan said.

"Records of tax, custody, and land seizure fill twelve rooms."

"Choose what people need for judgment. The hill will not wait for filing order."

Miren sent clerks for prisoner rolls and property seizures first. Route maps stayed. She had spent a career treating them as the capital's memory. Now she chose records of whom the maps had harmed.

The mountain shelf dropped another handspan.

The foundation crack widened. Tavra felt its movement only through her ribs and palms. Her legs lay at an angle that should have hurt. Their silence frightened her more than pain.

Kel saw her looking. "Your right foot is turned under."

"Straighten it so it does not break farther."

He used both hands. Tavra watched the splint rotate. Nothing reached her.

"After," he said, "we find a board with wheels."

"After, you finish this cut."

"I can do both."

The answer carried no promise of cure. She let it stand.

Ossa's spoken disclosure reached the far sections. White cloths rose and fell as local listeners checked exits. One group near the river stair withdrew because their approach had narrowed. Ruhan redirected them away from the field. Other trained people who had completed disclosure waited outside the salt, but Ossa did not call replacements by duty. The registrars recounted live participants.

The final number returned unchanged. Those who had withdrawn from one section joined no other. People shifted positions only within the waiting muster, opening wider gaps while keeping the disclosed count.

Seven thousand remained ready to take one step.

Tavra looked at Eda. "Can the provincial channels open together without closing into center?"

Eda turned her right ear toward the question. "Not together. Close enough that no one field takes the others' return."

"Ossa?"

"I can start windows," Ossa said. "Local keepers choose inside them."

Serad shook his head. "A window broad enough for choice permits destructive phase."

"No College terms," Tavra said.

He corrected himself with visible effort. "The roads may pull against one another."

"They may."

"You accept that?"

"I disclose it."

Serad looked toward the city below. People still crossed from the administrative hill. He could see Oris in every moving roof, Tavra knew. A winter town under a cliff. Six hundred bodies. A stair that remained while his family did not.

"You think motion becomes moral because many choose it," he said.

"No. It becomes answerable to more than you."

"If the north road tears and grain fails, who carries blame?"

"Everyone who chose the terms carries part. Cutters carry their work. Councils carry allocation. I carry what I taught. You carry what you hid."

"That is no responsibility. It disperses until nobody can be judged."

"Then keep records. Hold inquiry. Do not hold land."

The Court floor lurched. Serad caught the lectern with his good hand.

The old master interval sounded from two College drums. He had signaled them

while arguing. Trained companies stiffened. Eda's shoulders turned toward center by reflex. Ossa's empty chest answered the cadence even without straps.

Serad raised his hand for the full count.

Tavra could end him.

The foundation crack ran under the lectern stair. One deep cut through the supporting salt would drop that stair into the moving cavity. His shoulder could not catch him. The falling stone would break the master count before it began.

She set her knife against the line.

Serad saw. Neither of them looked away.

At Nareth, Tavra had obeyed him and buried a district. In Dorel, she had hidden from every consequence except the stone in her knees. Killing him now could feel like judgment while removing his testimony, his records, and his chance to answer before people he had used.

She turned the knife sideways and cut around the stair.

The salt released on both sides. The stair rose intact on a small island of Court stone. Serad lost his stance and sat hard on the upper step, but the ground beneath him held.

"You do not get a clean death in my score," Tavra said.

He looked down at the preserved stair. Understanding reached him with horror and anger. "You would leave me to watch roads fail."

"I leave you alive to hear what they call failure."

The College drummers waited for his hand.

Eda pulled the remaining command cords out of the salt and cut them into short lengths. Anet took one piece, Pellis another, and each company leader carried a fragment away from center. No drum received the full written interval.

Ossa climbed the west cradle again.

"Attention only," she called.

The bare rim sounded once in Veyr hands.

Across the public field, local keepers raised their signs. The north millers began a breath count. River sections spoke paired words. Kestan runners watched the moving shadow. Dorel voices held their market song at the note before weight.

Ossa did not complete any of them.

"First window open," she said.

The north sections chose.

Bare heels touched scored wrappings. Not one mass impact, but thousands of small contacts moved down the avenue. Some landed early. Others waited for a neighbor to regain balance. A white cloth rose near the eastern wall, and that local count stopped until a participant stepped out of the path.

The first public pressure reached Tavra's salt line.

It came softly enough to mistake for settling dust. Then the foundation channel warmed under her palm. Movement that Serad had forced toward center found the open branch and passed beneath the west gallery.

"Second window," Ossa called.

River voices chose their words. Feet crossed one simple curve and withdrew. The south residential join shifted. Ruhan shouted that the hospital road remained connected.

Eda opened the sixth provincial branch with her knife. Spring pressure rushed into wet salt. Somewhere beyond the capital, a stopped watershed moved. Water did not appear by magic in the Court. Only the empty drag under Eda's sole eased.

The third window opened.

Kestan sections followed shadow rather than voice. Their steps landed across a long interval. The anchor orchards' provincial channel released without fixing where those orchards should go next.

Serad called, "Stop. The western road is pulling north."

Tavra felt it. One channel scraped another, building torque at the Court's southern edge.

"Hold third branch where it is," she told Eda. "Ruhan, route check."

Ruhan's messengers ran. A grain road outside the city had shifted toward old pasture, but no buildings stood on the seam. Its carts would need a new crossing.

"Disclose the change," Tavra said.

Ossa passed the report to section keepers. People heard that a road had already moved and could still leave before their own step. The public count paused without collapsing.

A woman in the Dorel section removed her wrapping. Her neighbors opened an exit. She walked out of the salt. A trained cutter who had already registered and practiced stood waiting, not summoned by rank. The registrar confirmed her disclosure. She entered the open place by her own request.

The live count returned to seven thousand.

"Fourth window," Ossa said.

Dorel's market song crossed the held note. Their simple steps carried the rhythm of rebuilding stalls around a stone that moved every nine days. The foundation line widened.

Tavra's board shifted under her shoulders. Kel and the Hadrin cutter held it. She could feel the Deep Step now, not as a voice or intention, only the vast slow movement the Court had suppressed. It pressed upward along every open salt branch.

Serad felt it too. "The foundation is leaving its seat."

"Yes," Eda said.

"You cannot control where it goes."

"No."

Fear crossed her face. She did not hide it from the companies.

The fifth window opened.

More sections took their one step. Open heel, chosen weight, withdrawal. Thousands of tiny adjustments distributed what no center could survive. Some participants fell and received hands from neighbors. Local counts broke and resumed. Nobody took a second step to correct the first.

The administrative hill moved west.

At first the change measured less than a paving seam. Then the Still Court galleries leaned away from the civil market below. Held joints along the residential branches cracked in sequence.

"Hospitals?" Tavra called.

"South branch flexing," Ruhan answered. "Still joined."

"Dye quarter?"

"North branch opened at the market lane. Residential shelf stays with lower city."

"Judges' homes?"

"Cleared. They move with us."

Us. Ruhan stood on the administrative shelf now. Everyone inside the Still Court did.

The sixth window reached the outer avenues.

Ossa's voice had gone hoarse. She gave the opening to local keepers and stopped speaking. The count traveled without her. Every section chose its own moment inside the broad interval.

The ground answered in overlapping turns.

The mountain lifted slightly from its kneeling pause. Not upward to its former place, only away from the administrative roofs as the deep shelf slid out from under its line of descent. Forest soil spilled across the northern gallery. An old stair touched Court stone and broke free again.

Eda opened the seventh provincial channel.

Counter-motion left her burned soles in a rush. She collapsed onto her hands. Anet caught her shoulder without pulling her back to center.

The last public window remained.

Serad sat on the isolated stair. He could still signal the College drums. Instead he watched the widening gap between administrative hill and residential city. Miren's clerks carried prisoner rolls over the final temporary bridge. Civil residents

ran behind them.

“Bridge clear,” Ruhan called.

Miren crossed last. She left the imperial route maps in the archive.

Ossa looked toward every section keeper she could see. None looked back to her for a command. Signs rose locally.

The final participants stepped.

Seven thousand people had each taken one disclosed step. No person took the next one for them.

The Deep Step returned beneath the Still Court.

The foundation anchor rolled out of its copper cradle. The remaining master cords slipped into the crack. Tavra’s open salt line broke into separate curves as the shelf moved, preventing any single cut from becoming a permanent new score.

The administrative hill traveled west on its own deep shelf. Court, College offices, route archive, tax chambers, and the upper granary moved with it. Residential districts remained on connected branches around markets, wells, hospitals, and homes. The gap widened to a stone channel crossed by no held road.

The mountain settled beside the departing shelf. Its lower forest stood at a new angle. No building lay beneath it.

Provincial pressure released from the seven cradles. Some roads turned. Some hills lowered. Springs began seeking paths no Court map named. The ground did not become safe. It became moving country again.

The Still Court stopped a mile west of Meren’s residential edge.

No scored road connected it to the city.

Silence followed, uneven and human. People cried, argued, called names, and asked which routes remained. College dancers sat where their fields had broken. Public participants removed wrappings and examined bruised feet. Cutters marked every injury they could find.

The first lists stayed separate. Court apprentices recorded company wounds by field. Civil readers took names from public sections without converting them into military rolls. Sole courts collected failed wrappings beside successful ones. A physician marked Eda’s hearing loss without guessing whether it would improve. Another examined Tavra and wrote absent movement below the pelvis, lower-spine counter-motion, immediate accommodation required.

“No heroic language,” Tavra told the clerk.

The clerk scratched out sacrifice and wrote injury.

Near the seventh cradle, people found the split command skin face down in blood and salt. Ossa asked witnesses to lift it together so no one could claim she had altered the cuts after the fact. The erased orders remained visible along the

tear.

Kel leaned over Tavra. "Can you breathe?"

"Yes."

"Can you feel this?" He touched her left thigh.

"No."

He moved lower. "This?"

"No."

Eda crawled to them. Blood had dried at both soles. She positioned herself on Tavra's right so her good ear faced the conversation.

"You waited," she said.

"Yes."

"You asked."

"Yes."

Neither word repaired what preceded it. Tavra would not use the climax to demand forgiveness.

"Your feet?" she asked.

"Burned. Left hearing damaged. Hip still mine, though it objects."

"My legs are not answering."

"I know."

Serad descended his preserved stair. His shoulder had swollen under the coat. Two former apprentices moved between him and the remaining folios.

"I will not run," he said.

"There is nowhere scored to run," Ruhan replied.

Miren posted civil witnesses beside the folios. The surviving pages, the split command skin, Eda's bloody shoes, Tavra's copied page, and the broken foundation cradle remained where everyone could see them. No one burned the archive.

Ossa collected the cut command straps and placed them with the evidence. She kept the bare rim only after the Veyr miller handed it back.

Outside the separated hill, citizens began calling temporary crossings across the new gap. Ruhan refused to draw one until both sides named a term.

Tavra lay on her broken cutting board while the stone beneath the Court moved in a slow westward drift. She could not feel that motion through her legs. Her ribs felt it. Her palms felt it. Around her, people measured injuries and routes instead of victory.

Eda sat beside her, turned one listening ear toward the open ground, and began helping Kel record the feet that had paid.

Chapter 27 — The Roads After Empire

The first medicine cart reached the new gap and found no bridge.

Ruhan stood on Meren's residential side with his incomplete atlas open under one elbow. Across the stone channel, the separated administrative hill drifted west by a few yards each day. The Still Court rose on its edge, galleries broken but occupied. Former College dancers, civil clerks, prisoners who had chosen to remain for testimony, and several hundred residents waited there with one upper granary and no hospital.

The cart driver pointed at the gap. "My order says Court infirmary."

"Your order names a road that moved."

"The medicines spoil by tomorrow."

"Then we need terms today."

A College quartermaster waited opposite with a white cloth. Ruhan called the cart inventory across the channel. Fever bark. Burn salve. Clean wrapping. Two boxes of mineral poultice for lithified joints. The quartermaster offered archive paper and upper-granary flour in exchange.

A month earlier, a road office would have named the crossing, toll, schedule, and armed escort. Now six groups claimed standing: medicine workers, lower-city millers, hill residents, former College staff, injured public participants, and the neighborhood whose courtyard would hold the temporary approach.

They argued for three hours.

The courtyard tenants refused overnight traffic. The driver refused to unload without shelter. Hill residents wanted flour excluded from exchange because they considered the upper grain public property. Lower millers would not accept archive paper until civil witnesses confirmed it carried no custody records.

Ruhan wrote every refusal beside the proposed line.

His right wrist no longer needed a splint, but it remained too stiff for long writing. A Dorel clerk took dictation when the hand failed. Ruhan did not let her clean the page. Crossed terms showed what people had rejected.

At noon, both sides agreed to a rope-guided stone walkway for six hours. Two local cutters prepared step-salt around loose slabs. No center held them. Workers shifted stones by hand when possible and used one shallow ground-dance turn where the gap narrowed. A retired College center received that small counter-motion with full disclosure and released before pain deepened.

The medicine cart stayed behind. Packages crossed on backs.

When the final burn salve reached the hill, both sides erased the salt approach. The deep shelf continued west. No official pretended the six-hour crossing had become a road by habit.

The crossing closed before two hill children returned from visiting relatives below. Their mother demanded an extension. Courtyard tenants refused because night traffic would pass beside sleeping rooms. The argument nearly reopened the salt by force until a Kestan runner found a lower shelf moving parallel to the hill for part of the night.

It could carry people, not carts. The mother crossed with a lantern and met the children at its eastern end. Ruhan walked the shelf first, marked two crumbling edges, and erased his chalk after all three returned. By morning that route had moved beneath a retaining wall.

The incident entered the emergency record. So did the mother's anger, the tenants' refusal, and the fact that temporary terms separated a family for four hours. Revocable roads did not eliminate harm. They made the decisions and repairs visible enough to contest.

On the hill, medicines went first to burned center-dancers and public participants with infected cuts. Serad received a shoulder wrap after people in immediate danger, not as punishment and not as privilege. Tavra's mineral poultice remained below because it could not repair spinal counter-motion. Her care team requested pressure cushions, clean cloth, and a board narrow enough for residential doors instead.

Ruhan dated the crossing in the atlas and drew the line faintly.

Other emergencies allowed less argument. A Hadrin grain road turned into pasture and stranded three valley towns. Kesta's anchor orchards moved north, opening one pass and closing two. Dorel's market circuit shortened by half a day. Springs returned unevenly in the sixth watershed, flooding an abandoned imperial tollhouse while leaving two wells dry.

Route teams traveled without master maps. They carried dated pages, local anchor stones, simple release soles, and lists of who needed food first. Each crossing required someone to say what movement might cost.

Mistakes remained costly.

At a southern ridge, cutters opened a medicine path and blocked shepherds from winter grazing. The first agreement had excluded them because nobody at the table knew the flock had shifted. Shepherds dismantled the salt markers. The town called it sabotage. Ruhan called another meeting and made both words enter the record.

At the river stair, a temporary grain turn collapsed two market awnings. No one died, but three sellers lost a week's goods. The route accord had named bodily injury and ignored stall loss. Compensation took longer than rebuilding the approach.

People missed the old roads most when hungry.

They also remembered who had paid to keep those roads still.

The public inquiry began on the twelfth day after the separation.

No hall could hold everyone, and the Still Court lacked a fixed crossing. Testimony took place on both sides of the gap. Witnesses spoke from Meren's lower gallery. Serad and College leaders sat on their preserved stair across the channel. Civil scribes made duplicate records and exchanged them at each day's temporary walkway.

Ruhan attended because his atlas contained the moving wall route, provincial refusals, and the evacuation terms. He preferred passes to courts. A pass admitted when weather overruled intention. Courts often treated procedure as proof that intention had prevailed.

Miren opened by naming her own signatures.

"I authorized supply, compulsory attendance, and seizure of civic anchors," she said. "The folio presented to me concealed permanent ecological projections. I withdrew civil authority after learning that fact. Withdrawal did not erase the earlier orders or the harm they enabled."

Serad listened with his bruised shoulder bound to his chest.

When his turn came, he did not claim possession or madness. He described Oris. He described grain routes that had prevented famine, walls held long enough for children to leave moving houses, and provinces whose officials threatened war whenever a pass changed jurisdiction.

"I believed a permanent arrangement would prevent deaths that local negotiation repeatedly failed to prevent," he said. "I withheld projections from civil review because I believed fear of finite loss would block continental safety."

A Nareth survivor stood on the lower side. "You called our district finite?"

"Yes." Serad's voice broke, then steadied. "That word permitted me to continue."

"Do you still believe the Measure should have finished?"

He looked beyond the inquiry to the roads shifting around Meren. "I believe people will die because it did not."

Murmurs rose.

The presiding witnesses waited rather than striking for silence.

Serad continued. "I also know the center pages concealed deaths and land loss from people whose consent I considered an obstacle. Both statements remain true."

His coherence angered some listeners more than a plea would have. It also left his choices available for judgment. No pardon entered the proceeding. No execution shortened it. He and the College command circle remained under witnessed custody on the separated hill while charges were drafted for coerced service, concealed casualty projections, unlawful anchor seizure, and deaths from the early holds.

The inquiry questioned the cutters who altered Eda's practice shoes. One had followed Serad's direct sketch. Another had recognized that the crosscut trapped release and said nothing because emergency corrections fell outside ordinary review. Both insisted the foundation line protected provinces from unfinished torque.

Anet asked them why nobody told the person wearing the shoes.

The senior cutter answered, "A center who anticipates restraint may resist it at the wrong beat."

"So you needed her ignorance to keep her safe?"

"We needed completion."

The distinction entered the record.

Road-company pension officials testified next. They had tied food and housing to continued center service long after injured dancers requested release. The officials produced budgets showing that without imperial route tolls the pension system would have failed. Retired centers answered that a system funded by further injuries had already failed them.

Miren's former deputies tried to divide civil and College guilt at the charter boundary. Witnesses traced salt seizures signed by civil offices and command orders issued by the College. Some acts carried both seals. The public inquiry kept both names rather than allowing one institution to become the other's excuse.

Ossa testified beside the split command skin.

She named every conditioned cadence cut she recognized. Her left forearm tired before noon, so another witness held the skin while she pointed. She did not let the inquiry use her desertion as proof that Hadrin belonged to one guilty officer.

"The order traveled through my hands," she said. "The institution trained those hands, rewarded accuracy, and wrote Pel and the civilians as route loss. Judge my action. Also judge the structure that made one drummer convenient to blame."

Eda presented the surviving Folio Seven pages.

She wore soft open sandals over bandaged soles. She turned her right ear toward questions and asked speakers on her left to repeat themselves. The first clerk described that as temporary impairment. Eda stopped testimony until he removed temporary.

"You do not know that," she said.

He wrote partial left-ear hearing loss, duration unknown.

She explained the hidden foundation anchor, Serad's altered shoes, her chosen entry, and the destroyed center sequence. Serad challenged one technical detail about the sixth channel. Eda checked the page, corrected herself publicly, and continued.

Tavra testified from a low wheeled board built by Kel and two cartwrights.

The board had a back brace, leather hand loops, and wide wheels for rough ground. Two people helped transfer her from bed each morning. She could sit upright for an hour before the pelvis injury forced rest. Her legs carried no reliable sensation and no useful movement.

Ruhan watched the Court turn toward her as though injury made every answer sacred. Tavra noticed too.

"Do not use my body to settle the argument," she said. "I took a disclosed load after Eda chose the timing. That does not make every decision before it correct."

She named Nareth without asking acquittal. She described leaving Eda, hiding the score fragment, and repeatedly planning to substitute herself for her daughter. Then she explained why a stable road could save lives and still become a chain.

Serad asked her one question. "If the winter grain road fails, will you take responsibility?"

"For the cuts I teach and the costs I conceal, yes. I will not claim responsibility as a reason to own every foot."

The inquiry continued past the first month. Its purpose involved public judgment, not swift absolution. Provincial witnesses would take seasons to arrive. Evidence stayed under mixed custody: sole courts, civil clerks, injured dancers, and route communities each held witnessed copies. The originals remained in a dry chamber on the separated hill, reachable only by temporary crossing.

After Tavra's testimony, Ruhan helped Kel push the wheeled board to a rented room near the lower market. Eda followed with one hand on the wall when her burned feet tired. Inside, she and Kel transferred Tavra to a padded bench. Tavra directed every grip because sudden twisting drove pain above the place where sensation ended.

"You can leave," Tavra told Eda after Kel went for water.

"I know."

"I mean the room, not the city."

"I know that too." Eda adjusted her chair so Tavra sat on her right. "You keep offering exits after I have chosen to stay."

"I am practicing."

"It can become another way of asking me to reassure you."

Tavra looked toward the shuttered market. "Yes."

Eda unwrapped one foot. New skin had begun forming around the burns, tender and uneven. The knife wound in her left arch remained open at one edge. "I did not forgive you at the Court."

"I did not think you had."

"I loved you there."

Tavra's hands tightened on the board loops.

"Those are not the same thing," Eda said.

"No."

They sat without converting the distinction into comfort. When Kel returned, Eda helped rewrap her own sole and asked Tavra whether the pressure cushion needed turning. Tavra said yes. Eda asked where to place her hands before moving it.

Between inquiry days, Ruhan traveled.

His incomplete atlas became thicker and less complete. Every province added pages. Kesta contributed orchard routes with no final borders. Hadrun drew seasonal releases and marked where imperial pension houses stood. Veyr recorded its dye-yard crossing with the landlord's one-day terms attached. Dorel sent a market circuit that changed before the ink dried.

Several delegates proposed a central route council.

Ruhan listened until they began assigning permanent seats.

"Who removes a council that controls every grain crossing?" he asked.

"Member provinces," said a northern delegate.

"How?"

"By vote."

"What happens to a walking country with no fixed provincial count?"

The answer took too long.

They abandoned permanent authority and drafted route accords instead. Each accord named a purpose, start, end, affected communities, known bodily and material risks, compensation, exit routes, and a date for reconsideration. Any party could call a halt, though emergency food agreements required a short wind-down to prevent carts being stranded midpass.

The first drafts failed.

Millers wanted long terms so grain prices could settle. Cutters wanted short terms because ground response changed. City councils tried to sign for outlying farms. Kestan runners refused signatures tied to borders. Retired centers demanded injury support before anyone authorized a held crossing.

Ruhan kept the failures in the atlas.

By the fourth week, three valleys agreed on a grain approach lasting nine days. The term matched Dorel's market circuit, short enough for the road to be read again and long enough for carts to complete a round trip. Hadrun cutters would inspect daily. Two local centers volunteered for shallow corrections with a six-beat release. No body could serve center on consecutive days. Pension support came from a toll disclosed at both ends.

The road itself had shifted into an old quarry.

On opening morning, Ruhan stood beside the first cart. The quarry town wanted the line moved ten feet to spare a memorial wall. The valley millers objected that

the turn would tip loaded axles. Cutters tested both approaches. A third line around the wall added half a mile but kept the grade.

They amended the accord before laying salt.

Every signatory then read the changed terms aloud. A quarry tenant found that compensation still named only cart damage. She added injury to walls, wells, and work yards. A retired center added a clause requiring public record of pain that appeared after the crossing term expired. The millers objected to indefinite claims, so the parties set three later examination dates rather than pretending counter-motion ended with the road.

No imperial seal closed the page. Each affected group kept a copy, and the salt could not be laid until their versions matched. Ruhan marked one blank line for any community they had failed to identify.

Tavra and Eda arrived in a covered wagon.

Kel rolled Tavra's board down a ramp. The transfer jolted her spine, and she closed her eyes until the pain passed. Eda moved slowly beside her, sandals wrapped against quarry grit.

"You chose a road opening for your first outing," Eda said.

"I was promised an argument."

"You have standards."

"Falling, but present."

Eda positioned herself on Tavra's left, then noticed and moved to the right so conversation reached her good ear. The adjustment happened without comment.

Ossa arrived carrying the bare rim by hand, no straps. She had been asked to open the crossing with a ceremonial beat and had refused. A quarry child struck a work rhythm instead. Ossa joined only after the cart crews began their own song.

The road-company veterans inspected the step-salt. Their old bends remained. No cure followed imperial collapse. The new pension toll would not straighten them. It would pay for braces, food, and work that did not require further centering.

Ruhan opened the atlas to a clean page.

At the top he wrote: Quarry Grain Crossing. Term: nine days.

Below it he listed the memorial wall, axle grade, daily inspection, release rests, toll, and right to halt. He left the route line unfinished until the first cart reached the other side.

The cutters performed one shallow turn. Stone in the quarry floor shifted around the wall. A road wide enough for a grain cart settled along the longer grade.

Nobody cheered yet.

The driver took the reins. At the salt boundary, she asked who guaranteed the crossing.

"No one," Ruhan said.

She frowned. "Who answers if it fails?"

He pointed to the accord board where names, duties, and compensation stood in public view. "Those people answer for the work they named. The ground may still change."

The driver considered the road, the memorial wall, and the waiting towns. Then she guided the cart forward.

Wheels crossed the new stone without tipping. At the far end, a Hadrin cutter marked the hour and inspected the first shift under the axle.

Only then did people breathe.

Ruhan completed the faint line in his incomplete atlas. He stopped it at both ends and wrote the date when it must be questioned again, along with the names of those charged with calling that question in public.

Chapter 28 — Where the Ground May Go

One year later, Eda returned to Dorel on a road scheduled to disappear at sunset.

The cart crossed the eastern quarry while morning light reached the scored stones. A board beside the approach listed the term, weather reading, wheel limit, affected wells, and names of three people authorized to halt traffic. Someone had added a fourth name in charcoal after a shepherd challenged the original accord.

At the Dorel end, the road bent around a field that had not existed the previous spring.

Eda stepped down carefully. Scars crossed both soles, thicker under the left arch. Long journeys made them ache. Her left ear still heard voices as if a wall stood between speaker and listener. She turned her right side toward the market and let the familiar disorder reach her.

The leaning stall was gone.

A public square occupied its old place. Market shelters stood on wide runners so sellers could move them when the nine-day circuit shifted. Every stall displayed two prices: goods carried on currently agreed roads and goods carried by paths whose cost remained unsettled. Arguments began before breakfast.

The largest wall bore anniversary terms rather than a monument. Dorel would practice one open route at noon. Participation remained voluntary. Ground readers had inspected the field that morning. The proposed crossing might shorten the western water walk. It might also move two dye tables and alter drainage behind the kiln. The accord lasted one market circuit unless renewed.

Below the terms, affected people had written objections.

The dyers wanted raised tables before the practice. Kiln workers wanted runoff kept away from cooling pits. A family with a handcart wanted the slope reduced. Two children objected because the proposed line crossed their game square.

The market itself carried changes beyond movable shelters. A former toll booth served as an injury kitchen where road-company pensioners ate without proving current service. The sole court occupied three stalls and posted every failed cut beside the successful patterns. Sellers who used a temporary route contributed to repair funds at its ends instead of paying a distant office.

Not every change had improved trade. Salt cost more because several old supply roads now wandered through wet country. Western fruit spoiled while three towns argued over a hill crossing. One cloth merchant had closed his stall after a nine-day route ended and no replacement received consent. His empty shelter remained on the market plan so the loss did not vanish beneath stories of freedom.

People disagreed about whether to renew the anniversary route before practice began. Water carriers wanted the shorter walk. Dyers feared the line would drain their yard. Kiln workers asked for compensation if runoff spoiled a firing. The

children offered half their game square for one day, then withdrew the offer when adults treated it as permanent.

A sole-court reader added every change to the board. Nobody reduced the dispute to opponents of motion and defenders of safety. The route would have to answer the uses actually present.

Eda read every line.

"You can smile at the children's objection," Kel said behind her. "They drew a replacement square on Tavra's teaching sheet."

Eda turned her good ear. "Did she approve?"

"She asked what happened to the old square if the road did not move."

"And?"

"They are negotiating shared chalk."

Kel had more gray in his beard and a wider cart. A ramp folded from its side. He opened it while Tavra maneuvered a low wheeled board to the top.

Tavra descended backward using leather loops fixed beside each wheel. Kel kept one hand near the frame without touching. The board carried a padded seat, a narrow score table, knives, salt bags, and replacement cushions. Tavra's legs rested in shaped supports. Her right foot had healed crooked inside a soft brace; neither leg provided motion.

Halfway down, one wheel caught the ramp lip.

"Stop," Tavra said.

Kel stopped.

She shifted her weight with both arms, lifted the wheel using the side loop, and rolled over the lip. Sweat stood on her face by the time she reached ground.

Eda waited until Tavra looked up.

"Do you want a push?"

"Across the mud, yes. On stone, no."

Eda took the rear handle and moved the board through the wet patch. At the square's edge, she let go.

Tavra inspected her. "Your left sandal wears faster."

"My left foot disagrees with roads."

"Roads have survived worse criticism."

They did not embrace. Tavra disliked being leaned over on the board, and Eda had learned not to make reunion perform intimacy for onlookers. She touched Tavra's forearm. Tavra turned the touch into a brief handclasp.

The anniversary workshop began beside the well.

Thirty people had registered. Tavra refused the raised platform built for her and

taught at ground level where everyone could see the relation between board, hand, and salt. Dorel carpenters laid a hard strip under her wheels so she could move along the practice line.

She placed a copied open-heel pattern on the score table.

"Who owns this?" she asked.

Several students looked at Eda.

"The sole court keeps copies," one said.

"That answers custody." Tavra waited. "Who owns the cut?"

"Aren Dast created the first version," said a retired road dancer.

"He documented a gap used in older greetings. I altered it at Nareth. Kel found a safer shallow depth. Eda joined it to public fields. People in seven provinces changed its timing. Which one receives ownership?"

Nobody volunteered an answer.

A city clerk raised his hand. "Without a named authority, dangerous versions will spread."

"They already have," Tavra said. "Naming me owner would not recall them. It would let me license one version and pretend the others disappeared."

"What prevents misuse?"

"Records. Peer reading. Public disclosure. Injury support. Refusal. Inquiry when those fail."

"That does not prevent everything."

"No."

The clerk seemed offended by the admission.

A woman from the western water crews asked who could call herself a cutter. Tavra turned the question back to the group. Answers included apprenticeship, sole-court review, surviving a road company, completing a certain number of routes, and acceptance by affected communities.

"Each test excludes someone," Tavra said. "Some exclusions protect bodies. Others protect employment or reputation. Name which you are doing."

The retired dancer proposed that no person certify alone. A dyer objected that three-person panels would favor cities with enough trained readers. Kel suggested traveling review tables. The children asked whether a bad cutter could stop being one. That question produced the longest silence.

They drafted no universal rank. For the afternoon practice, they agreed on narrower duties. One person would cut, two would read, affected workers could halt, and an injury recorder would remain independent of the route crew. Any uncertainty about the ground stayed written beside the score.

Tavra demonstrated how she now cut from the board. Without hips to stabilize

the blade, she used a leather wrist loop and asked another reader to hold the sole against her table. The method allowed precision but tired her shoulders quickly. She named that limit before beginning.

"I teach differently because my body changed," she said. "Do not turn adaptation into proof that injury gave me wisdom. Other people built this board, tested these loops, and corrected the first angle I cut from it."

Kel held up two fingers. "Three angles."

"Your record is hostile."

"Publicly so."

Laughter loosened the group without erasing the lesson.

Tavra gave each group a practice sole with one deliberate error. One closed the heel. Another carried a crosscut that would trap release. A third hid its receiving load beneath decorative marks. Students had to find the error, explain the likely body cost, and state what they could not know without reading actual ground.

Eda worked with the children from the game square.

They found the closed heel because chalk dust gathered in it. The younger child wanted to carve a bird beside the gap. Eda asked whether the bird changed pressure. They tested it on damp clay. One wing deepened the outer edge.

"Then the bird cannot go there," the child said.

"It could be shallower."

"Would people think it means something?"

"Probably."

They removed the bird.

At another table, the retired dancer refused to cut because her hands shook. Tavra asked her to read while a younger carpenter held the knife. The dancer called depth and direction. The carpenter stopped before each turn and repeated the instruction. Neither person became the invisible helper of the other.

By midday, Tavra's lower-spine pain forced her flat.

Kel unfolded the board back and adjusted a cushion under her hips. Teaching continued from that position. Nobody called the change defeat. Nobody called it courage. A student held each sole where Tavra could inspect it without twisting.

Eda watched the old instincts cross her mother's face. Tavra still wanted to take the knife when a beginner cut badly. She now named the impulse.

"I want to correct this with my hand," she told the group. "If I do, you learn my movement and not the error. Start again. Tell me why this line closes."

The student found the answer.

At the end, the city clerk tried once more. "Will you authorize the public route score?"

"No."

"Will you certify the cutters?"

"No."

"Then what have you done here?"

"Taught what I know. Disclosed where I failed. Read their work."

The clerk looked toward Eda. "Will you establish a traveling school, at least? Communities need a standard."

Eda had received that proposal in six provinces. Each offered rooms, staff, and authority to issue sole marks. Every offer began with safety and ended with one office deciding whose practice counted.

"I travel when communities invite me," she said. "I leave copies and local readers. I do not keep a gate."

"How do we know whom to trust?"

"Ask who records refusal. Ask who pays for injury. Ask what they hide when the cut succeeds."

The answer dissatisfied him. Eda preferred that to obedience.

Her year of travel had produced no single method. In Kesta, orchard workers used shadow intervals and refused written borders. Along the sixth watershed, well keepers demanded that every score name downstream villages before opening springs. Hadrún pensioners taught apprentices to recognize pain before technique failed. Veyr weavers tied temporary route terms to market days because landlords had once treated access as a private favor.

Eda carried practices between them only with permission. Sometimes a community rejected an imported cut. Once, a spring council erased her entire lesson after local readers found that the receiving curve would drain into burial ground. She stayed to document the error and left without a credential to defend.

Communities also changed what she taught elsewhere. A Kestan refusal sign became a river-section cloth. A Dorel injury form gained space for lost stall goods after Meren's collapsed awnings. Tavra's board loops appeared in three pension houses, built to different widths because bodies and doors differed.

None of that required a school above the communities. It required travel, copying, argument, and the willingness to leave a useful blank when knowledge did not belong to the traveler.

After the workshop, she and Tavra ate beside the kiln. Tavra chose a place where her board could turn without help. Eda sat on her right.

For several minutes they discussed the western water walk. The dye tables could move uphill, but runoff might reach the kiln pits. Tavra proposed a shorter practice line. Eda thought it would place too much load near the children's replacement square.

"You still protect the open space first," Tavra said.

"You still think every open space wants a score."

"Not every one."

"Most."

Tavra considered. "Too many."

The admission carried no plea.

Eda broke bread. "I leave for Kesta next week."

"How long?"

"Two months. Orchard routes, then the sixth watershed if their sole court still wants an outside reader."

"Will you come back?"

"Yes."

"Because you want to?"

"Because I want to."

Tavra looked down at her hands. "I still hear your question in the kiln. Whether you had to disappear for me to tell the truth."

"You answered it."

"Not enough."

"There is no enough that changes the years."

"I know."

Eda's left ear caught the market as soft impact without words. Through the right she heard knives being packed away and children arguing over chalk. "You left me. You came back after I made a life that did not include you. You tried to make your body pay instead of asking what I wanted."

"Yes."

"I love you."

Tavra closed her eyes.

"I am not saying it to free you," Eda continued. "I am saying it because making you guess has become another kind of work I do not want."

"I love you too." Tavra opened her eyes. "I am sorry."

"I heard you."

Eda did not say the apology had repaired the abandonment. Tavra did not ask.

A pressure spasm tightened across Tavra's lower back. She gripped the board loops and waited through it. Eda stayed where Tavra could see her.

"Cushion?" she asked.

"After it passes."

When Tavra's hands loosened, Eda asked again. Tavra said yes and directed the adjustment.

Ossa began drumming in the market square.

She used a shallow hand drum with no command skin and no body straps. Her left forearm still weakened after long phrases, so three market musicians shared the rhythm. The dance had no center. Couples, children, retired road workers, and visiting cutters joined when they wanted and left without breaking anything.

Ossa saw Eda at the kiln and changed nothing in the beat.

That pleased Eda.

Ruhan arrived late with the atlas under his good arm. His right wrist had stiffened in cold rain, and a young route clerk carried the heavier folios. He opened the newest volume on the public board.

Maps filled some pages. Others held lists of temporary terms, failed crossings, injuries, and names of communities discovered after agreements were signed. Between them, deliberate blanks remained.

A Dorel merchant tapped one. "You know the western shelf exists."

"Yes."

"Why not draw it?"

"Three groups dispute its use. One asked me not to publish the spring approach until they can protect the wells."

"So travelers go without knowledge."

"They receive the risk and the local contacts. They do not receive a line that may become a claim."

The merchant muttered about inconvenient principles.

Ruhan handed him a dated pass around the shelf.

At noon, the route-practice assembly formed. Dyers had raised their tables. Kiln workers dug a runoff trench. The handcart family tested the revised slope. Children marked a new game square with shared chalk. Every affected group read the amended terms aloud.

No one asked Eda to stand at center.

She took a place beside the western water carriers. Tavra waited at the score edge on her wheeled board, serving as a reader only. Kel stood near the open heel. Ossa stopped drumming social dance and set the instrument down before approaching the route field.

Ruhan marked the practice route in his atlas with an ending date.

Local keepers gave attention calls. Participants entered in small sections. The movement used shallow turns and one-step greetings already taught. When a dye table shifted half an inch, its owner raised a red cloth. That section stopped. Cutters adjusted the runoff gap, disclosed the change, and asked again.

The owner lowered the cloth.

Practice resumed.

Stone beneath the western edge loosened. The proposed line settled around the kiln rather than through it. Near the children's square, the ground turned north. Their replacement chalk stayed untouched.

The route reached the water walk.

Before opening it, the assembly tested more than feet and carts. Kel pushed Tavra's wheeled board up the grade while she kept both hands away from the loops. One turn proved too narrow; the outer wheel slipped toward runoff stone. Workers widened that curve by hand. A woman with a walking brace tested the next section and found a ridge that caught her toe. Children marked it until cutters lowered the lip.

Tavra refused to let her board become the only measure of access. Water yokes, handcarts, pension braces, and market runners each found different faults. Every correction entered the day's record with the person who had named it.

Nobody named it permanent. The accord board gave it nine days, daily inspection, a load limit, and the right of any affected group to halt use. Sellers rolled two market shelters toward the new edge. Water carriers tried the grade with empty yokes, then with full buckets.

Eda took the first public crossing only after the people who needed it had tested the surface.

Her scarred soles recognized shallow movement. The ground shifted under one step, then held long enough for the next. She did not ask it for permission or hear a message in stone. Cutters, dyers, children, water carriers, and the changing shelf had shaped a usable crossing together.

At the far end, she turned back.

Tavra waited on the low board beside the kiln. Ossa had resumed the market dance. Ruhan left the new line open at its western edge, where the atlas page met a deliberate blank.

A water carrier passed Eda with two full buckets. Behind him came a handcart, three children, and a dyer moving one table before the afternoon rain.

Eda stepped aside and let them use the road.